

Celebrating 80 Years of Recovery, Unity and Service – The Foundation for Our Future

The 65th Annual Meeting of the
General Service Conference
of Alcoholics Anonymous

2015 Final Report | Confidential

The Sixty-Fifth Annual Meeting of the General Service Conference of Alcoholics Anonymous

*Celebrating 80 Years of Recovery, Unity and Service —
The Foundation for Our Future*

2015
Final Report

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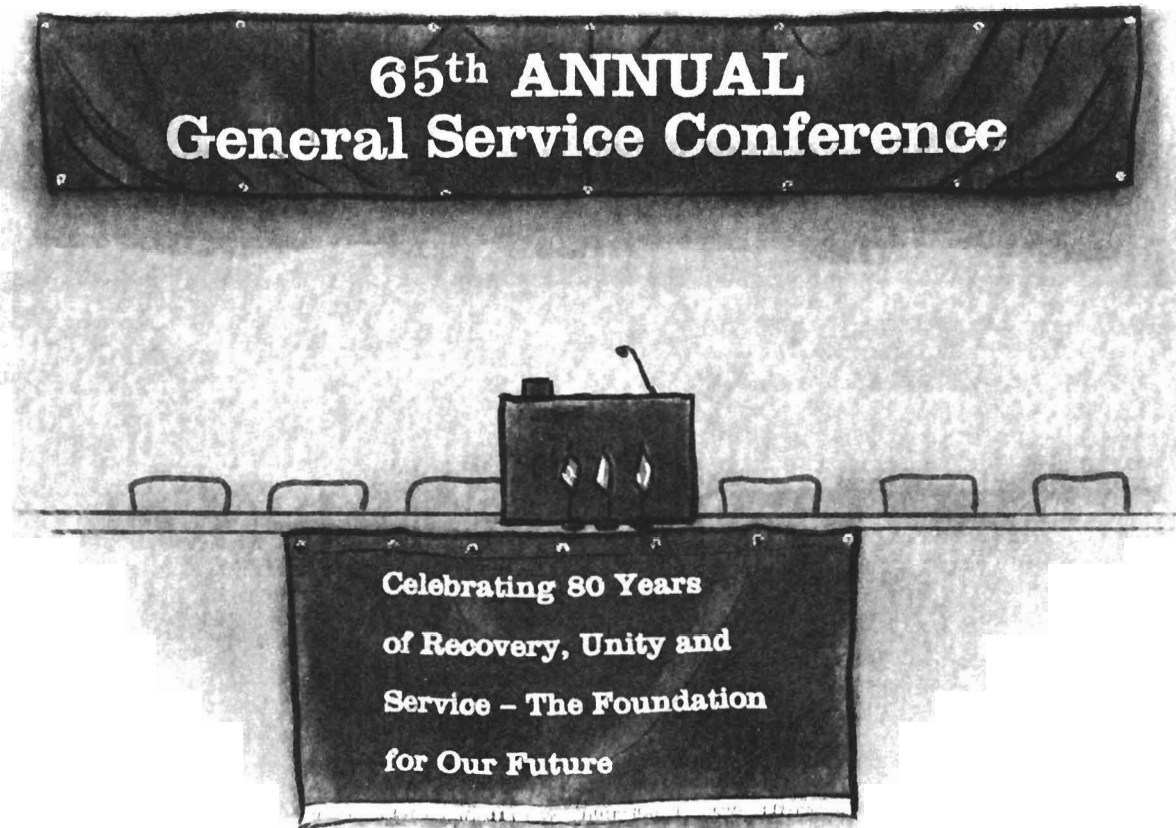
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Confidential—full names used

Since this report is a *confidential* A.A. document, for members only, it contains members' full names and addresses.

This usage—to facilitate communication within the Fellowship—was approved by the 1975 Conference. Such confidential use respects our Tradition of anonymity in *public* communications and with media (press, radio, TV, etc.).



The 65th General Service Conference of Alcoholics Anonymous in the United States and Canada was held at the Crowne Plaza Times Square in New York City, April 19-25, 2015. The 134 Conference members consist of delegates from the 93 Conference areas in the U.S. and Canada, trustees of the General Service Board, A.A.W.S. and Grapevine Board directors; and General Service Office and Grapevine staff members.

The Conference was officially opened Sunday afternoon with the roll call by G.S.O.'s general manager Phyllis Halliday, followed by greetings from the delegate chair Jake Jacobson, of Northern Minnesota. The Keynote Address was given by J. Gary Lutz, Northeast regional trustee.

This year's Conference was chaired by chairman of the General Service Board Terry Bedient; Phyllis Halliday, G.S.O.'s general manager; and Jake Jacobson, delegate chairperson. G.S.O. staff member Mary Cummings was Conference coordinator.

Sunday evening the Opening Dinner was followed by an open A.A. meeting, chaired by Michelle Dobek-Koinberg, Alberta/NWT, chairperson of the Conference Agenda Committee; the leader was Anne Fines, South Dakota. Speakers were: Steve Smith, G.S.O. staff; Sally Williams, Wyoming; Luc Tremblay, NW Quebec; Chet Parker, Southeast regional trustee; and Phyllis Halliday, general manager, G.S.O.

Conference week is filled with board and committee reports, presentations and discussions, area service highlights, sharing

sessions and committee meetings.

The main focus of the Conference though, is on the deliberations of each of the thirteen Conference committees, and it is during the committee meetings that the major work of the Conference is done. After a joint meeting with each corresponding standing trustees' committee, the Conference committees review material and background information, weigh and discuss various issues and come up with recommendations which may result in Conference Advisory Actions. (Highlights of Advisory Actions appear on page 3.)

Trustee elections were held Wednesday afternoon. Richard Purtell, of Pelham, NH, was elected Northeast regional trustee; and Yolanda Flores, San Antonio, Texas, was elected Southwest regional trustee. The new trustee-at-large/Canada will be Scott Huyghebaert, of Kamloops, British Columbia. At the Delegates Only meeting Tuesday evening Barb Colley, West Virginia, was selected to be the delegate chair for the 66th Conference; Tom Misteli, NE Texas, will be alternate chair.

Some Highlights from the Conference:

- *World Service Meeting* — The 23rd WSM was held last October in Warsaw, Poland. Bob Wilcox, trustee-at-large/U.S. gave an overview of the meeting. Then Rick Walker, G.S.O. staff member on the International desk, spoke on "A.A. Around the World."
- *80 Years — Happy, Joyous and Free* — Excitement is running

high as we rapidly approach ("Just 70 days!" said Georgia delegate Rebecca Thomason) the 2015 International Convention in Atlanta. Eva Sanchez, G.S.O.'s International Convention coordinator, ran down the highlights of the celebration. Then the Riverside Drive Players (G.S.O. and Grapevine employees) put on a humorous skit covering possible happenings during the July 2-5 weekend.

- *Electronic Voting* — In the first year of a two-year trial, members voted on committee recommendations during the Thursday session only. A survey was taken evaluating this process and will be included in a report to be compiled after the conclusion of the two-year trial. In 2016 the trial will take place on Friday.

- *G.S.O. Visit* — Tuesday afternoon delegates and their families and friends took the subway uptown to visit the General Service Office. For many it was their first trip to G.S.O. The highlight for many was the A.A. Archives — to sit on Bill's couch, to see the ancient typewriter used to type the manuscript of the Big Book, to view the memorabilia of past Conferences in the display case, as well as touring the office and meeting G.S.O. and Grapevine workers.

- *Conference Inventory* — This was the final year of a three-year inventory. Wednesday morning members split into 15 groups to discuss the final 14 questions. A summary of the report backs may be found on page 25 and a full report will be in the *Final Conference Report* (M-23), available in September. There will also be a complete publication, covering this three-year project, later in the year.

- *A.A. Meeting* — Each morning at 7:00 the G.S.C. Serenity Group met for coffee and sharing. James Hurst, Southwest Texas, chaired the open discussion meeting; Dave Allen, New Brunswick/P.E.I., was the secretary/treasurer.

Friday afternoon rotating Panel 64 delegates lined up around the room and each gave a moving and emotional two-minute farewell. The 65th General Service Conference was officially closed with the Serenity Prayer, led by Mary Jo Rone (English), Raymond Denis (French) and Jose Rivera-Vazquez (Spanish).

Rotating trustees gave their farewell talks at the closing brunch on Saturday morning: Frances L. Brisbane and Corliss Burke, Class A (nonalcoholic) trustees; Nancy Haynes, general service trustee; J. Gary Lutz, Northeast regional trustee; and Clayton Vandivort, Southwest regional trustee. Barb Kelly, trustee-at-large/Canada, was unable to attend the brunch.

In his Keynote Address on opening day of the Conference J. Gary Lutz, spoke of how far Alcoholics Anonymous has come in the past 80 years and outlined some of the challenges it faces in the future. In closing, Gary told members of the 65th Conference, "We frequently say to you at the close of each General Service Conference, 'You are now a part of A.A.'s history.' I would submit that you are also a part of A.A.'s future."

Greetings

Welcome members of the 65th General Service Conference. What a privilege and a honor to be the Delegate Conference Chair and the first to greet my fellow delegates, the trustees, both Class As and Bs, our general manager Phyllis, our board chair Terry, the G.S.O. and Grapevine staff members, and other invited guests to this Conference. May we each serve in the capacity God has chosen for us this week. Our theme "Celebrating 80 Years of Recovery, Unity and Service — The Foundation for Our Future," is appropriate as we finish our Inventory of the Conference and prepare to bring our past experience to bear in carrying us forward. The driving force behind our service must surely be found in our unity as recovering members of Alcoholics Anonymous.

This is our 65th Conference, so we recognize the first 15 years that set the stage for our future were brought about by leaders directed by God to ensure our future. These fine men and women stood fast to principles during difficult times, sowing the seeds that have continued to bear fruit in the knowledge that we strive to give all who suffer from the illness of alcoholism an opportunity to find sobriety and serve God. As delegates we are the leaders and the visionaries who help guide us to our future



by remembering the failures and successes of our past. We have never been alone. We sit on the shoulders of giants that deferred their own personal agendas to ensure the success of A.A..

As was written, ours is the sometimes thankless task of doing the groups' chores. We make sure the doors of A.A. remain open for the next alcoholic that is looking for a better life. Our Concepts remind us that as delegates we were chosen, either by election or from the hat, to be the cheerleaders of our movement. Alcoholics Anonymous is a society of drunks in action, so excited by the opportunity to enjoy this second chance at life that we forgo our own comfort to save the lives of our brothers and sisters. Those of us who were a part of last year's Conference have the responsibility to guide this year's newest members to be as compassionate and considerate to each other as those who showed us the way.

None of us is special by ourselves, but as a group, we carry God's power and the guidance from the last 80 years to make decisions that will help us meet the expressed needs of A.A. We have a great staff to guide us during this week. Please use the one sentence that has so deeply changed each of our lives: "Please help me."

Last year a past delegate told me that looking back on his experience here and what was accomplished, they had accomplished nothing that would make things worse and what they had done is hidden anonymously by God to ensure our place in A.A. We must not allow the good to be the enemy of the best. We are in no hurry to make decisions based on our limited knowledge. One of the old guys who guided me would say "Maybe we need to go home and talk to God about this one" after an especially heated battle.

Thank you for allowing me to stand before you. I am humbled to be a member of Alcoholics Anonymous, guided by God and the past 80 years of our Recovery, Unity and Service. This is the foundation for our future.

Michael "Jake" Jacobson, Northern Minnesota

Keynote Address

The theme of our Conference this year is "Celebrating 80 Years of Recovery, Unity and Service — The Foundation for Our Future." And there is indeed much to celebrate. Eighty years ago, two men met in Akron, Ohio: one struggling to maintain a precarious sobriety, and one firmly in the grip of this terrible disease. From that inauspicious beginning emerged a Fellowship and a program that now counts among its membership over 1.4 million in the United States and Canada alone, with an additional nearly three quarters of a million worldwide. From our program's simple beginnings, countless lives have been saved, families restored, and reparations made. Much to celebrate indeed!

We frequently say that "this is a simple program for complicated people." At its simplest, the program would have only a single principle: "Don't drink." But over the years, we have found it necessary to craft a total of three dozen principles — twelve to aid us in our recovery, twelve to help preserve our Fellowship, and twelve to assist us in carrying the message to those who still suffer.

We consider A.A. to have been "founded" in June 1935, when Dr. Bob is said to have taken his last drink. But it was not until 1939, that the nature of the program in general, and its Twelve Steps in particular, were published in the book, *Alcoholics Anonymous* — a book that later became known affectionately as the Big Book.

The Steps, of course, were the logical set of principles to be developed first. Recovery was certainly the sole focus in those early days. But this formative period was also fraught with

controversy. Debates ensued over issues such as money, membership, public relations, authority, governance, and anonymity, to name just a few. And it soon became apparent to Bill that if our Fellowship were to survive, some additional principles were needed. In April 1946, Bill published "Twelve Suggested Points for A.A. Tradition" in the Grapevine. These twelve new principles — now known as the Twelve Traditions — were formally adopted at the International Convention that was held in Cleveland, Ohio, in 1950. Three years later, the book *Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions* brought our first 24 spiritual principles together under one cover.

Around the time that the foundations for our Legacies of Recovery and Unity were being established, our general service structure was beginning to emerge. Bill spent several years working on the final set of principles that would ultimately guide us in our service around the globe, and at the 1962 General Service Conference, the Twelve Concepts for World Service were unanimously accepted.

And so, a little over a half a century ago, A.A.'s Three Legacies of Recovery, Unity and Service — along with the twelve principles underlying each one — were firmly established. Alcoholics Anonymous sat upon a solid, three-legged structure — indestructible for all time. What could possibly go wrong?

Well, so far, nothing. Oh, we certainly debate from time to time the interpretation of our principles. And we certainly question from time to time the relevance of some of them in today's world. And we actually have mechanisms in place through which we can even change them should we so choose. But to date, these 36 principles have remained the bedrock of our movement. So, should we assume that this will always be the case? Should we assume that these principles will continue to form a foundation for our future?

I would submit that today, Alcoholics Anonymous is facing challenges of a nature and a magnitude that could not even have been imagined eighty years ago. In the interest of time, I will name only a few.

Singleness of Purpose: The epidemic of drug abuse that is evident today was not nearly of this magnitude when A.A.'s principles were first being crafted. It is my belief that while our principle of singleness of purpose is as important today as it was in the beginning, it is now being challenged to a greater extent than ever before. The so-called "pure alcoholic" is a vanishing breed. How do we best counsel the multi-addicted in how to consider their "problems other than alcohol" while in the rooms of Alcoholics Anonymous? We want to honor our principles, but we do not wish to shut the door on any who need us.

Social Media: The relatively recent availability and widespread use of social networks and social media has placed new challenges on our principle of anonymity at the public level. When this principle was first being crafted, the concern was for the individual who purposefully stepped into a public forum and declared him or herself to be a member of our Fellowship. Today the potential for even an accidental anonymity break is enormous. Ever-changing privacy controls, hasty photo posting, and links to a network of so-called "friends" all conspire to diminish the control that we have over what we share and with whom. And yet, these new modes of communication have extraordinary potential for helping us connect with one another and for carrying our message of hope to those still suffering.

Diversity of Membership: While A.A. is no longer the collection of white males that it was in the beginning, our membership does not yet reflect the diversity of society at large. If we believe that the disease of alcoholism does not acknowledge the boundaries of gender, race, ethnicity, religion, age, economics, education, disability, or sexual orientation, then we have much

to do in terms of making our program attractive to those who are underrepresented in our rooms. Having said that, however, are we willing to invest the effort, the resources, and the open-mindedness necessary to create a welcoming, safe, and nurturing environment for everyone? If the only requirement for membership is simply a desire to stop drinking, then what are the impediments that are keeping so many who need us from not coming in?

Diversity in Service: If our general membership is not reflective of society as a whole in terms of diversity, our trusted servants seem even further removed in this regard. In 1967, Eastern Pennsylvania sent Louis R. to the General Service Conference. Lou was the first African-American delegate to participate in service at this level. It is said that Bill W. shed tears when he first greeted Lou. That historic moment opened the door to at least greater racial diversity within our service structure. But how far have we come in the intervening years? As far as we should? As far as we can? I invite you to simply look around.

Size of Our Membership: In its formative years, Alcoholics Anonymous experienced an explosive growth in membership. Some recent estimates, however, suggest that we have reached essentially a steady state. Our Membership Survey also suggests that the average age within our Fellowship is increasing. Are these trends due to alcoholism itself being on the decline? Is it because today's youth are no longer vulnerable to our common malady? I invite you to pick up a newspaper and simply take a look at what's going on within our society. We need to explore new strategies and new modes of communication to help keep our message alive and relevant, while still respecting the principle of "attraction rather than promotion."

The Decline of Print: Alcoholics Anonymous manages two publishing corporations: A.A. World Services, Inc. and the A.A. Grapevine, Inc. Both concerns grew up in the print world. Today's readers are migrating away from the printed word and toward electronic and audio media. Amazon's Kindle, Barnes & Noble's Nook, and Apple's iBooks are rapidly replacing the printed page for both books and magazines. And audio publishers such as Audible are migrating us from the eye to the ear. Alcoholics Anonymous must cope effectively with these trends if we are going to continue to carry our message through our literature, as well as through our "Meeting in Print."

Technology Polarization: Early in our evolution, while virtually everyone had access to the U.S. Postal Service, not everyone had a telephone. Today, we take for granted that there is a land-line in most homes, and there is a mobile device in many pockets and purses. There is a television set in most homes. There is also a computer in many homes, with access to the Internet. But "many" and "most" are not equivalent to "all." As we think about new technologies and social networks and emerging modes of publication, let us be mindful of the risk of creating two Fellowships: those with access, and those without. Communication via email, texts, social media, and methods that will be invented next month are exciting and powerful. But let us not assume that all of our Fellowship enjoys such access. If it is truly the case that the only requirement for membership is a desire to stop drinking, we must not risk excluding a subset of our members from our communication network simply because of a technological divide.

International Structures: Alcoholics Anonymous is no longer



merely a few groups in Akron and a few groups in New York. It is a global phenomenon. And while the United States and Canada are not the "bosses" of A.A., we are frequently looked to for guidance and example. Some countries are currently struggling with the question of just who A.A. is within their borders — countries in which multiple service structures are beginning to emerge. How do we interact with our friends who are currently struggling with these situations? How do we help in these developments while still respecting our principle of autonomy of A.A. entities? And finally..

Litigation: We live in a litigious society. In the world at large, everyone seems to be suing everyone else over anything and everything. Alcoholics Anonymous is not immune to this phenomenon. Our Traditions say that "Each group should be autonomous except in matters affecting other groups or A.A. as a whole." Does that mean that we have no collective spiritual responsibility for fostering the well-being of our members within these rooms or for promoting the understanding that, even while in the rooms, we are still obligated to adhere to the laws of society as a whole?

And so I repeat: While our thirty-six spiritual principles have stood us in good stead for the eight decades of our existence, are they sufficient foundation for our future in light of these myriad challenges that lay before us? You will not find the definitive answer to this question nor the definitive solution to any of the issues cited above in the short week ahead. But you will touch on many of these issues, and the conversations can certainly begin. And as you do think about these issues and talk about them and struggle to make decisions about them, I would remind you of Bill's words from a July 1965 Grapevine article entitled, "Responsibility Is Our Theme." Recognizing what a central role fear plays in the life of an alcoholic, Bill wrote:

In the fear of accumulated wealth and bureaucracy, we should not discover an alibi for failure to pay A.A.'s legitimate service expenses. For fear of controversy, our leadership should not go timid when lively debate and forthright action is a necessity. And for fear of accumulating prestige and power, we should never fail to endow our trusted leaders with proper authority to act for us. Let us never fear needed change.

We frequently say to you at the close of each General Service Conference, "You are now a part of A.A.'s history." I would submit that you are also a part of A.A.'s future.

J. Gary Lutz, Northeast regional trustee

■ Advisory Actions

Conference Advisory Actions represent recommendations made by the standing committees and approved by the Conference body as a whole or recommendations discussed and voted on by all Conference members during general sessions. The group conscience of the Fellowship in the United States and Canada was expressed in the following Advisory Actions, which the General Service Board accepted in its legally required annual meeting following the 2015 Conference.

AGENDA

It was recommended that:

- 1 The theme for the 2016 General Service Conference be: "Our Spiritual Way of Life: Steps, Traditions and Concepts."
- 2 The following be presentation/discussion topics for the 2016 General Service Conference:
 - a. Connecting With the Newcomer:
 1. All Inclusive — Never Exclusive
 2. Are We Doing Enough to Help the Newcomer — Are We Going to Any Length?
 3. Home Group — Where It Begins
 - b. Connecting With Each Other:
 1. Singleness of Purpose — Staying Pertinent in a Changing World
 2. Informed Group Conscience — The Key to Unity
 3. Be Involved, Be Inspired, Be of Service
 - c. Connecting With A.A. as a Whole:
 1. Participating in All of A.A.
 2. Understanding Self-Support
 3. Reaching Out to the Next Generation of A.A.s
- 3 The following be the workshop topic for the 2016 General Service Conference: "Anonymity—The Spiritual Foundation."

ARCHIVES¹

No recommendations.

COOPERATION WITH THE PROFESSIONAL COMMUNITY

No recommendations.

CORRECTIONS

No recommendations.

FINANCE

It was recommended that:

- 4 Phase 1 of the G.S.O. proposed plan (February 5, 2015) to translate pre-Conference and Conference material into Spanish and French be implemented beginning with the 2016, 66th General Service Conference.

At minimum the following items will be included:

- Welcome correspondence to new panel delegates:
 - Letter
 - Memo to a Delegate from a Delegate, The Role of the Delegate

- Communications Kit (71 pages total)
- Committee Material:
 - Agenda 1–3 pages per committee
 - Composition, Scope and Procedures for 13 committees (17 pages total)
 - History and Actions of 13 committees (484 pages total)
- Pre-Conference documents:
 - Board reports (G.S.B., A.A.W.S., A.A. Grapevine)
 - Trustee committee reports
- Conference Kit

This initial phase of translations would be coordinated by G.S.O. departments, including staff and Publishing department personnel. Costs currently estimated by G.S.O. for the initial phase would be included in the G.S.O./A.A.W.S. budget at approximately \$80-120,000 for the year. Actual cost may be higher or lower upon receiving competitive bids.

- 5 The trustees' Committee on the General Service Conference create a plan to translate all Conference material with a progress report given to the 2016 Conference Committee on Policy and Admissions that describes the process and costs, including options using third party translators and a proposal to change agenda submission deadlines.

GRAPEVINE

It was recommended that:

- 6 The revised pamphlet "A.A. Grapevine and La Viña: Our Meetings in Print" be approved.

INTERNATIONAL CONVENTIONS/ REGIONAL FORUMS¹

No recommendations.

LITERATURE

It was recommended that:

- 7 The revised draft pamphlet "Inside A.A.: Understanding the Fellowship and Its Service Agencies," with the revised title "Inside A.A.: Understanding the Fellowship and Its Services," be approved with minor corrections.
- 8 A comprehensive revision to the retitled pamphlet "Inside A.A.: Understanding the Fellowship and Its Services," be undertaken by the trustees' Literature Committee, to better reflect the full range of A.A. services, and that a fully revised draft pamphlet or progress report be brought back to the 2016 General Service Conference.
- 9 The revised pamphlet "Your A.A. General Service Office" be approved with minor corrections.
- 10 The trustees' Literature Committee update the pamphlet "A.A. and the Gay/Lesbian Alcoholic" to include a wider range of A.A. recovery experience from members who are gay, lesbian, bisexual, transgender and gender nonconforming, especially regarding being a newcomer and sponsorship. The committee requested that the title of the pamphlet be revised to reflect this broader scope and that a draft revised pamphlet or progress report be brought to the 2016 Conference Committee on Literature.

¹Members of this committee serve on this as a secondary committee assignment.

- 11 The trustees' Literature Committee develop literature for the alcoholic with mental health issues. The committee requested that a wide range of A.A. recovery experience be gathered from members with mental health issues, and from those who sponsor such members for inclusion in literature on this topic. The committee requested that a progress report be brought to the 2016 Conference Committee on Literature.
- 12 The pamphlet "A.A. for the Woman" be revised by gathering current sharing from women in A.A., and suggested inclusion of stories from women in the military, single mothers, and women of diverse backgrounds. The committee requested that a draft revised pamphlet or a progress report be brought back to the 2016 Conference Committee on Literature.

POLICY/ADMISSIONS

It was recommended that:

- 13 The 68th General Service Conference be held April 22-28, 2018, since these dates do not conflict with any significant holidays or hotel availability.
- 14 The policy regarding General Service Conference audio recordings, which reads:

Tapes of Conference presentations not be made available, affirming the 1979 General Service Board recommendation which prohibits making tapes of any Conference session for distribution outside of the A.A. Archives, except for the opening and the closing brunch.

Be revised as follows:

Audio recordings of General Service Conference presentations published in the General Service Conference *Final Report* and audio recordings of the trustees' farewell talks given at the closing brunch be made available in accordance with Archives' Policies. Access to all other General Service Conference sessions will continue to be prohibited.

PUBLIC INFORMATION

It was recommended that:

- 15 The video public service announcement, "Doors," developed by the trustees' Public Information Committee, be approved with the following change:
 - Rerecord the dialog voice-overs using professional voice

actors in English, Spanish and French, removing any sense that the voices are recorded phone calls, at a cost not to exceed \$24,000.

- 16 The video public service announcement, "Doors" be centrally distributed, tracked and evaluated at a cost not to exceed \$40,000 in addition to the work of local committees, and that the information gathered from the process be forwarded to the 2016 Conference Public Information Committee for their review.
- 17 The video public service announcements "A Force of Nature" and "Testimonials" be discontinued.
- 18 The Membership Survey pamphlet and the one-way Membership Survey display be updated to reflect the findings from the 2014 Alcoholics Anonymous Membership Survey, with minor edits.
- 19 In light of the potential for continuing to improve the relevance and usefulness of the aa.org website on a timely basis, the A.A.W.S. Board be authorized to produce and post audio/video service material on the aa.org website provided the following conditions are met:
 - Audio/video service material produced via this process provides information already available on aa.org.
 - Proposed audio/video service material is for posting on aa.org only (audio/video items produced for distribution beyond the aa.org website will continue to require Conference review and approval).
 - Proposed audio/video service material is reviewed for content by an appropriate trustees' committee prior to posting — with the prerogative to request input from the appropriate Conference committee prior to forwarding to the A.A.W.S. Board.
 - Proposed audio/video service material is reviewed and approved for posting by the A.A.W.S. Board — with the prerogative to request input from the appropriate Conference committee prior to posting.

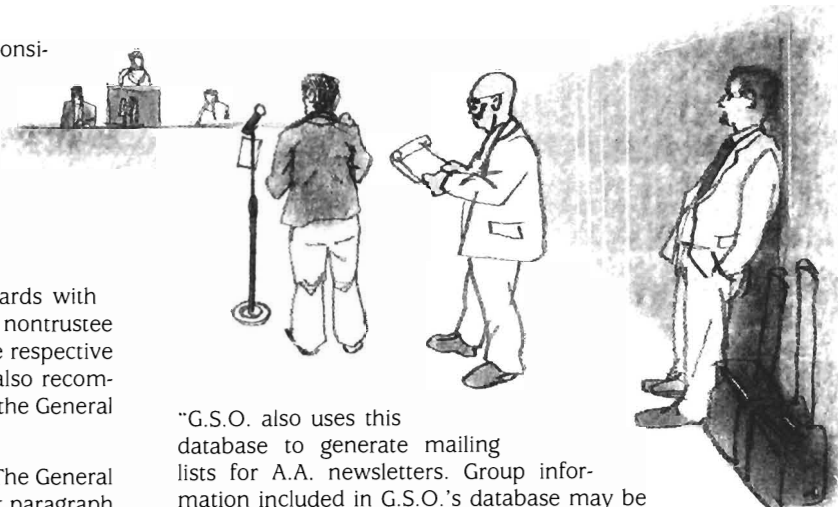
REPORT AND CHARTER

It was recommended that:

- 20 The following paragraph be edited for stylistic consistency and incorporated into Chapter 9 (The General Service Board) of *The A.A. Service Manual*.



"The Trustees' Nominating Committee is responsible for recommending to the General Service Board candidates for General Service Trustee, Class A Trustee, and nontrustee director. The candidates approved by the General Service Board are subject to the approval of the General Service Conference. The Trustees Nominating Committee receives advice from and consults with the A.A.W.S. and the A.A. Grapevine boards with respect to potential General Service Trustees, nontrustee directors, and Regional Trustees to serve on the respective boards. The Trustees Nominating Committee also recommends a slate of trustees to serve as officers of the General Service Board."



"G.S.O. also uses this database to generate mailing lists for A.A. newsletters. Group information included in G.S.O.'s database may be used by areas and districts for various purposes: the delegate may use it to communicate with groups; some areas use it for their meeting locators or to generate mailing lists."

- 21 Under **NOMINATION PROCEDURE** in Chapter 9 (The General Service Board) of *The A.A. Service Manual*, the first paragraph that currently reads:

"General service trustees are chosen from among current or past nontrustee directors of the two corporate boards, A.A. World Services and A.A. Grapevine, Inc. Since nontrustee directors are already serving (or have served) on one of the corporate boards, their qualifications are well known to the members of the respective boards, and it has been the privilege of those boards to propose the name of a candidate to represent them on the General Service Board."

Be revised to read (deleting the final phrase):

"General service trustees are chosen from among current or past nontrustee directors of the two corporate boards, A.A. World Services and A.A. Grapevine, Inc. Since nontrustee directors are already serving (or have served) on one of the corporate boards, their qualifications are well known to the members of the respective boards."

- 22 Under **NOMINATING** in Chapter 9 (The General Service Board) of *The A.A. Service Manual*, the following sentence be inserted to begin the description of the trustees' Nominating Committee:

"Reviews procedures for selection of candidates."

- 23 Under **Choosing Nontrustee Directors** in Chapter 10 (The Board's Operating Corporations) of *The A.A. Service Manual*, the second paragraph that currently begins:

"The nominating committee of the corporate board reviews all of the resumes received."

Be revised to read (text addition in **bold**):

"**Working in concert with the trustees' Nominating Committee**, the nominating committee of the corporate board reviews all of the resumes received."

- 24 In the section **Group Information** in Chapter 2 (The Group and Its G.S.R.) of *The A.A. Service Manual*, the following text be added to the end of the second paragraph:

"The group information provided on these two forms is stored in G.S.O.'s database, which is accessible to the area registrar."

- 25 In the section **Group Information** in Chapter 2 (The Group and Its G.S.R.) of *The A.A. Service Manual*, the following text be added to the beginning of the third paragraph:

- 26 The following text be added at the end of the section **District Information** in Chapter 3 (The District and the D.C.M.) of *The A.A. Service Manual*:

"The information provided on this form is stored in G.S.O.'s database, which is accessible to the area registrar. G.S.O.'s database also provides the capability for the area registrar to identify district officers and service chairs with local or specific information that then can be used to facilitate communication."

- 27 In Chapter 5 (The Area Committee) of *The A.A. Service Manual*, a new section be added after **Financial Support** with the following text:

"Area Information"

The outgoing delegate provides G.S.O. with contact information for all incoming area officers and committee chairs. This information is stored in G.S.O.'s database, which is also accessible to the area registrar, and is used to communicate with these officers and committee chairs throughout their rotation."

- 28 A new subsection of the section **STIMULATING INTEREST IN GENERAL SERVICE** be added to Chapter 1 (Introduction to General Service) in *The A.A. Service Manual* with the following text:

Reactivating districts: Frequently, there is a need within an area to attempt to reactivate districts or groups that have become inactive or are unrepresented. Areas encourage participation in general service in many ways, especially by direct contact with groups by district/area officers to provide information about service events and opportunities to carry the message beyond the group level. Sometimes there is district-to-district sponsorship in which an active district shares its experience and suggestions to "jump start" activity among groups within the inactive neighboring district.

- 29 A new section on "Regional Forums" be added to Chapter 9 (The General Service Board) of *The A.A. Service Manual* before the "World Service Meeting" section with the following text:

"Regional Forums"

Regional Forums, which originated in 1975, are week-



end-long sharing and informational sessions which provide unique opportunities to share and exchange valuable experience, ask questions and spark new ideas. They are also designed to help the General Service Board, A.A. World Services, and A.A. Grapevine; and G.S.O. and Grapevine staff members stay in touch with A.A. members, trusted servants and newcomers throughout the A.A. service structure. G.S.O.'s staff member on the Regional Forums assignment coordinates details for the Forum and works closely with the volunteer host chair who recruits volunteers to assist staff with hospitality, set-up and registration during the Forum. Forums are held on a rotating basis, at the request of each region. There is no registration fee for Regional Forums. The General Service Board covers the expenses of meeting rooms. As all Forums are intended to be sharing sessions, no formal actions result. Sharing is captured in Forum Final Reports, which are distributed to all attendees, and are available on G.S.O.'s website. Regional Forums carry A.A.'s message of love and service by improving communication at all levels of our Fellowship."

30 A new section on "Local Forums" be added to Chapter 9 (The General Service Board) of *The A.A. Service Manual* and requested that draft language be brought back to the 2016 Conference Committee on Report and Charter.

31 The *Twelve Concepts for World Service* and the Twelve Concepts section of *The A.A. Service Manual/Twelve Concepts for World Service* include the following pages in the same order as published in the 1990-1991 Edition:

- Title page;
- Copyright page;
- Preface;
- The Twelve Concepts (Short Form);
- The Twelve Concepts (Long Form);
- Contents page with short descriptions of the Twelve Concepts and page numbers;
- Introduction.

32 A limited run of the A.A. Regional Directories (Canadian, Eastern U.S. and Western U.S.) be printed annually for purchase upon request.

TREATMENT FACILITIES/ SPECIAL NEEDS/ACCESSIBILITIES

No recommendations.

TRUSTEES

It was recommended that:

33 The following slate of trustees be elected at the annual meeting of the members of the General Service Board in April 2015:

Class A

Leslie S. Backus, B.A.	Hon Ivan L.R. Lemelle
Terrance M. Bedient, FACHE	Peter Luongo, Ph.D., LCSW-C
John Fromson, M.D	David M. Morris, C.P.A
Michele Grinberg, J.D.	

Class B

Richard Boisvert	William Noonan
Joel Castellaw	Chet Parker
Joe Downey	Richard Purtell
William (Bill) Farnsworth	Andrew Ware
Yolanda Flores	Bob Wilcox
Scott Huyghebaert	Albin Zezula
Ed Martin	

Note: The General Service Board will operate short one Class B regional trustee.

34 The appointment of the following slate of officers of the General Service Board be approved at the Second Quarterly Meeting of the General Service Board in April 2015:

<i>Chairperson</i>	Terrance M. Bedient, FACHE
<i>First vice-chairperson</i>	Michele Grinberg, J.D.
<i>Second vice-chairperson</i>	William Noonan
<i>Treasurer</i>	David M. Morris, C.P.A.
<i>Secretary</i>	Andrew Ware

35 The March 2015 appointment of the following officers by the chair of the General Service Board be approved at the annual meeting of the members of the General Service Board in April 2015:

<i>Assistant treasurer</i>	Donald W. Meurer
<i>Assistant secretary</i>	Julio Espailat*

*Will be replaced at G.S.O. staff rotation in summer of 2015.

This appointment process is in accordance with the General Service Board Bylaws.

36 The following slate of directors be elected at the annual meeting of the members of the A.A. World Services Corporate Board in April 2015:

Carole Boerner	Phyllis Halliday
Richard Boisvert	David Noll
Beau Bush	William Noonan
Joe Downey	Chet Parker
Julio Espailat*	

*Will be replaced at G.S.O. staff rotation in summer of 2015.

37 The following slate of directors be elected at the annual meeting of the members of the A.A. Grapevine Corporate Board in April 2015:

Lynda Bergeron	Ed Martin
Ami Brophy	Paz Preciado
Joel Castellaw	Albin Zezula
William (Bill) Farnsworth	
Ivan Lemelle	

38 The Bylaws of The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc., as amended to comply with the New York State nonprofit law, be approved at the annual meeting of the members of the General Service Board in April 2015.

■ Presentations and Reports

23RD WORLD SERVICE MEETING/ A.A. AROUND THE WORLD

Sunday morning before lunch Conference members heard reports on the WSM, held last October.

The Three Legacies: Vital For All Generations

The 23rd World Service Meeting (WSM) was held October 12 — 16, 2014, at the Sofitel Hotel in beautiful Warsaw, Poland. 61 World Service delegates were in attendance, representing over 41 countries. I am extremely honored and humbled to have represented our U.S./Canadian structure.

The World Service Meeting is held every two years; one year here in New York and the other year's location is awarded by bid to a participating country so it can be held in various locations throughout the world. The purpose of the World Service Meeting is to provide a forum for countries to share their experience of how A.A. is working within their structures. This meeting provides enormous opportunities for participating countries to strengthen A.A. in their land by learning from the success stories of others. Many of the countries represented sponsor other countries.

The U.S. and Canada provide the principle event planning and organization. The week is organized with a varied schedule consisting of country highlights, workshops, presentations, committee meetings and sharing sessions. This varied format allows for countries to get a very real sense of how Alcoholics Anonymous is working around the world.

Much of the work of the World Service Meeting is achieved through its four committees: Agenda, Literature/Publishing, Policy/Admissions/Finance, and Working With Others. (I was assigned to the Policy/Admissions/Finance Committee.) These committees review items related to their respective scopes that ultimately increase participation, ensure the integrity of the translation of our literature, and share experience on effectively carrying the A.A. message.

One of the highlights of the World Service Meeting is the Country Highlights. Each country is invited to give a two-minute presentation of its history, structure and how A.A. is reaching those in need. Many seemed to have missed the memo on the two-minute time limit and went on and on. This didn't bother me though; I could listen to the development of A.A. around the world all day long!

This year we welcomed four new countries, which was heartwarming to see. They were the Czech Republic, Hong Kong, Iran and Romania. I'd like to highlight a few thoughts on Iran. Their delegate, Ali, shared how A.A. faces many difficult cultural and political barriers. Iran is an Islamic country with strict religious laws, therefore the government doesn't recognize A.A. In fact, it is referred to by many as "Nameless Sobers" in order to keep under the government's radar. Because of nonrecognition by the Iranian government, groups are not allowed to hold meetings in public buildings and are forced to hold them "underground" or outside in open spaces where temperatures range from 5 to 104 degrees Fahrenheit. Despite these difficulties, A.A. in



Iran has managed to translate the Big Book into Farsi and is reaching many suffering alcoholics, growing to approximately 12,000 members and more than 300 groups.

As the Fellowship has found its way to new lands, our literature has always led the way. In 1991 the International Literature Fund was started when participating countries of the World Service Meeting started raising funds to offset the cost of start-up literature for countries not able to finance their own. Since its inception, contributions of over \$1.5 million have been received, allowing for our literature to be translated, produced and put into the hands of so many suffering alcoholics around the world. This fund is under the purview of the Literature/Publishing Committee of the World Service Meeting and gives A.A.W.S. the latitude to prioritize the use of these funds, as they often facilitate this process.

Each participating country brings much of its translated literature to the World Service Meeting and it is displayed at the literature table. Seeing our literature translated into so many languages is tangible evidence of the good work of the World Service Meeting.

Similar to what we experience here, many tight bonds are made among the World Service delegates. By the end of the week I felt very connected to everyone in the room. In all my A.A. travels around the world, I have experienced firsthand that our disease knows no boundaries and how alike we all are. This fact was more apparent than ever throughout this week. Certainly here, we were people who ordinarily would not mix but all stood together, united for one purpose: To fulfill our responsibility to be sure that the hand of Alcoholics Anonymous is available to anyone, anywhere, who reaches out for help.

We closed the 23rd World Service Meeting by joining hands and reciting the Serenity Prayer in 28 languages, a truly awe-some experience.

Thank you for the opportunity to serve our wonderful Fellowship.

Bob Wilcox, Trustee-at-large/US

A.A. Around the World

I've been asked to share with you, in five minutes, about A.A. around the world. The International desk is the contact point at G.S.O. for those residing outside of Canada and the United States. It is a truly exciting assignment, where you can see A.A. springing up in places where it did not exist before. As the staff

member on this desk, I'm commonly in touch with members on all continents. Even from the vantage point of this desk, what can be seen is only a small fraction of A.A.'s world activity.

And in the time allotted, this talk can only scratch the surface of what I have seen and experienced in my limited time during this rotation.

A.A. is at different stages of growth in countries all over the world. Currently there are 62 countries with their own general service offices, each of them autonomous. There are several opportunities for representatives from established structures to share their experience face-to-face on the national level. Our trustees-at-

large are our delegates to the World Service Meeting and the Meeting of the Americas, and G.S.O. management and staff are invited to the other zonal meetings as observers and resources. Zonal meetings, which will take place this year, include the Asia-Oceania Service Meeting in Dubai, U.A.E.; the European Service Meeting in York, England; and the Sub-Saharan Africa Service Meeting in Johannesburg, South Africa.

G.S.O. staff may also be invited to national events, such as a General Service Conference or a convention. In February, trustee-at-large/U.S. Bob Wilcox and I went to Yokohama, Japan, where more than 2,000 members celebrated the 40th anniversary of the first Japanese speaking meeting. Before 1975, Japanese members had attended English-speaking meetings. Bob and I shared about our structure at the opening meeting, and Bob participated in a Cooperation With the Professional Community symposium on Saturday.

In Japan, I met with a delegation from Mongolia, including the chair of their General Service Board. They inquired about translations and our Traditions, asking about groups that didn't participate in the service structure and didn't contribute to their G.S.O. Sound familiar?

Around this time last year, Bob and I went to El Salvador for the 36th Central American Convention, and last October Bob traveled to the 26th Anniversary of A.A. in Latvia. International trips this year include the General Service Conference of Ukraine and the Italian National Convention. International trips are intended to help us carry the message and to further our relations with A.A. structures that express a need for shared experience.

A.A. literature carries the message internationally, too. The Big Book is available in 69 languages, and A.A. pamphlets in more than 90. We have pamphlets in languages that I had never heard of when I came to work at G.S.O., including Twi (spoken in Ghana), and Shan (spoken in Southeast Asia). Working through G.S.O.'s Publishing Department, A.A. as a whole carries the message in ways that my group and I could not do on our own. The Publishing Department is constantly coordinating additional translations to carry the message around the world.

A.A. continues to reach new lands. In 2013, A.A. started in Liberia; it is a wonderful story, but too long to share here. Last year, we heard from Bonnie, an A.A. member with the Peace Corps in Albania, who was interested in starting a meeting. We sent her literature in English. Working through G.S.O.'s Publishing Department, Bonnie has been connected with Albanian speakers in the U.S. and in Germany; they are working together on translations into Albanian. Shortly after receiving Bonnie's email, we received an email from a retired couple about starting a meeting in Macedonia. We sent them literature in English, Croatian and Serbian. By one of those A.A. "coincidences," they are 45 minutes from Bonnie in Albania, so we put them in touch. We hope these efforts take root and result in the first ongoing A.A. groups in these countries.

I've heard A.A. members say that you can find an A.A. meeting wherever you travel. Having been on the International assignment this last rotation, I can tell you that that is not true. There are still countries where there is no A.A., and others where there are vast distances between meetings and members. G.S.O. lists A.A. contacts in 176 countries around the world, but this number is not static. For instance, a professional from Armenia contacted the office for A.A. information. We provide literature upon request to professionals all over the world, and try to connect them with A.A. locally. We had one A.A. member listed in our records at the time in Yerevan, the capital. When I emailed the contact, she told me she had moved back to California. With no A.A. contact in Armenia, I shared information with the professional about how professionals helped start A.A. in Australia

and Canada. I also sent her A.A. literature to read and pass on to suffering alcoholics that she was trying to help and, since many Armenians speak Russian, I gave her the contact information for the G.S.O. in Russia.

When A.A. members travel we look for meetings, not only so that we can stay sober ourselves, but so that we can pass on A.A. to others. If the Fellowship of Alcoholics Anonymous does not exist at our destination, we can create it. We can find drunks "by asking a few doctors, ministers, priests or hospitals." (*Alcoholics Anonymous*, p. 89) We can talk about our program, inform professionals, share with alcoholics, and provide them with literature. We may not be able to find established A.A. meetings everywhere we go, but we can be the spark that ignites them. The A.A. message of hope will continue to spread as long as we, the members, carry it with us, and act as its messengers.

Rick Walker, G.S.O. staff

OUR COMMON WELFARE THROUGH GRATITUDE IN ACTION

Sunday afternoon the Presentation/Discussion session was chaired by Frank Malota, Western New York.

Diversity in A.A. — Our Heritage of Inclusion

My name is Cesar, and I am an alcoholic. I have the honor to serve Mid-Southern California, Area 09, as the Panel 64 delegate. My Conference Committee is Public Information. It is a huge privilege to share on this topic with you. My heart began to beat from the moment I received the invitation, just thinking about being here, before you, my dear friends of the 65th General Service Conference.

I started to drink when I was 14 years old. I am the oldest of five brothers, and my parents had many dreams for me, but my drinking habits (coupled with my bad conduct and poor attitude) resulted in some not-so-good decisions. My social habits were not so good either, and very quickly I turned into an alcoholic with many problems. When I was 20 years old I moved to California to look for ways to improve my life, but my problems came with me, and things only got worse. It was then that an A.A. member with much patience and tolerance took me to my first A.A. meeting. I first entered the doors of A.A. 19 years ago, and I have not had a drink since.

To be honest, during my early days in A.A. I did not care too much about the Traditions or the Concepts. My focus was on the Steps, for my recovery. After practicing these Twelve Steps, gratitude began to flourish within me—gratitude toward our



community as a whole. During a business meeting in my home group at that time, I raised my hand to take part in general service. My quality of life changed immensely and my sobriety was enriched with the spiritual experiences that I encountered by walking this path. At times, I feel afraid and nervous to take on some extra work that I may not be able to perform, but as usual, I feel strongly inspired by the love I feel for A.A.

I have been in general service for 16 years. When I made myself available for delegate, I had my name picked out of the hat on three different occasions. The Higher Power of my understanding said "no" the first two times. The third time that my name was again picked from the hat, my Higher Power said "yes." Very interesting things started to unfold from then on. I had been warned that my life was going to change, but I was never told to what magnitude.

I continue to attend my home group business meetings, be a sponsor to newcomers, and take care of my responsibilities, and at the same time, I am enjoying my service as delegate. Best of all, I am living this spiritual experience to the max.

Very soon we will celebrate 80 years of our Fellowship. This makes me recall everything our pioneers in A.A., including Dr. Bob and Bill W., did to leave this program for future generations, so it could go to other countries and other cultures. Today we can appreciate that there is A.A. activity all over the world. I have the privilege to go and see the diversity of the groups in our area. We have meetings in Farsi, Spanish, and Japanese, as well as meetings with American Sign Language, with ASL interpreters. We also have committees that carry on events, workshops, and roundtables, to motivate members to carry the message to the alcoholics who still suffer. Many times I see committee events with little participation, and it is there where I choose to travel within my geographic area—visiting groups, districts, committees, central offices, and other local events to which I have been invited.

All of the committees, meetings, and events that I mentioned have talked about our upcoming 80 years celebration. I can see and feel that our members have done a good job taking on the responsibility that our pioneers passed along through our literature. Whenever I have an opportunity, I thank our English-speaking members for allowing us, the Spanish-speaking community, into the A.A. structure so that we, too, can participate and share our experience. Right now I would like to take this opportunity to say to all of you: "Thank you, thank you, and thank you for your support!"

I am grateful that our early pioneers saw wisdom in our spirit of inclusiveness, our heritage of inclusion, and achieving diversity within A.A. In Bill's essay on Tradition Three it is written that we were gripped with fear in our early years. A.A. was fragile and recovery was so precious. Recovery should be open to all

who suffer from alcoholism. We in Alcoholics Anonymous have a solution. We can never deny that solution to our fellow sufferers regardless of race, religion (or lack of religion), culture, gender, sexual orientation, background, or personality.

Our heritage of diversity continues to grow. In 1958 the Conference recognized that the deletion of the word "honest" before the phrase "desire to stop drinking" from the Traditions was part of the A.A. movement's evolution. In 1968 the Conference voted that the first World Service Meeting would be held here in New York. And we continue evolving today toward inclusion, as we can see from our current proposals.

In 1985, Area 9 approved its first Spanish-speaking district. Today we have six of them. As you can see, I come from a culture where we practice and carry out celebrations on a different level, with music, dance, noise—the list can grow as long as anyone would like. But in A.A., I see that this type of celebration manifests gratitude. But we must keep in mind that we have a responsibility to move forward, and to continue to carry this message of life to other ethnic groups within our areas. There is still much work to be done, and that is what I promote every time I have an opportunity.

The development of our literature—all the booklets, books, and committees that have been added through the years—has been due to particular needs. I like this, and I'm proud to belong to this great movement that cares for all, and not only for a particular group of people. I hope that this will always be the character of A.A., with a vision toward the future—to reach out to all types of alcoholics that still suffer, no matter who they are or where they come from, because they will be the future members of the Conferences to come, the delegates to be, and the future of Alcoholic Anonymous.

That is why it is my duty to reflect and honor all of our A.A. principles, so that through my example the responsibilities of these principles get transmitted to future generations.

We should celebrate, and celebrate proudly. We should let our gratitude shine. We have grown from humble beginnings, and we have come so far. Lives have been saved and changed forever. Not just for us drunks, but for all of the people we love (and for those who love us). We were supposed to be hopeless and destined to ruin. But our founders stumbled upon grace—the grace of one drunk helping another. And out of that grace came our Steps, Traditions, and Concepts. We had a lot of help, but we listened and accepted. It is a miracle that this little flame has grown so much. But, while we celebrate, we must not lose sight of the work that we still have to do: to expand upon our spirit of diversity and to make all who suffer from alcoholism feel welcome.

I have laughed on this journey, I have gotten mad, I have cried, and I have been sad very few times, but above all, I have lived life to the fullest. With this ideal, the Conference invites me to celebrate, but with responsibility. I know that we have done wonderful things together, but there is still more to do, so we can't forget that there is a legacy to follow.

My heart is full of blessings and of gratitude for this opportunity. Thinking back on when I took my first drink, to my last, this journey has been the most remarkable that I have ever taken in my life. I know that it will be extremely hard to pay A.A. back, because the more I try to pay with service, more blessings arrive and the debt continues to grow.

I would like to conclude by saying that I will be greatly thankful for the rest of my life. I love Alcoholics Anonymous, and I thank you for my life and for my sobriety. Service is a Legacy of Love.

Cesar Flores, Mid-Southern California



Safety and Respect — Practicing the Principles Begins in Our Home Group

Greetings and warm wishes from Hudson/Mohawk/Berkshire, Area 48, which covers much of Upstate New York. This topic on "Safety and Respect — Practicing the Principles Begins in Our Home Group" is especially pertinent in our area now, and has been for several years. As a brand-new delegate I started receiving calls from D.C.M.s to come to their district meetings to help with issues of safety (usually disruptive behavior by an attendee at the meeting), and while it has been useful to discuss this at the district level, the resolution of each issue has happened at the groups' business meetings. There is only a brief mention in the pamphlet "The A.A. Group" on how to handle situations like this, but it does say "Almost every group problem can be solved through the process of an informed group conscience." ("The A.A. Group," p. 31)

Sometimes coming up with solutions has been difficult. At an LGBT meeting a young woman reported to group members that she was accosted in the hallway outside the meeting room and "forcibly groped" by a man who had followed her out of the meeting. She was adamant that she did not want the police called. At the group conscience meeting, that was attended by 36 concerned members, we identified the issues, and every member had a chance to express his or her thoughts and concerns. Initially the consensus was that the group couldn't do anything that would be punitive, citing "tolerance," but as more members spoke it was awesome to watch the minority opinion prevail, and soon the consensus was that, for the safety of all who attend the meeting, something had to be done to prevent further incidents. Two members volunteered to speak to the man who accosted the woman, one member volunteered to write up a statement to be read at the beginning of the meeting, and another volunteered to speak to the police about how to handle such a situation in the future. (We did refer to the *Box 4-5-9*, Fall 2010, article on "A.A. and the Law," noting "we are not above the law.")

In my own home group, we had increased incidents of inappropriate language being used and this led to two women getting up and walking out during a meeting. (One returned at the end of the meeting and said she would never attend this meeting again, citing disrespect and lack of safety.) We had a business meeting and came up with a statement to read at the beginning of each meeting. Some of the members felt that the statement was too harsh and judgmental, but we did forge this: "In keeping with our singleness of purpose we ask that the topic be about alcoholism and recovery. The group conscience of this group is that our language should reflect respect for ourselves and one another, especially for newcomers, not only because we are at an A.A. meeting, but because we are meeting in a church. Part of recovery through the spiritual principles of our program is becoming mindful of the use of profanity and language that some might find offensive."

I had occasion to attend a Treatment Facility meeting at the psychiatric center, a meeting we had started with the Special Needs committee. This weekly meeting is very important to the patients who attend and they know the staff can opt to shut down if it becomes harmful to the patients. After there had been a disturbance, the patients themselves held a group conscience meeting to formulate a statement: "Out of respect for others we ask that you limit your sharing to the topic or reading. If you disrupt the meeting the chairperson will put you out. You can only have one cup of coffee. If there is coffee left at the end of



the meeting you can have another cup if nobody else wants it."

Doesn't seem harsh to me. It seems right to the point as a way to protect the safety of those in attendance and insure that the meeting will continue. Yes, it begins in our home group, but it also begins with each member too. And, in my home group, "I Am Responsible."

Pat Latimer, Hudson/Mohawk/Berkshire (New York)

Safeguarding Our Traditions Through the Evolution of Technology

When I first accepted this loving invitation to present I was stumped. I lost two nights of sleep worrying over what I could possibly say to help guide us for years to come. Armed with a small prayer and faith, I started my journey with some questions. "How have we guarded them up until now?" "What did our founders say?" My search began with my Digital Archives Subscription from the Grapevine; I have always found the answers there. The following is from the June 1951 issue "To Serve Is to Live," by Bill W.

"Our first General Service Conference of Alcoholics Anonymous gathered at New York City in April, 1951. It was composed of 37 U.S. and Canadian delegates plus A.A.'s General Service Headquarters staff and trustees. The single purpose of our Conference was to serve A.A. throughout the world.

"This unexciting statement now carries a deep meaning for all who were there. We came to believe that A.A.'s future had been made secure. We became certain that A.A. could live for so long as God might need us."

Why did each witness of the Conference feel so deeply about it? I think for two reasons: The group conscience of all Alcoholics Anonymous was heard to speak for the first time. And we realized, as never before, how perilous "faith without works" might really become. So it was that A.A.'s group conscience heard its first high call to service.

"Making this plainer, let's look for a moment at a single A.A. member. Faith alone does not Save him. He has to act, do something. He must carry his message to others, practice A.A. principles in all his affairs, else he slips, he withers and he dies. Look now at an A.A. group. Can pure faith, mere belief in right principle and sound tradition, make the Group a going concern? Not in the least. Each A.A. group, as such, must also function, do something. It must serve its appointed purposes or it, too, withers and falls apart.

"Now our Conference delegates were able to apply this principle to A.A. as a whole. The delegates could see far beyond the

single A.A. and his particular group. In a flash, they took in the stark fact that A.A. as a *whole* must continue to function or else it might well suffer that common penalty of faith without works, which is disintegration. Gone was the comfortable illusion that should each A.A. group tend strictly to its own affairs God would then reward our shortsightedness by guarding A.A. as a whole entirely by himself—including our Headquarters, A.A.'s public relations, and the welfare of the millions who still don't know. The delegates saw that this would spell faith without work and without responsibility, that could never be. Of course much works would always have to be done, much responsibility would have to be taken by many. To A.A. as a whole, every member would need to give a little.

"Of age now, our Fellowship would have to begin looking after its own vital services; these couldn't be thoughtlessly left in the sole custody of our isolated, unknown and unsupported board of trustees. The work of our Foundation and A.A.'s "GHQ" would have to become widely understood and directly backed up by A.A. itself. Nothing was plainer, thought the delegates. When, therefore, you next see your local Conference member, you may find him talking something like this:

"Thanks for sending me to New York. I've just spent three days at A.A.'s World Headquarters. Our trustees, General Office and Grapevine people turned the place inside out so we delegates might vision its past, present, and future. What we saw and felt was startling.

"Very suddenly we got the feeling of A.A. as a whole. We looked out upon a Fellowship of surpassing unity, one on which the sun never sets, a world communion four thousand times larger than a single A.A. group.

"We then realized that this wonder had been made possible by the devoted service of a few; those Headquarters workers whose decade and more of labor had enabled us in distant fields to garner that great harvest of 120,000 fellow sufferers into the safety of our fold, and into the affectionate respect of the whole world. Our unseen servants at the Foundation had done all this because Dr. Bob and Bill had asked them to.

"But now they were saying to us delegates, 'Soon you must lend a hand. These are A.A.'s arms of service, these are our Traditions. Come and help us administer them; times have changed, we oldsters are perishable. This is your Legacy of Service. Please accept it now and guard it well.'"

On its next pages, Grapevine will report our Conference in some detail. So I paragraph here only a little of what I know the delegates carried home in their hearts.

"The Conference scene that Sunday afternoon we last met will always be a precious memory in the annals of A.A. For in that historic assemblage we could all hear the voice of Alcoholics Anonymous. These were the words, 'To serve A.A. is to live. We gladly accept our Third Legacy and may we guard it well and use it wisely. God grant that the Legacy of Service remain ever safe in our keeping.'

"In that final hour the torch of Service did pass from the hands of us who are older to yours, which are younger; it passed to every oncoming generation of those children of the night whose darkness, God willing, shall be banished within the Society of Alcoholics Anonymous all through the bright years which destiny surely holds in store for us."

You can ask yourself, "Why are we here this week?" Sure we are here to do the business set before us, but also for Panel 64 delegates to pass the torch to the incoming Panel 65 delegates. Dr. Bob and Bill looked out upon a Fellowship of surpassing unity, one on which the sun never sets. As I look out upon you today I see the same unity. I can hear our founders say, "Soon you must lend a hand. These are A.A.'s arms of service, these are our Traditions. Come and help us administer them; times have

changed and continue to change. This is your Legacy of Service. Please accept it now and guard it well."

Thank you all for allowing me to be one of the Guardians, something that I will cherish for many years to come. I also believe that A.A.'s future has been made secure.

Jim Wilson, Western Ontario

Inventory — Looking Back to Move Ahead

Members of the General Service Conference of Alcoholics Anonymous of the United States and Canada, look at where we are today. We are here at our 65th Annual Meeting to celebrate our first 80 years of Recovery, Unity and Service — The Foundation for Our Future.

Looking back at our past we see that our simple kit of spiritual tools has helped millions of alcoholics to recover. An unbreakable bond of unity has allowed us to trudge side-by-side on the Road of Happy Destiny. In 80 years, we have enjoyed considerable success. With an attitude of joyful gratitude, let us look at where we are today.

Looking back, we see that the General Service Conference has fulfilled its responsibilities remarkably well. Looking ahead, the Conference seeks to be of maximum usefulness as the guardian of our services, Steps and Traditions, and to be the voice and conscience of our Fellowship as a whole. And so, the Conference has undertaken "a fearless inventory of our defects as we go along, the better to undertake their mending." (Bill W., "Responsibility is Our Theme," Grapevine, July 1965.)

We cannot underestimate the importance of this first-ever General Service Conference Inventory. It challenges us to look at how well the Conference functions as the voice and the conscience of our society. It asks us to consider how well the principles of our Twelve Concepts are reflected in Conference actions and composition. It calls upon us to examine how well the Conference maintains communication throughout the Fellowship's structure. It requires us to look at how well the Conference does when selecting A.A.'s leaders today and inspiring its leaders for tomorrow.

But the inventory by itself is mere information — an account of the Conference's assets and liabilities. What happens when the inventory is over is critical to the current and future success of the Conference. To paraphrase the Big Book, "having made an Inventory of the General Service Conference, what shall we do about it? Is the Conference's work then done?" If the General Service Conference Inventory is to have any true impact in helping us move ahead, it must be followed by action.

When I speak of "the Conference" I refer not to our operational structure or this one week in April, but to the people who work within our structure. Look where we are today. *We* are the Conference. It is up to us to begin the process of moving ahead, of putting plans into action.

A comprehensive report of the General Service Conference Inventory will come out later this year. We will do well to study it carefully and accept it with humility and gratitude. We will have a written record of our defects; this will be of great value as we look ahead and make good estimates for the near, and more distant, future.

Knowing that solitary self-appraisal is insufficient, we will gain much by sharing the report—throughout our interconnected circles of love and service. We will benefit greatly by discussing our shortcomings with trusted servants at all levels of our structure. It will give everyone who is willing the opportunity to help create plans for the betterment of our Conference. Let us involve and inspire our leaders of tomorrow as they continue the challenging assignment we have only just begun.

Delegates, directors, trustees and staff members of A.A. World Services and Grapevine are the General Service Conference. Taking its inventory means we also take our own. As Bill saw it 50 years ago, "In so surveying our Society of Today, I hope that I shall not be regarded as the wise and righteous elder who would admonish and exhort his fellows. If I inventory A.A.'s shortcomings, be also assured that I am also taking stock of my own. I know that my errors of yesterday still have their effect; that my shortcomings of today may likewise affect our future. So it is, with each and all of us." (*ibid*)

As we look at where we are today, celebrating 80 years of Recovery, Unity and Service, let us also celebrate our General Service Conference Inventory. We have begun a journey of strengthening our foundation and moving ahead towards the future. Above all, as we look at where we are today, let us be mindful that our Conference succeeds because of "...the spiritual power that flows from the activities and attitudes of truly humble, unselfish and dedicated A.A. servants." (*The A.A. Service Manual/ Twelve Concepts for World Service*, p. 62)

"For so long as we shall humbly meditate in this spirit upon our great yesterdays, just so long will God grant us our vision of tomorrow." (Bill W., "The Vision of Tomorrow," Grapevine, January 1952)

Cathi Clark, Southern Indiana

FINANCE REPORT

Monday afternoon, the Finance report, followed by questions and sharing, was given by David Morris, treasurer of the General Service Board and chairman of the trustees' Finance and Budgetary Committee. Slides referenced in this report are not included in this publication, but are available upon request. For more details please see the finance section of this Report, as well as the trustees' Finance and Budgetary report.

Good afternoon. My name is David Morris and I am a Class A trustee and treasurer of the General Service Board. It is my privilege to deliver the treasurer's report to the 65th General Service Conference of Alcoholics Anonymous or, as it is more commonly referred to, "Finance Around the Picnic Table," the phrase coined at the 59th Conference.

That phrase means that much of the finance discussion during Conference is "preaching to the choir." As always, what we need is better communications about what finance really means when members talk about it around the euphemistic picnic table before and after meetings. Clear and concise communication is the key. Although our finances have grown much more complex, remember that Corporate Poverty is more a state of mind, rather than the size of our bank account. "Too much — and we argue over perilous wealth and lose sight of our primary purpose of carrying the message. Too little — and we risk losing the ability to carry the message at all."

As the agenda indicates, we will review the Fellowships' self-support efforts; the service activities of the General Service Office; the publishing activities of A.A. World Services, A.A. Grapevine and La Viña; the Pension Plan Obligation; and the Reserve Fund. During the next few minutes we will discuss 2014 actual results compared to 2013 actual results, 2014 actual results compared to 2014 budget, take a look at the 2015 budgets, and discuss thoughts for 2016 and beyond.

Slide 2 Based on your very constructive feedback on my finance presentation at last year's General Service Conference and at several Regional Forums, I have substantially revamped this year's presentation to make it clearer but, unfortunately, lon-

ger. Since it is shared throughout the Fellowship, it was pointed out that each slide should be able to stand on its own and not have the benefit of my commentary from the podium. Further, the slides should better consider the broad range of backgrounds and understanding of the members throughout the Fellowship. Thus, for each subject, I have first tried to present a simplified overview discussing the item so that all members will understand the key takeaway concept and then have several detailed background slides for those members who are more passionate about the subject and want to know every detail.

Today, we will focus on eleven key numbers in 2014 highlighted in yellow on this slide:

- Self-support contributions – \$6,898,068
- G.S.O. general fund total expenses – \$9,725,210
- G.S.O. general fund loss – \$2,827,107
- A.A.W.S. total revenue – \$16,872,671
- A.A.W.S. net income – \$4,203,763
- Grapevine net sales – \$3,012,463
- Grapevine net income – \$325,827
- La Viña net sales – \$134,809
- General Fund support of La Viña – \$132,026
- Reserve Fund – \$14,094,966
- Coverage ratio – 9.8 months

However, if I fail in my mission, then Don Meurer, chief financial officer of the General Service Office, Eugene O'Brien, controller of Grapevine, and I will be available throughout the week for your questions. Our goal is to help you become familiar with A.A.'s financial position so that you can communicate clearly to your areas. Enhancing your understanding of our finances is one sure way to improve the service structure. Your areas will be listening carefully to what you report after the Conference, so let us know what we can do to enhance that.

Slide 3 emphasizes the importance of the Seventh Tradition and self-support.

Slide 4 shows that the General Service Office received contributions of \$6,898,068 in 2014, compared to \$6,906,371 in 2013, a minor decrease of approximately \$8,303. The 2014 actual contributions received were \$101,932, or 1.5%, less than the 2014 budget of \$7,000,000. 82,927 actual contributions were received during 2014, 3,564 more than the 79,363 contributions received during 2013. The \$6,898,068 is one of the key numbers highlighted in yellow on **Slide 2**.

Slide 5 shows the 30-year history of generally increasing dollar contributions. However, as the chart shows, there has essentially been little or no growth in our contributions over the last several years.

Slide 6 is a chart of the percentage of groups that contribute to G.S.O. It shows that only 41.6% of the groups contributed in 2014, specifically 27,103 contributing groups out of 65,222 total groups. The bad news is that the proportion of contributing groups is at an all-time low of 41.6%.

Slide 7 combines the two previous slides of the 30 year history of the dollar contributions and the percentage of groups that contribute to G.S.O., the line with red square boxes running across the slide with the percentages on the right side.

Slide 8 As you are aware, the A.A.W.S. Finance Subcommittee on Self-Support has worked diligently during the past several years towards a goal of developing sustainable self-support initiatives. With the ever-present possibility that print media sales might decline in the future, it is vital that the Fellowship fully embrace the Seventh Tradition. Delegates, other trusted servants and G.S.O. staff have offered many creative and practical ways to communicate the message of the need for self-support, and we are grateful for everyone's participation. Popular efforts have

been the restoration of our November Gratitude Month and also to focus on the use of Birthday Envelopes. The answer to self-support may very well be in sustained communication — and it is here where we continue to need your help and suggestions.

We are grateful for every member who contributes to his or her local group, as a portion of those monies do work their way up to G.S.O., helping ensure that G.S.O. has the necessary resources to continue providing the services that our members and groups are seeking. A special word of thanks goes out to all the delegates, D.C.M.s, and G.S.R.s, who have worked to help make this possible. And I hope information from this Conference will help assist in your communication about self-support around the picnic table and why a single dollar put into the basket today at a meeting is no longer enough.

Slide 9 pictorially illustrates how the value of one dollar has changed from the early days of A.A. up to modern times. It shows that the \$1.00 cup of coffee in 1945 or \$1.00 placed in the Seventh Tradition basket in 1945 is now equivalent to \$13.00 today.

Slide 10 is the detail that supports the prior slide. What does it cost today to support those same services from an earlier time. A one-dollar service then costs \$13.00 today. Another way to think about this, what was the price of a drink when you stopped drinking and what is it today? So remember, “A dollar ain’t what it used to be.”

Slide 11 transitions us to our service structure.

Slide 12 is a repeat of Slide 2 and highlights our next topic, the cost of providing service to the Fellowship. In 2014, it was \$9,725,210 and is highlighted in yellow.

Slide 13 details the direct cost of each of the major service functions performed at the General Service Office for the last three years. The total cost of all G.S.O. service functions was \$9,725,210 in 2014, compared to \$9,507,582 in 2013, an increase of \$217,628, or 2.29%. Most of the individual service functions were essentially even or flat in 2014 compared to 2013, but I will highlight a few differences. In 2014, the General Service Conference was held in Rye, New York, compared to midtown New York City in 2013, which explains the decrease from \$906,376 in 2013 to \$796,593 in 2014. We had the World Service Meeting in Warsaw, Poland, in 2014 and the net cost, which falls to G.S.O., was \$158,569. There was no such meeting in 2013. Finally, there is \$262,917 of costs incurred during 2014 for the upcoming International Convention in Atlanta in July 2015. We are all familiar with the remaining functions listed. Public Information, Corrections, Archives, to name just a few, with the possible exception of the last caption entitled Supporting Services. For 2014, the amount is \$3,182,273. This includes the administration, finance, human resources, information technology, rent, and other indirect overhead costs. It would not be possible for the major service functions listed to operate without these support services.

Slide 14 is a bar chart of selected major service functions and their 2014 costs.

Slide 15 is similar to prior direct cost slide, except that the cost of Supporting Services, for example, \$3,182,273 in 2014, has been allocated back across all of the service functions to determine the fully absorbed cost of each activity. The 2014 direct costs of Group Service were \$2,405,615, but were increased to \$3,575,627, when they were allocated an additional \$1,170,012, of their share of Supporting Services. The total of \$9,725,210 in 2014 on this slide is exactly equal to the total of \$9,725,210 on Slide 13.

Slide 16 breaks down the first line of the preceding slide entitled Group Service (fully allocated) of \$3,575,627 in 2014 into its various component services. This slide provides a broader understanding of the extraordinary range of services performed by the

G.S.O. on behalf of all of the groups across the U.S. and Canada, such as *Box 4-5-9*, Records, Translations, etc. A complete list of activities is available on the AA.org website.

Slide 17 is the detailed analysis of the General Service Conference covering the past four years and has been included simply because this is the number-one question that I received during the past year. The slide shows all of the costs and delegate and area contributions. The 2014 direct costs of \$796,593 agrees back to the amount listed on Functional Expenses — Direct Costs on **Slide 13** and the \$1,184,031 agrees back to the amount listed on Group Service Activities — Fully Absorbed on **Slide 15**.

Slide 18 provides a numerical breakdown by function of the 81 General Service Office employees who perform all of the work. This is another question that is frequently asked.

Slide 19 calculates the shortfall of \$2,827,142, which is the difference between contributions received of \$6,898,068 and cost of the services provided of \$9,725,210. Thus, only 70.9% of the cost of services was covered in 2014, compared to 72.6% in 2013.

Slide 20 displays the 70.9% for 2014 along with the percentage of services covered by contributions for all years since 2000. As is evident from this chart, there is a shortfall every year.

Slide 21 displays key member statistics. This is an entirely new slide. To be honest, I found the old slide that had been used for a number of years confusing and difficult for me to easily convey the message to you. Thus, I have completely revamped this version. It shows the same information, but in a more understandable form, at least to me. How do we arrive at these numbers? They are simple calculations from the amounts shown on our financial statements on **Slide 2** and **Slide 19** divided by the number of members and groups shown on the Contribution Statistical Report. Please remember that those numbers are only as good as the data we can capture in an Anonymous Fellowship system.

Specifically, using the 2014 cost of services provided of \$9,725,210, we can calculate that cost of services provided is \$7.08 per member, or \$149.10 per group. Using the 2014 contributions of \$6,898,068, we can calculate self-support per member of \$5.02, or per group of \$105.76. As can be seen, the costs of services provided are *not* fully covered through self-support is \$2.06 per member and \$43.35 per group.

In addition, this key member statistics slide has three new pieces of information at the bottom. Since I have previously noted that only 27,103 groups, or 41.6%, actually contribute towards Seventh Tradition Self-Support, we now show an average amount contributed by those contributing groups of \$254.51 in 2014.



Slide 22 reconciles the total expenses of \$25,354,689 on **Slide 2** and other expenses, numbers that are contained in the various financial statements and this presentation to the cost of service of \$9,725,210, so that you can see how they all relate to each other. This slide is solely for the true accountants in the Fellowship.

Slide 23 moves us to A.A.W.S. publishing activities and literature profits.

Slide 24 summarizes the financial performance of publishing in 2014 compared to 2013. Net sales of literature were \$16,872,671 in 2014, compared to \$12,605,109 in 2013, an increase of \$4,267,562, or 33.9% more. After deducting the cost of literature sold; costs of shipping and warehousing; program expenses; and supporting expenses, A.A.W.S. publishing had an Excess of Revenue over Expenses or Net Profit of \$4,203,763 in 2014, compared to \$2,632,651 in 2013, an increase of \$1,571,112, or 59.7%. Both \$16,872,671 and \$4,203,763 were highlighted in yellow on **Slide 2**.

Slide 25 is a reconciliation of the major items that caused 2014 revenues to increase by \$4,268,098, from \$12,841,973 in 2013 to \$17,128,071 in 2014. Specifically, the 75th Anniversary Big Book contributed \$1,888,880, the estimate of the 3rd quarter 2014 bulk purchases made prior to the October 1, 2014 literature price increase contributed \$2,000,000, and incremental 2014 sales activity over 2013 contributed \$397,218.

Slide 26 provides background on the General Service Conference's prior involvement with the 75th Anniversary Big Book and the reasons underlying the decision to produce the book and the inventory write down.

Slide 27 details the gross revenue earned from the sale of 177,888 copies of the 75th Anniversary Big Book that generated \$1,888,880 in gross revenues. From this amount was deducted the cost to produce the book of \$904,032 and inventory write down of \$823,152, resulting in a net profit on the book of \$161,696. It should be noted that this \$161,696 net profit is just 3.8% of the 2014 Excess of Revenue over Expenses, or Net Profit of \$4,203,763, which shows that the 75th Anniversary Big Book was not a significant contributor to 2014 positive results. Also, the write off of \$823,152 is included in the \$4,928,491 in the financial statement caption entitled "cost of literature sold" shown in **Slide 24**. The inclusion of this write down is why the gross profit percentage of 58.6% in 2014 is so much lower than the similar percentage in 2013 of 64.3%.

Nearly 90% of the 177,888 75th Anniversary Books sold were sold in the first half of 2014. Given these initial sales, a reorder was made in the late spring or early summer to print more books. However, in the second half of 2014, sales of the 75th Anniversary Book suddenly and dramatically dropped to around 3,000 or less per month. First quarter 2015 sales are even lower, with only 3,800 books being sold. Given this massive decline in sales volume, generally accepted accounting principles required A.A. to examine its year-end inventory levels of 165,000 printed and completed books, along with its work-in-progress inventory, and determine whether a write down of accounting value was necessary for slow moving and/or obsolescent items. It was determined that 125,000 completed 75th Anniversary Books, along with the work-in-process, required a write down in accounting value, leaving 40,000 books in inventory in our December 31, 2014 balance sheet. This was deemed a reasonable level of inventory, given 2015 sales projections considering 2015 International Convention. All of this was done with the full involvement and concurrence of our Independent Auditors.

Finally, if we are fortunate enough to sell all of the 40,000 books in inventory, we can also sell the 125,000 books that for accounting purposes were written off. These written-off books for accounting purposes are all available for sale, with each of

these books sold being additional revenue and profit to A.A. in the future.

Slide 28 provides history on prior literature price increase.

Slide 29 was created to help put into perspective the October 1, 2014 price increase of the Big Book from \$8.00 to \$9.50. The decision for the price increase was fully vetted at both the A.A.W.S. and G.S.B. board meetings. In both cases, it was agreed that for the long-term viability of A.A. additional revenue is needed to maintain the level of service that the Fellowship has come to expect and is continuing to seek. I created this slide to help put in perspective that even at \$9.50 the Big Book today is still a bargain compared to what it has sold for over the past 75 years.

Slide 30 provides the principle literature titles sold both in number of items and their dollars in 2014 and 2013. The fascinating point of this slide, besides the sheer number of Big Books and the other titles listed that continue to be sold each year, is the information included in the footnotes: 68 translations of the Big Book with 13 pending, along with publications in 87 languages.

Slide 31 shows number of the Big Books sold during the last two decades.

Slide 32 is 2014 actual results compared to 2014 budget. The principle reason for the increase of actual over budget in publishing revenue is that more 75th Anniversary Big Books were sold than budgeted and the size of the bulk purchases of all literature prior to the October 1, 2014 price increase was much larger than budgeted.

Slide 33 illustrates how the \$2,827,107 shortfall between contributions revenue and the cost of service provided is covered by the profit from literature sales of \$4,203,763, resulting in a net of \$1,376,656 for 2014. This net compares to \$31,544 in 2013.

Slide 34 provides the historical net results since 2002 of the General Service Office, showing \$1,376,656 for 2014.

Slide 35 is 2015 budget compared to 2014 actual results for A.A.W.S. publishing activities, which is down substantially from 2014. The 2015 net literature profits of \$3,568,089 will again be used to offset the shortfall between the 2015 budgeted cost of service of \$10,370,964 and 2015 budgeted contributions of \$7,000,000, resulting in a net budgeted profit of \$197,125 in 2015. Please note that to simplify this slide, I have purposely not included the last three numbers just mentioned, but they are in **Slide 65** when we get back to the 2015 budget discussion.



Slide 36 transitions us to A.A. Grapevine.

Slide 37 displays the net profit or loss of Grapevine over the last 13 years, especially the very excellent operating results of \$315,205 in 2013 and \$325,827 in 2014.

Slide 38 displays the continuous long-term downward trend of magazine subscriptions over the past two decades. This downward trend actually started back in 1989 and is essentially a 4% – 5% per year decline. 2014 printed subscription levels were down to 74,000.

Slide 39 shows that Grapevine had reported total magazine income of \$2,230,375 in 2014, compared to \$2,242,363 in 2013, a decrease of \$11,988. The decline in magazine income mirrors the continued decline in print subscriptions, which is shown at the top of the slide. On the positive side, other publishing income was \$782,088 in 2014, compared to \$776,976 in 2013, an increase of \$5,112.

When we subtract the cost of goods sold and delivery costs, along with the three operating expenses listed, this results in \$325,827 of excess of revenue over expenses in 2014. This compares to \$315,205 for 2013, an increase of \$10,622. This increase is due to the continued positive results achieved in other publishing activities and expense saving generated in both editorial costs, and general and administrative costs.

Finally, if you add magazine income of \$2,230,375 and the other publishing revenue of \$782,088, these two numbers equal \$3,012,463, which is one of the key numbers that I highlighted on Slide 2. The other Grapevine number on this slide and Slide 2 is the excess of revenue over expenses of \$325,827.

Slide 40 summarizes Grapevine's actual financial performance in 2014 compared to 2014 budget. In summary, Grapevine had an excess of revenue over expenses of \$325,827, compared to \$98,241 in the 2014 budget, an increase of \$227,586. This is due primarily to \$130,242 of additional revenue and \$101,057 of savings in operating expenses, when compared to budget.

Slide 41 provides the principle titles of Grapevine's other publishing income of \$782,088 in 2014 and illustrates how publishing of *The Language of the Heart* and other such titles have contributed significantly to Grapevine's continued profitability by offsetting the continuing decline in magazine subscriptions.

Slide 42 is a new slide developed to explicitly show that the contribution percentage of Other Publishing Revenue to total Grapevine revenue has remained relatively flat over the last several years and has NOT grown like some in the Fellowship have contended.

Slide 43 sets forth the 2015 budget compared to 2014 actual results. The 4% – 5% decline in the basic Grapevine subscriptions is projected to continue, but it is offset by continued strong other publishing income. Net publishing revenues are down by \$99,937. However, when expense growth is considered, Grapevine is projecting an operating loss of \$14,606 in 2015.

Slide 44 moves us to our Spanish-language magazine, La Viña, and shows the subscription history since its launch in 1997.

Slide 45 shows the financial results of La Viña. Gross profit from the sale of magazines and related items was \$69,778, an increase of \$6,244 from 2013. After deducting the costs and expenses of \$201,804, the result was a net shortfall between revenue and expenses of \$132,026. This compares to similar shortfalls of \$142,544 in 2013 and \$115,820 in 2012. However, on the negative side, subscriptions are projected to decline to 9,860 in 2015 from 10,380 in 2014. This results in a much larger budgeted shortfall of \$159,457 in 2015, an increase of \$27,431, or 21%, compared to 2014 actual.

Slide 46 Remember that La Viña's deficits are paid for or subsidized initially by the Reserve Fund or then the General Fund, which houses all contributions received from the Fellowship. Since 1996, the cumulative difference or shortfall between reve-

nue earned and expense of providing this service is nearly \$1.7 million.

Slide 47 is my pitch to subscribe to Grapevine and La Viña. It only costs 8 cents a day for Grapevine and 3 cents a day for La Viña.

Finally, the special subcommittee of the trustees' Finance and Budgetary Committee, chaired by Class B trustee Clayton V. from the Southwest Region, finished its work on looking at how La Viña should be reported to the General Service Board and the Fellowship. In summary, after giving consideration to the various previous General Service Conference actions and preferences voiced over the years, the subcommittee agreed that the activities should be shown, just as I have shown you in the preceding slides. That is, to maintain the accountability to the Fellowship, both revenues earned from subscriptions sold and all expenses required to produce La Viña, should be disclosed, along with the net shortfall that this service results in, and that this shortfall should simply be called the "shortfall between revenue and expenses." Then, the amount of the transfer from the General Fund should be disclosed to show the additional cost of this service. Finally, the use of the term "net loss" or "net exposure" should no longer be used in reporting to the Fellowship, except where it is required either for generally accepted accounting purposes or for U.S. federal tax reporting.

Slide 48 illustrates the 2014 transfer of \$1.5 million from the Reserve Fund to the Pension Plan fund and provides a segue into the topic of the Pension Plan.

Slide 49 lists the benefits of the 2014 transfer of \$1.5 million from the Reserve Fund to the Pension Plan. The transfer had the positive impact on both operating corporations of lowering the total 2014 cash pension costs to \$1,690,100 from \$2,105,000 in 2013; specifically, saving \$373,000 for A.A.W.S. and \$42,000 for Grapevine. Also, the total 2015 pension expense for both operating corporations will be \$1,500,000 and should continue to be at this level over the next several years, assuming no dramatic market events. The transfer was projected to have a negative effect of lowering the Reserve Fund Ratio to 9.4 months.

Slide 50 shows the pension plan assets and liabilities for the last three years, specifically with the 2014 liability increasing to \$36.1 million from \$27.7 million.

By way of background, A.A. established a Defined Benefit Pension Program for its employees in 1965. Last year, we reported on the transitioning from a Defined Benefit Plan to a Defined Contribution Plan for new A.A.W.S. and G.V. employees. This was accomplished with a new Defined Contribution Plan established January 1, 2013 for new employees hired subsequent to January 1, 2013. Over the very long-term, this change will have the effect of capping the Pension Plan obligations and over time reducing the ongoing cost. These obligations are funded out of A.A.W.S. and Grapevine current operations and now account for about 9%-10% of the G.S.O. operating expense budget, down from 12% in 2013.

Slide 51 The next three slides are for the accountants and actuaries in the Fellowship. This slide outlines some of the various rules and regulations that A.A.'s defined benefit pension plan is subject to and that have to be considered annually. As you are aware, the Moving Ahead for Progress in the 21st Century Act and admonitions of our Independent Auditors brought to the forefront of our recent finance discussions the continuing need to focus on our long-term obligations for post employment commitments to current employees and retirees, for both pension and postretirement medical benefits. Our benefit plans are periodically reviewed, but remember that as long as G.S.O. remains in business, pension benefits, which have already accrued, cannot be changed.

Slide 52 provides details of the size and complexion of the defined benefit plan showing the number of employees (84 in

2014) and retirees (115 in 2014) covered along with the related average salary and benefits payable over the next 5 years (\$1,577,133 in 2015 and increasing thereafter). These future benefits payable amounts are projected to be greater than the cash contributions being put into the plan, so if future market returns are not robust enough to make up the difference, we could be in a situation where we might need to increase future pension contributions. Also, the slide shows the demographics of the plan populations and why this pension obligation will be with us for a very long time.

Slide 53 reconciles the “ins and outs” of the Pension Plan obligations or liabilities at the top of the slide and the Pension Plan assets at the bottom of the slide. This slide illustrates the extreme volatility of numbers that goes into determining the annual pension expense. The decline in the discount rate from 4.76% to 3.89% during 2014 resulted in a net \$8,395,645 increase in the projected benefit obligations or liabilities from \$27,658,491 to \$36,054,136 at December 31, 2014. The positive upward movement of the stock market in 2014 resulted in an annual investment gain of \$1,758,870, or 7.3% growth. The net of these items resulted in the increase in the unfunded status from \$3,569,738 in 2013 to \$8,205,766 in 2014.

Slide 54 shows the long-term liabilities or obligations, assets in trust funds that are specifically earmarked for these liabilities, and the resulting net unfunded status of both our pension plan and retiree medical plan. The net exposure increased from \$6.6 million at December 31, 2013 to \$12.5 million at December 31, 2014. This net increased exposure was the result of the interest rate used to discount the retirement liabilities or obligations decreasing from 4.76% at December 31, 2013 to 3.89% at December 31, 2014. This negative was offset by the positive upward trend of the stock market and the \$1.5 million Reserve Fund transfer, which translated into plan assets growing \$4.1 million or 15% in 2014.

Slide 55 transitions us to the Reserve Fund.

Slide 56 defines the Reserve Fund Ratio as the number of months that the Reserve Fund could cover the operating expenses of the two operating corporations. Refer to footnote 1 on Slide 22, Reconciliation of Expenses, to find and understand which expense amounts are used for this calculation.

Slide 57 shows the relationship between the Fellowship, G.S.O. and the Reserve Fund. To pay its bills and fund obligations, the General Service Office has only two sources of money: contributions and literature sales. At the end of each year, any cash more than necessary to pay bills on time is transferred to the Reserve Fund. Because 2014 results of \$1,376,656 were positive, G.S.O./A.A.W.S. was able to contribute and transfer \$1,200,000 to the Reserve Fund in early 2015.

Slide 58 shows the relationship between the Fellowship, Grapevine and the Reserve Fund. To pay its bills and fund obligations, Grapevine has only one source of money — subscriptions and literature sales. At the end of each year, any cash more than is necessary to pay bills on time is transferred to the Reserve Fund. Similar to last year, Grapevine's positive operating results in 2014 allowed it to contribute and transfer \$240,000 from its operating accounts to the Reserve Fund in early 2015. This \$240,000 compares to \$260,000 for last year.

Slide 59 shows the Reserve Fund ratio from 1989 to 2014, from a low of 7.5 months in 1989 to a high of 12.4 months in 1994. At December 31, 2014, the ratio is 9.8 months. You may recall a Conference Action recommending that the Reserve Fund be maintained between 9 and 12 months.

Slide 60 provides a reconciliation of how we arrived at the actual 9.8 months and various Reserve Fund ratios that you may have come across. The Reserve Fund ended 2014 with a balance of \$14,094,966, equal to 9.8 months of operating expenses

of \$17,337,255. Again, this expense amount can be found on **Slide 22** and footnote 1 on that slide. The Reserve Fund of \$14,094,966 at December 31, 2014 is down from \$15,301,653 at December 31, 2013, primarily because of the 2014 transfer out of \$1,500,000 to the Pension Fund, offset by the 2014 inflow of the Grapevine's contribution of \$260,000 for its 2013 results. The 9.8 months at December 31, 2014 is slightly better than the estimated 2014 budgeted amount of 9.4 months included in my finance presentation last year, because 2014 actual operating expenses were less than 2014 budgeted operating expenses.

In the interest of complete transparency, if we assume that the transfers of the \$1,200,000 for G.S.O./A.A.W.S. and \$240,000 for Grapevine could have occurred before December 31, 2014 so the Reserve Fund was a hypothetical \$15,534,966 (instead of its real balance of \$14,094,966), then the projected or pro forma ratio would have a 10.8, using 2014 operating expenses. This number is used by some when discussing the Reserve Fund.

For the 2015 budget, we start with Reserve Fund at December 31, 2014 of \$14,094,966 and add the \$1,200,000 contribution from G.S.O./A.A.W.S. and the \$240,000 contribution from Grapevine, both made in early 2015, so the Reserve Fund increases to \$15,534,966. Then, we compare the adjusted \$15,534,966 to the 2015 budgeted operating expenses of \$18,627,000 and this results in a budgeted ratio of 10.0 months. However, we then must subtract out \$1,300,000 (the maximum authorized by the General Service Board for the cost of relocating Grapevine to the 11th floor and reconfiguring the 11th floor for various other efficiency moves) from the Reserve Fund, and this results in a budgeted ratio of 9.2 months for year-end 2015.

Finally, our Independent Auditors have affirmed that the Reserve Fund is in fact adequate for the short-term and long-term obligations for which it is intended.

Slide 61 shows the so-called “ownership details” of the General Service Board Reserve Fund for the last four year, along with 2015 budget. For many, the 2014 statistics of \$216.10 equivalent balance per group, or \$10.26 equivalent balance per member, are an easier way of discussing the Reserve Fund around the picnic table.

Slide 62 summarizes the investment guidelines of the Reserve Fund and shows the balance of \$14,094,966 and annual interest earned of \$33,313 in 2014. These guidelines severely limit the types of eligible investments, resulting in a rate of return for both 2014 and 2013 that was less than 1.0%.

Slide 63 is the same slide that I used last year to provide budget information on the 2015 International Convention in Atlanta, with comparisons to the prior four International Conventions and the actual results. The General Services Board approved both the overall budget and per person registration fees at its February 3, 2014 meeting. The Atlanta budget continues to be on target.

Slide 64 repeats the original Slide 2 showing the 2014 actual results, along with the 2014 budgets. Its purpose is to recap all of the 2014 information that I have just presented you today and to provide a bridge to the next slide, which details the 2015 budgets.

Slide 65 is simply the accumulation of the 2015 budgets for each of the operating corporations that I have presented. It projects a combined 2015 profit of only \$23,000. The trustees' Finance & Budgetary Committee and the General Service Board approved these amounts at our February 2015 meeting. Please rest assured that we continue to closely monitor the financial budgets, estimates and projections always with an eye towards fiscal prudence. 2015 and future years will undoubtedly be marked with uncertainty and perhaps some surprises due to the continuing volatile economic times.

Slide 66 summarizes the various trends that I have noted



during this presentation. For G.S.O./A.A.W.S., membership, contributions and literature sales are flat or show little growth, but expenses continue to slowly increase. For Grapevine, magazine circulation continues to decline and expenses are slowly increasing. When these trends are considered over the long-term, the General Service Board voted in November 2014 to establish a Feasibility Study Subcommittee to examine the future. I am chairing that subcommittee. It consists of four Class B trustees, Billy N., Chet P., Andrew W and Albin Z., along with both the G.S.O. general manager and the CFO, plus the Grapevine executive editor and the controller. We have no agenda and no direction yet and are still trying to determine how best to reach out to the General Service Conference and the Fellowship to get direction and guidance on what to do with these trends.

Slide 67 is the Feasibility Motion approved by the General Service Board at its November 2, 2014 meeting. "The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc. undertake a comprehensive feasibility study of the current business models, corporate structure, and long-term sustainability of the GSB and both operating Corporations, keeping in mind the Spiritual Basis of Alcoholics Anonymous."

Slide 68 is the self-support and literature policy formally adopted by the General Service Board at its February 3, 2014 meeting. I include it again for your reference, and it provides an excellent transition into my concluding remarks.

Slide 69 I want to acknowledge the extraordinary talent and dedication that I am privileged to observe as treasurer. Thank you to members of all the finance committees of the operating organization, who sort through enormous details throughout the year. Thank you to Phyllis Halliday and Ami Brophy for competently overseeing our operating corporations. And a very special thank you to Don Meurer and Eugene O'Brien, our talented and dedicated finance managers. Likewise, a special thanks to our Independent Auditors, who do an extraordinary job, always exhibiting professionalism and independence. The information included in my slides will be contained in the complete report of our Independent Auditors that will be included in the *Final Conference Report*.

And remember, Finance has no importance in and of itself. Finance is simply a way to help carry the message to the still-suffering alcoholic.

David Morris, Treasurer, General Service Board

G.S.O. RELOCATION STUDY REPORT

Monday afternoon the following summary of the Report was presented.

Summary Presentation to General Service Conference

The 2014 G.S.O. Relocation Study was conducted well ahead of the lease expiration date of December 31, 2018. This was to ensure the present building and city locations remained viable choices for G.S.O. in light of the proposed plan of the co-location of A.A. Grapevine, Inc. and A.A. World Services, Inc. (G.S.O.) offices on the 11th floor. It would also allow sufficient time to consider the issues and needs so as to provide for proper long-range planning. On a broader level, consideration of the office location and the related costs is also connected with the ongoing discussion of self-support and with the review of needs related to the Reserve Fund.

Background of the General Service Office — As indicated in *The A.A. Service Manual* (p. S77), the "national headquarters" that we now call the General Service Office (G.S.O. for short) "...serves all A.A. groups in the United States and Canada, and also offers services to A.A. overseas, especially in countries where there is no service structure... [It] is generally regarded as the 'senior' office." While initially located in Newark, NJ, New York City has been home to G.S.O. since 1940, with the office relocating numerous times. In 1992, the office moved to its current location at The Interchurch Center, 475 Riverside Drive, on the Upper West Side of Manhattan. The Interchurch Center has interesting connections with A.A. history. The nondenominational, nonprofit Interchurch Center is devoted entirely to not-for-profit agencies, and in 2001–2002 won the Pinnacle Award as building of the year for its size category. John D. Rockefeller, Jr., who helped our Fellowship in its early days to embrace the principle of self-support, contributed the land for this building and, through the Rockefeller Foundation, provided funding for its construction. However, we pay our own way as tenants in this building and continue to be guided by the principle of self-support.

Background of Relocation Studies and Related Conference Actions — Relocation studies have been conducted approximately every 10 years, the most recent consisting of the 2005 G.S.O.



Relocation Study These reports were conducted to determine an appropriate venue for the operations of G.S.O. and provide recommendations based on objective factors, such as financial considerations and cost effectiveness and on subjective factors that could impact G.S.O.'s ability to deliver its services to the Fellowship.

First let's go back to the 1977 General Service Conference, which approved the following Advisory Action as a Floor Action.

"It was agreed that, as recommended by the General Service Board, it would not be in the best interest of the Fellowship to relocate the General Service Office at this time."

Dr. Jack Norris, in his report as chairman of the General Service Board, noted that "The board received and approved a report by the A.A.W.S. Office Relocation Study Committee. The report was forwarded to this Conference with the recommendation that the General Service Board feels it would not be in the best interests of the Fellowship to relocate G.S.O. at this time."

He also commented that the General Service Office and the Grapevine have succeeded in keeping operating costs down. This effort to keep operating costs down continues today, almost 40 years later.

1988 Conference Presentation — Relocation Study Report — With the G.S.O. lease for the 475 Park Avenue South location to expire in three years, John Bragg, G.S.O.'s general manager, presented a summary report to the Conference in 1988 on the outcome of studies by the A.A.W.S. and Grapevine Boards and management on the question of future location of those offices. This report has been referred to as the "Fantus Report" after the Fantus Company, a consulting firm for planning and movement of company operations that completed the 1988 study. The full report, which was distributed to the General Service Board and the Conference for review, focused on a number of "objective factors," including recurring and nonrecurring costs, and determined that a significant difference existed between New York and the five other prototype cities in the United States. A second "critical decision element" considered the benefit of availability of professionals in literature, publishing and communications in New York City. Based on this Relocation Study Report, the "A.A.W.S. and Grapevine Boards recommended that the operations remain in the New York area, but that an intensive study be made of ways to reduce current operating costs when the present lease expires in 1991" and to "include the possibility of

the movement of parts of the office to low-cost rental areas, or the entire office to a suburban location."

In 1992, following additional investigation of low-cost office space in New York City, the General Service Office moved to its present location at the Interchurch Center and, in so doing, incurred a relocation cost of about \$3,300,000.

1997 Report — 1996 Ad Hoc Site Review Committee Final Report — This committee was appointed by the chairman of the General Service Board to complete an initial review of the current office site at 475 Riverside Drive, to report its suitability to the board, and to provide any recommendations for change, improvements or other options. While the lease wasn't going to expire until 2001, this review was consistent with the established process whereby sufficient time was allowed to implement the recommendations, particularly if it was to relocate the General Service Office. The committee was selected so as to be geographically diverse, and included Bob Pelot, then a Quebec delegate, who is now the Eastern Canada regional trustee. The Ad Hoc Committee chair, Class A trustee Art Knight, Jr., reported to the Conference just as I am doing today

Having completed its review, the committee made three recommendations to the General Service Board in February 1997 that were unanimously accepted as follows:

- 1 That the site remain in New York City where we have historical roots and a heritage for our spiritual foundation.

2. That the current site at The Interchurch Center be retained, with investigation into early renewal of our lease at current rates. In other words, locking in the favorable rent for a longer period of time.

- 3 That the general manager of the G.S.O., the executive editor of the Grapevine and the staff all continue to look for opportunities to reconfigure office activities and space for further economic savings.

As a result of this review process and the recommendations accepted by the General Service Board, the A.A.W.S. Board approved extending the lease with The Interchurch Center to 2008 and completed capital improvements that included the reconfiguration of space.

In regards to the history and heritage of A.A.'s services, the 1997 Ad Hoc Site Review Committee made the following comment that was also repeated in the current report presented today: "The history of A.A. surrounding the New York area provides an anchor point for our Fellowship. The further we grow away from the days of members who knew our founders, the more we need roots."

2005 Conference Presentation — Relocation Study Report — The 2005 relocation study was prepared by the general manager and G.S.O. employees using the Project Management Office (PMO) approach in order to consider the current needs and to provide information in a timely manner in the event a recommendation was approved to relocate the General Service Office. Using this approach, which for the first time was completed in-house, a project plan and analysis model was created that focused on concrete financial factors, i.e., recurring costs and nonrecurring costs, as well as subjective factors, particularly staff impact and the history and heritage of Alcoholics Anonymous. With this study, the current location was compared with three geographically diverse metropolitan areas. During the review by the A.A.W.S. Board and the General Service Board, the view was expressed that the outcome was a high-quality report that is comparable to previous third party reports.

The following key issues were considered by the A.A.W.S. Board in its review:

- Existing lease expires in December 2008 — Opportunity exists to benefit from current lease rates at whatever location.
- Some capital improvements are needed in the existing office space, i.e., replacement of carpets that would be done at our expense. Better to wait until confirmation of longer-term tenancy at The Interchurch Center,
- The Grapevine, which sublets space from A.A.W.S., is planning to give up 1,500 to 2,000 square feet of space, thus requiring a smaller space of 8,000 to 10,000 square feet.

In reviewing this relocation study, the following key items were summarized:

- The annual difference in operating costs of \$5.1 million at the present location were compared with the three alternative locations, with two being higher and one slightly lower.
- Nonrecurring costs associated with a relocation of the General Service Office to assumed alternative locations ranged from \$6.6 million to \$7.7 million. In all three cases, the two major components of these costs, representing about 68% of the total relocation costs, consist of office construction averaging \$2.3 million and of the same severance cost of \$2.5 million. Costs of moving to a new location would be a significant drain on our current Reserve Fund and reflect a minimum of 44 years to recover these nonrecurring costs.
- Assessing that the current office location meets the current needs of the G.S.O., and finding no concrete financial case for moving from the current location (realizing that the small reduction in recurring costs would be overshadowed by the substantial one-time costs associated with a move) the 2005 Relocation Study report recommendation was not to relocate the General Service Office.

2014 G.S.O. Relocation Study

Methodology — The current relocation study, which you were given to review, was developed by Talley Management Group, an external independent consulting firm, with assistance from G.S.O. management.

The analysis and findings are based upon information gathered from the following sources:

- 2005 Relocation Study.
- A.A.W.S. current financial and operations information.
- Publicly available federal Internet data resources.

Conclusions/Recommendation — The report conclusions are as follows:

1. Although the impact of a potential move is not as costly as it has been determined in the past, a concrete case for moving from the current location cannot be made at this time.
2. The reduction in recurring costs that might be realized in another location (i.e., Indianapolis) is overshadowed by the substantial one-time costs associated with a move.
3. The subjective implications of moving G.S.O. to another city, regardless of cost savings, are significant, considering the history of the office in New York.

Based on these conclusions (and consistent with all previous studies), the recommendation was for the General Service Office to remain in its present New York City location.

William B. Noonan, Trustee and A.A.W.S. Board Chair

2015 INTERNATIONAL CONVENTION

Thursday evening's Presentations were on the upcoming International, "80 Years — Happy, Joyous and Free." The moderator was Ivan Lemelle, Class A trustee.

Welcome to Atlanta!

Thank you for the opportunity to speak on the "2015 International Convention — welcome to Atlanta." Happy, Joyous and Free — Area 16, Georgia, is on fire and we are working hard to be ready to host the world in **70 days!**

The process for the 80th International Convention started in 2002. I remember when I was a G.S.R. in 2004, it was announced that we had been selected to host the 2015 Convention; at the time it seemed so far away. The large meetings will be held in the Georgia Dome, which is the world's largest cable-supported dome stadium. The breakout sessions will be held in the Georgia World Congress Center, which is the second largest convention center in the world.

In January, we had a volunteer kick-off meeting, which incorporated part of the Atlanta drum line with about 1,600 volunteers in attendance, including people from neighboring states.

Over the last several months, our core volunteer committee has kicked into full swing. The chair of the volunteer committee is Patty L., Panel 60 delegate. On our area website, A.A.georgia.org, is the link to the volunteer hub where you can sign up for the area of interest where you would like to volunteer. By the end of March, we had about 2,600 volunteers signed up. Email notices are going out to keep up the excitement. They are branching out to the Southeast region for additional volunteers by attending assemblies and district functions.

On May 17th, we will have the volunteer training session, which will be held at the Georgia World Congress Center. We are in the process of developing the best way to make the training accessible to people who are unable to attend the session or who are volunteering from outside the area.

The goal of our volunteers is for the guests at the Convention to see us on the streets of Atlanta, in the Convention Center, at the Georgia Dome, hotel lobbies, foreign-language desk, all of the major transportation hubs and more. I have personally asked to be a greeter at the airport on Tuesday.

My role as delegate is to host the delegate/trustee luncheon on Saturday, July 4th, which will be held in the Georgia Ballroom at the Georgia World Congress Center. I hope you will join us for the luncheon.

I wanted to provide a few fun facts about Atlanta:

- The famous Varsity Restaurant in Atlanta serves the highest amount of Coca-Cola in the world. The restaurant caters to nearly 3 million servings of Coca-Cola annually.
- In Atlanta, it is against the law to tie a giraffe to a telephone pole or street lamp. So you might want to leave your giraffe at home.

Atlanta is a great city for hosting A.A.'s International Convention celebrating 80 years. I hope you have Georgia on your mind and we look forward to seeing you in Atlanta!

Rebecca Thomason, Georgia

2015 International Convention

In a little over two months an anticipated 50,000 people from around the world will join together in Atlanta, Georgia, July 2-5 in celebration of the 80th Anniversary of Alcoholics Anonymous. 80 Years — Happy, Joyous and Free!

At this date, we have a registration of over 40,000, which is 10% ahead of the advance registration for San Antonio at this time. Already, members from over 90 countries have registered and it may be that all continents will be represented. However, like unwrapping a gift, let's wait to see what's inside!

Registration opened on September 3 and after a temporary glitch, online registration soared. Approximately 10,500 people from around the world registered on the first day. Within five days, over 16,000 had registered. Of course, technology has changed this. In 2005, about 70 percent registered online. In 2010, approximately 89 percent of our attendees registered online. So far, for this Convention, about 95% of folks have registered online. About 50% are first-timers to the International Convention which is consistent with previous conventions.

Our Convention hotel block includes over 170 hotels in the Atlanta area, as well as two university dorms. To help attendees get back and forth over the Convention weekend, a shuttle bus system has been organized, and there will also be shuttle buses for special needs.

About half of those registered for the Convention have prepurchased the special 2015 Convention souvenir book, *Alcoholics Anonymous: 80 Years — Happy, Joyous and Free*. And, the Grapevine's commemorative edition of the book *Happy, Joyous and Free* has been preordered as well. Also, subscriptions to the Grapevine and La Viña have been sold through the preregistration process.

We have put special emphasis on anonymity in advance information about the Convention and in each meeting format for the Convention. The Box 4-5-9 spring issue featured the article, "Anonymity and the 2015 International Convention." The Convention program also includes a new meeting titled, "Anonymity and the Convention — I get It!" Additionally, we will have an "Anonymity" Booth at the Convention center to provide information about anonymity in A.A.

The Convention Advance Program guide has been sent by email or mail to all registrants and is available on G.S.O.'s A.A. website. The International Convention APP will be available in May for download on mobile devices. Also, new to the Convention will be the "Carry the Message" pavilion where attendees can discover the variety of service opportunities that our Fellowship offers and where members can meet and exchange experience in service with members from other regions.

In Atlanta, the Registration and Hospitality Hall will open on Wednesday morning, and the local Volunteer Host Committee will be ready to welcome Convention-goers. The Host Committee is unbelievably enthusiastic and well organized. A convention of this size would be impossible without strong local support and we are extremely grateful to Patty L., Georgia Area 16 past delegate, who is chairperson of the Host Committee and her cochairs Tom H. and Jim T., who are spending countless hours organizing approximately 4,000 volunteers, along with their subcommittee chairs who will be greeting attendees at the airport, Marta stations, train station, in hotel lobbies, at the stadium, convention center, downtown Atlanta and who will answer the hundreds of questions that attendees will have. We will also have bilingual and multilingual members to help staff the International Hospitality Room in the Hospitality Hall and will greet members at the airport and in some of the hotels.

A "Party in the Park" and several dances are scheduled to

kick off the Convention on Thursday night. There will be music and dancing in Centennial Olympic Park adjacent to the Georgia World Congress Center. Bands and DJs are also scheduled inside the Convention Center itself, and at nearby hotels.

In all, more than 225 A.A. meetings will appear on the final Convention Program. At midnight on Thursday, Marathon Meetings will start in the Hyatt Regency Hotel and will run until Sunday morning. Friday and Saturday from 9:00 a.m. to 5:00 p.m. meetings will take place in the Convention Center and at the Omni Hotel. Al-Anon meetings will be held at the Atlanta Marriott Marquis Hotel. Meetings during the day will be held in many languages, including American Sign Language, and there will be simultaneous interpretation for the Big Meetings in the Georgia Dome. In 2010, there were about 60 deaf members registered. Currently close to 600 registrants are deaf. We have increased the number of meetings interpreted in ASL and we are providing a Deaf/ASL Hospitality room in the Convention Center.

For an A.A. community that resides throughout the US/Canada and who for many years has networked with each other online, this will be a unique opportunity for them to meet face-to-face for the first time and especially to welcome the deaf newcomers who one-day-at-a-time, are planning to be there.

Present during the Convention will be two special guests who are links to A.A.'s early history: Laurie Lukens, daughter of Ruth Hock, who was A.A.'s first national secretary who worked with Bill W., and Sr. Judith Ann Karam, Congregational leader of the Sisters of Charity, the order to which Sister Ignacia belonged.

The first Big Meeting will take place on Friday night with the opening Flag Ceremony and three speakers. On Saturday night, there will be the wonderful Oldtimers Meeting with members who have 50 or more years of sobriety throwing their names into the hat in hopes of being randomly selected to share for a few minutes. Finally, we will gather for the Convention closing on Sunday morning, when we will be presenting Sister Karam with a copy of the 35th millionth book, *Alcoholics Anonymous*, in gratitude for the role that Sister Ignacia played in A.A.'s fledgling years as she worked with countless alcoholics in hospitals and presented many opportunities for A.A.s to carry the A.A. message of hope and recovery to alcoholics under her care. The Convention will end with a three-speaker meeting.

All of us who are working on the International Convention want to do everything we can to make July 2-5 a wonderful and memorable event that will continue to shed glimmers of hope to alcoholics around the world.

I would like to close with an excerpt from our Big Book, *Alcoholics Anonymous*:

"We have been speaking to you of serious, sometimes tragic things. We have been dealing with alcohol in its worst aspect. But we aren't a glum lot. If newcomers could see no joy or fun in our existence, they wouldn't want it. We absolutely insist on enjoying life. We try not to indulge in cynicism over the state of the nations, nor do we carry the world's troubles on our shoulders. When we see a man sinking into the mire that is alcoholism, we give him first aid and place what we have at his disposal."

Alcoholics Anonymous, p. 132

Eva Sanchez, G.S.O. staff



■ Report of the 2015 General Service Conference Inventory

"We cannot underestimate the importance of this first-ever General Service Conference Inventory. It challenges us to look at how well the Conference functions as the voice and the conscience of our society. It asks us to consider how well the principles of our Twelve Concepts are reflected in Conference actions and composition. It calls upon us to examine how well the Conference maintains communication throughout the Fellowship's structure. It requires us to look at how well the Conference does when selecting A.A.'s leaders today and inspiring its leaders for tomorrow."

— Cathi C., Southern Indiana Delegate
"Inventory — Looking Back to Move Ahead"
2015 Conference Presentation

Taking inventory, in the best sense of the word, is a fundamental aspect of the A.A. program. As cofounder Bill W. reflected in *A.A. Comes of Age* (page 231), "Just as each A.A. must continue to take his moral inventory and act upon it, so must our whole society if we are to survive and if we are to serve usefully and well." An inventory, then, at the level of general service is a natural outgrowth of that which is done to maintain individual sobriety throughout the A.A. Fellowship. However, as noted in the Keynote Address at the opening of the 2013 General Service Conference, the inaugural year of the General Service Conference Inventory Plan, "Inventory of the Conference and personal inventory in the Steps are not quite the same. At the Conference, the emphasis will be on effectiveness in carrying out the purposes of the Conference, not on 'character defects.'"

The address continued, "We don't take inventory simply because it is, in and of itself, a good thing (like kindness, or generosity), but rather because it is an important element of our continued sobriety. The same holds true for our service inventories, including the Conference inventory which we are now undertaking. We are not here to take pride in doing the responsible thing by taking an inventory. We are here to help assure the unity and effectiveness of A.A. in its mission to carry the great message of hope to anyone, anywhere, who has a desire to do something about his or her drinking problem."

A Brief History

In August 2008, following successful inventories taken by the General Service Board and its two operating corporations, A.A. World Services, Inc. and A.A. Grapevine, Inc., a General Service Board subcommittee was formed to discuss a proposal for a General Service Conference Inventory. After considerable discussion, a year later the GSB established a subcommittee to fulfill the charge of putting together a process or procedure by which a Planning Committee with representation from all membership segments of the General Service Conference could be established. The results of the subcommittee's deliberations were accepted by the GSB and referred to the Conference Policy/Admissions Committee in 2010.

After evaluation and discussion by the 2010 Conference Committee on Policy/Admissions and further deliberation by the entire Conference, a detailed 2010 Advisory Action was passed to develop a comprehensive inventory plan.

The 2011 Conference Committee on Policy/Admissions reviewed the inventory plan and proposed to the full Conference "that the General Service Conference conduct a thorough inventory of itself in accordance with the Comprehensive Plan formulated by the Conference Inventory Planning Committee."

The Inventory Plan

The areas covered by the inventory plan were:

- I. **Logistics** (suggesting that the inventory be conducted at three consecutive Conferences: 2013, 2014 and 2015);
- II. **Participation** (outlining the categories and terms of rotation of Conference members to serve on the Planning Committee);
- III. **Reporting** (detailing a methodology for reporting the Conference inventory, including publication of a thorough report in the *Final Conference Report* of each year of the inventory, along with summaries of each years' inventory for publication in the A.A. Grapevine, La Viña and Box 4-5-9, and a separate comprehensive report of all three years' input to be prepared after the inventory process is completed);
- IV. **Finance** (developing a cost structure for conducting and reporting the inventory);
- V. **Inventory Questions** (covering the overall effectiveness of the Conference and the Conference process; the composition of the Conference; the committee system; the effectiveness of the yearlong process; Conference preparation, in terms of background, content, delivery, etc.; the Conference week schedule; the General Service Board and corporate boards; and the question of leadership and what might be the most desirable qualities considered for leaders in A.A.)

The recommendation was accepted by the full Conference and passed as an Advisory Action of the 2011 General Service Conference, with implementation to begin in 2013 and each year's results to be shared with the Fellowship through the *Final Conference Report*, Box 4-5-9, Grapevine and La Viña.

First-Year Results

In 2013, the first year of the Inventory Plan, a series of Inventory workshops were held for Conference members during the 2013 Conference, with the results of each group's discussions reported back to the full Conference. A number of common and interconnected themes surfaced through the reports.

The major topics were summarized to include:

- **Communication:** When the flow of information throughout the Fellowship, from the trustees to the delegates, from delegates to the areas, from areas to districts and groups, is transmitted unevenly, it can lead to misunderstanding and misapprehension on the part of the Fellowship. As much as possible, communication (at all levels) should focus more on the "why" of particular actions/suggestions/recommendations. This will help improve transparency and offer greater insight into the issues at hand.
- **Use of Technology:** In today's changing digital world, particularly at the Conference level, where the dissemination of information and communication is so critical, technology can help to reach new people (both in terms of service and recovery) and to provide for the wide dispersion of materials related to the General Service Conference. Technology could also be well applied at the Conference itself, facilitating communication between committees, for voting and tabulation, and for presentation of items to the Conference as a whole.
- **Conference Orientation and Preparation:** Providing delegates and the Fellowship with a clearer picture of what happens at the Conference and how decisions are arrived at

is an important aspect of the Conference experience. It was noted that some areas and regions prepare their delegates very well, while others do not; a consistent presentation prior to the beginning of the Conference could provide all delegates with the same level of preparedness.

- **Participation and Timing:** The development and distribution of agenda items and background information is critical in facilitating thorough discussion and review by the Fellowship. Suggestions were made that full participation in the Conference process from groups and delegates may be curtailed because agenda items and background material are not getting out to the Fellowship early enough. In addition to concerns about the timing of deadlines, there was the sense that delegates, as representatives of the groups, were not well utilized in the selection of yearly agenda items. Emphasis was encouraged on the “year-round” concept of the Conference and the idea of having Conference committees in general and the Conference Agenda Committee in specific more involved in the development of committee agendas was frequently expressed.
- **Information:** Many delegates expressed being “overwhelmed” with the amount of material that must be gone through and some found the background materials to be inadequate in terms of providing the “reasoning” for certain agenda items. It was felt that more frequent communication and exchange of information between the Conference committees and their corresponding trustees’ committees could help refocus the Conference process throughout the year, rather than pushing everything into a narrow timeframe during and just preceding each Conference.

Second-Year Results

In 2014, the second year of the Inventory Plan, additional themes surfaced covering the overall effectiveness of the Conference and the Conference process itself. The major topics were summarized to include:

- **Language Equality:** An overriding concern was expressed about the issue of language equality and the need to reach a level of parity in terms of the preparation and distribution of Conference agenda items and background information in all three languages represented by the Conference to ensure full participation throughout the Fellowship.

(Note: The 2014 Conference voted that a plan be created by the General Service Office to translate Conference Material into French and Spanish for use during the Conference, with a report being presented to the 2015 General Service Conference that should include costs and any other considerations deemed necessary to allow timely translations to occur. See 2014 Conference Advisory Action #11. for clarification)

- **Diversity:** Full participation in the Conference process was also related to the question of diversity, as many workshop groups reported, and it was noted that the Conference itself could pay attention to this issue as the average age at the Conference was reported as 57. It was suggested that the Conference, and delegates in particular, find ways to reach out to underrepresented populations of all kinds. “We need to recognize the value of all kinds of leaders: good organizers, good talkers, good listeners, good cheerleaders, and the multiple roles we need to fill,” noted one workshop report.
- **Conference Agenda and Deadlines:** In the spirit of full representation at the Conference and to reflect more of the Fellowship’s ongoing concerns, the question of how agenda items are developed was widely discussed, with

requests made for more input from delegates in the determination of agenda items. Additionally, many felt that the current timing and distribution of Conference agenda items and background information limited input from the Fellowship, noting that getting an informed conscience from the groups depends on providing the information to them in a timely manner.

(Note: The 2014 Conference Agenda Committee requested that the trustees’ Committee on the Conference explore the potential role that the Conference Committee on Agenda might play in the selection process of Agenda items in the future and provide a report to the 2015 Conference Agenda Committee regarding the current and historical process of Agenda item selection.)

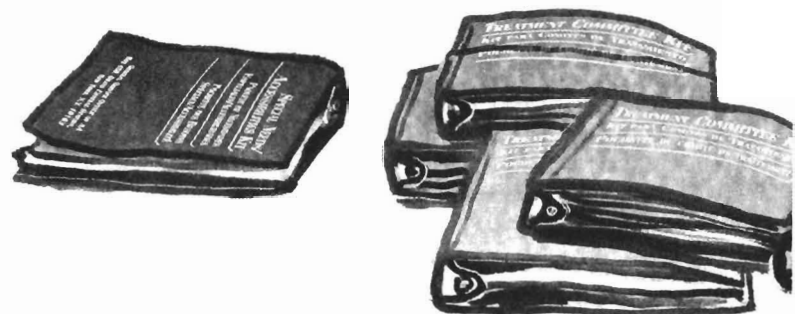
- **Conference Theme:** It was expressed that the Conference theme could be a powerful way to encourage greater involvement in the Conference process from the Fellowship, but that the themes, often unwieldy and unrelated to the general membership, were not utilized in any meaningful way throughout the year. Delegates and G.S.O. were encouraged to incorporate the Conference theme more prominently throughout the Fellowship on a yearlong basis to help establish focus on the Conference and increase participation.

(Note: The 2015 Conference selected the theme for the 2016 General Service Conference: “Our Spiritual Way of Life: Steps, Traditions and Concepts.”)

- **Communication:** Communication is a key element in the Conference process and is one of the facets upon which trust is built. It was generally felt that more intensive year-round communication between trustees’ committee chairs and Conference committee chairs would be beneficial, and that the flow of information from regional trustees to delegates helps provide a bridge between the board and the Fellowship at large. Transparency regarding decisions taken on behalf of A.A. and the spirit of true collaboration throughout the Conference structure help to build trust and restore effectiveness.
- **Technology:** The 2014 Conference Committee on Policy/Admissions recommended that electronic voting at the Conference be given a two-year trial at the 2015 and 2016 Conferences, and that the trustees’ Committee on the General Service Conference provide a report to the 2017 Conference Committee on Policy/Admissions on electronic voting for their evaluation. (See 2014 Advisory Action #22).

Year Three — The Inventory Continues

To address the inventory questions proposed for the 2015 GSC and to allow for an equitable and representative cross-section of Conference members, 15 separate workshop groups were estab-



lished, each with a moderator and reporter. Meeting for two-and-a-half hours during the Conference on Wednesday, April 22nd, the full range of inventory questions was covered by Conference members, with reports prepared from each workshop group.

Subsequently, each group reported directly to the full Conference on Friday, April 24th, with additional discussion and commentary on the Conference floor following each workshop report.

Some Common Concerns

Over the course of the third year of the Inventory, a number of significant issues relating to Conference practices and procedures surfaced that cut across many different Inventory questions and a number of different Concepts. The major topics were summarized to include:

- **Working Together and Increasing Trust:** Three familiar areas were articulated in terms of creating a more balanced working relationship between the trustees and the Conference: a) making sure that agenda items are received as far in advance as possible to ensure full participation throughout the Fellowship; b) finding ways to keep the trustees and Conference committees in meaningful contact throughout the yearlong Conference process; and c) cultivating more input from delegates regarding agenda items. “For authority to be commensurate with responsibility,” said one report, “there should be ready access between the general membership and service leaders.... Communication among equals helps ensure this.”

(Note: The 2015 Conference Agenda Committee again requested that the trustees’ Committee on the Conference fully explore the potential role that the Conference Agenda Committee might play in the selection process of Agenda items in the future and provide a report to the 2016 Conference Agenda Committee — See the Additional Committee Considerations section of the 2015 Final Conference Report.)

- **Engaging the Fellowship:** Engaging the Fellowship with relevant and ongoing information about the Conference is not a new problem. Many reports recognized the historical gap between individual A.A. members and the Conference itself. “If we are not working locally to engage the full Fellowship,” said one report, “the disconnect between the GSC and the average member will remain. The connection needs to be made between what happens at the Conference and how it helps the drunk on the corner.” Many obstacles can come between the membership and general service — such as family and work obligations, health issues, time constraints, etc. — but trying to limit such obstacles will help attract a broader spectrum of people. “Participation by the average A.A. is blocked by the

idea that the Conference is complicated, intense,” noted one report. “Can we simplify communication about our process? Find a way to de-mystify the language?”

- **Carrying the Message in a Diverse and Changing Society:** To be truly representative of the Fellowship, the Conference and the board need to keep inviting diversity by reaching out to members of all ages, races, income, education and language levels, those with special needs, and those with differing professional backgrounds. More diversity on the board would help establish trust throughout the Fellowship as our population changes in the future, and reaching out to underrepresented population groups expands our inclusivity. “Diversity begins with us, one-on-one,” said one report. “We can’t have a democratic organization without having the top of the pyramid fully participating.”
- **Improving Communication:** Progress was made in having Conference material available as soon as possible in English, French and Spanish, as requested by the 2014 Conference, and the 2015 Conference approved two items to keep that progress moving forward (see 2015 Advisory Actions #4 and #5). One common theme expressed through many reports was the importance of listening as a fundamental aspect of good communication. As one report noted, “We can get so caught up in A.A. rigidity, but if motivated by the spirit of listening, our group conscience can result in good decisions.”
- **Looking Toward the Future:** One report indicated that the Conference Inventory itself is going a long way to ensuring balance between responsibility and authority, and that continuing some sort of regular review/assessment will help avoid future discrepancies between authority and responsibility. And now that the Inventory is done, perhaps it is time to take a similar approach to the Concepts and develop a plan to look at them in depth to ensure the ongoing effectiveness of the Conference, the board, and the entire general service structure.

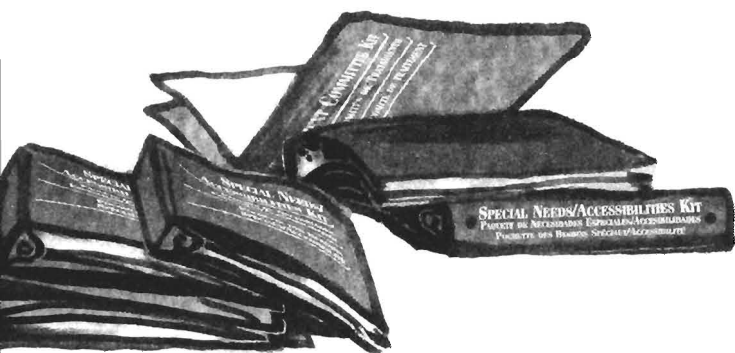
CONCLUSION:

‘Interconnected Circles of Love and Service’

In all its actions, the General Service Conference seeks to be of maximum usefulness as the guardian of A.A.’s services, Steps and Traditions, and to be the voice and conscience of the Fellowship as a whole. As planned, the General Service Conference Inventory has spanned three Conferences and will come to a close with publication of a comprehensive report covering all three years.

“We cannot underestimate the importance of this first-ever General Service Conference Inventory,” noted Southern Indiana delegate Cathi C. in the 2015 Conference presentation, ‘Inventory — Looking Back to Move Ahead.’ “But the inventory itself is mere information,” she continued, “an account of the Conference’s assets and liabilities. What happens when the inventory is over is critical to the current and future success of the Conference. To paraphrase the Big Book, ‘having made an Inventory of the General Service Conference, what shall we do about it? Is the Conference’s work then done?’....

“Knowing that solitary self-appraisal is insufficient, we will gain much by sharing the report throughout our interconnected circles of love and service. We will benefit greatly by discussing our shortcomings with trusted servants at all levels of our structure. It will give everyone who is willing the opportunity to help create plans for the betterment of our Conference. Let us involve and inspire our leaders of tomorrow as they continue the challenging assignment we have only just begun.”



In closing, said Cathi, “As we look at where we are today, celebrating 80 years of Recovery, Unity and Service, let us also celebrate our General Service Conference Inventory. We have begun a journey of strengthening our foundation and moving ahead toward the future.”

Summary of 2015 Inventory

Question 1:

Reflecting on Concept Two, how can we better serve as the actual voice and be an effective conscience for our whole society?

We need to educate ourselves, our groups, our areas, and the general public through clear and ongoing communication, connectivity and planned initiatives; to engage and communicate with A.A. members and groups regarding how necessary their input is. Utilizing, and living, all three Legacies is important to gaining full participation throughout the Fellowship. “We can’t have a democratic organization without having the top of the pyramid [the groups] fully participating.” To do this, it is important to see other perspectives and to be as informative, loving and available as possible. “We can get so caught up in A.A. rigidity, but if motivated by the spirit of listening, our group conscience can result in good decisions.”

Recommendations/Suggestions:

- Give more time to the minority opinion at the area level.
- Reaffirm that the groups are in charge; show how the Conference impacts groups; involve D.C.M.s in the communication process to and from the Conference.
- Reach out to those groups not listed and nonparticipating groups — attend and absorb what these groups value and what their message is.
- Consider video conferencing to reach geographically remote communities.
- Translate background material into French and Spanish.
- Involve delegates more in the Conference selection process for agenda items.
- The make-up of the board of trustees could better reflect the diversity of the Fellowship.
- Many obstacles can come between the membership and general service — such as family and work obligations, health issues, time constraints, etc. Try to limit obstacles and make it easier and less time-consuming for members to participate in general service. This will help attract a broader spectrum of people.
- The A.A. Membership Survey could be an effective tool to reach underrepresented groups.
- Delegates should try to involve more groups in the pre-Conference process.

Question 2:

Reflecting on Concept Three, how can we effectively balance the freedoms and responsibilities that come with the right of decision?

Keeping “the good of A.A.” foremost in our thinking — respecting the roles represented by all parts of the triangle — is critical in maintaining balance within the Fellowship. “We have to make A.A. better, not just our areas,” said one report. Actions should be measured against the effect they might have on the alcoholic who still suffers and we shouldn’t underestimate the knowledge and interest of the Fellowship. “Responsibility involves listening to all sides,” stated one report, adding that we have to be careful

not to be so critical as to demoralize those we are trying to serve. “Provide the best and most timely information that you can to the group that you are responsible to so that they can participate fully and effectively in giving you their initial input; if their initial input is well-informed you are less likely to need to exercise the right of decision.”

Complete reporting of Conference actions, including an explanation of any new information that may have affected the vote, is part of the delegate’s responsibility, along with trying to balance majority and minority opinion relating to Conference decisions. “Just because we don’t have to consult or report about a particular item, doesn’t mean that we shouldn’t,” explained one report. And it’s important, said another, to stay friendly with those we are trying to serve, even those with whom we may disagree. “We may learn more from the minority than the majority.”

Recommendations/Suggestions:

- More time at the Conference should be spent on substantive issues, not word-smithing. When Conference members get microscopic it takes away from important issues.
- Some decisions can/should wait until we obtain a fuller group conscience. It’s important to better involve the groups in the Conference process, even if it takes more time.
- Concepts workshops at the local level can help the Fellowship better understand the right of decision.
- Increasing the time between releasing the agenda and background material and the start of the Conference itself may help to increase the Fellowship’s understanding of issues facing A.A. as a whole.

Question 3:

How might any one of the Concepts be revised in essence or wording to more effectively and relevantly guide our leaders?

“We don’t need to change the Concepts — just live them,” was a sentiment often expressed. Yet, many recognized the difficulties of applying these principles in a changing society and engaging the Fellowship to learn more about our Third Legacy. “Participation by the average A.A. is blocked by the idea that the Conference is complicated, intense.... Can we simplify communication about our process? Find a way to de-mystify the language?”

Some felt that the Concepts can be seen as separate entities, with some more important than others, rather than as an interconnected group of matched principles. Additionally, it was expressed that without cooperation and communication, ideas like the right of decision can be pitted against the right of participation. It’s important to focus on the relevance of the Concepts at the group, district and area level in order to engage the interest of individual members and to communicate in ways that resonate with diverse groups and all ages.

Recommendations/Suggestions:

- Annotated, narrative and simplified Concept tools need to be developed for use throughout the Fellowship — along the lines of the Concepts Checklist and the Concepts Illustrated.
- The Conference process does not provide enough time to focus on and address the future needs of the Fellowship; it is important that the Conference not become entirely reactive, but also extend a vision for A.A.’s future.
- Now that the Inventory is done, take a similar approach to the Concepts and develop a plan to look at them in depth at next year’s Conference, and beyond.
- Have more workshops on the Concepts at the local level; include more stories about the Concepts in Grapevine, La Viña

and Box 4-5-9; create a summary table of contents similar to what is in The Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions.

- *The Concepts are not a history book or a policy document. The Conference could take three Concepts a year for four years and develop clearer narratives reflecting current experience, including examples of how we actually use the Concepts within the Fellowship. These examples could then be included in The A.A. Service Manual.*

Question 4:

Is the size and structure (proportions of delegate/trustee/staff) of the Conference the most effective for conducting the work of the Fellowship? If not, how could it be made more effective?

It was the general consensus that the proportions and structure of the Conference are good, but that more work needs to be done to develop diversity within the Conference body. To be truly representative of the Fellowship, the Conference needs to keep inviting diversity, not quotas, by reaching out to members of all ages, races, income and education levels, those with special needs, and those with differing professional backgrounds. "Diversity begins with us, one-on-one," said one report.

In terms of participation at the Conference, it was noted that a good idea can come from anyone, and that staff, delegates and trustees have equal access to share information. Some questions were raised about increasing the representation of staff at the Conference and the possibilities of adding new areas as ways of expanding the Conference body itself. However, in general, it was felt that the current size of the Conference is workable and while expansion is something to keep on the radar for continued discussion, no changes were needed at this time.

Recommendations/Suggestions:

- *Perhaps linguistic districts could become areas with their own delegates?*
- *Translation of background material is needed to empower and strengthen participation for all members.*
- *Greater use of technology will enhance communication.*
- *The time may be approaching to consider new delegate areas/regions to achieve greater equity in terms of numbers of groups represented and geographic area covered, as it relates both to delegates and regional trustees.*

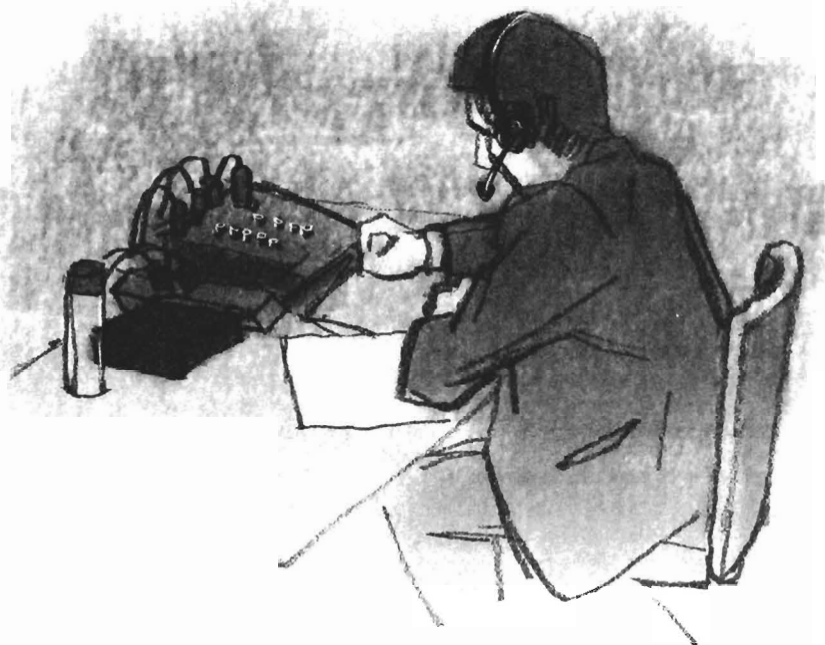
Question 5:

Does the Conference committee system function in accordance with our principles?

If not, what changes should we consider regarding:

a) structure b) composition c) effectiveness?

Most reports recognized the benefits of working within the committee system, but questions of balanced workloads and expanding collaboration between Conference committees were also raised. Some committees (for example, Literature) characteristically seem to have a heavier workload and can be over-taxed for time, while other committees are lighter. Finding ways to balance these workloads is important. Additionally, it was felt that there could be more collaboration between committees and that cross-pollination is a good thing. Committees can become insular and this may lead to micromanaging agenda items and getting bogged down in excessive word-smithing rather than



keeping the focus on substantive issues.

The benefit of working in small groups was noted, which helps achieve transparency among delegates, trustees and staff "Quit separating us," added one report. "Delegates need more interaction time with trustees and staff "

Recommendations/Suggestions:

- *There is not enough time at the Conference. More communication throughout the year between the trustees' committees and the corresponding Conference committees could help ease the time crunch. Perhaps it's necessary to add more days to the Conference schedule?*
- *Make the agenda item deadline earlier to allow for greater input from the Fellowship.*
- *It is important to trust the informed group conscience and not get bogged down in microscopic analysis and word-smithing.*
- *Give delegate chairs a larger role in the agenda selection process.*
- *Consider giving trustees and staff a voice and vote at the committee level.*
- *Utilize technology (conference calls, Skype, etc.) to allow committees to meet before the Conference.*
- *Allow a broader segment of the Fellowship to view proposed material before the Conference (i.e., PSAs) to gain a wider conscience.*
- *Since trustees get to express a preference about the Conference committees they are assigned to, why not let delegates also rank their committee preferences? This might bring more relevant experience to committees.*

Question 6:

How can we better communicate that the Conference process is more than one spring week in New York?

Reaching — and engaging — the Fellowship with relevant and ongoing information about the Conference is not a new problem. Many reports recognized the historical gap between individual A.A. members and the Conference itself. Communication remains the principal means of bridging this gap and it was suggested that communication is best achieved on a face-to-

face basis and be framed in language that is meaningful to an A.A. member rather than using “academic” language or service jargon. Said one report, “If we are not working locally to engage the full Fellowship, the disconnect between the G.S.C. and the average member will remain. The connection needs to be made between what happens at the Conference and how it helps the drunk on the corner.”

Several reports mentioned the low percentage of participation in general service in their areas, making the importance of communication even greater. Also discussed were breaks in the chain of communication, sometimes occurring at the D.C.M. and G.S.R. levels.

While it is primarily the job of the delegate to make the Conference connection throughout the Fellowship, G.S.O. can help facilitate communication about Conference matters and can reach out to the general A.A. population on an ongoing basis with information about the Conference.

Recommendations/Suggestions:

- *Things that G.S.O. can do:* use the A.A. website homepage to carry information about the Conference throughout the year; place G.S.C. banners across all communication pieces (newsletters, contribution acknowledgments, etc.); have a brief Conference Planning update in Box 4-5-9 at regular intervals throughout the year or communicate the progress of Advisory Actions throughout the year; utilize Grapevine and La Viña to share information from past delegates and past trustees about the Conference; communicate information to G.S.R.s about new agenda items as soon as they are approved by the trustees; use dashboard to post final trustee committee reports; have Conference committees meet via conference call prior to the Conference to discuss their agendas.
- *Things that delegates can do:* use Conference workshop topics for local roundtables; hold pre- and post-Conference assemblies; highlight the ownership of the Conference by the groups; explain the process — connect the group with the Conference through examples; use local events to share about the Conference and underline matters of relevance or importance to the local groups; use the Conference theme throughout the year to generate and maintain interest; track ideas or items from the area and show their progress and development through the Conference process; explain what the words “Conference-approved” mean on our literature and how they get there; throw out a hot topic occasionally to get people involved and point out that participating in the process is the only way to effect change; share your area highlights with groups; utilize the essay by Bernard Smith, “Why Do We Need a Conference?” as a way to reach members emotionally and spiritually.

Question 7:

How do the delegates and regional trustees support the yearlong process effectiveness?

All levels of the service structure — G.S.R.s, D.C.M.s, delegates, trustees, etc. — serve together to accomplish the task of supporting the Conference process. However, when the delegates and trustee within a region form a strong bond, each delegate has many sources for help. Keeping past delegates and past trustees involved can be very helpful in carrying the message of how the Conference process works, and coordinating and collaborating with area chairs can help provide the Fellowship with pertinent Conference information.

Having regular conference calls between regional trustees and delegates, delegate chairs and committee members, delegates and alternate delegates, delegates and D.C.M.s/ GSRs can be invaluable. Additional technologies can also enhance effectiveness and magnify the reach of our communication efforts: podcasts, CD recordings of the delegate’s Conference report, password protected area websites. Ongoing communication about the Conference strengthens unity.

Recommendations/Suggestions:

- *Engage the Fellowship, don’t just “report” data.*
- *Creative presentation of the delegate’s report and Final Conference Report can generate interest: one delegate distributes the Final Conference Report along with a mock “stock certificate” and emphasizes that each member is a shareholder in A.A. and that the Final Report will give them all the details they need. Another gives the analogy: the Final Conference Report is to the area what the group business meeting minutes are to the members.*
- *Increased communication from trustees’ committees throughout the year will help support effectiveness in the areas.*
- *Expand use of the dashboard to allow sharing and posting by delegates throughout the year; allow constant access to board reports, agenda items and background material as they are approved by the trustees.*
- *Share A.A.W.S. Highlights throughout the year with Intergroup/ Central Offices.*
- *Continue the discussion on how to attract more agenda input from our French and Hispanic members.*

Question 8:

What more could be done to prepare delegates for the Conference?

Given the time constraints of the Conference process, it was felt by many that what materials there are for committee members are well-delivered via either the dashboard or CD. However, three general issues came to the forefront in the discussion of this question: the timing of delegates receiving agenda items and background material (they are needed earlier), the languages that the materials are available in (should be English, French and Spanish), and the most effective use of time at the Conference (more focus on the yearlong process would be helpful).



Recommendations/Suggestions:

- *Are the Area Highlights and the preparation they require the best use of our time? Could they be submitted as a written report and then allow the delegate to speak extemporaneously on three burning issues in their area?*
- *Rather than asking delegates to read opening and closing fragments from our literature, would it be more beneficial instead to ask delegates to prepare a mini-presentation on topics important to A.A., forcing them to learn more about a particular issue?*
- *Encourage areas to hold mock or mini-conferences to help prepare the delegate.*
- *Have a more systematic buddy/mentoring system at the Conference.*
- *Have agenda items and background material posted on the dashboard as soon as they are approved, better utilizing the yearlong Conference process.*
- *Present delegates with more information regarding what to expect at the Conference — schedule, process, logistics, personal details (travel, dress, accommodations, etc.), and more information on what is expected during committee meetings.*
- *Have more time for delegates to ask for additional information.*
- *Utilize past delegates for pre-Conference mentoring and information.*
- *Provide delegates access to all proposed agenda items submitted, with a full explanation of why a proposed item did not make the final agenda.*

Question 9:

What Conference activities give participants the most opportunities to be leaders?

It was generally felt that all Conference activities provided opportunities for leadership. Committee work, being present and prepared, the responsibility of considering the area conscience and voting for what is best for A.A. were all cited. Said one report, "It is important to remember that we are leaders and that we are also servants. Some of our leadership derives from how well we perform as servants to the Fellowship." And another: "Leadership is not a thing but an attitude of service." It was noted, as well, that even after rotation, the mantle of leadership does not dissipate, it just changes.

Recommendations/Suggestions:

- *Listening and waiting for our opinion to form before speaking can be an aspect of leadership.*
- *A good leader learns patience and tolerance by asking questions.*

Question 10:

Does the time allotted and the manner in which information is communicated from the trustees and board members allow delegates to adequately understand and/or question their reports? How could this be improved?

Recognizing that board and trustee reports provide a lot of detailed and critical information, it was generally agreed that more time would be helpful for these reports to be digested and questions formulated, perhaps spreading them out over more than one day. The finance report was mentioned specifically as needing more time, along with the A.A.W.S./Grapevine reports and the joint meetings between trustees' and Conference committees. One report noted, "A.A. should not go the way of the world, where everything is accelerating. We should take the necessary time to do our business well and fully."

Recommendations/Suggestions:

- *Provide one-page executive summaries along with the A.A.W.S., Grapevine and Finance presentations.*
- *Post the A.A.W.S., Grapevine and Finance reports on the dashboard at least one week before the Conference to allow for more time to assimilate the information and ask questions.*
- *What if the Conference process was on a two-year cycle? It would allow more time for all our activities, including board reports, and would provide a chance for our most important topics to be more broadly discussed among the Fellowship.*

Question 11:

Reflecting on Concept Six, how can the Conference ensure that the authority we delegate to the General Service Board is commensurate with the responsibility we have entrusted to them?

Recognizing the unusual relationship between the board of trustees and the Conference, many reports expressed gratitude for the structure of checks and balances as it is set up. This is not the typical business experience, and provides continuing evidence that "the A.A. way" works. It was felt that transparency and open communication between the trustees and the Conference lead to trust and a truly informed group conscience and that, along the way, we should not shy away from difficult discussions. Additionally, it was noted that the need for transparency goes beyond the week at the Conference. "For authority to be commensurate with responsibility, there should be ready access between the general membership and service leaders... 'communication among equals' helps ensure this," said one report.

Three familiar areas were articulated in terms of creating more balance between the trustees and the Conference: making sure that agenda items are received far enough in advance to ensure full participation; finding ways to keep the trustees and Conference committees in contact throughout the yearlong Conference process; and allowing more input from delegates regarding agenda items. Progress in these areas, it was felt, would go a long way toward keeping the flow of information to and from the Fellowship open. "We need a balance of authority and to outwardly look for demonstrations of trust," said one report. "A great start happened this year allowing delegates to participate at board weekend, but we must continue to talk, eyeball-to-eyeball."

Keeping the focus on "what will help the still suffering" is a good way of keeping ourselves on track, as the focus can sometimes veer too much toward the business details related to the work of the trustees. Ours is a fellowship of the spirit and we need to maintain that outlook.

One report indicated that the Conference Inventory itself is going a long way to ensure balance between responsibility and authority, and that continuing some sort of regular review/assessment will help avoid future discrepancies between authority and responsibility.

Recommendations/Suggestions:

- *The problem is not that the GSB has too much authority, it is that the focus is and should be on balance between the Conference and the board.*
- *Conference committees should be more proactive in asking trustees for more information in order to gain a clearer understanding of specific issues or concerns.*
- *More continuity and clarity regarding communication from the trustees to the delegates would be appreciated. When an item has been discussed by the trustees and reported out as simply "no action taken," it can create uncertainty. Perhaps a fuller explanation of why no action was taken would help develop greater understanding.*

- The flow of information between all three boards, delegates and groups needs to continue so that the A.A. shareholders are aware of what happens at the Conference and throughout the year.
- More diversity on the board would assist with establishing more trust throughout the Fellowship as our population changes in the future.
- Is the decline in contributions to G.S.O. and the drop in Grapevine subscriptions the "power of the purse" in action?

Question 12:

Reflecting on Concept Eight: (a) How well is the General Service Board exercising custodial oversight and how effectively are they serving as the principal planners and administrators of policy and finance? (b) What are the boundaries between oversight vs. delegation? When is each practiced?

The general consensus was that the board is exercising its custodial oversight well, and that the administrative aspects relating to A.A. operations take a great deal of time. Nevertheless, there are a number of areas in the operation of A.A.'s essential services where the Fellowship would like to have input. "This Fellowship is unique as a large nonprofit corporate entity," explained one report. "Individuals who have recovered from cancer cannot or dare not suggest how the American Cancer Society run its board. Yet we in A.A. have a cooperative, almost interpersonal, relationship between board and members."

With issues of interest ranging from self-support and Reserve Fund management to organizational initiatives to improving communications and the use of technology in today's changing world, it is important for the trustees to recognize that there are matters the Fellowship would like to have input on. And by asking questions about these and other issues, delegates and A.A. members are not implying that the trustees are not fulfilling their oversight responsibilities. Questions and answers on matters of interest to the Fellowship lead to the ongoing flow of communication — often repetitive (as something may be clearly explained to one panel of delegates but not as clearly explained to the next) — that ultimately leads to understanding.

It can be difficult for the Fellowship to assess GSB oversight of the corporate boards, as reports provide mostly business criteria and it is difficult to know if the actual interactions between the entities are good, bad, or indifferent. So trusting the process is a key element, especially when boundaries between the corporate entities must be flexible in order to achieve necessary goals. "We are only as good as the information we are provided with," added one report, and "there is room for improvement in clarity and accuracy when communicating mistakes in large fiscal or policy matters."

Recommendations/Suggestions:

- Trustees might benefit from service on both corporate boards rather than just one.
- Continued oversight from the board is needed in matters involving significant monetary investment or major changes in policy.
- Some concerns have been raised that A.A.W.S. and Grapevine are being pushed closer together by the board and are losing some of their corporate boundaries, which raises the long-term question of how they can maintain two distinct corporate identities.
- Grapevine and A.A.W.S. oversight is impossible without the support of the Fellowship.
- More time could be spent on the board regarding strategic planning.
- Are the services we are providing the ones the Fellowship wants?

Question 13:

Should the Fellowship have more direct influence in the selection of Class A trustees, corporate directors, and general service trustees? If yes, how might that be accomplished?

The Fellowship should not necessarily have more direct influence in the selection of board members and trustees, but should have more influence in generating the pool of candidates from which these A.A. servants are chosen. Often the actual roles of these trusted servants are not well known, so disseminating more information throughout the service structure on what these people are asked to do for the Fellowship might help enlarge the pool of available candidates.

Recommendations/Suggestions:

- Openings for board members and directors need to be widely announced and well in advance in order to provide for timely and appropriate submission of candidates from the Fellowship.
- The Conference Committee on Trustees should have greater involvement in the actual selection process.
- The selection of nontrustee directors should extend more often beyond past delegates and emphasize candidates with solid professional experience.
- What if the Fellowship were asked what skill sets they think are needed on the boards, not just a one-way communication from the boards themselves?
- Limiting terms and condensing the amount of time trustees and directors are required to commit to might help to enlarge the pool of available candidates.
- Consider including nonalcoholics as appointed committee members. This might provide a pathway for Class A trustees.

Question 14:

How well is the Third Legacy Procedure serving us? How could it be improved?

"The Third Legacy procedure embodies our best principles of trust, love, humility and service," stated one report. "It is more than just the hat. It's thoughtful concern with the welfare of the whole and the well-being of the individual."

Some concerns were raised, however, that while pulling a name from the hat takes the ego and politicking out of the selection process, are we getting the people with the best qualifications? For some the process seemed to be "a crap shoot," while most seemed comfortable with how the procedure is used not only at the Conference but throughout the Fellowship.

Recommendations/Suggestions:

- When voting on trustees at the Conference, people often don't know all the candidates. When submitting resumes, perhaps candidates could all be asked to answer the same five or six uniform questions in writing. That would provide voters with a better comparative basis for all candidates.
- Perhaps we should consider pulling the name of the next chairman of the GSB out of the hat?



■ Reports from the General Service Board, A.A.W.S., and Grapevine Corporate Boards

GENERAL SERVICE BOARD REPORT

Trustees' report: Greetings and welcome to the 65th General Service Conference. A special welcome to delegates and staff attending their first Conference this year. This week we are embarking together on a spiritual adventure under the theme, "Celebrating 80 Years of Recovery, Unity and Service — The Foundation for Our Future." This year the Conference will consider many and diverse questions, and will also complete a three-year inventory process, developed with the theme "The General Service Conference Takes Its Inventory — Our Solution in Action."

Last April, your General Service Board welcomed Richard Boisvert as Eastern Canada regional trustee; Joel Castellaw as Pacific regional trustee; and Joe Downey as general service trustee. On the G.S.O. front, Doug Richardson retired in December 2014 after 18 years at G.S.O. Doug was hired as a staff member, occupying several staff desks throughout the years, then retired as director of Staff Services. Angel Calvillo, our Spanish editor, also retired at the end of December. Angel had been with G.S.O. since 1991. Phyllis Halliday, G.S.O. general manager, announced her retirement effective in October 2015.

Since our last Conference the General Service Board has met four times; the annual members meeting in May, then quarterly board meetings in July, November and February. Some highlights of those meetings included discussion of how to involve online groups in the General Service Structure. We will continue consideration of this important topic in August.

The General Service Board will continue ongoing discussions on their Code of Conduct and Confidentiality Policy, the orientation for new trustees, and the search for the new general manager. A Search Committee has been formed and the position opening announced with résumés to be received by April 15. If all goes well, interviewing will begin in June with a decision targeted for August 1st.

At the February meeting of the General Service Board, special meetings of the members of A.A. World Services, Inc. and of A.A. Grapevine, Inc. were convened to approve minor revisions to Bylaws to comply with the New York State nonprofit Revitalization Act of 2013. Revisions to the G.S.B. Bylaws have been forwarded to the General Service Conference for approval. Also in February, we welcomed the Conference delegate chair and the Conference committee chairpersons to the General Service Board weekend. Delegate chairpersons attended an orientation at G.S.O., met with their committee staff secretaries, and participated in sessions of corresponding trustees' committees. The practice of inviting Conference committee chairpersons to a Board Weekend began in 1991. It continues to refresh the Conference process and helps delegate chairpersons fulfill their trusted servant responsibilities to the Conference and A.A. as a whole.

Since the 64th Conference, your General Service Board hosted Regional Forums in Idaho, Quebec

and Puerto Rico. On the International scene, trustees and G.S.O. staff were invited to El Salvador, Columbia, Poland, Latvia, Japan and Mexico. A highlight of trustee and staff travel included General Service Board representation at the 23rd World Service Meeting in Warsaw, Poland. There were 61 delegates from 41 countries in attendance at this international sharing session, and we were delighted with first-time participation by the Czech Republic, Hong Kong, Iran and Romania.

This year our trustees-at-large will be attending the 19th REDELA (Meeting of the Americas) in Mexico City, Mexico, which is the A.A. Zonal Meeting corresponding to the A.A. service structures in North, Central and South America. Zonal service meetings are invaluable to emerging countries and are held, in addition to the Americas, in Asia-Oceania, Europe and Sub-Saharan Africa. Zonal meetings will take place this year in Dubai, U.A.E.; York, England; and Johannesburg, South Africa. They provide opportunities to discuss the challenges of creating service structures, literature distribution and practicing A.A. principles in all their affairs.

Also this year we are celebrating A.A.'s 80th Birthday with a big party in Atlanta, Georgia on July 2-5, 2015. The theme of our International Convention is "80 Years — Happy, Joyous and Free." A.A. members and their friends and families from all over the U.S., Canada and the world will come together to celebrate sobriety, greet old friends and meet new ones "happy, joyous and free."

In 2013, the General Service Board shared with the Conference a list of 14 initiatives designed to strengthen the function and cooperation of our three boards. To oversee implementation of those initiatives, a trustee task force was appointed with representation from all three boards. In accountability to the Conference, I am pleased to summarize the final task force report:

Initiative 1. To facilitate communication between affiliates, meeting minutes are now freely exchanged between the boards.

Initiative 2 The board accepted the task force recommendation — based upon the Relocation Study commissioned by the G.S.O. — that the General Service Office remain in New York. Further, by the end of 2015, both Grapevine and G.S.O. space will be consolidated on the 11th Floor of 475 Riverside Drive, which will reduce overhead and streamline the use of space.

Initiative 3. A.A.GV and A.A.W.S. are now invited to send an employee to meetings of the other affiliate board. Every affiliate board member is invited — and encouraged — to attend meetings of the other affiliate board. Both affiliate boards have issued a standing invitation for all trustees to attend a board meeting, and new general service trustees will actually be scheduled to attend these meetings.

Initiative 4. To enhance trustee effectiveness, the board is studying ways to improve trustee orientation, both in July and throughout the year. Each board weekend now includes current issues and strategies being implemented by each operating corporation. We will also study the board weekend schedule to allow for more time for strategic discussion, earlier presentation of financial reports and insure time for the 1728 meeting.

Initiative 5. The trustees considered the possi-



bility of nontrustee directors serving on both corporate boards during their term of office, but took no action.

Initiative 6. It was suggested that the trustees set the size and composition of any affiliate board. We discovered our Bylaws already include this provision.

Initiative 7. This initiative proposed that eligibility for election as a general service trustee not be limited to current and past nontrustee directors. It was considered by the trustees' Nominating Committee, with no action taken.

Initiative 8. The proposal that nonalcoholics be eligible to serve as appointed committee members on trustee committees was considered by the trustees' Nominating Committee, and no action was taken.

Initiative 9. Grapevine continues to inform the General Service Board on potential distribution models to enhance the engagement of the areas and intergroup/central offices and to expand subscriptions, circulation and readership.

Initiative 10. To assure that licensing and translations of Grapevine literature are maintained for the benefit of A.A., the G.S.B. acknowledged that by way of a written agreement, G.S.O.'s licensing manager will also manage A.A. Grapevine translations and licensing functions.

Initiative 11. To enhance the effectiveness of information technology for G.S.O. and Grapevine offices, the G.S.B. chair will appoint an ad hoc committee to consider the composition, scope, and procedures for a standing IT committee of the General Service Board.

Initiative 12. That G.S.O. and Grapevine continue to study the most effective and economical use of contractors.

Initiative 13. The Grapevine continues to study the design and development of the Grapevine and La Viña products in order to realize efficiencies and to ensure that A.A.GV meets its magazine and corporate overhead expenses.

Initiative 14. This initiative had to do with consistency in accounting and financial reporting. Though auditors determined that we are consistent across the three boards, we continue to enhance management reporting to assure that trustees are getting the information needed for future planning.

Initiative 15. This initiative, titled "Serving the Fellowship," was added by the General Service Board to reflect its work in planning for the future. The trustees unanimously adopted a mission statement that reads: "The mission of the General Service Board is to serve the Fellowship of Alcoholics Anonymous." The board is drafting statements that elaborate how the General Service Board should serve the Fellowship, now and in the future. During this Conference week, we hope to begin receiving delegate input on the value of services provided on behalf of the General Service Board. The trustees have also launched a comprehensive feasibility study of the current business model, corporate structure, and long-term sustainability of the General Service Board and both operating corporations, keeping in mind the spiritual basis of Alcoholics Anonymous.

At the close of this Conference, six trustees will rotate; Frances Brisbane, Corliss Burke, Nancy Haynes, Barbara Kelly, Gary Lutz and Clayton Vandivort. We are grateful for their dedication, self-sacrifice and tireless service on behalf of the Fellowship.

As we continue to seek new trusted servants, it is suggested that we remain mindful of the importance of diversity when seeking friends of A.A. as candidates for Class A (nonalcoholic) trustees in 2015-2016 and stress the value that diverse experience and backgrounds can bring to A.A. This might include a variety of professional backgrounds including doctors, lawyers, financial professionals, clergy, media and public relations pro-

fessionals, correctional administrators, social workers, educators, communications, information technology and military professionals.

Our charter says "The Conference will replace the founders of Alcoholics Anonymous..." Each of us has an obligation, to those not yet here, of keeping the meeting doors open to those who need A.A. so desperately — no matter whom they are or what their background is.

Our sharing this week will enable us to reach decisions based on an informed group conscience. We demonstrate our love for the Fellowship as we demonstrate our respect for our fellow delegates. How we say things will be remembered long after what we say has been forgotten. Our resolve to communicate within our principles and bring forth what is best for the future of A.A. should be our guide post and a measure of our success this week. I am grateful that a power greater than ourselves inspires us in all our endeavors. I am grateful for the opportunity to serve the Fellowship of Alcoholics Anonymous.

Terrance Bedient, chairperson

ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS WORLD SERVICES, INC.

Directors' report: Alcoholics Anonymous World Services, Inc. (A.A.W.S.) is a not-for-profit corporation, composed of nine directors. Members of A.A.W.S., Inc. are the 21 trustees of the General Service Board, who elect the nine directors responsible for oversight of the General Service Office (G.S.O.), group services, printing and distribution of Conference-approved literature and service material. A.A.W.S. owns copyrights on A.A. literature, and is responsible for translations of A.A. literature, including titles licensed to A.A. boards in other countries.

A.A.W.S. directors include two general service trustees and two regional trustees; three nontrustee directors; G.S.O.'s general manager and staff coordinator. Essential nonvoting support personnel attend each board meeting: G.S.O. staff, chief financial officer, publishing director, human resources manager, archivist, and board secretary.

Each year directors serving on Alcoholics Anonymous World Services, Inc. report to the General Service Conference on A.A. publishing, group services provided by G.S.O., and other activities linked directly to A.A.'s primary purpose. I am privileged to present this report on behalf of my fellow directors. The purpose of the publishing activities and group services provided by A.A.W.S. and G.S.O., as requested from the Fellowship, is to support members' and groups' Twelfth Step efforts to reach the still-suffering alcoholic. The structure, composition and responsibilities of Alcoholics Anonymous World Services, Inc. are described in Chapter 10 of *The A.A. Service Manual*.

The A.A.W.S. Board has met seven times since the 64th Conference to receive reports from G.S.O. management and staff, review updates on group services activity, track progress on implementation of Conference and board recommendations related to A.A.W.S., review financial reports, price new and revised publications, consider publishing operations and G.S.O. administrative matters, discuss requests from A.A. members and non-A.A.s seeking permission to reprint A.A. copyrighted literature, and to address other pertinent matters. (Concurrent with the seven board meetings, the A.A.W.S. Board met twice to conduct strategic planning sessions.)

The A.A.W.S. Board utilizes the committee system to address extensive agendas, to gather background material, and to thoroughly consider requests. The board, in turn, discusses committee reports and votes on any recommendations presented by a board committee in these reports. In addition, the board conducts long-range and strategic planning. Committees of the

A.A.W.S. Board are: Technology-Communication-Services (*formerly entitled Services*), which addresses the needs of service assignments, reviews G.S.O. communications with the Fellowship, and oversees G.S.O.'s A.A. website; Publishing reviews format requests, reprints, international translations of literature and other publishing matters; Finance oversees budgeting and financial results and self-support efforts; and Nominating recommends candidates for A.A.W.S. nontrustee director and general service trustee vacancies.

Group Services — A net total of 1,387 new A.A. groups in the U.S. and Canada were listed at G.S.O. last year. Each new group's general service representative (G.S.R.) or contact receives A.A. literature and basic information to encourage the group to link with their local structure and support Twelfth Step activities. The service piece, "Services Provided by G.S.O./A.A.W.S.," describes in detail the services provided by the A.A. staff assignments and other employees at G.S.O.

G.S.O.'s A.A. Website — Oversight of G.S.O.'s A.A. website is the responsibility of the A.A.W.S. Board of Directors, acting through its Technology-Communication-Services and Publishing Committees and in accordance with the Twelve Traditions of Alcoholics Anonymous.

- **Website Redesign:** The www.aa.org website redesign was deployed on June 3, 2014. Currently averaging over 30,000 visitors a day, reaching 40,000 on a few occasions, the contemporary designed site provides users with an overall greater ease in navigating the site with a more intuitive search functionality, and a more-user-friendly organization of information for A.A. trusted servants. Popular new features include an enhanced "A.A. Near You" page, and an updated Archives portal. We most recently posted web banners online — both with still and dynamic A.A. images — for local A.A. websites with links to A.A. materials on www.aa.org.

- **Online Store:** Traffic on the two A.A.W.S. Online Store sites (bulk order customers and general consumers) continues to increase at a steady pace. Currently we are achieving about 54 % of our total literature sales online.

- **Activity Reports:** The board approved the 2014 Quarterly and Annual Website Activity Reports, and forwarded them to the trustees' Committee on Public Information. These reports detail requests for changes and additions to the website and how they are addressed. The annual report is provided to the Conference Committee on Public Information by the trustees' Committee on Public Information.

Representatives from G.S.O. attended the inaugural National A.A. Technology Workshop held August 8-10, 2014 in St. Louis, MO. Bringing together trusted servants who manage local A.A. websites, the event provided an opportunity for the participants to exchange ideas on using technology to carry the life-saving message of Alcoholics Anonymous.

Forums and Other Events — Throughout the year, G.S.O. staff members are invited to attend and participate in many local and area service events, conferences and conventions. These trips help provide information about G.S.O. to A.A. gatherings and help staff to gather local experience to add to other collected experience available from G.S.O.

- **Regional Forums:** A.A.W.S. directors and G.S.O. staff have participated in four Regional Forums in 2014: the Western Canada Regional Forum in Winnipeg, Manitoba in February; the Pacific Regional Forum in Boise, Idaho in July; the Eastern Canada Regional Forum in Laval, Quebec in August; and the Southeast Regional Forum in Isla Verde, Puerto Rico in September.

- **National A.A. Archives Workshop:** G.S.O. Archivist Michelle Mirza attended the 18th National A.A. Archives Workshop held

in King of Prussia, PA, October 9–12, 2014. There were 250 in attendance, including local area and district archivists from around the United States and Canada. Michelle delivered a wonderful Power Point presentation on Friday night on the mission of G.S.O. Archives and how our team of archivists strive to fulfill that mission.

- **Intergroup/Central Office/A.A.W.S./A.A. Grapevine Seminar:** The 29th Annual Intergroup/Central Office/A.A.W.S./A.A.G.V. Seminar was held in Chicago, IL, September 25-28, 2014. Members of the A.A.W.S. and A.A.G.V. Boards, as well as management and staff from both offices, attended including the G.S.O. staff member serving as liaison to intergroup/central offices.

International — Trustees, G.S.O. general manager and the International desk staff member receive invitations from A.A. in other countries to share information regarding licensing and translations and experience with A.A. groups and trusted servants in local service structures. Highlights include:

- **23rd World Service Meeting:** 61 delegates representing over 41 countries and zones traveled to share their experience, strength and hope at the 23rd World Service Meeting held October 12-16, 2014 in Warsaw, Poland. Rick Walker did an excellent job in coordinating this event. Phyllis Halliday served as chair throughout the week, and Jim Malone, Steve Smith and Clay Rittenhouse were key in supporting the committees with reports. The energy and excitement of the attendees was contagious and invigorating. Central to the discussions, workshops and committees was an overwhelming gratitude in A.A., for serving the Fellowship and passing it on within their countries, both inside A.A. and to the public. Country sponsorships have increased and commitments have been made to continue this work. There was strong recognition of the growth and need for new translations and formats of our A.A. literature, as well as continuous support of our International Literature Fund.

- From February 20-22, 2015, Bob Wilcox (trustee-at-large/US) and G.S.O. staff member Rick Walker attended a celebration in Yokohama, Japan, marking the 40th anniversary of the first Japanese-speaking meeting in that country. There was an enthusiastic crowd of over 2,000. Bob and Rick made brief presentations on their roles at the opening ceremony. The celebration also provided several opportunities for Bob and Rick to respond to questions from trustees of their General Service Board and other A.A. members.

Financial — Complete audited financial details for 2014 are included in the Conference Manual and *Final Conference Report*. Here is an overview:

- Total contributions for the year ending December 31, 2014, were \$6,898,068 (1.4 % less than budget and .1 % less than 2013 as well).

- Gross sales for the year 2014 were \$17,128,071 (14.4 % more than budget and \$4,286,098 more than the year 2013).

- Gross margin from literature sales was \$11,943,789, approximately \$780,159 more than budget and \$2,329,151 more than 2013.

- For the year 2014, net revenues were \$568,511 (3.5 % more than budget).

- For the year 2014, total operating expenses of \$15,415,814 were approximately \$612,702 less than budget and \$431,151 or 2.9 %, greater than the prior year. Total personnel costs were approximately \$320,071 less than budgeted and \$25,320 greater than 2013.

2015 Budget: The A.A.W.S. Board approved the 2015 budget of the General Service Office with a net profit of \$197,125; after review by the trustees' Finance and Budgetary Committee, the

budget was approved by the General Service Board.

Publishing — Sales: We ended the 2014 year with \$17,128,000 in total gross sales (including digital book sales) which was \$2,152,100 (14.37%) over budget for the year.

- **Digital Publishing:** Endorsed as a 2013 Conference Advisory Action, negotiations with distributors resulted in A.A. literature being published with Apple, Barnes & Noble, and Amazon. The first publication, *Alcoholics Anonymous*, Fourth Edition (English) went live in mid-December 2013, followed by *Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions* (English) in early January 2014, followed by *Daily Reflections* and *Living Sober*. The conversion process for the remaining books continued in 2015 with “*Pass It On*,” *Dr. Bob and the Good Oldtimers*, and *Experience, Strength and Hope* — the most recent addition.

- For the year 2014, 61,927 ebook units were sold, for a total income of \$235,200.

- **International Translations:** As of December 2014, there are 68 translations of *Alcoholics Anonymous* in distribution, with 13 new translations pending. A.A.W.S. prints the Big Book in 52 languages, with 35 printed by local service structures. Fifty-three countries are licensed to print and/or distribute 1,710 publications in 53 languages. A.A.W.S. has published literature in an additional 34 languages — for a total of 87 languages. Additionally, the professional translation service supervising the process of the Navajo translation of *Alcoholics Anonymous* advised us that it is possible that the translation (in audio format) will be completed by the third or fourth quarter of 2015. We are also pleased to report that a license for digital publishing rights has been issued to Germany for the first international ebook version of the Big Book.

The A.A.W.S. Board reviewed and discussed at length our established licensing policy for granting international General Service Boards’ rights to reproduce and distribute A.A.W.S.-copyrighted literature. While it was noted that at the time the Conference Charter was written, it was not anticipated that multiple structures would form in one country, the A.A.W.S. Board agreed that the spiritual aspect behind our established policy ultimately promotes unity within each country. Accordingly, the A.A.W.S. Board has reaffirmed the current policy of one license per country.

75th Anniversary Commemorative Alcoholics Anonymous — Approximately 178,000 copies of the *75th Anniversary Commemorative Alcoholics Anonymous* were distributed in 2014. The response to the special edition Big Book was overwhelmingly positive and it was one of the main contributors to the overall level of sales for the year. We are pleased to note that the book will be on sale at the 2015 International Convention in Atlanta — and for the balance of the year.

- An early reorder of the book created an overstock situation — resulting in a significant write-off in the 2014 profit and loss against the more than \$1,600,000 in gross income.

- A specially created trilingual booklet, “A Brief History of the Big Book,” is being offered free of charge with each commemorative Big Book sold. The booklet is also being offered for sale in ten-packs.

- An eight-panel brochure, “They Needed a Book,” based on the Archives exhibit about the origin of the Big Book, is in the final stages of completion. This attractive information piece will accompany the commemorative edition and will be available in time for the 2015 International Convention.

G.S.O. and Staff Operations

- **Co-Location Project:** Following the General Service Board’s recommendation, we are moving forward with the project to co-lo-

cate the General Service Office and the A.A. Grapevine office on the 11th Floor of 475 Riverside Drive. Preconstruction planning has neared completion. The construction — slated to commence in early fall of 2015 — will be divided into five phases, with completion anticipated by January 2016.

- **2015 International Convention of Alcoholics Anonymous:** We are delighted with response of the Fellowship to the 2015 International Convention in Atlanta, Georgia, July 2-5, 2015. As of March 1, 2015, registration was at 36,344 and climbing, with over 90% registering online. We look forward to seeing you in July and celebrating “80 Years — Happy, Joyous and Free.”

- **Employees:** At year-end 2014, G.S.O. had 81 full-time employees, 3 part-time employees (2 of whom are part-time retirees), and 2 temporary employees.

- **New Employees:** In December 2014, we welcomed Cynthia Garippa to the General Service Office. Hired as our new IT manager, Cynthia has hit the ground running with a myriad of projects and cost-saving initiatives.

- **Retirees:** In December 2014, we bid a fond farewell to Doug Richardson. Doug came to the General Service Office in 1995 as an A.A. Staff member. For the last four years of his tenure, Doug served as the Director of Staff Services. We also said goodbye to Angel Calvillo, Spanish Editor in Publishing, who retired in December 2014 after more than twenty-three years, expertly translating literally thousands of words during his tenure at the General Service Office. Most recently, we bid adieu to Joe Dennen, who retired as of April 1, 2015 after a twenty-eight year tenure at the General Service Office, where he worked as staff assistant and secretary to the A.A.W.S. Board.

Last, but not least, we will bid a fond farewell to Phyllis Halliday, G.S.O.’s general manager, who announced her intent to retire as of October 2015. Phyllis’s retirement will mark the conclusion of a seven-year period of outstanding service and commitment at the General Service Office, not to mention the distinction of G.S.O.’s first female general manager. We are all grateful to Phyllis for her dedication and service, and wish her well in her new endeavors.

G.S.O. Visitors: In 2014, G.S.O. welcomed 2,213 visitors (including several groups of 10 to 60 members). It is not unusual to see visitors standing quietly with tears in their eyes in front of the multiple translations of the Serenity Prayer in the entrance hallway — many of whom have traveled great distances to visit G.S.O. and to express their gratitude for their sobriety.

Archives: One of the main highlights for visiting members is the G.S.O. Archives, where the welcoming Archives staff provides information and answers questions. Last year, the Archives staff responded to 1,480 requests for information and research — a clear indication of the Fellowship’s continued interest in A.A. history.

Reprint Requests: During 2014, A.A.W.S. granted permission/did not object to 98 requests to reprint from A.A. literature, and denied permission (including lack of authority to grant permission) to 64 requests.

The directors of A.A. World Services, Inc. and the staff of your General Service Office continue to make every effort to help carry our message of hope and recovery to those both in and out of our rooms. We much appreciate the continuing support of our great Fellowship in helping to further these efforts, and look forward to another year of “Trudging the Road of Happy Destiny” together.

William B. Noonan, chairperson A.A.W.S., Inc.

■ Literature Distributed — 2014

ENGLISH

Books

Alcoholics Anonymous	495,580
Alcoholics Anonymous (soft cover)	454,271
Alcoholics Anonymous (large print)	47,176
Alcoholics Anonymous (pocket abridged)	135,777
Alcoholics Anonymous (large print/abridged)	13,099
Alcoholics Anonymous (eBook)	20,551
Daily Reflections	156,014
Daily Reflections (eBook)	10,099
Daily Reflections (large print)	15,673
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (reg. ed.)	177,282
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (gift ed.)	4,697
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (soft cover)	193,273
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (large print)	24,538
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (pocket ed.)	44,524
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (eBook)	22,467
A.A. Comes of Age	7,431
A.A. Comes of Age (eBook)	378
As Bill Sees It	28,611
As Bill Sees It (soft cover)	24,811
As Bill Sees It (large print)	6,601
As Bill Sees It (eBook)	564
Dr. Bob and the Good Oldtimers	7,940
"Pass It On"	5,793
Experience, Strength & Hope	9,753
Total	1,906,903

Booklets

The A.A. Service Manual/ Twelve Concepts for World Service	22,255
Living Sober	147,067
Living Sober (large print)	8,488
Living Sober (eBook)	2,946
Came to Believe	46,397
Came to Believe (large print)	4,278
Came to Believe (eBook)	1,199
A.A. in Prisons: Inmate to Inmate	16,062
Total	248,692

Pamphlets

A.A. and the Armed Services	11,865
A.A. and the Gay/Lesbian Alcoholic	27,649
A.A. as a Resource for the Health Care Professional	27,286
A.A. for the Native North American	16,330
A.A. for the Woman	77,242
The A.A. Group	81,973
A.A. in Your Community	31,919
A.A. in Correctional Facilities	15,654
A.A. in Treatment Settings	15,531
The A.A. Membership Survey	18,656
The A.A. Member — Medications and Other Drugs	71,804
A.A. Tradition — How It Developed	25,823
A.A.'s Legacy of Service	11,871
A Brief Guide to Alcoholics Anonymous	109,105
Circles of Love and Service	54,262
Bridging the Gap	25,590
Members of the Clergy Ask About A.A.	13,049
The Co-Founders of Alcoholics Anonymous	9,702
Do You Think You're Different?	88,164
Frequently Asked Questions	171,108
Frequently Asked Questions (large print)	5,569
G.S.R.	37,045
A.A. Grapevine — Our Meeting in Print	15,807
How A.A. Members Cooperate	14,068

How It Works	52,172
If You Are a Professional	23,458
Inside A.A.	35,952
A.A. for the Black and African American Alcoholic	21,677
Is A.A. for You?	317,297
Is A.A. for Me?	93,052
Is There an Alcoholic in the Workplace?	13,917
Is There an Alcoholic in Your Life?	56,190
It Happened to Alice	26,367
It Sure Beats Sitting in a Cell	38,123
The Jack Alexander Article	16,741
Let's Be Friendly With Our Friends	8,673
A Member's-Eye View of A.A.	36,136
Memo to an Inmate Who May Be an Alcoholic	29,681
A Message to Correctional Professionals	9,904
A Newcomer Asks	282,913
Problems Other Than Alcohol	93,592
Questions and Answers on Sponsorship	254,214
Speaking at Non-A.A. Meetings	11,726
The Twelve Concepts for World Service Illustrated	28,448
The Twelve Steps Illustrated	49,337
Twelve Traditions Flyer	5,647
The Twelve Traditions Illustrated	52,437
This Is A.A.	231,978
This Is A.A. (large print)	5,649
Three Talks to Medical Societies by Bill W.	12,298
A.A. for the Older Alcoholic (lrg Print)	40,401
Too Young?	45,264
Understanding Anonymity	54,318
What Happened to Joe	27,341
Young People and A.A.	77,089
A.A. for the Alcoholic with Special Needs	13,502
Many Paths to Spirituality	80,728
Total	3,123,294

Miscellaneous

Wallet cards-two-fold	224,495
Wallet cards-I Am Responsible	41,739
Wallet cards-Anonymity	29,235
Anonymity Display Card	1,800
Parchment-scrolls	1,854
Placards	313
C.P.C. Workbook	1,113
Archives Workbook	652
Corrections Workbook	833
P.I. Workbook	1,269
Treatment Facilities Workbook	1,111
Treatment Facility Kit	292
Special Needs Workbook	400
A.A. Guidelines	73,010
Group Handbook	2,115
Wire Racks	1,348
Audio CDs	534
DVDs	4,264
Alcoholics Anonymous (4th Ed cd album)	2,208
A.A. Comes of Age (cd album)	285
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (cassette album)	21
Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions (cd album)	1,040
TV Public Service Announcement	240
Radio Public Service Announcements	122
Twelve Steps Shade displays	1,443
Twelve Traditions Shade displays	1,306
Fact File	1,931
Table Top Display 12 & 12	389
Living Sober (cd album)	294
Total	395,656
Grand Total	5,674,545

SPANISH

Books & Booklets

Alcohólicos Anónimos (Alcoholics Anonymous soft cover)	11,074
Alcohólicos Anónimos (Alcoholics Anonymous hardcover)	9,991
Alcohólicos Anónimos (Alcoholics Anonymous abridged pocket size)	5,149
Alcohólicos Anónimos (Alcoholics Anonymous Large Print)	3,548
Alcohólicos Anónimos (Alcoholics Anonymous Large Print/Abridged)	557
Alcohólicos Anónimos (Alcoholics Anonymous) (eBook)	185
Como Lo Ve Bill (As Bill Sees It)	4,085
A.A. Llega a su Mayoría de Edad (A.A. Comes of Age)	1,949
El Dr. Bob y los Buenos Veteranos (Dr. Bob and the Good Oldtimers)	2,160
Transmitelo (Pass it On)	2,064
Reflexiones Diarias (Daily Reflections)	7,739
Reflexiones Diarias (Daily Reflections) (eBook)	94
Viviendo Sobrio (Living Sober)	10,948
Viviendo Sobrio (Living Sober) (eBook)	39
El Manual de Servicios de A.A./ Doce Conceptos para el Servicio Mundial (A.A. Service Manual/Twelve Concepts)	2,969
Doce Pasos y Doce Tradiciones (Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions)	14,799
Doce Pasos y Doce Tradiciones (Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions) (eBook)	159
Llegamos a Creer (Came to Believe)	5,133
A.A. en Prisiones de Preso a Preso (Inmate to Inmate)	4,884
Doce Pasos y Doce Tradiciones (pocket ed.)	3,121
Doce Pasos y Doce Tradiciones (large print)	4,411
De las tinieblas hacia la luz	3,189
Total	98,247

Pamphlets

A.A. en Su Comunidad (A.A. in Your Community)	4,080
44 Preguntas (44 Questions)	17,542
Esto es A.A. (This is A.A.)	18,639
Es A.A. para Usted? (Is A.A. for You?)	47,201
Hay un Alcohólico en su Vida? (Is There an Alcoholic in Your Life?)	4,715
Carta a un Preso que Puede Ser Un Alcohólico (Memo to an Inmate)	3,756
El Punto de Vista de un Miembro de A.A. (A Member's-Eye View)	1,985
Alcohólicos Anónimos por Jack Alexander (Jack Alexander Article)	1,848
Seamos amistosos con nuestros amigos (Let's be Friendly with our Friends)	1,121
Tres Charlas a Sociedades Medicas por Bill W (Three Talks to Medical Societies)	3,426
Un Principiante Pregunta (A Newcomer Asks)	7,227
Como Trabaja el Programa (How It Works)	3,852
Lo que le Sucedió a José (What Happened to Joe)	4,872
Comprendiendo el Anonimato (Understanding Anonymity)	2,820
El Grupo de A.A. (The A.A. Group)	5,692
Preguntas y Respuestas sobre el Apadrinamiento (Questions and Answers on Sponsorship)	5,744
El Miembro de A.A. — Los Medicamentos y Otras Drogas (The A.A. Member — Medications and Other Drugs)	3,273
Las Doce Tradiciones Ilustradas (The Twelve Traditions Illustrated)	4,431

A.A. en Centros de Tratamiento (A.A. in Treatment Centers)	1,028
Los Jóvenes y A.A. (Young People and A.A.)	5,742
La Tradición de A.A. — ¿Cómo se Desarrolló? (A.A. Tradition — How It Developed)	2,192
Una Breve Guía a A.A. (A Brief Guide to A.A.)	9,037
A.A. en las Instituciones Correccionales (A.A. in Correctional Facilities)	1,715
Problemas Diferentes del Alcohol (Problems Other Than Alcohol)	3,957
Es Mejor que Estar Sentado en una Celda (It Sure Beats Sitting In a Cell)	4,185
¿Cómo Cooperan los Miembros de A.A.? (How A.A. Members Cooperate)	1,702
Dentro de A.A. (Inside A.A.)	2,705
A.A. como Recurso para los Profesionales de la Salud (A.A. as a Resource for the Health Care Professional)	1,180
Un Ministro Religioso Pregunta Acerca de A.A. (The Clergy Asks)	1,407
R.S.G. (G.S.R.)	2,289
¿Se Cree Usted Diferente? (Do You Think Your Different?)	5,782
Le Sucedió a Alicia (It Happened to Alice)	3,895
Hablando en Reuniones no-A.A. Speaking at non-A.A. Meetings	1,388
A.A. Para la Mujer (A.A. for the Woman)	6,953
Encuesta Sobre los Miembros de A.A. (A.A. Membership Survey)	925
¿Hay un alcohólico en el lugar de trabajo? (Is there an alcoholic in the workplace?)	2,546
Es A.A. Para Mi? (Is A.A. for Me?)	9,070
A.A. para el alcohólico de edad avanzada (A.A. for the older alcoholic)	3,693
Los Doce Pasos Ilustrados (The Twelve Steps Illustrated)	4,613
Círculos de Amor y Servicio (Circles of Love & Service)	2,940
Uniendo las Orillas (Bridging the Gap)	2,271
Los Doce Conceptos Ilustrados (Twelve Concepts Illustrated)	3,248
A.A. para los alcohólicos gays/lesbianas (A.A. for the Gay and Lesbian Alcoholic)	1,551
El Legado de Servicio de A.A. (A.A. Legacy of Service)	804
Si Usted es un Profesional (If you are a Professional)	1,486
El Grapevine y La Viña de A.A. (Grapevine Our Meeting in Print)	1,668
¿Demasiado Joven? (Too Young?)	2,914
Alcohólico Necesidades Especiales AA for the Alcoholic with Special Needs	657
Muchas sendas hacia espiritualidad Many Paths to Spirituality	893
Total	236,660
Grand Total	334,907

FRENCH

Livres (Books)

Les Alcooliques Anonymes (Alcoholics Anonymous — format relie)	3,387
Les Alcooliques Anonymes (Alcoholics Anonymous — format souple)	1,070
Les Alcooliques Anonymes (Alcoholics Anonymous — format poche)	484
Les Alcooliques Anonymes (Alcoholics Anonymous — large print)	864
Les Alcooliques Anonymes (Alcoholics Anonymous — large print/abridged)	45
Les Alcooliques Anonymes	

(Alcoholics Anonymous) (eBook)	202
Les Douze Etapes et les Douze Traditions (Twelve & Twelve — format relie)	1,779
Les Douze Etapes et les Douze Traditions (Twelve & Twelve — format souple)	917
Les Douze Etapes et les Douze Traditions (Twelve & Twelve — large print)	384
Les Douze Etapes et les Douze Traditions (Twelve & Twelve — format poche)	442
Les Douze Etapes et les Douze Traditions (Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions) (eBook)	98
Le Mouvement des A.A. devient Adulte (A.A. Comes of Age)	242
Reflexions de Bill (As Bill Sees It)	1,901
Reflexions Quotidiennes (Daily Reflections)	3,306
Reflexions Quotidiennes (Daily Reflections) (eBook)	74
Dr Bob et les pionniers (Dr. Bob and the Good Oldtimers)	241
Expérience, Force & Espoir (Experience, Strength and Hope)	289
Transmets-Le (Pass It On)	445
Les A.A. en Prison (A.A. in Prison)	557
Total	16,727

Plaquettes (Booklets)

Nous en sommes venus a croire (Came to Believe)	1,270
Vivre ... sans alcool! (Living Sober)	3,050
Vivre... sans alcool! (Living Sober) (eBook)	1
Le Manuel du Service et les Douze Concepts	1,149
Total	5,470

Brochures (Pamphlets)

Voici les A.A. (This is A.A.)	7,144
Les A.A.: 44 Questions (44 Questions)	2,418
Les A.A.: sont-ils pour vous? (Is A.A. for You?)	9,347
Les A.A. pour la femme (A.A. for the Woman)	1,944
Collaboration des membres des A.A. (How A.A. Members Cooperate)	525
Y a-t-il un Alcoolique dans Votre Milieu de travail? (Is there an alcoholic in the workplace?)	628
Le membre des A.A. face aux médicaments et a la drogue (The A.A. Member — Medications & Other Drugs)	1,104
Les A.A. — Article du Saturday Evening Post (The Jack Alexander Article)	366
Collaborons avec nos amis (Let's Be Friendly With Our Friends)	181
Questions et reponses sur le parrainage (Questions and Answers on Sponsorship)	1,597
Les A.A.: Une ressource pour les medecins (A.A. as a Resource for the Health Care Professional)	1,706
Les A.A. dans les centres de traitement (A.A. in Treatment Facilities)	337
La Tradition des A.A. et son developpement (A.A. Tradition/How It Developed)	379
Vous vous occupez prof. d'alcoolisme? (If You Are a Professional)	523
L'Histoire de Nicole (It Happened to Alice)	367
Jean face a son probleme d'alcool (What Happened to Joe)	358
Les A.A. dans votre milieu (A.A. in Your Community)	584
Problemes autres que l'alcoolisme (Problems Other Than Alcohol)	1,563
Point de vue d'un membre sur les A.A. (A Member's-Eye View of A.A.)	121
Les Douze Traditions illustrees (The Twelve Traditions Illustrated)	1,596
Les A.A. dans les etablissements correctionnels (A.A. in Correctional Facilities)	509

Ca vaut mieux que de languir en prison (It Sure Beats Sitting in a Cell)	836
Petit guide pratique sur les A.A. (A Brief Guide to A.A.)	1,997
Les membres du clerge se renseignent (Members of the Clergy Ask About A.A.)	178
Les deux fondateurs d'A.A. (The Co-founders of A.A.)	116
Message a l'intention d'un detenu (Memo to an Inmate)	531
Message aux Dir. d'Etabl. Correctionnels (Message to Correctional Facilities Administrators)	212
Le groupe des A.A. (The A.A. Group)	2,068
Les Douze Concepts illustres (Twelve Concepts Illustrated)	1,073
Le sens de l'anonymat (Understanding Anonymity)	1,870
Trois causeries a des societes medicales (Three Talks to Medical Societies)	301
Y-a-t-il un alcoolique dans votre vie? (Is There an Alcoholic in Your Life?)	973
Le R.S.G. (The G.S.R.)	1,260
Causeries a l'exterieur des A.A. (Speaking at Non-A.A. Meetings)	157
Trop jeune? (Too Young?)	1,231
La Structure de l'Association des A.A. (Inside A.A.)	944
L'Heritage des Services des A.A. (A.A.'s Legacy of Service)	475
Cercles d'amour et de service (Circles of Love & Service)	993
Vous croyez-vous different? (Do You Think You're Different?)	914
Sondage sur les membres des A.A. (The A.A. Membership Survey)	1,026
Les jeunes et les A.A. (Young People & A.A.)	1,576
Votre B.S.G. (Your G.S.O.)	1,742
AA pour l'alcoolique plus age (AA for the older alcoholic)	1,404
Un nouveau veut savoir (A Newcomer Asks)	4,168
Les A.A. sont-ils pour moi? (Is A.A. for Me?)	1,512
Favoriser de rapprochement (Bridging the Gap)	421
Les Douze Etapes Illustrees (Twelve Steps Illustrated)	758
Les A.A. et les gais et lesbiennes alcooliques (A.A. for the Gay and Lesbian Alcoholic)	261
Les A.A. et les Autochtones d'Amerique du Nord (A.A. and the Native North American)	103
Pour L'alcoolique Besoins Speciaux (A.A. for the Alcoholic with Special Needs)	407
Différentes avenues la spiritualité (Many Paths to Spirituality)	1,555
Lignes de conduite A.A. (Guidelines)	1,959
Total	66,318

Divers (Miscellaneous)

12 & 12 (cd album)	317
Les Alcooliques Anonymes (cd album)	326
Carte 12 Etapes/12 Traditions (Wallet card 12 Steps & 12 Traditions)	1,793
Carte anonymat (Francais/anglais) (Anonymity wallet card)	857
Carte Je Suis Responsable (I am responsible wallet card)	400
Notre Methode (How It Works)	14,852
Pochette de l'Information Publique	10
Pochette de la CMP	10
Prière de la Sérénité (12x16) (Parchment Serenity Prayer)	31
Dossier d'Information sur les A.A. (Fact File)	60
Total	18,656
Grand Total	107,171



A.A. GRAPEVINE, INC.

Directors' report: A.A. Grapevine, Inc. is one of two affiliate corporations of the General Service Board and the multimedia publisher of Grapevine magazine content, available on various platforms and in a variety of formats. A.A. Grapevine, Inc. also publishes Spanish-language content in La Viña magazine and its related book, CD and audio formats.

By charter, the A.A. Grapevine Board consists of seven to ten directors. Since the 64th Conference, there have been eight directors: two general service trustees; two regional trustees; three nontrustee directors; and the executive editor/publisher.

As a rule, the purpose of the Grapevine Corporate Board is to serve the A.A. Fellowship in the following ways:

- To oversee the publishing operations of A.A. Grapevine, Inc.
- To provide sound financial management of the corporation.
- To establish corporate policies and set corporate priorities.
- To engage in the ongoing process of strategic planning.
- To operate in accordance with the principles of A.A. as expressed in the Twelve Steps, Twelve Traditions, and Twelve Concepts.

The board strives to engage the Fellowship and to ensure members' awareness of the myriad of possible uses for the tools provided to help carry the message!

The A.A. Grapevine Board met in person seven times since the last Conference and once via an all-day teleconference. In 2014-2015, two standing committees were active: the Nominating Committee, chaired by Bill Farnsworth, facilitated all facets in the selection of candidates for board openings and selecting a general service trustee; the Finance & Budget Committee, chaired by Albin Zezula, provided oversight for the budget process. Three ad hoc committees were continued: the Governance Committee, chaired by Nancy Haynes; the Grass Roots Committee, chaired by Ed Martin; and the Carry the Message Committee, chaired by Lynda Bergeron. The A.A. Grapevine Board is considering changes to its committee structure: (1) expanding the scope of the Nominating Committee to include the items handled by the ad hoc Governance Committee; and (2) combining the ad hoc Grass Roots and Carry the Message Committees into one new ad hoc committee for the coming year. The Editorial Advisory Board, consisting of members with particular expertise in media, met five times, always by teleconference in 2014.

Since the last Conference, A.A. Grapevine, Inc. has produced 12 issues of Grapevine, six issues of La Viña, an annual wall

calendar and pocket planner, and two ebooks. La Viña magazine continues to be published in 64 pages in response to the 2010 Conference Advisory Action to maintain spiritual parity with Grapevine magazine.

A.A. Grapevine, Inc. distributed 106,158 Grapevine and La Viña books, CDs, and other items, including the two latest book titles: *Sober and Out* featuring stories by A.A. members who are lesbian, gay, bisexual, and transgendered (and a few friends) and *The Grapevine Daily Quote Book*, a compilation of the Grapevine Daily Quotes from the previous year.

Circulation — Grapevine's average monthly print circulation was 74,000 in fiscal year 2014 (this is more than budget by 599 and less than 2013 by 3,126). The Grapevine Online (GVO) averaged 5,262 subscribers in 2014. The average bimonthly circulation of La Viña was 10,379 (this is 228 less than budget and 234 above 2013 levels).

Operations — During 2014, A.A. Grapevine continued operational cost-control measures resulting in expenses coming in under budget.

Financial — Complete and audited financial details for 2014 are included in the Conference Manual and Final Conference Report. Here is an overview:

- Grapevine ended 2014 with net income of \$325,828 against budgeted net income of \$98,240.
- Gross profit for the magazine and subscription products reached \$1,529,063. Gross Profit on the magazine was ahead of budget by \$146,945.
- Gross Profit on books and related items was \$509,303.
- Overhead Costs were budgeted at \$1,820,694 versus an actual of \$1,719,637. This was a savings of \$101,056. This savings occurred mainly in Website Expenses and General and Administrative Expenses.

La Viña — La Viña is published by A.A. Grapevine, Inc., and expenses not covered by income are funded by the General Service Board as a service to the Fellowship. La Viña had an average circulation of 10,379 per issue. Gross Profit on the magazine was \$59,447. This is ahead of budget by \$2,180. Gross Profit on Related Items was ahead of budget by \$2,433, and overhead was under budget by \$4,935. The net cost for 2014 was \$132,026, or \$9,548 less than was budgeted.

A.A. Grapevine and the Reserve Fund — A.A. Grapevine maintains a balance in the Reserve Fund to fund its unfulfilled subscription liability. The balance at December 31, 2014 was

\$1,943,500, and the actual subscription liability as of that date was \$1,920,000, meaning that the liability is overfunded. In March 2015, A.A. Grapevine, Inc. had excess working capital and made a transfer of \$240,000 into the Reserve Fund. This is the second year in a row in which A.A. Grapevine, Inc. was able to make a substantial transfer of excess working capital to the Reserve Fund. The A.A. Grapevine Board continues to be deeply grateful to the staff for these tremendous achievements.

Website — The website was redesigned to better serve the Fellowship and to engage a wider and more diverse audience; it remains central to Grapevine's current and future plans. Month end December 2014 reports indicate that an average of 43,598 unique visitors visit an average of 3.19 pages on aagrapevine.org each month. A dedicated web page, aagrapevine.org/GV70, provided information and downloadable resources to assist anyone who wanted to have a GV 70th anniversary event during 2014. A new web page, aagrapevine.org/Challenge, has been created to track the progress of the 2015 Subscription Challenge (see below for further details).

Also featured is a calendar for local events throughout 2014 and seven new free audio stories. A centralized audio page was established on the website for Grapevine's audio offerings, including a showcase for the Audio Project, offering up to 7 minutes-long recorded stories submitted by members; 210 audio stories have been received and have been archived to date.

Grapevine and La Viña launched the 2015 Subscription Challenge earlier this year. This is a challenge for each state, province and territory to increase new Grapevine and La Viña subscriptions in 2015, between January 26 through December 20. All new subscriptions for Grapevine or La Viña in print, digital, or Grapevine Complete count towards the totals. Redeemed Subscription Gift Certificates also count, but they must be redeemed. The state, province or territory with the greatest percentage growth in new paid subscriptions or subscription gift certificates will have a special section in a 2016 issue of Grapevine or La Viña featuring members' stories from that state, province or territory.

Grapevine offers a complimentary Grapevine Daily Quote, featuring excerpts drawn from the archives of classic Grapevine literature. Selections are posted daily on aagrapevine.org and may be requested on an opt-in basis for daily email delivery. Subscriptions number 31,984 as of March 2015.

Grapevine and La Viña subscribers are committed to the print magazine, for personal use and as an invaluable Twelfth Step tool, and, in keeping with the Fellowship's desire and support, the print publications will continue. At the same time, Grapevine's online offerings have the potential to continue to attract new subscribers with few conversions from print. AAGrapevine.org is becoming the premiere connection with the Fellowship; the majority of subscriptions/purchases now occur online, and digital communications are both effective and cost saving. About 25% of AAGV's online subscribers opt for both the online services and the print magazine. Offered as a bundle, the Grapevine Online subscription provides unlimited access to previously unpublished stories, Audio Grapevine, the Story Archive and the current online issues of both Grapevine and La Viña.

At current prices, GV's basic online subscription costs subscribers about ten cents a day, and the print subscription is eight

cents per day. The GVB and management team's efforts continue to broaden awareness of the magazines, books, audio and website to carry the message through an expanded subscriber base. Limited Fellowship New Vision (FNV) list-sharing efforts with A.A.W.S. have contributed to the growth of the informational quarterly email newsletter "Grapevine and Your Group." In addition, Grapevine and La Viña subscription options were included in the International Convention online registration forms and as of March 1, 2015, 737 registrants chose to subscribe to either the Grapevine or La Viña. The Grapevine Board is seeking to expand these efforts, including seeking new connections through opt-in choices on roundup or conference registrations. Organization-wide support is essential to the continued health of AAGV, Inc.

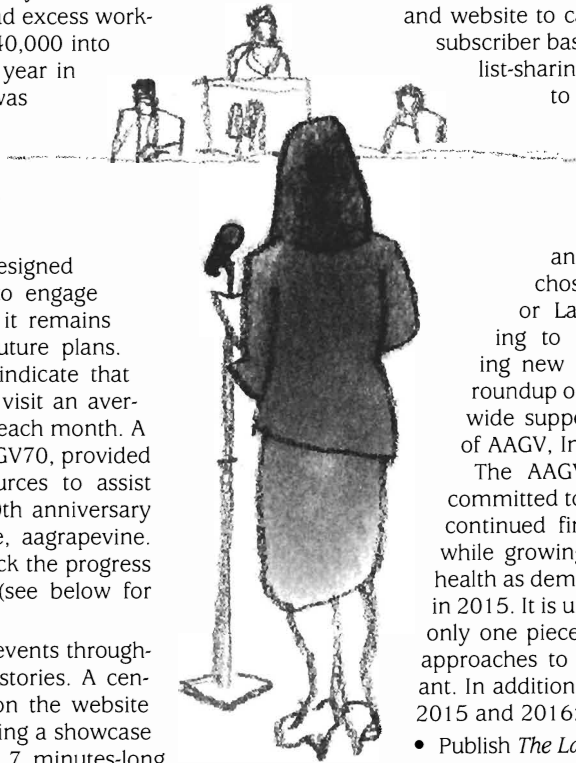
The AAGV Board and management team are committed to self-support, and A.A. Grapevine, Inc.'s continued financial vitality, with member support, while growing and evolving. The focus on financial health as demonstrated throughout 2014 will continue in 2015. It is understood that cost reduction represents only one piece of the break-even formula, while new approaches to additional revenue are equally important. In addition, the Grapevine Board is considering for 2015 and 2016:

- Publish *The Language of the Heart* in audiobook format.
- Development of a mobile-friendly version of the Grapevine.

- Preparations for the Grapevine and La Viña presence at the 2015 International Convention in Atlanta.
- Continue expanded communications with groups directly through broader use of group contact information provided through Fellowship New Vision (FNV).
- Exploring the use of opt-in selections on local roundup and conference registration forms for those who wish to receive Grapevine email messages.
- Publish a GV commemorative item for the International Convention in Atlanta in 2015.
- Offer existing GV CD content in MP3 formats.
- Reimagine the GV website for increased currency and relevancy, including the introduction of regional pages.
- Publish audio content through third-party vendors.
- Expand the digital subscriber base and communications.
- Proceed with the move to the 11th floor office space after a remodel is finished later in 2015.
- Provide a rewarding and supportive work environment for staff, including training and development in line with stated objectives.

As a mirror of the membership, Grapevine both reflects and belongs to the Fellowship. For over 70 years, Grapevine has conveyed the "Voices of A.A." as a tool for many in recovery, evolving over time and reliably carrying the message to anyone who reaches out for the hand of A.A. Should the Fellowship desire that Grapevine and La Viña continue into the future — for alcoholics and friends, many of whom may not know about A.A. yet — additional subscribers will be required. Organization-wide support for A.A. Grapevine, Inc. is integral to this effort, to our history and to our future.

Andrew Ware, chairperson



Books

Best of Bill (Hard Cover)	1,571
Best of Bill (Soft Cover)	4,578
Best of Bill — Large Print (Soft Cover)	1,043
Best of Bill — French (Soft Cover)	1,823
The Home Group — French (Soft Cover)	488
Le Langage Du Coeur	622
En Tete a Tete	4,037
The Language of the Heart (Hard Cover)	2,497
El Lenguaje del Corazón	2,356
Best of the Grapevine I (Soft Cover)	394
A.A. Around the World	268
The Language of the Heart (Soft Cover)	3,492
Thank You For Sharing	476
Spiritual Awakenings	2,417
The Home Group — Revised (Soft Cover)	1,194
I Am Responsible: The Hand of AA (Soft Cover)	539
Emotional Sobriety (Soft Cover)	5,915
The Language of the Heart (Large Print)	608
In Our Own Words	638
Beginners' Book	3,337
Voices of Long-Term Sobriety	1,016
A Rabbit Walks Into a Bar	2,178
Spiritual Awakenings II	1,445
Step By Step	2,105
Emotional Sobriety II (Soft Cover)	3,187
Young and Sober	1,793
Into Action	1,533
Happy, Joyous & Free	2,087
One On One	3,846
No Matter What	3,133
Grapevine Daily Quote Book	8,694
Sober and Out	3,328
Best of Bill — Spanish	2,465
Lo Mejor de la Viña	933
El Grupo Base	1,419
Total:	77,455

E-books

The Language of the Heart	1,131
Best of Bill	1,222
Best of Bill — Spanish	73
Step by Step	94
Emotional Sobriety I	848
Emotional Sobriety II	262
Spiritual Awakenings I	151
Spiritual Awakenings II	63
Young and Sober	26
Into Action	56
Happy, Joyous & Free	111
Other	1,009
Total:	5,046

CDs - English

1,760

CDs - Spanish

1,820

Total: 3,580

Miscellaneous

20,077

Grand Total 106,158

	APRIL 2015	APRIL 2014	INCREASE/ DECREASE
UNITED STATES*			
Alabama	525	575	(50)
Alaska	410	370	40
Arizona	1,474	1,434	40
Arkansas	378	394	(16)
California	6,542	6,613	(71)
Colorado	1,298	1,330	(32)
Connecticut	951	1,003	(52)
Delaware	299	300	(1)
District of Columbia	150	138	12
Florida	3,971	3,970	1
Georgia	1,719	1,713	6
Hawaii	356	334	22
Idaho	500	477	23
Illinois	2,257	2,385	(128)
Indiana	1,050	1,038	12
Iowa	642	694	(52)
Kansas	681	746	(65)
Kentucky	590	635	(45)
Louisiana	555	568	(13)
Maine	434	466	(32)
Maryland	957	975	(18)
Massachusetts	1,675	1,763	(88)
Michigan	2,269	2,261	8
Minnesota	1,791	1,895	(104)
Mississippi	306	326	(20)
Missouri	1,161	1,178	(17)
Montana	426	486	(60)
Nebraska	603	610	(7)
Nevada	654	673	(19)
New Hampshire	433	481	(48)
New Jersey	2,014	2,092	(78)
New Mexico	446	483	(37)
New York	3,873	4,172	(299)
North Carolina	1,759	1,664	95
North Dakota	288	300	(12)
Ohio	1,803	1,780	23
Oklahoma	540	526	14
Oregon	1,151	1,166	(15)
Pennsylvania	3,877	4,039	(162)
Rhode Island	236	227	9
South Carolina	639	685	(46)
South Dakota	244	265	(21)
Tennessee	721	791	(70)
Texas	2,645	2,699	(54)
Utah	371	421	(50)
Vermont	257	268	(11)
Virginia	1,669	1,801	(132)
Washington	2,056	2,027	29
West Virginia	271	268	3
Wisconsin	1,681	1,735	(54)
Wyoming	204	223	(19)
Puerto Rico	19	15	4
U.S. Possessions/APO	49	42	7
Virgin Islands	34	31	3
Subtotal US	61,904	63,551	(1,647)
CANADA*			
Alberta/NWT	714	708	6
British Columbia/YKN	856	923	(67)
Manitoba	274	288	(14)
New Brunswick/PEI	208	232	(24)
Nova Scotia/ Newfoundland/Labrador	290	345	(55)
Ontario	2,671	2,832	(161)
Quebec	243	235	8
Saskatchewan	300	342	(42)
Subtotal Canada	5,556	5,905	(349)
FOREIGN*			
(59)	669	728	
Grand Total	68,129	70,184	(2,055)
LA VI—A SUBSCRIPTIONS*			
	Mar./Apr. '15	Mar./Apr. '14	Diff.
	7,893	8,273	(380)

(*does not include monthly orders)

■ Trustees' Committees and G.S.O. and Grapevine Reports

ARCHIVES

Trustees' report: The trustees' Archives Committee was established by the General Service Board and held its first meeting in October 1973. This committee is responsible for developing and implementing the policies that govern the Archives services and makes recommendations to the General Service Board on Archives procedures and budget. Through its group conscience, and guided by A.A.'s principles and professional standards, the committee undertakes and upholds responsibility and authority for the maintenance and use of the Archives.

The committee supports the G.S.O. Archives' commitment to permit access to members of Alcoholics Anonymous and others for research purposes. The committee, since the 2014 General Service Conference, granted permission to nine researchers for use of archival material. The permission also included access to archival audio recordings for limited use. Each request is carefully considered through recommendations from the Archivist and established Archives policies. The permission to conduct research is granted conditional on a signed agreement to strictly maintain the anonymity of all members, alive and deceased, including A.A.'s cofounders.

At the committee's first meeting in August, we made our annual review of the History and Actions and noted some significant actions and Archives policies. We reviewed the report of the 2014 Conference Archives Committee and noted that the revised video *Markings on the Journey*, approved by the 64th General Service Conference, is now available for distribution. In response to the Additional Committee Consideration on adding sharing of experience in the Archives Workbook, the committee noted that there are resources available on preservation and legal issues concerning Archives in the Archives Workbook and on the "Archives and History" portal of G.S.O.'s A.A. website. The committee added that sharing from local archives on preservation could be included in a future printing of the Archives Workbook.

We formed a subcommittee to review the Archives "Sound and Video Access Policies." At the committee's November meeting, a revised policy, which included substantive changes in procedures and a new title, "Sound and Moving Image Access Policies and Procedures," was approved.

In considering a research request to consult recordings of the General Service Conferences, the committee requested that the Archivist prepare historical background on the 1984 Advisory Action regarding General Service Conference recordings. Following review and discussion of the report, the committee recommended the following suggestion for revision be forwarded to the 2015 Conference Committee on Policy/Admissions:

Recordings of General Service Conference presentations be made available for distribution, in accordance with Archives' Policies, to include audio recordings of keynote presentations; other selected presentations; talks from the Opening Dinner A.A. meeting and the trustees' farewell talks given at the closing brunch. Access to all other General Service Conference sessions will continue to be prohibited.

The committee asked the Archivist to share on how digital material is managed in the Archives. The Archivist noted that the Archives' Deed

of Gift form should be amended to include an addenda for accepting digital items. We requested that a review of the Deed of Gift form be made at the committee's meeting in August 2015.

Throughout the year, we were kept apprised of projects executed by the Archives staff, as well as tabulated research inquiries handled by the staff. The archivist also informed the committee of projected goals outlined for the upcoming year.

Frances Brisbane, chairperson

Archivist's report: The mission of the General Service Office Archives is to permanently document the work of Alcoholics Anonymous, to make the history of the organization accessible to A.A. members and other researchers, and to provide a context for understanding A.A.'s progression, principles and traditions. The Archives staff assumes full ownership of the material under our care. This means that we exercise professional judgment in acquiring, appraising, organizing, preserving, securing and managing the vast array of historical material we manage.

The Archives staff provides resource material and service to A.A. members, researchers and others about A.A. history, responds to worldwide information requests, and offers professional support to local areas, districts or groups interested in researching their history. In 2014, we responded to over 1,550 requests for information. This is one of the many ways that we are committed to rendering service to the A.A. community and others. We welcomed new local archivists and committee chairs serving either in the area or district position and furnished each individual with an Archives Workbook, Guidelines and other resources. A revised printing of the Workbook became available in September and contains a new section, "Sharing On Digital Archives."

We endeavor to raise awareness of A.A.'s history and archives through our electronic newsletter, *Markings: Your Archives eNewsletter*. The newsletter is published three times a year, in English, Spanish and French, and delivered to subscribers via A.A.'s Digital Delivery system.

We have been reporting on our ongoing multiyear project that involves the development of the Archives audio catalog. This project, which commenced in 2012, requires listening to over three thousand recordings of oldtimers, early friends of A.A. and others. The collection includes a series of oral history interviews conducted by Bill W. in the 1950's, talks of significant early friends who supported the fledgling Fellowship and other valuable recordings. Thus far, we have completed listening to and cataloging over 2,000 recordings; we anticipate completing the cataloging project by June 2015.

In keeping with our mission, the Archives associate archivists and senior archivist worked with several personal collections and papers to preserve, arrange and create Finding-Aids. One of the collections include the papers of David Aronofsky, a former Panel 27 delegate who later served as trustee-at-large/U.S. The Archives staff also processed papers from former chairpersons of the General Service Board: Jim Estelle, Leonard Blumenthal and Elaine McDowell.

Another ongoing project instituted in 2013 entailed the scanning of early group correspondence from the United States, Canada and around the world (1940s through



1950s). The scanning assistant has digitized thousands of letters from Alabama through New York. The original letters are preserved for permanent storage in the Archives' secured offsite facility while user copies are maintained onsite. We anticipate a completion date of this project by December 2016.

The G.S.O. A.A. website, redesign last year, provided an opportunity to restructure the "Archives and History" portal. The newly redesigned portal strives to provide an extraordinary and educational experience to end-users. The overall goals being twofold: to present an interface that allows the users to travel through the site efficiently; and to enhance the appearance of the site by adding visual details, such as graphics. We continue to build the audio archives on the website and last year added excerpts of a talk by Sister Ignatia on the early days of A.A. and working with Dr. Bob.

In commemoration of the 75th Anniversary of the book *Alcoholics Anonymous* in April, the Archives staff created a Timeline exhibit on the publishing history of the book, titled "They needed a book." We also created a new travel exhibit that can be made available for use by local committees at various A.A. events.

None of this work would be possible without the help of a very capable team of archivists, working to ensure that we fulfill our mission and goals.

Finally, the Archives staff extends gratitude to those members and others who have generously donated material to the Archives within the past twelve months.

Michelle Mirza, archivist

AUDIT COMMITTEE

Trustees' report: The trustees' Audit Committee, formed by the General Service Board in 2003, is composed of a minimum of three and a maximum of five trustees who are appointed by the chairman of the General Service Board. The committee was created as a proactive measure to assist the General Service Board in fulfilling its fiduciary obligation of Prudent Corporate Governance.

The committee meets, at least twice a year, with the outside auditor and G.S.O. and Grapevine management; separately with the auditor; and in executive session without the auditor. The Audit Committee reports to the General Service Board and reviews such items as audit process, audit results, internal controls, best accounting practices, and management integrity. The Audit Committee also recommends appointment of the auditor to the board.

David Morris, chairperson

COMPENSATION COMMITTEE

Trustees' report: The trustees' Compensation Committee, formed in 2006 by the General Service Board, consists of at least four trustees. The committee was created as a proactive measure to assist the General Service Board in fulfilling its fiduciary obligation of Prudent Corporate Governance.

The Compensation Committee reports to the General Service Board and reviews and advises A.A. World Services, Inc. (A.A.W.S.) and A.A. Grapevine, (AAGV) Inc. on such items as overall compensation philosophies and policies, best compensation practices, and compliance with the IRS for executive compensation for nonprofit organizations.

The Compensation Committee reviewed and revised the list of comparable organizations for A.A. World Services, Inc. and A.A. Grapevine, Inc. The committee worked with A.A.W.S. and A.A.G.V. to obtain the services of Astron Solutions to prepare

compensation studies for the highest-paid executives in each corporation. The committee received the reports and met with Astron Solutions via teleconference, both in general session and in executive session. The reports indicated that all salaries reviewed are within reasonable levels and do not represent excessive compensation.

J. Gary Lutz, chairperson

CONFERENCE

Trustees' report: The committee met three times since the 2014 General Service Conference. During that period, we reviewed the Report of the 2014 Conference Agenda Committee and the Advisory Actions pertaining to the Conference, including the theme chosen for the 65th General Service Conference, "Celebrating 80 Years of Recovery, Unity and Service — The Foundation for Our Future."

The committee discussed the Summary of the Evaluation from members of the 64th G.S.C. and the notes of the G.S.O. Sharing Session and noted the overall positive feedback.

The committee also noted that the 2014 Conference Advisory Action regarding translation of G.S.C. background will be considered by the trustees' Committee on Finance. The committee reviewed the report of the 2014 Conference Agenda Committee and agreed to create a subcommittee in response to two Additional Committee Considerations:

- The committee reviewed and discussed their Composition, Scope and Procedure and agreed that point #3 of the current Scope, which is to consider "The Conference Agenda, and where appropriate, to make suggestions for improvement to the trustees' Committee on the Conference," is ambiguous. The committee requested that the trustees' Committee on the Conference explore the potential role that the Conference Committee on Agenda might play in the selection process of Agenda items in the future and provide a report to the 2015 Conference Agenda committee.
- The committee requested that the 2015 Conference Agenda Committee be provided with a report regarding the current and historical process of Agenda item selection.

The committee accepted and agreed to forward to the 2015 Conference Agenda Committee the report from the trustees' Committee on the General Service Conference on the Conference Agenda Process, developed in response to two Additional Committee Considerations from the 2014 Conference Agenda Committee.

The committee also agreed that point #3 of the current Conference Agenda Committee Scope, which is to consider "The Conference Agenda and, where appropriate, to make suggestions for improvement to the trustees' Committee on the Conference," refers to the calendar or schedule of Conference week. The committee agreed to forward the suggestion that the Conference Agenda Committee add a review of the Conference week schedule (Conference Agenda) to the standing items on their agenda.

In response to the report's recommendation that the trustees' Committee on the General Service Conference send highlights of their meetings to the Conference Agenda Committee, the committee recommended to the General Service Board that point #2 of the Procedure in the trustees' Committee on the General Service Conference's Composition, Scope and Procedure be revised to read, "Following the quarterly meetings, meeting highlights are sent to the Conference Agenda Committee and reported in the Quarterly Report." [Recommendation approved by the G.S.B. at their February 2, 2015 meeting.]

The report recognized and affirmed the long-standing practice of the Grapevine Board inviting the Conference Grapevine Committee chair to attend their meeting that occurs just prior to the Winter Board Weekend. The committee agreed to forward to the Grapevine Board the suggestion to memorialize the policy that the chairperson of the Conference Grapevine Committee be invited to sit with the Grapevine Board chair and participate in the meeting of the Grapevine Board at the Winter Board Weekend.

The committee also:

- Discussed current policy and practice on distribution of General Service Conference background and agreed that current G.S.O. practice, distributing Conference background only to Conference members, is in accordance with the Conference Charter. The committee noted that the Conference Charter provides for area delegates to develop their own policies and practices for distribution of General Service Conference background within their areas.
- Discussed a request from a delegate to provide area alternate delegates with access to the Conference Dashboard and agreed that Conference Dashboard access continue to be limited to Conference members. The committee noted that all of the materials on the Conference Dashboard are readily available to delegates in both electronic and hard-copy formats.
- Discussed a suggestion that "the trustees' Committee on the General Service Conference develop a policy and procedure that would allow each Conference Committee chair to confer with the corresponding trustees' Committee chairperson and the Committee secretary to discuss the background available and appropriate for the Committees' agenda items," and agreed to create a subcommittee to bring back a report on this topic.
- Reviewed the report of the Subcommittee on Conference Background Development, and recommended to the General Service Board that: Prior to the distribution of Conference Committee background, each Conference Committee secretary will confer with the Conference Committee delegate chair and the corresponding trustees' Committee chairperson (if any) to review a list of the proposed background for each of the Committees' agenda items. [Recommendation approved by the G.S.B. at their November 3, 2014 meeting.]
- Reviewed and accepted the preliminary budget for the 2015 General Service Conference and forwarded it to the trustees' Finance and Budgetary Committee.
- Discussed the role of delegate chairs during the Winter Board Weekend and asked the secretary to bring back a draft policy based on the committee's discussion for review. At their next meeting the committee discussed a draft policy regarding the role of delegate chairs at the Winter Board Weekend, recommending to the General Service Board that:
 - Each year the General Service Board welcomes the chairpersons of Conference committees and the Conference Delegate Chairperson at the Board Weekend prior to the General Service Conference.
 - Delegate chairpersons are invited to sit with the trustee chairperson at the meeting of their corresponding trustees' committee and participate in the meeting. The trustees' committees welcome input from the delegate chairs of their corresponding Conference committees; however, they are not voting members of the corresponding trustees' committees.
 - Delegate chairpersons of other Conference committees are welcome to attend meetings of trustees' committees that are of interest, along with other noncommittee members, with participation at the discretion of the trustees' Committee chair.
 - During Board Weekend trustees' Committee background is



made available only to members of the trustees' committee, including ex-officio members and trustee emeriti.

- Committee meeting agendas are made available to all those attending the meeting. Those attending the meeting who are not members of the committee are asked to return the agenda to the committee secretary at the close of the meeting. [Recommendation approved by the G.S.B. at their February 2, 2015 meeting.]
- Reviewed the 2014 Conference Policy/Admissions Committee's Advisory Action that "During a two-year trial period the General Service Conference include one day of electronic voting on all nonelection votes, on the Thursday of the 2015 General Service Conference and on the Friday of the 2016 General Service Conference, and that the trustees' Committee on the General Service Conference provide a report from data gathered from the 2015 and 2016 General Service Conferences, evaluating electronic voting to the 2017 Conference Committee on Policy/Admissions for consideration." At their November 2, 2014, meeting the committee had a demonstration of the electronic anonymous voting system that will be used for the two-year trial period of electronic voting on all nonelection votes, on the Thursday of the 2015 General Service Conference and on the Friday of the 2016 General Service Conference.
- Discussed the process of forwarding proposed agenda items to Conference Committees that do not have a corresponding trustees' committee and concluded that no change to the current process was necessary.
- Discussed the relationship of the trustees' Committees and the Conference Committees that do not have a corresponding trustees' committee and agreed to invite the chairperson of the 2015 Conference Policy/Admissions Committee to their January 31, 2015 meeting.
- Reviewed the 2014 Conference Policy/Admissions Committee's Additional Committee Consideration: "The committee discussed the 2008 Conference Advisory Action regarding responsibility for site selection of the General Service Conference and took no action. The committee considered that the current hotel site-selection process by the General Service Office management is appropriate. The committee suggested that, in the spirit of clear communication, reports describing the hotel site-selection process of all future General Service Conferences be provided to the Conference Committee on Policy/Admissions for their information." The committee noted that the G.S.C. will take place at

the Crowne Plaza Times Square Hotel in New York City in 2015 and 2016, and looks forward to receiving a report describing the hotel site-selection process of future G.S.C.s.

- The committee agreed to forward to the A.A.W.S. Board the following requests:

- To ask the General Service Office (G.S.O.) to investigate the possibility of holding the General Service Conference on the West Coast every other year.
- Request that the General Service Office management, whenever possible, select a site outside of New York City in which to hold the General Service Conference.
- Reviewed a list of topics submitted to the Conference assignment at G.S.O. for consideration as agenda items in 2015. Forty-five items were forwarded to trustees' and Conference committees, to the General Service Board, or A.A.W.S. or Grapevine Corporate Boards; two items were tabled and on three the committee agreed to take no action.
- Discussed and agreed to forward to the Conference Policy/Admissions Committee a request "that a recording of the A.A. meeting at the opening dinner of the General Service Conference be provided to each member of the General Service Conference."
- Approved the request from the General Service Board of the Czech Republic for a member of their service structure to attend the 2015 General Service Conference as an observer and agreed to forward the request to the 2015 Conference Committee on Policy/Admissions.
- Discussed and agreed to forward to the Conference Committee on Report and Charter the following request: "Consider including on page S41 or S42 a flow chart similar to that on page S37 with a dashed line to the side of 'A.A. Groups' leading to a box reading 'Intergroup/Central Offices'."
- Discussed and agreed to forward to the Conference Committee on Report and Charter the following request: "Restore the 'contents' page (as it was published in 1978 in *The A.A. Service Manual/Twelve Concepts for World Service*) on the page prior to the Twelve Concepts Short Form."
- Discussed and agreed to forward to the trustees' Literature Committee a request to develop a book of Conference presentations derived from *Final Conference Reports*.
- Discussed and agreed to forward to the trustees' Public Information committee a request that the Advisory Action from the 61st General Service Conference regarding the "Policy on actors portraying A.A. members or potential A.A. members in videos produced by the General Service Board or its affiliates" be rescinded.
- Discussed and agreed to forward to the trustees' Committee on Finance the following request:
 - The G.S.C. Finance and Trustees committee to review the price increase and determine if the price increase follows: the General Service Board "Self-Support of the World Service of Alcoholics Anonymous," in particular the statement:
 - "It is the policy of the General Service Board that income from literature sales should only be in the amounts required to allow continued provision of vitally needed services and maintenance of a Reserve Fund."
 - Tradition Seven: "...the principle that A.A. must always stay poor. Bare running expenses plus a prudent reserve would henceforth be the Foundation's financial policy.... At that moment, we believe, the principle of corporate poverty was firmly and finally embedded in A.A. tradition."
 - Concept XII Warranty Two; "Sufficient operating funds, plus

an ample Reserve, should be its prudent financial principle."

- Agreed to forward to A.A.W.S. Inc., a request to "Task the staff of the General Service Office with the development of a website template that could be used by Areas and Districts in the United States and Canada."
- Agreed to forward to A.A.W.S. Inc. a request to "Task the staff of the General Service Office with the development of a searchable, web-based, mobile-friendly database of meetings in the United States that is consistent with General Service Office records. This database would also be available to Areas and Districts and should include an interactive map. Only meetings that desire a web presence should be included in the database."
- Agreed to forward to the A.A.W.S. Board the following request "for the area delegates to have a 'List Serve' as a part of aa.org to provide an effective and anonymity protected method for the area delegates to easily communicate with each other."
- Agreed to forward to the General Service Board a request to consider "the idea of a 'nongeographic district' comprised of the North American-based Online AA Groups. Perhaps such a district could be adopted by a delegate area so that the consciences of these groups could be included in the General Service Conference process."
- Agreed to forward to the General Service Board a request to consider changing the structural relationship between online groups and the General Service structure.

Discussed and agreed to forward to the General Service Board the following request: "That a panel be formed to look at our present rate of growth and look for ways that this might be improved. Beyond the group, district and area inventory."

Discussed the following request and agreed to take no action, noting that the General Service Conference has discussed this issue at two recent General Service Conferences:

To continue the development of spiritual parity between the Grapevine and La Viña by providing the Grapevine Board with the freedom and flexibility to:

- Develop independent business models for the Grapevine and La Viña that reflect publishing trends and the expressed needs of the Fellowship;
- Make decisions with regards to formatting that are responsive to the readership demands of each publication respectively;
- Create financial reports for Grapevine and La Viña that show each as unique services to the Fellowship;
- Reaffirm that "spiritual parity" means the Grapevine and La Viña are to be treated as equally important by the General Service Board and the Grapevine Board.

Discussed and took no action on a proposed agenda item that "The Conference recognize and declare La Viña to be a necessary service to the A.A. Fellowship and, in accordance with that recognition, that the Conference endorse the Grapevine's continued publication of La Viña going forward as a service to our Fellowship." The committee noted that this policy was already established by the 2001 Advisory Action that states "La Viña continue to be published by the A.A. Grapevine and supported by the General Service Board as a service to the Fellowship."

Discussed a request that "The GSC Literature Committee review all proposed literature pricing by A.A.W.S. After review the Literature Committee would then send the proposal to the General Service Conference for disapproval if any," and agreed to take no action. The committee noted that review of proposed pricing is not in the scope of the Conference Literature Committee and that pricing of literature published by A.A.W.S. falls under the purview of the A.A.W.S. Board.

- Reviewed and approved the schedule for the 65th General Service Conference week. The committee noted that the chair and secretary of the Conference Committee on Archives have notified the Conference coordinator that they will not have a luncheon meeting on Thursday this year.

A random drawing was held to fulfill the number of voters required for election of the Northeast regional trustee during the 65th General Service Conference. The committee forwarded to the secretary of the trustees' Nominating Committee and Conference Committee on Trustees two additional delegate voters and two additional trustee voters.

- *The committee tabled discussion on the following topics for their next meeting in August 2015:*

A request "that all Conference members be sent the same background material, with the exception of digital media and works in progress" for their August 1, 2015 meeting and asked the secretary to provide additional background.

A request that "An A.A. Guideline be prepared that lays out what YPAA [Young People in A.A.] is, how it operates, what its relationship to the Fellowship and the service structure might be, and how young people would go about finding and joining their area YPAA," for their August 1, 2015 meeting and asked the secretary to provide additional background.

The committee wishes to thank all of the A.A. members, groups, districts and areas that submitted Conference agenda proposals for their participation in the process.

Our committee sincerely hopes that everyone has a productive and enriching Conference experience and that we will all continue to enjoy the wonderful life that has been given to us.

Nancy Haynes, chairperson

Staff report: The Conference coordinator is the G.S.O. contact for General Service Conference members. The Conference process continues throughout the year and the coordinator corresponds regularly with delegates and alternate delegates, who cooperate to make the annual Conference responsive to the needs of the Fellowship. The coordinator of the Conference is also the contact for area and district committee members, as well as past delegates, in the 93 areas throughout the United States and Canada. The annual meeting of the General Service Conference, which first met in April 1951, is the closest thing A.A. has to a group conscience in the U.S. and Canada.

A.A. members are encouraged to submit topics through their area structures for consideration by the Conference. Suggested topics may be forwarded to a trustees' committee for consideration and, where appropriate, referred directly to a Conference committee. Occasionally topics are submitted that are more appropriately under the purview of either the A.A.W.S. or Grapevine Boards. These items are accordingly forwarded to those boards for their attention. The Conference coordinator is responsible for:

- Serving as secretary to the Conference Agenda Committee

and the trustees' Committee on the General Service Conference.

- Assembling suggestions for the Conference theme and presentation/discussion and workshop topics that are reviewed by the Conference Agenda Committee, which makes selections that are recommended to the Conference for approval. In Conference inventory years 2013-2015 there are no workshops.
- Working with the G.S.O. staff and general manager on planning and coordinating each phase of the Conference.
- Scheduling and assembling reports and other information for the Conference Manual; and, with the guidance of the Publishing Department, the summer edition of *Box 4-5-9* and the *Conference Final Report*.
- The Conference coordinator cooperates with the G.S.O. IT professionals to develop and maintain necessary digital platforms for transmission of Conference material to Conference members.
- This year the Conference coordinator gathered sharing from area delegates regarding the translation of Conference related materials in their areas.

Mary Cumings

COOPERATION WITH THE PROFESSIONAL COMMUNITY/TREATMENT/ SPECIAL NEEDS-ACCESSIBILITIES

Trustees' report: The trustees' Committees on Cooperation With the Professional Community and Treatment Facilities were combined by action of the General Service Board in April 1998. Then, in August of 2009, the trustees' committee expanded its scope to include service to Special Needs-Accessibilities Committees and oversight of Special Needs literature. The title of the committee has been changed to Cooperation With the Professional Community/Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities. Since the 2014 General Service Conference, the trustees' Committee has met three times.

Cooperation With the Professional Community (C.P.C.) — The committee undertook the following tasks this past year:

- Reviewed the Additional Committee Consideration to add an index of *About A.A.* to the C.P.C. Kits and requested that the staff secretary work with Web Services to continue to broaden the availability of the *About A.A.* search function that is currently on G.S.O.'s website, aa.org.
- Reviewed the Additional Committee Consideration to add Grapevine, La Viña, and La Vigne to C.P.C. Kits and requested that the staff secretary work with A.A. Grapevine, Inc. and A.A.W.S., Inc. in order to select and provide the appropriate A.A. Grapevine and La Viña informational insert.



- Approved the draft service piece guidelines, created as a resource for Class A trustees, when speaking at professional events on behalf of A.A.

- Reviewed the subcommittee report on the "Use of Class A trustees in C.P.C. Efforts" and requested that the subcommittee continue to meet and discuss the process for the selection of national professional events at which to exhibit. It was also suggested that the subcommittee continue to discuss the development of a Class A presenter's evaluation form, as well as ways to enhance local C.P.C. committee participation at all exhibits. The committee asked that the staff secretary continue to gather feedback on C.P.C. presentations by trustees at professional conferences. As a result of abstract submissions to professional conferences, Alcoholics Anonymous thus far has been accepted to present at three National Professional Conferences.

- *American Probation and Parole Assoc. Conference*, Tampa, Florida, January 2015

- *American Physician Assistants Conference*, San Francisco, California, May 2015

- *National Drug Court Professionals Conference*, Washington, DC, June 2015

Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities:

- The trustees' committee reviewed the Conference Committee on Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities' Additional Committee Consideration to change the language in the line from Gloria's story in "A.A. for the Alcoholic with Special Needs" and agreed to take no action, noting that the current language is clear in the full context of the story.

- The trustees' committee reviewed and took no action on requests to change the committee name and add text regarding partial hearing loss to the *Special Needs-Accessibilities Workbook*. After wide-ranging discussion the committee suggested a thorough review of the Special Needs-Accessibilities Workbook, which has not taken place since 2008, be undertaken by a subcommittee to be formed by the trustees' committee on Cooperation With the Professional Community/Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities at their August 2, 2015 meeting.

- The trustees' committee requested that the staff secretary provide a memo reflecting the committee's wide-ranging discussion as background for the August 2015 trustees' Committee on Cooperation With the Professional Community/Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities.

- The committee requested the memo include additional shared experience from local committees, consideration of adding text related to partial hearing loss, exploration of what is currently considered appropriate vernacular for what is termed "special needs," and consideration of technology applications and advances related to carrying the A.A. message through Special Needs-Accessibilities service work, and whether or not information needs to be included in the workbook.

- The trustees' committee expressed support for posting contents of A.A. literature items produced on audio cassette and CD-ROM on G.S.O.'s website, aa.org, and requested the A.A.W.S. Board considering posting of the material.

- The trustees' committee reviewed the request to include a Braille pamphlet in the Special Needs-Accessibilities Kit and took no action, noting that there is not a widely expressed need.

The trustees' committee reviewed the request to change the word "Treatment" in the pamphlet "Bridging the Gap" (P-49) to a generic term and took no action, noting that there is not a widely expressed need.

Bob Wilcox, chairperson

Staff reports:

Cooperation With the Professional Community — Experience indicates that many professionals are aware of A.A., yet relatively few know what A.A. is or what it is not. It appears that even fewer have been to an "open" A.A. meeting. The staff member on the Cooperation With the Professional Community (C.P.C.) assignment, along with an assistant, provides information about A.A. and facilitates communication with those outside A.A. who may have direct contact with the still-suffering alcoholic through their professional work.

The C.P.C. desk responds daily to numerous inquiries from professionals. Many of these professionals were put in touch with local C.P.C. committees who responded with offers for direct contact, information about how to send clients to meetings, offers of literature, or other means to assure that A.A. is a resource for professionals.

The Summer/Fall 2014 issue of *About A.A.*, our newsletter for professionals, featured an article titled, "Bringing Up the Touchy Subject of a Patient's Drinking" and an article highlighting "The Role of A.A.'s Class A (nonalcoholic) Trustees." The Winter 2015 issue of *About A.A.* featured an article titled, "To Employers." Some area C.P.C. committees have requested additional copies when exhibiting or providing information to local Human Resource professionals. In addition, there was an article communicating about A.A. exhibiting at professional Conferences.

Currently, more than 9,000 professionals receive *About A.A.* Over 6,000 recipients of the newsletter receive *About A.A.* via A.A.'s Digital Delivery system. The C.P.C. desk is currently working with the Intra-Office Website Committee to simplify the subscription process of email delivery.

Professional exhibits continue to result in requests for additional A.A. information, as well as personal contacts with local committee members. The C.P.C. assignment arranged for displays at 25 national or international conferences of professionals in 2014. At these exhibits, G.S.O. provides the booth space, display and literature; local C.P.C. committees coordinate A.A. volunteers who staff the booth to answer questions and provide literature and contacts. Professionals in a broad range of fields visited the A.A. booth at these national events. In the interest of extending the hand of A.A. to all who suffer, each year some Public Information events are also included, such as The GLBT Expo and The Assoc. for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication. In addition, 12 local exhibits were referred to area C.P.C. committees. G.S.O. also supplied C.P.C. material for several exhibits and events set up by local committees.

The C.P.C. staff member greets students from Cornell University Medical Center who visit G.S.O. throughout the year. These future physicians are provided information on A.A. as a possible valuable resource when they encounter the still-suffering alcoholic. The students are provided with literature, given a brief introduction to the A.A. program, a tour of G.S.O. and provided with information on how to find "open" A.A. meetings.

During visits, in the fall and winter of 2014, topics that peaked the highest interest amongst medical students were those regarding Tradition Two (group conscience) and Tradition Ten (Alcoholics Anonymous has no opinion on outside issues).

G.S.O. has purchased new C.P.C. floor displays for exhibiting purposes. These will replace the tabletop displays which had been damaged from years of use. The floor model design has a simple setup and will leave room for more A.A. pamphlets and publications on the C.P.C. literature table.

At the request of the trustees' Committee on C.P.C./T/SN-A, the C.P.C. staff person has been actively submitting abstracts to professional conferences for trustees to speak about A.A.

The staff member on C.P.C. also serves as a liaison representative to several national meetings, such as the National



Institute for Alcohol Abuse and Alcoholism (N.I.A.A.A.) and provides information about A.A., when requested, by other Twelve Step Fellowships.

Racy Joseph

Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities/LIM — The purpose of the Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities assignment is to share A.A. and service committee experience and information with trusted servants involved with these distinct committees. While the two types of service committees which make up this assignment may strive to carry the A.A. message of recovery from alcoholism to different populations of alcoholics, the overall purpose of the assignment is to share A.A. and service committee experience and information through literature, activity updates and other communications. The assignment currently communicates with approximately 1,051 area, district and intergroup/central offices Treatment, Bridging the Gap (BTG), Hospitals and Institutions (H&I) and Special Needs-Accessibilities committee chairpersons. That is 70 more chairpersons than 2014.

Communication with these trusted servants begins with a welcome letter from the assignment coordinator, along with some of the service, related materials that might be helpful as the committee chair starts out in their new position. While physical materials are still sent through the mail, the new trusted servants are also directed to G.S.O.'s A.A. website (www.aa.org) where A.A. Guidelines, service committee workbooks, and other A.A. materials may be read and/or printed. In addition, all area-level service committee chairs receive a list of other area-level service committee chairs to facilitate sharing of experiences and activities.

During their term of service, committee chairs receive updates on other committees' activities thorough articles in *Box 4-5-9*, as well as receiving updates from the assignment coordinator that may contain ideas, activities, questions and solutions from other committees. These assignment updates also contain items of interest from the General Service Office, requests for sharing on a particular question when appropriate, and efforts to address areas of potential confusion.

The Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities assignment always welcomes correspondence from newly sober clients in treatment centers, and from professionals in those facilities. In addition, communication is received from alcoholics with special challenges (blindness, deafness, brain injury, etc.) asking for A.A. literature in a format that they can understand. Each inquiry receives a response from the staff member who, as often as possible, links these professionals, treatment clients and alcoholics with special needs to the appropriate local committee member in the Fellowship who can serve as an additional resource.

The staff member on this assignment serves as secretary to the Conference Committee on Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities, and as co-secretary to the trustees' Committee

on Cooperation With the Professional Community/Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities.

This staff member is also a regional correspondent to one of the eight regions in the U.S. and Canada, sharing A.A. experience with hundreds of A.A. members monthly via emails, phone calls and written correspondence.

Finally, the *Loners-Internationalists Meeting (LIM)* is under the purview of this assignment. G.S.O. receives an average of 15-20 shares per month which comprise a *confidential* bimonthly bulletin sent to Loners, Homers, Internationalists, and to Loner Sponsors and Port Contacts—members unable to attend meetings in person. The *LIM* bulletin includes full names and addresses of the 424 participants who correspond with one another year round.

Steve Smith

CORRECTIONS

Trustees' report: The trustees' Committee on Corrections recommends to the General Service Board actions that support carrying the A.A. message to alcoholics confined in a variety of correctional settings. Since the 2014 General Service Conference, the committee has met three times.

At their August 2014 meeting the committee reviewed, discussed, and accepted the staff update on the new video project to replace, *It Sure Beats Sitting in a Cell*.

In keeping with 2014 Conference Corrections Committee Additional Committee Consideration, the committee agreed to add the DVD *Carrying the Message Behind These Walls* to the Corrections Kit.

In August 2014 the committee reviewed and discussed the Corrections Correspondence Service for Canada and also discussed the progress report on the development of a service piece on ways to engage more members to participate in Corrections service.

At the November 2014 meeting the chairperson of the Subcommittee on Corrections Engagement Strategy, provided an oral progress report on the subcommittee. Challenges and possible solutions in Corrections service were discussed by the committee.

In November the secretary of the trustees' Corrections Committee reviewed the selection process and announced the company chosen to produce the new Corrections video.

At the January 2015 meeting, the committee heard a verbal progress report on the development of the new Corrections video. The production style will be a documentary and will be built around stories shared by alcoholics behind the walls. Currently, California, Missouri, New York, North Carolina, and Ontario are being targeted as potential production locations and the process of applying for access into corrections facilities in these states and province has begun. A set of questions has been developed to acquire sharing on the specific topics identified by the trustees' Corrections Committee and from some areas.

The committee will receive a progress report for review at their August 2015 meeting.

Also at the January meeting, the committee reviewed the background provided on developing the Corrections Correspondence Service for Canada and agreed on the importance of continuing discussion on C.C.S. in Canada. The discussion was tabled for their August 2015 meeting.

Based on the ongoing need for more outside male volunteers to fill the requests from inmates for C.C.S., the committee agreed to forward the following discussion topics to the 2015 Conference Committee on Corrections: discuss the Corrections Correspondence Service (C.C.S.), and discuss ways to engage members in Corrections service.

Also at the January 2015 meeting it was reported that the final version of the service piece, "Engaging A.A. Members in Corrections Work" will be sent to the committee and made available on G.S.O.'s A.A. website and in the Corrections Kit.

The committee discussed a memorandum from the A.A. Grapevine Board chair regarding unmet requests from inmates for Grapevine/La Viña subscriptions forwarded by G.S.O.'s Corrections desk. Following discussion, the committee agreed to request that the Corrections coordinator explore ways to forward the unmet requests to local area Corrections committees and present a report to the committee at their August 2015 meeting.

As a follow up to the 2014 Conference Corrections Committee's Additional Committee Consideration that was forwarded from the General Service Board to the committee, the committee reviewed the background and discussed whether there is a need to develop a Conference-approved pamphlet addressing Bridging the Gap (BTG) activities for Corrections. Following discussion, the committee agreed to take no action. The committee agreed that there was adequate information in existing Corrections literature on prerelease programs.

Bill Farnsworth, chairperson

Staff report: The Corrections assignment is responsible for helping A.A. members and local committees carry the A.A. message to alcoholics confined in a variety of correctional settings. Approximately 500 pieces of mail a month arrive from inmates, many requesting free literature, others asking to participate in our Corrections Correspondence Service (C.C.S.) or for help in making contact with A.A., either by asking for a meeting in their facility or for a prerelease contact. While not everyone who writes to G.S.O. has a problem with alcohol, all letters are answered; those indicating they have a drinking problem are provided with basic literature, information about Twelve Step services specifically designed for the alcoholic who is incarcerated, and a warm invitation to participate in the Fellowship and program of recovery of A.A.

If an incarcerated alcoholic requests free literature, he or she may be sent a Big Book, a copy of Grapevine or La Viña, a selection of pamphlets, and often the booklet *A.A. in Prison: Inmate to Inmate*, with an explanation that the enclosed literature is made possible through the voluntary contributions of A.A. members throughout the United States and Canada. However, this assignment tries to avoid being viewed as the primary source of A.A. literature, since "carrying the A.A. message" in this way is an A.A. service opportunity. Requests for multiple copies for an inside group, or ongoing requests from the same facility, are usually referred to local A.A. members doing this type of Twelfth Step service. This practice is also in keeping with past recommendations of Conference and trustees' Committees on Corrections.

The Corrections Correspondence Service, coordinated by

this assignment, continues as one of our most valuable efforts. Many alcoholics who are incarcerated are looking to turn their lives around and crave outside support from A.A.s with whom they can share their experience, strength and hope. To fill their requests, this assignment puts out regular requests to the Fellowship through various channels for new correspondence volunteers — especially males. One of the challenges to this staff assignment is explaining why — when A.A. members continue to volunteer their time — we can never completely close the gap. The short answer is that every day more and more alcoholics in correctional facilities discover that the root of their problem is alcohol and decide to do something about it! Once they come across the message of Alcoholics Anonymous, they want to share their journey with someone, just like the rest of us. In 2014, we linked 815 male and 282 female alcoholics in prison to an outside A.A. correspondent through the C.C.S. In order to meet those requests, we needed to be able to match the inmates with 1,097 outside A.A. volunteers. Although many of those offered to write to more than one incarcerated alcoholic at a time, the number of volunteers needed remains large. And that is the data for just one year.

One of the most gratifying aspects of the assignment is communicating with area and district Corrections, Hospitals and Institutions, and Bridging the Gap committees. The desk fields daily calls and emails from A.A. members doing Corrections service work. In 2014, we passed along to area Corrections committee chairs 354 requests from inmates, Corrections professionals, and A.A. members taking meetings in Correctional facilities for prerelease contacts, outside support, or A.A. literature. We send out a periodic activity report to each of these committee chairs with updated information or requests for shared experience. This past year included a call for male participants in our Corrections Correspondence Service; a request for shared experience from corrections committees on engaging members in Corrections

Estimates of Groups and Members as of January 1, 2015.

	Groups	Members
United States	6,143	1,283,704
Canada	5,079	89,793
Sub-Total	65,222	1,373,497
Correctional facilities ²	1,440	35,349
Internationalists	2	20
Lone Members	0	59
Total	55,664	1,408,925
Outside U.S. & Canada ³	48,662	631,704
Grand Total	115,326	2,040,629

1. The General Service Office does not keep membership records. The information shown here is based on reports given by groups listed with G.S.O., and does not represent an actual count of those who consider themselves A.A. members.

2. U.S. and Canada only.

3. We are aware of A.A. activity in approximately 170 countries, including 61 autonomous general service offices in other lands. Annually we attempt to contact those G.S.O.s and groups that request to be listed in our records. Where current data is lacking we use the previous year's figures

service and an update, and a request for shared experience with the Corrections Correspondence Service in Canada, sent to all the listed Corrections committees in Canada.

G.S.O.'s A.A. website has a special section where most Corrections service material can be found, including current and past issues of the newsletter *Sharing From Behind the Walls* (SFBTW). This quarterly publication contains excerpts of sharing from A.A. members in prison who have written to G.S.O. This desk prepares selections from these A.A. members' letters and sends them a copy of the excerpt along with a request to reprint it in a future issue of SFBTW. The permission letter also mentions the possibility that the newsletter might be posted on G.S.O.'s website. Posting this anonymity-protected newsletter on the website and inviting members who take meetings into correctional facilities to print out copies is another way of ensuring that the sharing from this population of alcoholics gets into the hands of those who need it most.

A.A. members involved in Corrections service frequently ask how they can get their fellow members on the "outside" to commit to speaking or sponsoring a meeting in a correctional facility. Often, people in the Fellowship unfamiliar with this type of Twelfth Step activity express the fear that the alcoholic in prison will not identify with an A.A. member who has not been to prison, and are reluctant to commit to the amount of time institutions sometimes require for orientation seminars to qualify to go into their correctional facilities. *Carrying the Message Behind These Walls*, a video created to encourage A.A. members to participate in corrections service, addresses many of the concerns that may hold members back from this rewarding Twelfth Step work.

We receive many letters from inmates expressing their gratitude for the hope found in the literature received, as well as for the many dedicated members who take the time to reach out inside the walls by bringing an A.A. meeting into the institution or via our Corrections Correspondence Service.

Clement Cann

FINANCE AND BUDGETARY

Trustees' report:

2014 Budget vs. 2014 Actual Results

General Service Office — At last year's Conference, we reviewed the proposed budget for 2014 and reported that G.S.O. expected a loss from operations of approximately \$295,444. However, for the year 2014, G.S.O. turned in positive results from operations of \$1,376,656, a net improvement of \$1,081,212. This was due to publishing revenues being significantly greater than budget and expenses being less than budget.

Net sales of publishing activities for 2014 were \$16,872,280, approximately \$2,166,280 (14.7%) more than budgeted. Manufacturing and royalty expense were \$1,386,100 greater than budgeted, and shipping and warehousing expenses were \$109,700 greater than budgeted as well. This resulted in a gross profit of \$9,893,976, or \$670,416 (7.3%) greater than budgeted. Adding to these positive publishing results were the Fellowship's actual self-support contributions of \$6,898,068, which were \$101,900 (1.4%) less than budgeted. Finally, operating expenses were \$612,702 (3.8%) less than budgeted.

A.A. Grapevine — The 2014 Grapevine budget anticipated a net profit of \$94,232. Instead, the actual results were significantly better for the Grapevine, a net profit of \$325,829. For the year, Gross profit from other Publishing income was approximately \$11,656 better than budgeted, while interest was \$4,700 less than expected. Expenses for the year were \$101,050 less than budgeted as well.

Reserve Fund — At December 31, 2014, the Reserve Fund

balance represented approximately 9.8 months of operating expenses, compared to a budgeted 9.4 months of 2014.

2014 Actual Results vs. 2013 Actual Results

General Service Office — Our revenues essentially come from two sources: contributions from the Fellowship and profits from literature sales.

Contributions of \$6,828,490, received from *groups and members* (excluding funds received from World Service Meeting countries) were approximately \$41,752, or .6% less than the \$6,870,242 received during 2013. The \$6,828,490 in contributions came from 27,103 groups, individuals, and service entities. That, for comparison, represents approximately 41.6% of the 65,222 groups listed with G.S.O., down slightly from the 42.5% reported last year. As shown on the Contributions Statistics report, included in the Conference material, there are 65,222 groups, some 528 greater than the 64,694 groups reported last year. It is important to remember, however, that the statistics we discuss concerning number of groups, membership and averages are only a reflection of the information we capture on "our systems." We report to you what you report to us.

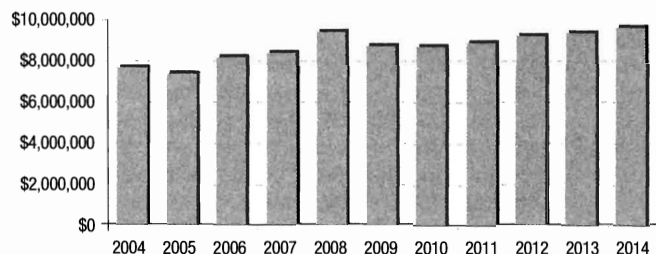
During 2014, 82,927 contributions were received, approximately 3,564 more than the 79,363 contributions that were received during 2013, and compares with 80,936 received in 2012, 80,683 received during 2011 and 77,185 in 2010. Beginning in June 2010, we implemented the online Contributions function. For the period June through December 2010, we received approximately 1,056 contributions via the online method, representing approximately \$82,500. During 2011, we received approximately 1,748 online contributions, \$156,553 and in 2012, 2,346 contributions or \$213,400 were received. During 2013, 2,980 were received for a total of \$302,230. During 2014, we received approximately 4,000 online contribution for a total of \$379,599. Beginning in 2002, we commenced recording funds received on behalf of the World Service Meeting International Literature Fund as Contributions to G.S.O. Total contributions of \$6,898,068 received by G.S.O., reflected in our 2014 financial statements, include approximately \$69,600 received to help carry the message around the world from those participating countries. The comparable comparisons for prior years were: 2013, \$36,130; 2012, \$34,665; 2011, \$74,588; 2010, 129,518; 2009, \$133,715; 2008, \$137,600; 2007, \$144,400; 2006, \$145,000; 2005, \$135,000; 2004, \$128,357; 2003, \$102,900; and 2002, \$108,000.

Turning to the other major component of our income, net sales of literature were \$16,872,280, an increase of \$2,166,280 over the prior year. During 2014, approximately 1,130,500 Big Books were sold compared with 973,000 Big Books in 2013, 947,430 Big Books in 2012 and 945,500 in 2011. Not included in the 1,130,500 Big Books just noted were sales of 177,888 copies of the 75th Anniversary Edition (\$1,888,880). Printing and manufacturing costs, shipping expenses and royalty payments were in the aggregate \$1,495,864 greater than 2013. Included in manufacturing costs for the year was an allowance for an inventory write down for excess inventory of the 75th Anniversary Edition in accordance with Generally Accepted Accounting Principles (\$823,000). The Gross profit of \$9,893,976 was \$670,416 greater than 2013. The combination of contributions and net literature sales resulted in total G.S.O. revenue of \$16,792,471, \$568,511 greater than 2013. Total operating expenses for G.S.O. during 2014 were \$15,415,814, approximately \$431,151 greater than 2013, but \$612,702 less than budgeted.

For the year 2014, there were a few significant variations from 2013 expense lines. The single largest item was in Retirement expense, approximately \$348,000 less based on a reduced funding requirement due to a transfer of \$1,500,000

from the Reserve Fund to the Pension Fund. Professional fees were approximately \$167,000 greater than 2013, due primarily to costs incurred for legal representation based on various litigation matters. Contracted services was \$189,000 more than 2013, primarily due to upgrading the Order Entry-Warehousing, Contributions, Accounting and FNV Systems. Other expenses were considerably below 2014, specifically Furniture and Equipment expenses and Travel and Meetings. Furniture and equipment was less than 2013, primarily due to the 2013 write

Service Spending 2004-2014



off of unamortized costs of the app due to the A.A.W.S. Board decision to discontinue support of the app and move to third party vendors. Travel and Meetings were below 2013, primarily due to the 2014 Conference being held outside of Manhattan.

Expanding on the use of the Fellowship's money in providing services to the Fellowship — in 2014, \$9,725,210 was spent to provide Services to the Fellowship, approximately \$217,628 more than the \$9,507,582 spent in 2013 and compares with \$9,254,131 spent in 2012; \$8,747,139 in 2011; \$8,642,112 in 2010; \$8,783,762 in 2009; \$9,447,300 in 2008.

The 2014 service dollar was spent on the following activities: Group Services 32. % (which includes various group contact-type costs in addition to *Box 4-5-9*; A.A. Directories; records and files; contributions processing; and French services); the General Service Conference, 12.2%; Loners, International Assignment and Overseas Services, 6.1%; trustees' and directors' activities, 5.6%; Regional Forums, 6.7%; Archives, 10.3%; C.P.C., 4.5%; Public Information, 4.9%; Corrections, 4.7%; Treatment, 1.8%; Special Needs, 1%; Nominating, 3.5%; Convention, 4.0%; World Service Meeting, 2.4%; and other various 0.3%.

Contributions provided 70.1% of the support for these services and 29.9% came from the profit from literature sales. This compares with 72.6% and 27.4% in 2013; 70.9% and 29.1% in 2012; 71.6% and 28.4% in 2011; 74.2% and 25.8% in 2010; 71.7% and 28.3% in 2009 and 68.1% and 31.9% in 2008.

2015 G.S.O. Budget — Sales for 2015 are budgeted at \$2,308,071, approximately 13% lower when compared with 2014. Ongoing unit sales are expected to be approximately even with 2013, however, the 2015 budget anticipates the effect of the general literature price increase effective October 1, 2014 and accounts for large literature purchases made by clients prior to the October 1, price increase. Sales of the 75th Anniversary Edition of the first edition of the Big Book is expected to have minimal impact on 2015 revenue. With Contribution revenue in 2014 just slightly less than budget and even with 2013, contributions for 2015 have been budgeted to increase by \$101,932 (1.5%) to \$7,000,000, based on ongoing self-support communication efforts. Dividing **total** Contributions received (\$6,898,068) by the 65,222 groups listed gives us an average of about \$105.76, down slightly from last year's \$107, while expenses to sup-

port services to those groups amounted to approximately \$149 (up \$3 from last year).

Trusted servants continue to explore methods to reduce the costs of operations, as well as assess the services supplied. We are trying to make more use of electronic communications wherever possible to reduce the costs of postage and supplies. One should remember that as we continue to strive to have literature available throughout our Service Conference, in Spanish and French, as well as English, lower print runs in non-English languages usually result in higher production costs. Nevertheless, we generally have the same selling prices regardless of the manufacturing cost; therefore lower overall gross profit margins for low volume items affect the overall gross profit percentages and make literature price increases necessary from time to time.

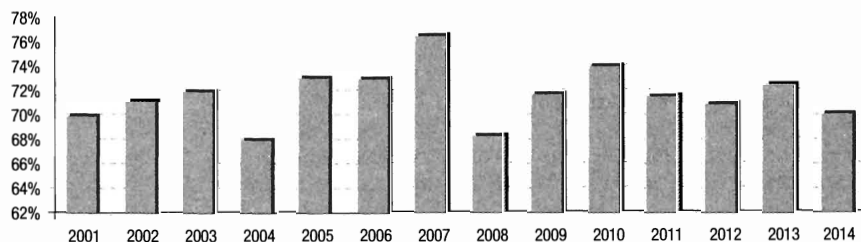
Recent pricing history — In 2005, after reviewing financial matters, trusted servants recommended an increase in prices of books and booklets (except the Big Book), as well as an imposition of a small shipping charge effective July 1, 2005. This followed, by one year, the restoration of the price of the Big Book on July 1, 2004. *PREVIOUSLY*, the price of the Fourth Edition was set at \$5.00 (a \$1.00 per book reduction from \$6.00), reducing the expected Gross Profit with a goal of reducing the Reserve Fund. Projections at that time anticipated that, depending on contributions, the price would be restored in a few years. Prices of books and booklets were increased effective July 1, 2009, anywhere from \$.25 to \$2.00. When reviewing and recommending the 2014 budget, the A.A.W.S. Board considered how revenue and expense assumptions ultimately affect the long-term fiscal health of the General Service Board and its Reserve Fund. Accordingly, the budget assumed a literature price increase October 1, 2014.

The 2015 budget anticipates approximately a 6.6% increase in costs when compared with 2014 actual results, with "People Costs" being the principle driver due to inflation and new staff. For 2015, we have hired a full-time IT manager and anticipate additional staff in the accounting department. As noted previously, we were able to reduce Pension cost to both corporations by several hundred thousand dollars a year as a result of the General Service Board transfer of \$1,500,000 from the Reserve Fund to the Pension Trust.

Based on these preliminary assumptions — approximately a 13% decrease in sales, a 1.5% increase in contributions, and an increase in total operating expenses — the projection for 2015 is for a profit from operations of \$197,125. During the budget process, the A.A.W.S. Board, as well as the trustees' Finance Committee, remains cognizant of the level of the Reserve Fund. Management continues to assess expenses and operations with an eye towards reducing costs.

The Reserve Fund (and Historical Reference for price adjustments) — In 1994, G.S.O. lowered prices and increased discounts on literature. These changes were undertaken to lower the Reserve Fund, which was at that time approaching the upper limit of 12 months of combined operating expenses established by the General Service Conference. In subsequent years, it became necessary to restore the revenue stream with pricing

% of Services Supported by Contributions



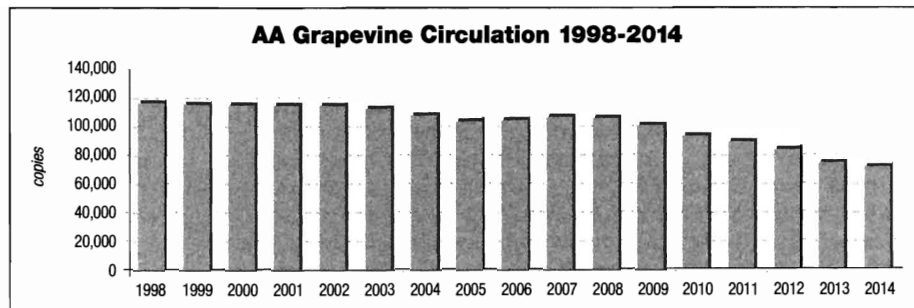
adjustments. As noted in previous reports, G.S.O. management was charged with presenting on-going budgets with sufficient revenue that, with all things being equal, would maintain the Reserve Fund at a nine-month level of operating expenses. The adjusted balance used for the number of month's calculation at December 31, 2014 of \$14,094,966 amounts to about \$216 per listed A.A. group.

The Grapevine — At the Grapevine, gross magazine income for 2014 of \$2,230,376 was approximately \$11,987 less than the prior year. Total magazine income includes the print magazine, single copies, back issues, Digital Magazine Subscriptions, GV Online, Digital Archives Project Subscriptions, and the Audio Grapevine. The average paid circulation for print magazines continued its long-term decline of about 5% per year down to 74,000 for 2014, which compares to 77,126 for 2013; 83,263 for 2012; 90,493 for 2011; 93,104 for 2010; 102,281 for 2009; and 104,993 for 2008. Subscriptions for the Online magazine averaged 5,262 during 2014, compared with 5,175 during 2013; 5,535 during 2012; and the 2014 budget of 4,561.

Gross profit on the magazine of \$1,529,063 was \$51,374 more than 2013, and \$146,945 greater than budgeted. Other publishing income of \$782,088 was \$5,112 greater than 2013 actual, but \$5,472 less than budgeted. Total income, including interest earned, was \$2,045,465, \$41,450 greater than 2013, and \$126,530 greater than budgeted.

Costs and expenses for editorial, circulation and business, and administration were \$1,719,637. Costs and expenses were \$30,826 greater than 2013, and \$101,057 less than budget. The Grapevine reported a profit from operations of \$325,828, which was approximately \$10,624 greater than the 2013 result of \$315,204, and \$227,588 greater than the budgeted profit of \$98,240.

The Grapevine's 2015 budget anticipates magazine income of \$2,113,375 (approximately \$117,000 less than the \$2,230,375 realized in 2014), a decrease in magazine direct costs of \$20,553, and a gross profit of \$1,432,614 is anticipated. Gross



costs of publishing were \$62,439, resulting in a \$59,447 gross profit. During 2014, La Viña realized approximately \$10,331 from the sales of other items, net of costs. Operating expenses directly associated with the publication were \$201,804. These include the editorial, circulation and administrative costs attributable to La Viña. Therefore, the overall net shortfall between revenues on the magazine and all costs to produce and distribute La Viña was \$132,026. This shortfall of \$132,026 was covered by the General Fund of the General Service Board. The 2014 shortfall compares with the 2013 shortfall of \$142,544; \$115,820 for 2012; \$69,725 for 2011; \$75,481 for 2010; \$54,472 for 2009; and \$76,260 for 2008.

For 2015, the net cost to the General Service Board for the La Viña magazine is budgeted to be approximately \$159,457 (\$27,432 greater than 2014), with circulation anticipated to be slightly (519) lower. The Grapevine Board and the trustees' Finance Committee continue to monitor progress and report results to the Conference. Since the inception of the magazine, approximately \$1,658,100 has been invested in La Viña in excess of revenues generated. In 2001, the General Service Board recommended that La Viña continue to be published and agreed to provide the necessary funding.

Other Items

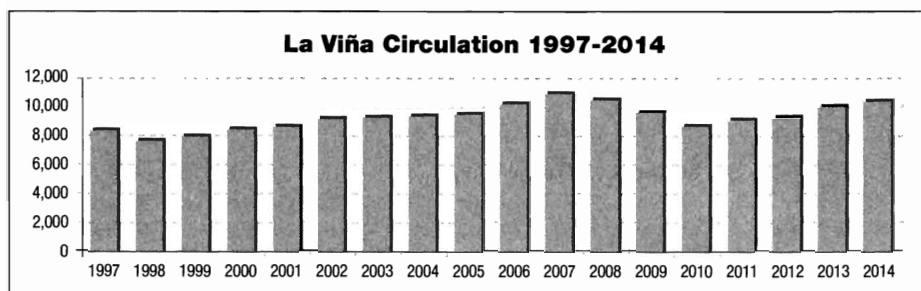
Pension Funding — As noted in prior reports, the A.A.W.S. and A.A. Grapevine Corporate Boards, as well as the trustees' Finance and Budgetary Committee, continue to receive information and recommendations from the Retirement Plan's actuaries concerning funding requirements as a result of 2006 pension legislation enacted by the U.S. Congress. This legislation called for accelerated funding of pensions, which is a departure from the previously accepted method of long-term funding of pensions over the employee's working life.

At the February 2014 General Service Board meeting, the trustees' Finance and Budgetary Committee recommended and the General Service Board approved a transfer of \$1,500,000 from the Reserve Fund to the Pension Trust. This action, coupled with the

improved stock market results during 2013 and 2014, all contributed to significantly reducing the annual pension expense contribution in the 2014 and budgeted amount in 2015.

Pension Plan Changes — A subcommittee of the General Service Board was formed in late 2011, the objective of which was to coordinate the review and selection of pension plan options for transitioning from a Defined Benefit Plan to a Defined Contribution Plan for new A.A.W.S. and G.V. employees. During 2012, amendments were approved to close the old Pension Plan to new employees and create a new Defined Contribution Plan for employees hired after January, 1, 2013. During 2013, new employees began participation in the new Defined Contribution Plan.

La Viña — The Committee received a request concerning the



profit from magazine is anticipated to be approximately \$96,447 less than 2014. Gross profit on other publishing income is anticipated to decrease approximately \$3,492 to \$509,305, while interest income is estimated slightly higher than 2014. A loss for 2015 of \$14,606 is anticipated, compared with the \$325,829 profit for 2014.

La Viña — La Viña is the Spanish-language magazine approved by the 1995 General Service Conference. Since then, the magazine has grown from an idea to a full-fledged publication with a 2014 average circulation of 10,379. This compares with a 2013 average of 10,145; 2012 average of 9,157; 2011 average of 8,982; 2010 average of 8,741; 2009 average of 9,663; 2008 of 10,404.

During 2014, subscription income was \$121,886 and direct

reporting of and overall support of the La Viña magazine and forwarded it to a 2014 subcommittee for review and discussion.

August 2014 trustees' Finance Committee Meeting — A report from the subcommittee discussing La Viña reporting was presented by Clayton V. The trustees' Finance Committee accepted the report with appreciation. The consensus of the committee was that any "Official Documents" — Audited Financial statements, Tax Returns, etc., will continue to reflect financial activities as they are. However, for internal Fellowship documents, we will try to use the term "Shortfall" when referring to the difference between revenue and expenses of La Viña. A subcommittee, consisting of the treasurer, a few trustees to be identified, the CFO, the Grapevine controller and the outside auditor will discuss alternate methods of "internal" reporting of La Viña activities and report back at the November meeting.

November 2014 trustees' Finance Committee Meeting — The committee received and voted to accept the report from the Subcommittee on La Viña, with the modification of paragraph two and numbered points 3 and 4 with the substitution of the word "Affiliate" for the word "Subsidiary."

La Viña Subcommittee Final Report and Recommendation

The task of the Subcommittee has been to examine those communications from G.S.O. and the Grapevine where the financial results of La Viña were reported and to determine what, if anything, might be changed in the narrative reporting to the Fellowship of La Viña's financial results. The Subcommittee met several times by telephone conference. It presented an interim report which is attached hereto.

In reports, such as the *Final Conference Report*, minutes of the GSB and the Grapevine, *Box 4-5-9*, etc., the financial results of La Viña are often portrayed in the same manner as those of G.S.O. and the Grapevine. Reporting in this manner might give an undue emphasis to the La Viña results inasmuch as it was not a subsidiary corporation of the GSB.

The financial responsibility of funding any La Viña shortfall rests with the General Fund of the GSB, a somewhat unique situation in that La Viña has characteristics of a service, while at the same time has revenue identifiable with it. The GSB has an obligation to the Fellowship to be transparent in its reporting of all financial dealings. The narrative reporting of La Viña's financial results has been reported in the present fashion for many years and any change in reporting might be viewed by the Fellowship as an attempt by the GSB to be less transparent in its reporting. The Subcommittee makes the following recommendations to the trustees' Committee on Finance that the following be adopted as the policy of the GSB regarding narrative to the Fellowship on the financial results of La Viña:

1. The overall reporting policy of the GSB and its corporations in its narrative reports should be that whenever financial results of La Viña are reported, such reports should be carefully considered with a goal toward providing adequate disclosure of financial results while avoiding any presentation which might be perceived as discriminatory.
2. The financial results of La Viña should be reported in a transparent and understandable manner.
3. Reports regarding La Viña's financial results should not give the impression that La Viña is a subsidiary corporation of the GSB equal in status with A.A.W.S. and the Grapevine.
4. The financial results of La Viña should be reported in a manner which is proportionate to their financial magnitude when compared with the overall financial size of the GSB and its subsidiary corporations.

5. The Fellowship, in reporting on the financial results of La Viña, should be sensitive to the method the results are portrayed to avoid emphasizing the financial results of this service versus the financial results of other services provided to the Fellowship.

6. In reporting to the Fellowship, the most accurate reference to the difference between La Viña revenues and expenses is "shortfall" if the difference results in a net cost to the board.

Self-Support Policy — Following up on the 2007 subcommittee on a "Consistent Message," the trustees' Finance Committee recommended and the General Service Board adopted the following policy on February 2, 2014:

Self-Support of the World Services of Alcoholics Anonymous

The A.A. spiritual principle of self-support enables us to pursue our primary purpose of carrying the message to the still-suffering alcoholic with a shared sense of responsibility for our lifesaving work and without interference or financial dependence on outsiders. From our Fellowship's earliest days, the expenses of the General Service Office, and the world services provided by it, have exceeded the amount derived from contributions of A.A. groups and members. As a result, providing these needed services has necessarily been supported in part by income from the sale of A.A. literature. It is the policy of the General Service Board that income from literature sales should only be in amounts required to allow continued provision of vitally needed services and maintenance of a Reserve Fund. We hope that the day will come when A.A. groups and members, through their contributions, will be able to fund fully the services provided by the General Service Office. If that is achieved, revenues from literature sales will only be needed in amounts necessary to cover the actual costs associated with literature production and to maintain a Reserve Fund.

A.A.W.S. Self-Support report 2014 work

The Committee heard a report from A.A.W.S. on Self-Support efforts (the work of the previous TFC subcommittee on self-support efforts having been assigned to A.A.W.S.). Items under discussion by the A.A.W.S. Finance committee include: (1) updating the Green Card; (2) Discussion of Contribution acknowledgements; (3) Quarterly Contribution letters; (4) Founders month; (5) One page "services provided" points; and (6) Review of the Birthday Envelope and uses.

Strategic Initiative

A topic of "Strategic Initiative on Structure" was introduced and a discussion followed during the November 2014 meeting. After the Committee members had a thoughtful discussion, others present at the meeting also provided input.

The Committee recommended and the General Service Board adopted on November 2, 2014, that: "The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous Inc. undertake a comprehensive feasibility study of the current business models, corporate structure, and long-term sustainability of the General Service Board and both operating Corporations, keeping in mind the Spiritual Basis of Alcoholics Anonymous.

In summary, your trusted servants continue to vigilantly monitor the financial affairs of A.A. Steps have been taken over the past several years to enhance the net revenue streams of our publishing activities, to diligently manage the expense side of our support services and to address our long-term obligations, all with the goal of helping insure that the Fellowship's finances remain in good condition. While the economic outlook for 2015 and beyond may be uncertain as the economy unfolds, we will

continue to monitor events with our goal to insure the financial wherewithal to carry our message.

David Morris, treasurer

GENERAL SHARING SESSION

Trustees' report: Since the 64th General Service Conference, the General Service Board has held three General Sharing Sessions. In July 2014, the topic was "A.A. in the Public Eye." Jim Malone, G.S.O. staff member, shared on the topic, "A.A. in the Face of Criticism. Our Critics Can Be Our Benefactors." Corliss Burke, Class A trustee, shared on "Avoiding Public Controversy while Providing Clear Information about A.A." and Josh Eggleston, appointed committee member, shared on "A.A. in the Public Eye; Public Information; Our Responsibility."

During the November 2014 board weekend, the Sharing Session topic was "The Spirit of Tradition Six; Cooperation Without Affiliation: Actual or Implied?" Clayton Vandivort, regional trustee, was asked to share on "Where Do We Draw the Line? Cooperation or Affiliation?" and Richard Boisvert, regional trustee, presented on "Use of the A.A. Name in Sobriety Related Activities: Sober Dance or A.A. Dance?"

In February 2015, the Sharing Session topic was "Autonomy in A.A." Joel Castellaw, regional trustee, shared on "Autonomy and the Relationship Between the A.A. Group and the A.A. Service Structure," and Ed Martin, Grapevine director, shared on "Autonomy and the Group Conscience."

Complete copies of these presentations are available and may be requested from the Staff coordinator at G.S.O.

John Fromson, chairperson

A.A. GRAPEVINE, INC.

Office report: Since the last Conference, A.A. Grapevine, Inc. has produced 12 issues of Grapevine; six issues of La Viña; three new books (*Grapevine Daily Quote Book*, *Sober and Out* and *One on One* — French); three ebooks, same titles as print books, a wall calendar; and a pocket planner.

The 70th anniversary of Grapevine magazine in 2014 was shared with the Fellowship throughout the year by directors and staff traveling to events, inviting members to celebrate by having Grapevine events and by incorporating time for a Grapevine celebration into the programs of existing annual events. Grapevine posted a resource page on its website www.aagrapevine.org/GV70, with suggestions and a PowerPoint presentation that could be downloaded for use at these events. The GV70 celebration and resource page was well received and used by the Fellowship extensively in their events throughout the year. As a follow-up to the GV70 celebration, Grapevine initiated a Fellowship-wide 2015 Subscription Challenge for Grapevine and La Viña. The state or province with the largest number of new subscriptions for each magazine, expressed as percentage growth by late December 2015, will receive a special section in Grapevine and/or La Viña devoted to A.A. in that state or province.

In 2014, A.A. Grapevine started collecting audio story submissions from the Fellowship. Grapevine continues to collect stories for its Audio Project and, as of January 2014, has 210 audio stories. Nine stories are available free on www.aagrapevine.org, as examples for members who wish to record a story.

The A.A. Grapevine website continues to grow and in 2014 received an average 43,598 unique visitors each month. Throughout the year A.A. Grapevine worked on improving the website, with work continuing into 2015. A.A. Grapevine created landing pages to improve the user experience for the purchase of subscriptions or books, such as *The Language of the Heart*. There are more improvements coming in 2015, most notably,

a project to improve the member's experience when using the Story Archive.

In 2014, Grapevine and La Viña also commenced the Carry the Message communication effort to inform members and groups about an option to purchase Subscription Gift Certificates to give to local committees for distribution to members in need.

Eugene O'Brien, controller

GROUP SERVICES/WEB SERVICES

Staff report: To assist groups, the General Service Office develops service material based on an indicated need, and shares information and experience not found in Conference-approved literature. A seven-page list describes the service items. Examples of service material include: Group Handbooks; G.S.R. and D.C.M. Kits; A.A. Guidelines; Referral List of Fellowships Similar to A.A. and the 2014 "Anonymity Online" and "Responding to Disasters."

G.S.O. offers an A.A. website at www.aa.org to serve the Fellowship of Alcoholics Anonymous as a resource for A.A. members, those seeking help from A.A., professionals working with alcoholics, the media, and the public at large. G.S.O.'s website provides accurate and consistent information about A.A., provides details about services coordinated by G.S.O. and encourages participation of A.A. members, groups and committees in A.A. services and activities.

Current ongoing projects involving Group Services and Web Services:

- The Group Services coordinator collaborates with the Special Projects manager regarding the three regional A.A. Directories (Canadian, Eastern U.S., and Western U.S.), G.S.O.'s group and service committee records, and intergroup/central office records and lists.
- Supervises the updating of G.S.O.'s available service material upon request, and in Spanish and French, whenever possible.
- Functions as G.S.O.'s liaison to some 500 intergroup/central offices and intergroups in the U.S. and Canada. Coordinates A.A.W.S.'s participation at the annual intergroup/central office seminar and serves on the seminar's Policy and Site-Selection Committees. The 30th Annual Intergroup/Central Office Seminar will take place in Ft. Lauderdale, Florida, in September 2015.
- Serves as a resource to the managing editor regarding the updating of *The A.A. Service Manual*.
- The Web Services coordinator collects feedback on design and content from visitors to G.S.O.'s A.A. website, and collaborates with the Digital Media manager to continually update and improve www.aa.org — completing a total redesign in June 2014 to provide visitors a user-friendly and more contemporary online experience.
- Shares collected experience with local website committees upon request and prepares Website Activity Reports to the A.A.W.S. Board and the Conference Committee on Public Information.
- Attends the annual National A.A. Technology Workshop, which was first held in August 2014 to provide a forum to gather, share and seek solutions to technology-related issues faced by local A.A. trusted servants, primarily those who support A.A. websites.

The staff member on Group Services/Web Services serves as secretary of the Conference Committee on Report and Charter, as secretary to the A.A.W.S. Technology/Communication/Services Committee, as chair of the Intra-Office Website Committee, and as regional correspondent for all of Canada.

M. Tracey Ober

INTERNATIONAL

Trustees' report: This committee is responsible for suggesting policies and actions to assure that the A.A. message is available around the world, especially in areas where there is no established service structure. We provide shared experience, support translations of A.A. literature in other languages, and encourage the expansion of regional or zonal meetings. The committee is the primary link between the international A.A. community and the U.S./Canada General Service Board of Trustees.

The 2015 Literature Assistance budget of \$50,000 will allow A.A. World Services to translate and publish a variety of foreign language books, pamphlets and reprints. A portion of this expense will be drawn from the International Literature Fund, representing contributions from A.A. groups and structures around the world. A.A.W.S. holds the copyrights on all foreign-language versions of our Conference-approved material and issues licensing agreements for publication and distribution to those countries which have an established general service board. When necessary, we translate and publish the material, subject to scheduling by the Publishing Department and approval of the A.A.W.S. Board. The Big Book is currently available in 69 languages, and other literature is available in approximately 92 languages.

The 23rd World Service Meeting (WSM) was held October 12-16, 2014 in Warsaw, Poland, with the theme "The Three Legacies: Vital for All Generations." In attendance were 61 delegates representing 41 countries or linguistic zones, including four countries participating for the first time: the Czech Republic, Hong Kong, Iran and Romania. Representing our General Service Board was first-term delegate Bob Wilcox, trustee-at-large/U.S. G.S.O. general manager Phyllis Halliday presided at the event and staff member Rick Walker served as WSM coordinator. Staff members Jim Malone, Clay Rittenhouse and Steve Smith acted as secretaries to the WSM committees. The committee discussed how our World Service Meeting delegates could encourage those in attendance in Poland to engage other countries to participate in future World Service Meetings.

Over the past few years, the General Service Board and General Service Office have received fewer invitations from other countries to attend events ranging from conventions,

anniversary celebrations, conferences, board meetings, office visits, and regional assemblies. In 2014, in addition to the World Service Meeting, trustees and staff visited Colombia, El Salvador and Latvia. Tentative international travel for 2015 includes the 11th Mexican Convention of A.A., A.A. Japan 40th Anniversary, the General Service Conference in Ukraine, and the Zonal Meetings (Asia-Oceania Service Meeting, European Service Meeting, Sub-Saharan Africa Service Meeting and the Meeting of the Americas).

The committee reviewed the function of the Trip Consultation Team, which makes decisions about accepting invitations for international travel. The Team is composed of the chair of the General Service Board, both trustees-at-large, one additional trustee, the general manager of G.S.O. and the staff member on the International assignment. The committee also reviewed the Trip Consultation Team International Invitation Review Worksheet. For each international invitation, this form is completed and provided to the trustees' International Committee for their information.

The committee heard information about the necessity of having adequate interpretation on international trips to insure the ability of representatives of our structure to communicate with local members. The committee reviewed a draft of guidelines for adequate interpretation, and agreed to continue to revise the document. If necessary, we may coordinate arrangements for a professional interpreter for our representatives, which may include travel costs and related expenses.

We continue to be encouraged and inspired by the international A.A. community and General Service Boards and offices in other countries, which carry the A.A. message to countless thousands in new regions and across difficult linguistic, cultural and economic barriers.

Barb Kelly, chairperson

Staff report: The International desk receives correspondence from groups, individual A.A.s and professionals interested in obtaining information about A.A. in countries outside of the U.S. and Canada. Additionally, the staff member corresponds with 61 international general service offices and/or literature distribution centers.

The International desk is also responsible for communication with structures, groups and members outside the United States/Canada. Correspondence arrives at the International desk in many languages and is answered in the appropriate language, often accompanied by A.A. literature. In order to accomplish this, the staff member on the assignment is assisted by a bilingual (English-Spanish) assistant and outside professional services. Where there is a nearby office, we provide that contact information. We emphasize our trust in the fact that these members can maintain sobriety, help others and become independent in their own countries.

The International staff member benefits from the experience of G.S.O. staff, cooperation with the Publishing Department, and the support of the trustees' International Committee, which he or she serves as secretary. Other responsibilities on the assignment are:

- Serving as coordinator for the biennial World Service Meeting (WSM) and maintaining contact with WSM delegates and their offices throughout the year
- Maintaining close communications with



our Publishing Department on requests for new translations of literature, and the beginnings of new general service or information offices that may be able to distribute literature to local members and groups.

- Each year, A.A. World Services receives offers to translate our literature into foreign languages. The Big Book has now been translated into 69 languages, and additional translations are in progress. Primary in consideration of each request is the need to ensure the integrity and authenticity of A.A.'s message. To that end, the Publishing Department has the responsibility of having each translation checked against the English original. In countries where there is a general service board licensed to publish or distribute A.A. literature, an approved translation is often financed and published there. Where a stable A.A. structure is not yet present, the A.A.W.S. Board undertakes the new publication when funds are available.
- Handling communications related to overseas travel, and attendance at Zonal Service Meetings. Our trustees-at-large (U.S. and Canada) are our delegates to the Meeting of the Americas (REDELA). Other Zonal Meetings include the Asia-Oceania, European, and Sub-Saharan Africa Service Meetings.
- Working closely with our Records Department to ensure that our International A.A. Directory (for countries outside of the United States and Canada), which is published annually, contains updated contact information for G.S.O.s, central offices and intergroups, groups, foreign contacts and Loners around the world.

Rick Walker

INTERNATIONAL CONVENTIONS/ REGIONAL FORUMS

Trustees' reports:

International Conventions — Since the 2014 General Service Conference our committee has met three times. The purpose of the trustees' committee as it relates to International Conventions is to work on plans for each forthcoming International Convention. The objectives of the 2015 International Convention, with its theme "80 Years — Happy, Joyous and Free," are:

- To provide opportunities for a rededication of attendees to the primary purpose of A.A.
- To enable attendees to witness the success and growth of the A.A. program around the world.
- To let the world know that A.A. is alive, flourishing and available as a community resource, locally and internationally.

The committee acts and makes recommendations in order to fulfill the broad purposes of the General Service Board, as those purposes relate to the strengthening of the Fellowship and the advancement of its message, through well-planned International Conventions. The detailed work inherent in putting on the Convention is executed by the Conference coordinator and a professional Convention Consultant.

In keeping with the 2014 Advisory Action, the committee noted that plans are underway for the anonymity-protected photograph of the flag ceremony and an encrypted, anonymity-protected Internet broadcast of the 2015 International Convention Opening Flag Ceremony.

We reviewed the list of non-A.A. professional friends of A.A. who were suggested as potential speakers at the 2015 International Convention. The committee also reviewed and approved the tentative schedule of professional panels and participants. Similar to previous International Conventions, the 2015 Convention program will include several professional panels

with speakers from various professional fields and backgrounds: medicine, psychology, healthcare, social work, corrections, court programs, EAP, military, veterans, treatment, clergy, etc. We agreed to extend invitations to special guests who are surviving links to A.A.'s early history: Laurie Lukens, daughter of Ruth Hock and Sr. Judith Ann Karam, CSA, FACHE, Congregational Leader of the Sisters of Charity. Ruth Hock was A.A.'s first national secretary and worked with Bill W. The Sisters of Charity is the order to which Sister Ignatia belonged. The committee recommended to the General Service Board that the 35th millionth Big Book, *Alcoholics Anonymous*, be presented to the Sisters of Charity of St. Augustine at the 2015 International Convention.

The committee agreed that invitations be extended to one board representative from the following Fellowships: Narcotics Anonymous (N.A.) and Gamblers Anonymous (G.A.). They will be invited to participate on the panel "A.A. and Other Twelfth Step Fellowships."

We reviewed and approved the formats for the Friday night, Saturday night and Sunday morning Big Meetings that will be held in the Georgia Dome. Additionally, we reviewed the speaker selection process, and affirmed the principle that we strive to select speakers who did not speak at the previous Convention.

The committee noted that plans are underway for a "Carry the Message" pavilion at the Convention Center where there will be service booths for C.P.C., Corrections, Public Information, Treatment, Special Needs-Accessibilities and the A.A. Grapevine. In addition, there will be an "Anonymity" informational booth, located near one of the main entrances to the Convention Center and in close proximity to the Media/Press Hospitality room.

The committee agreed that a booth for *La Vigne*, the French language, Grapevine-styled magazine of the four General Service Quebec areas, be provided at the 2015 International Convention similar to 2010 and 2005 International Conventions.

We also discussed the 2030 Site-Selection Guidelines and noted the need to be sensitive to any potential conflict of interest on future trustees' Committees on Conventions/Regional Forums.

Regional Forums — Since the 2014 General Service Conference, Regional Forums have been held in the Pacific, Eastern Canada and Southeast regions. All were well attended by enthusiastic A.A. members interested in learning more about the General Service Board, General Service Office and A.A. Grapevine. Many in attendance were experiencing their first Forum. Each Forum was viewed as an opportunity to exchange information among local trusted servants, A.A.s interested in service, trustees, directors and staff of G.S.O. and Grapevine. Equally important was the opportunity to hear sharing of experience, strength and hope, as well as challenges and successes of A.A. members on the front lines of service. Following each Regional Forum the trustees' Committee on International Conventions/Regional Forums reviewed a summary of the Forum evaluation questionnaires.

In July 2014, the committee reviewed and approved the schedule for the 2014-2017 Forums and the board members attending each one. In November 2014 the committee reviewed and accepted the preliminary 2015 Regional Forums budget and forwarded it to the trustees' Finance and Budgetary Committee. They also reviewed summaries of the evaluation questionnaires for the 2014 Western Canada, Pacific and Eastern Canada Regional Forums.

In January 2015 the committee recommended to the General Service Board that a request for a Local Forum, received prior to the 64th Conference, to be hosted by Area 84, Northeast Ontario, in September 2015 be approved.

2015

May 29-31	Northeast	Albany, NY
August 21-31	West Central	Casper, WY
	'Additional'	
September 11-13	Western Canada	Whitehorse, Yukon
October 9-11	Southwest	St. Louis, MO
November 13-15	East Central	Milwaukee, WI

Ivan Lemelle, chairperson

Staff reports:

The International Convention assignment entails coordinating every aspect of the many processes and plans that go to make up the A.A. International Conventions, held every five years. Working with four committees — Trustees, Conference, G.S.O. Planning, and Host — the International Convention coordinator is responsible for making sure that the Convention comes together as a wonderful opportunity for A.A. members to celebrate gratitude and sobriety.

Plans proceed apace for the 2015 International Convention, which will be held in the wonderful city of Atlanta, July 2–5, 2015. The Convention theme, chosen from suggestions sent in by the Fellowship, is “80 Years – Happy, Joyous and Free.” Throughout the Convention week, more than 4,000 local A.A.s, coordinated by the Atlanta Volunteer Host Committee, will welcome visitors from around the globe. The 2015 International Convention will kick-off with a “Party in the Park” with dances and celebrations flowing from Centennial Olympic Park to the Georgia World Congress Center and back out to the Park and local hotels. During the day on Friday and Saturday the Convention Center will be packed with Topic Meetings, Panels, Regional Meetings and Workshops. Approximately 650 speakers will participate in over 200 meetings. Friday night, Saturday night and Sunday morning all attendees will come together for the Big Meetings in the Georgia Dome, conveniently located next to the Convention Center.

The traditional flag ceremony of nations in attendance will take place at the Friday night meeting in the Georgia Dome stadium. Similar to the previous International Convention, the Flag Ceremony will have unlimited broadcast over the Internet starting Saturday morning, and will remain available until Monday at midnight. The broadcast will be anonymity protected. On Saturday night, oldtimers chosen from the hat will share about their years of experience, strength and hope in Alcoholics Anonymous.

For family members and loved ones who belong to Al-Anon or Alateen and will accompany us to Atlanta, daytime Al-Anon/Alateen meetings and other events will take place at the Atlanta Marriott Marquis.

Information about the Convention has been made available through G.S.O.'s A.A. website, in Box 4-5-9, and in A.A. Grapevine. The website will be updated as we move ahead and the Convention app will be available for download in May. Excitement is plentiful as this 80th Anniversary celebration draws nearer. Georgia on our minds!

Eva Sanchez

Regional Forums: The staff member handling Regional Forums is responsible for coordinating and following through on all

arrangements necessary for holding Regional Forums and Additional Regional Forums in the U.S. and Canada. These sharing weekends help foster wider communication and understanding among A.A. groups, members and trusted servants in a region, the General Service Board, A.A. World Services, Inc., A.A. Grapevine Corporate Board, and Grapevine and General Service Office staff. Regional Forums are organized by the General Service Board and regularly scheduled at the invitation of a particular region every two years.

The Regional Forums coordinator at G.S.O. distributes the annual Regional Forum flyers and individual Forum registration forms to trusted service workers in the region and coordinates Forum details: hotel arrangements, program, displays, on-site registration, etc. The Regional Forums coordinator works closely with the host contact who recruits volunteers to assist staff with hospitality, set-up and registration during the Forum weekend. The location for a Regional Forum is decided jointly by the regional trustee, area delegates and G.S.O., who also suggest presentations and workshops. The Regional Forums coordinator is also responsible for overseeing the preparation and distribution of an “early bird” newsletter at each Forum and forwarding a Forum Final Report to all who attend. Advance planning and on-site work gets done with the help of a very able staff assistant.

In October 2006, the General Service Board implemented Additional and Local Forums on a five-year trial basis. In July of 2012, the General Service Board agreed to discontinue Additional Regional Forums after completion of the eight region cycle in 2016. The board noted the cost of each Forum and the impact on the attendance and effectiveness of Regional Forums when three consecutive yearly Forums are held in any one region.

The General Service Board also agreed that regions continue to be encouraged to support Local Forums structured to meet cultural, accessibility and population considerations within their own A.A. communities, and that the trustees' Committee on International Conventions/Regional Forums continue to annually approve, at its July meeting, travel of up to two members of the General Service Board, nontrustee directors of the A.A.W.S. or Grapevine Boards or the G.S.O. or Grapevine staff at up to three Local Forums. The staff member on the A.A. Regional Forums assignment serves as cosecretary to the trustees' and Conference International Conventions/Regional Forums Committees.

Clay Rittenhouse

LITERATURE

Trustees' report: This report offers a summary of the literature projects of the trustees' Committee on Literature since the 2014 General Service Conference.

Projects resulting from 2014 Advisory Actions and Additional Committee Considerations of the General Service Conference:

- *Literature which focuses on spirituality* — The new Conference-approved pamphlet, “Many Paths to Spirituality,” was published in September 2014.
- *“Circles of Love and Service” pamphlet* — The revised Conference-approved pamphlet “Circles of Love and Service” was published in September 2014.
- *Correction to Foreword of Big Book* — Text related to the addition of appendices on page XI in the Preface of *Alcoholics Anonymous*, which currently reads:

“The second edition added the appendices, the Twelve Traditions, and the directions for getting in touch with A.A.” was replaced with:

“The second printing of the first edition added the appendix ‘Spiritual Experience’; in the second edition, the appendices

on A.A. Tradition, the 'medical view' and 'religious view' of A.A., the Lasker Award and information on how to contact A.A. were added, and the appendix on the Alcoholic Foundation was discontinued."

Additional Items reviewed, discussed and forwarded to the 2015 Conference Committee on Literature:

- Suggested revisions to the pamphlet "Inside A.A.: Understanding the Fellowship and Its Service Agencies."
- Suggested revisions to the pamphlet "Your A.A. General Service Office."
- Requests to update "A.A. for the Gay/Lesbian Alcoholic."
- Requests to consider combining *Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions* with the *Twelve Concepts for World Service* into a new book.
- Request to create literature for the alcoholic with mental health issues.
- Request to update/revise the pamphlet "A.A. for the Woman."

No Action Items: At their quarterly meetings the committee thoroughly discussed and took no action on the following items:

- A request to change the text of the Foreword to the Second Edition of *Alcoholics Anonymous* to be as it was originally published. The committee found that the historical information available did not warrant the change being made.
- A request for *Daily Reflections* Volume 2. The committee noted that the sharing in *Daily Reflections* is not dated and there is not a widely expressed need from the Fellowship for a second volume.
- A suggestion to develop A.A. material for the disabled veteran. The committee noted that the pamphlet "A.A. and the Armed Services" had recently been updated. The staff secretary was asked to keep this request on file as a reminder to consider stories from disabled veterans during future updates of stories.
- A request for "a pamphlet written by and for A.A. unbelievers." The committee agreed that this is not the right time for this proposal so soon after the publication of "Many Paths to Spirituality" and they requested that the staff secretary keep this request on file as a reminder to consider stories from atheists, agnostics and freethinkers during future updates of stories in our literature.
- A suggestion to revise text on page 28 of "Is A.A. For Me?" The committee reviewed the content of the requested changes and appreciated the effort behind the work but acknowledged that it

expressed an individual's interpretation and was not reflective of the Fellowship as a whole.

- A request to create a book of Conference presentations. The committee discussed the many challenges inherent in this project, the presentations are contained in individual *Conference Reports*, and observed that it is not recovery based and has not been a widely expressed need from the Fellowship.
- A request to add Membership Survey data and/or accompanying artwork to several pamphlets. After careful discussion, the committee concluded that the Membership Survey data would not enhance the pamphlets and had the potential to make A.A. less attractive to potential members and to those professionals recommending them to A.A.
- A request that the Twelve Steps be identified as "The suggested program of recovery" wherever they appear in our literature. The committee noted that there is no widely expressed need to make this change throughout our literature.

Chet Parker, chairperson

Staff report: As secretary to the trustees' and Conference Committees on Literature, the Literature coordinator works closely with the editors, writers and illustrators on reviewing all new recovery pamphlets, books and audiovisuals, in accordance with recommendations from the General Service Conference. Along with the Publishing Department, the coordinator follows the progress of writers and illustrators on the updating and revising of all existing recovery books, booklets and pamphlets. Final design and production of all this material is under the auspices of the A.A. World Services Publishing Department.

The Literature desk receives and responds to correspondence about A.A. literature from A.A. members and groups. Many of these inquiries are passed along to our Order Entry Department, our Customer Service representatives, our Publishing staff and our Archives staff. Contact is also maintained with all current area, district, and intergroup/central office literature chairpersons. Each newly elected literature chairperson receives a welcoming letter and guidelines to assist the chairperson in this vital responsibility. There are currently 68 area, 382 district and 21 intergroup/central office literature chairpersons listed with G.S.O. The Literature assistant is invaluable in supporting and helping facilitate the responsibilities of this aspect of the assignment.

The Literature staff member also gathers sharing for Box 4-5-9.



working closely with the Publishing Department managing editor and the G.S.O. editorial committee to continue to provide the Fellowship with news and notes from G.S.O. These 'news and notes' may include articles containing shared experience from A.A. Conference-approved literature that addresses questions raised in multiple phone calls, emails and letters to staff members. G.S.O. always welcomes committee sharing on service from the Fellowship, which may be included in articles so that *Box 4-5-9* can be an accurate reflection of both Fellowship and G.S.O. activities.

Box 4-5-9 is published in English, French and Spanish with current quarterly distribution of 64,309 copies in English, 2,077 copies in French and 3,395 copies in Spanish. In addition, there are currently 10,481 subscribers to the digital delivery service for *Box 4-5-9* available through G.S.O.'s A.A. website, www.aa.org. Also on the website the interested A.A. member can find a digital copy of every issue of *Box 4-5-9* going back to the original issue from 1956.

As literature is essential in helping to carry our message of recovery, this remains a challenging and rewarding assignment.

Mary Clare Lynch

NOMINATING

Trustees' report: The trustees' Committee on Nominating of the General Service Board was first appointed by the chairman of the board on January 18, 1944. At that time primary responsibilities were to "establish criteria for and to review resumes of trustee candidates and directors and to make recommendations regarding electoral procedures and matters which may affect the composition of the board and election to it." (History and Actions of the trustees' Committee on Nominating)

Since that time the trustees' Committee on Nominating generally has met three times each year and, with the forming of the General Service Conference in 1951, the committee began to meet annually with the Conference Committee on Trustees. The responsibilities of the committee grew over time to encompass criteria for all vacancies, whether in the ranks of trustees or among key service directors and staff members.

Activities of this committee in the past year:

- **Class A Trustee Election:** The committee reviewed the resumes, curriculum vitae, and other background material of 27 applicants who had made themselves available to serve as Class A (nonalcoholic) trustees. The committee chose seven applicants to interview in January 2015.

Following the interviews, the committee recommended to the General Service Board that Leslie S. Backus, B.A. and Peter Luongo, Ph.D., LCSW-C, be invited to serve as Class A trustees to succeed Frances L. Brisbane, Ph.D. and Corliss R. Burke, B.Ed. following the 2015 General Service Conference.

- **Regional Trustee Elections:** The committee recommended to the General Service Board, as eligible for election in April 2015, all candidates submitted for Northeast and Southwest regional trustees and all candidates for trustee-at-large/Canada.

- **Board Slates:** The committee reviewed and recommended proposed slates of General Service Board members, officers of the board, and A.A. World Services and A.A. Grapevine directors to the annual meeting of the members of the General Service Board in April 2015, following presentation at the 2015 General Service Conference for disapproval, if any.

- **A.A.W.S. Directors:** The committee recommended that Richard Boisvert serve as trustee director for a two-year term on A.A. World Services, Inc. to succeed J. Gary Lutz.

- **A.A. Grapevine Directors:** The committee recommended that Ed Martin serve as a general service trustee, replacing Nancy Haynes on the A.A. Grapevine Board; the committee recommended that Joel Castellaw serve as trustee director for a two-year term to succeed Andrew Ware on A.A. Grapevine Board; the committee also recommended that Class A trustee Ivan Lemelle be added to the A.A. Grapevine Board.

- **Committee's Composition, Scope and Procedures:** In the past year the committee has worked extensively on revisions to: Procedure No. 5 (Grapevine and A.A.W.S. Boards — Procedures for Nominating General Service Trustees), and recommended to the General Service Board that when a general service trustee vacancy occurs on the board of an affiliate corporation, the nominating committee of the board concerned will consider the following in its search "Nontrustee directors currently serving on either affiliate board." Replacing the previous phrase "currently serving on its board."

Procedure No. 9 (Guidelines for Hiring General Manager, G.S.O.), and recommended to the General Service Board that the section which currently reads:

"The following procedures draw on the experience of the past and are suggestions only:"

Be revised to read:

"The following procedures draw on the experience of the past:"

Procedure No. 11 (Procedures for Electing Regional Trustee Candidates in the U.S. and Canada) the committee recommended to the General Service Board revised language for "unexpected vacancies" which will remove any ambiguity from the decision making process.

Procedures and Areas of Authority contained in the trustees' Committee on Nominating's Composition, Scope and Procedure. The committee recommended to the General Service Board revisions that clarify the A.A.W.S. positions covered in the Areas of Authority and to change the section for "approval of the recommendation" to reflect current practice.

Appointed Committee Members: The committee recommended the reappointment of Caroline Carney of New York, NY and Josh Eggleston of Durham, North Carolina for additional one-year terms as appointed committee members on the trustees' Committee on Public Information.

J. Gary Lutz, chairperson

Staff report: This assignment's staff member is responsible to the trustees' Committee on Nominating, and to the Conference Committee on Trustees, serving as secretary to these committees as well as to trustees' subcommittees. Since the last Conference, the staff member prepared background, minutes and reports for three quarterly trustees' committee meetings. The staff member worked with the trustees' committee on vacancy announcements, sent time commitment and interest status letters to Class A candidates, accompanied by a new document, "Information for the prospective Class A trustee." The staff member later sent follow-up letters to Class A candidates, and organized the interview scheduling processes of the search for two Class A trustees to succeed Frances Brisbane and Corliss Burke. The staff member also coordinated the transcription and review of resumes for 40 Class B trustee candidates who made their names available to participate in this year's Conference elections procedure.

Clay Rittenhouse

PUBLIC INFORMATION

Trustees' report: The trustees' Committee on Public Information is charged with the responsibility of helping the membership carry the A.A. message of recovery through the general public to the alcoholic who still suffers. We do this by recommending and coordinating activities that include: creating a greater public understanding of the Fellowship of Alcoholics Anonymous; producing video and audio public service announcements (P.S.A.s); preparing and posting press releases on aa.org; coordinating health fairs and other community and school exhibits with local P.I. committees; conducting the triennial A.A. Membership Survey; and carrying A.A.'s message through electronic as well as print media. Projects over the past year have included:

- *Anonymity* — Because this vital principle lies at the heart of all our Traditions, the committee discussed a number of topics and related literature:

- *Annual Mailings:* The committee reviewed and accepted the text of the annual Anonymity Letter to the Media, to be emailed to approximately 30,000 media professionals following the 2015 General Service Conference. A brief video on anonymity, intended as a companion piece to this annual communication, has also been produced and will be screened for the 2015 Conference Public Information Committee.

The committee also reviewed the text of the Memo to Tapers. The staff secretary will follow up with distributing this item in 2015 in the same manner as 2014, including copying all delegates on this mailing.

- *Development of Anonymity Resource Page on aa.org:* Suggestions for a new Anonymity Resource Page were forwarded to the Intra-Office Website Committee (I.O.W.C.) so that all available resources on anonymity might be gathered for easy access. The new page is expected to launch in spring 2015.

- *2015 International Convention:* The committee received information from the staff secretary regarding planning for the press/media room, as well as efforts to safeguard the anonymity of A.A. members attending the Convention.

- *Oversight of G.S.O.'s A.A. Website* — The committee reviewed quarterly reports from the A.A.W.S. Board regarding changes to aa.org, updates on website activity, a summary of requests from

the Fellowship regarding the website and a summary of actions taken by the A.A.W.S. Board in response to those requests and status reports on the redesign of G.S.O.'s A.A. Website. As a follow-up to the 2014 Public Information Comprehensive Media Plan, web banners to facilitate traffic to the aa.org website are now available for download on aa.org. These web banners will also make it possible to submit video P.S.A.s as "pre-rolls" on Hulu, an online platform for television and film content. An annual report by the A.A.W.S. Board was forwarded to the 2015 Conference P.I. Committee, along with a report from the trustees' P.I. Committee on potential uses of website analytics.

- *The Grapevine/La Viña Website* — The committee reviewed reports from the Grapevine Board on the Grapevine/La Viña Website activity.

- *A.A. Videos for Young People Project* — Submission guidelines for the A.A. Videos for Young People Project were updated to encourage more submissions.

- *Media Training* — The committee approved a proposed plan for media training for board members and staff who may interact with the press; an initial training session was conducted in February 2015.

- *Public Information Comprehensive Media Plan* — In July, a subcommittee was appointed to explore recommendations for continuing development and implementation of the Public Information Comprehensive Media Plan. The committee asked the staff secretary to continue sharing information about the plan with the corporate boards. The committee also forwarded to the 2015 Conference Committee on Public Information the 2015 Public Information Comprehensive Media Plan.

- *Membership Survey* — Over 30,000 questionnaires were sent to area delegates for distribution to more than 823 groups randomly selected in the U.S. and Canada. Area delegates gathered completed questionnaires and returned them to G.S.O. Results have been forwarded to the 2015 Conference Public Information Committee to update the A.A. Membership Survey pamphlet and tabletop display.

- *Video P.S.A.s* — At the July meeting a subcommittee was formed to consider the following recurring agenda items for the Conference Committee on Public Information. (a) review current



video P.S.A.s for relevance and usefulness, and (b) assess the need for a new video P.S.A. The committee forwarded to the 2015 Conference Committee on Public Information the report from the subcommittee on Video P.S.A.s., which included recommendations for retiring two video P.S.A.s and the suggestion that “Tengo Esperanza,” currently available only in Spanish, be translated into English and French.

A second subcommittee was formed to produce a new television P.S.A., as requested by a 2014 Advisory Action. The new spot, an animated P.S.A. entitled “Doors,” has been forwarded to the 2015 Conference Public Information Committee.

- **P.I. Kit** — Contents of the Public Information Kit are viewable on the redesigned aa.org website on the Public Information committee resource page.

The committee remains committed to do all it can to assist the membership in its service of carrying the message of recovery through public resources to the general public and to the alcoholic who still suffers, and welcomes suggestions from the Fellowship as to what more can be done.

Clayton Vandivort, chairperson

Staff report: This assignment is charged with assisting the A.A. members who carry our message to the suffering alcoholic through the public — schools, health fairs, community events, libraries, and all forms of the media. Below are some of the ways that this task is carried out:

- Communicate with 850 P.I. committee chairpersons at the area, district and intergroup/central office or group level to provide them with Workbooks, Guidelines, and current shared information on Public Information activity.
- Provide literature to supplement the efforts of local Public Information committees which are serving as a resource about Alcoholics Anonymous at local health and community fairs.
- Provide P.I. committees with information regarding the production and distribution of video and audio Public Service Announcements (P.S.A.s), in order to enhance their efforts on the local level, and refer all media requests for P.S.A.s to local committees.
- Respond to all inquiries that come to the office from the media, providing them with accurate information about Alcoholics Anonymous. Coordinate media coverage of International Conventions, held every five years. Work closely with Publishing Department regarding development and distribution of press releases.
- Read and process a number of newspaper, magazine and Internet feature stories that mention Alcoholics Anonymous, and receive information from members regarding anonymity breaks at the level of press, radio, films, television and the Internet.
- Pass along instances of anonymity breaks in the media to the delegate in the area in which the break occurred, and provide them with an opportunity to contact the member and share experience regarding our Eleventh Tradition.
- Send out the Annual Anonymity Letter to the Media. In April 2014 it was emailed to over 29,000 media outlets in the U.S. and Canada. This included daily and weekly newspapers, wire services, radio stations, and TV networks, stations and cable services. A brief video on anonymity was produced in-house to accompany the 2015 mailing.
- Coordinate production of new television and radio Public Service Announcements as necessary, and work with the Publishing Department regarding available formats and delivery options.
- Work closely with the Publishing Department regarding devel-

opment and updating of Conference-approved and assignment related service material.

- Coordinate the triennial A.A. Membership Survey. The results of triennial surveys are published in pamphlet form and as a table display for visual information about Alcoholics Anonymous at public events.

- Participate as a member of the Interoffice Website Committee (I.O.W.C.), which reviews suggested changes to the aa.org website, a key aspect of our Public Information efforts.

The goal of Public Information work at G.S.O. is to see that the A.A. message of recovery reaches the still-suffering alcoholic by informing the general public about the A.A. program.

Jim Malone

STAFF COORDINATOR

Staff report: The General Service Office provides services to A.A. groups and members, and shares A.A. experience when available. Eleven A.A. members comprise the “G.S.O. Staff” with each person responsible for a functional assignment in addition to responding to requests from a specific region in Canada and the U.S., or from other countries. The staff coordinator shares responsibility for corresponding with members from the Southwest region, covering the busy six months of the year for the Conference coordinator.

In 2014, the staff received 89,959 pieces of correspondence by mail, email and fax, a 17.5% increase over correspondence received in 2013. The staff also answers many phone calls daily. The staff coordinator helps to assure that letters are answered when staff members are involved in large projects or away from the office to attend A.A. events, or at times of illness or vacation. Mail, email, faxes, etc., are responded to within ten business days.

G.S.O. staff benefits from the experience of A.A. groups gathered over many years. These resources are passed on to members who seek guidance for their group, central office, district or area assembly. Questions and requests for sharing from the Fellowship are often brought to weekly staff meetings, so that responses reflect either research from A.A. literature or service material or the collective experience of G.S.O. staff and archives. Our weekly staff meetings provide a forum for sharing ideas on how to better serve A.A. groups and members or how to provide the most complete answers to Fellowship inquiries.

G.S.O. staff members serve as secretaries to trustees’ and Conference Committees and also are voting members of the General Service Conference. The staff coordinator is secretary to the Conference Policy/Admissions Committee.

In 2014, G.S.O. welcomed a total of 2,213 individuals, including many English- and Spanish-speaking groups ranging in size from 10 to 50. Each visitor had an opportunity to see and hear “how G.S.O. works” and view a display of Grapevine materials during a tour of G.S.O. Often visiting members and guests attend the open A.A. meeting held at G.S.O. at 11:00 a.m. on Fridays. This is an opportunity for the G.S.O. staff to welcome A.A. members from all over the world or from around the corner.

The staff coordinator has the privilege of serving as a director on A.A. World Services, Inc. in accordance with Concept IV, and also serves as liaison between staff members and other G.S.O. departments. None of these activities would be possible without the dedication and skill of a very capable support staff.

Julio Espallat

■ Area Service Highlights — Panel 65 Delegates

(Only first-term delegates give Area Highlights)

Alabama/Northwest Florida: Area 1 includes the entire state of Alabama and the portion of Florida in the Central Time Zone. We have 23 districts, approximately 475 active groups, and about 10,000 A.A. members. Our area assembly is held quarterly in Auburn, AL. The object of our area assembly is to be the conduit of information between G.S.O. and Area 1 districts and groups. During 2014 our area had to dissolve our Hispanic district, which covered all the Hispanic groups in the area. It was very difficult for the groups to have district meetings and was very expensive. April is our pre-Conference assembly, and the remaining ones are dedicated to the business of our area. We have groups and districts assigned to a particular committee and we have the same committee structure as the General Service Conference. The D.C.M.s are provided with a CD copy of the background material, and they provide hard copies to the groups assigned to the committees. During the pre-Conference assembly the committee chairs obtain a sense of the committee on each agenda item. At the Sunday morning meeting each committee member provides a conscience for each agenda item and presents this as a part of our "Input to the Delegate Meeting," along with the reasoning behind each decision. On my path to delegate I served as the area's registrar who chairs the Report and Charter Committee. Now, by coincidence or not, I am assigned to the Conference Report and Charter Committee. — *Jim Stone*

Arkansas: Area 4, which includes the entire state of Arkansas, has 264 active groups in 13 districts; 12 districts are geographic and the 13th is our first linguistic district. Arkansas is essentially a rural area with a couple of urban spots. As a result, we have found it easiest and cheapest to host our weekend assemblies in the same central location each quarter. Our assemblies include committee, district, and business sessions, but we also have other interesting sessions. Our area holds a Tradition and Concept study at each assembly. Past and current delegates answer questions during our "Ask-It-Basket" session. Our 10 permanent committees all remain actively engaged in service. Our state convention, the Old Grandad, is the oldest A.A. convention west of the Mississippi River and will celebrate its 75th anniversary this year. Our Archives committee houses materials for display at presentations and conventions, and contains one of the most comprehensive collections in the nation. In order to foster unity, all of our D.C.M.s share experiences and solutions in our Group Relations committee, chaired by a past delegate. I am grateful for the many past delegates in our area who remain engaged in A.A. activity. It is a privilege to be a part of such a service-oriented area. — *Rebecca McNeill*

British Columbia/Yukon: Area 79 is the second largest area in the U.S./Canada service structure, covering over 900,000 square miles. We have 48 districts (some larger than California) and approximately 800 groups. Our quarterlies and assemblies move throughout our vast and diverse area to foster unity. We have an average of 300 members attending these meetings, with over 90% district participation. Our area's 14-member General Service Committee fulfills approximately 120 requests annually for participation at local events. Our website continues to evolve, providing easier access to information and through our secure "trusted servant site," facilitating communication with our groups. We have just completed a trial period of having three Area 79 Micro Forums, which provide sharing and informational sessions in an attempt to reach out to districts, which have recently been unable to participate. Our C.P.C. committee staffed information tables at two medical conferences, as

requested by G.S.O., and at two provincial medical conferences on our own initiative. Recently delegate's reports have been presented to most districts and inside federal correctional facilities. We are looking forward to increasing our area unity by hosting the 2015 Additional Western Canada Regional Forum in Whitehorse, Yukon, 2016 BC/Yukon Convention in Abbotsford BC, 2016 Western Canada Regional Forum in Kamloops, BC and, of course, the 2025 International Convention in Vancouver, BC. It is a privilege to serve Area 79. — *Jennifer Kuntz*

California (Central): Although Area 93 is the newest and youngest area in the Conference Structure, and an outgrowth of Area 5, we have come into our own and are growing as is revealed to us by the results of our 4th "quadrennial" Area Inventory in 2014. We continue to serve in ways such as: Preservation and Group History Workshops, Longtimers Events, and Gratitude Days hosted by our Archives committee. Our C.P.C. committee cooperates with a myriad of professionals, with emphasis on schools. Both Grapevine and La Viña committees have been hosting Story Writing Workshops at and outside of area assemblies. Our La Viña committee is very active at multi-area La Viña Anniversary Events, resulting in increased subscriptions and stories. We held two Area Literature Workshops — in 2013 and 2014 — thanks to our Literature Committee. P.I. efforts filled literature racks and placed P.S.A.s on TV and radio. Our Registration committee completed its Mapping Project of more clearly delineating all the districts in Area 93. Treatment keeps on trudging, making great strides. Delegate Opinion Polls are available online for G.S.R.s and other area members to be better heard. Paraphrasing from our Twelve and Twelve: Service, gladly rendered, obligations squarely met, troubles well accepted or solved, we in Area 93 are indeed partners in a common effort freely giving Love and Service. — *Lisa Part*

California (Northern Coastal): Area 6 runs north to the California-Oregon border and south into Monterey County. It includes approximately 60,000 members in 2,144 groups within 153 subdistricts inside 23 districts, which has 18 English-speaking districts with an overlapping 5 Spanish-linguistic districts and a new birth of a Mandarin Chinese group. I'm proud to say six of our D.C.M.C.s are young people full of enthusiasm and looking toward our growing future generation. We have a monthly Area Committee Meeting that includes area business; standing committees, such as Bridging the Gap, Archives, P.I./C.P.C., Interpretation & Translation, Finance, Web, and District Committee Member; and Literature, Grapevine and La Viña Sharing Sessions. All of our services are fully self-supported through the groups, districts and area members. Our budget is over \$100,000 annually. We have four assemblies a year to allow more participation from our G.S.R.s. We continuously translate and interpret our services to better serve throughout the area. One of the most rewarding experiences is when our eight area officers, including the delegate, interact with the members, especially new G.S.R.s, by visiting the districts every month. — *Raymundo Lujano*

California (Southern): Area 5 encompasses most of the greater Los Angeles area, from Malibu on the west to Rancho Cucamonga on the east, the San Gabriel mountains on the north to Roscrans Blvd on the south, bordering Area 9. We are surely one of the smallest areas geographically, as well as being one of the most densely populated. We have 32 active districts, five of them being overlaying Spanish-speaking districts. Our west side combined districts make up about half of all districts. We have

15 active standing committees, the most recently established being Cooperation With the Elder Community and Corrections. Our Corrections committee has done well, working with the L.A. metropolitan jails allowing A.A. members to meet one-on-one with inmates every Sunday, to share our experience, strength and hope with them, and to let them know that we are here for them. Over the past four years we have implemented an audit subcommittee, responsible to the corporate directors. We have four area assemblies, four area committee meetings, four steering committee meetings and one Spanish-speaking Forum each year. Spanish-to-English interpretation is supplied. We partake in a four-Area D.C.M. Sharing Session, which rotates between us and three of our neighboring areas. We also hold a pre-Conference workshop, with Conference Agenda presentations, given by our committee chairs, or topic-appropriate area committee member, followed by roundtable discussions and report-backs. This has proven to be a very effective way to engage our area, encouraging all to get involved with the Conference process, so that our delegate is well informed with group and area conscience in preparation for the General Service Conference. — *Scott Mulligan*

Colorado: Area 10 encompasses the entire state of Colorado, and is composed of 981 groups (50 are Spanish-speaking) in 32 districts (two are Spanish-speaking and three are not currently participating at the general service level), with approximately 20,000 members. Our districts bid to host our area assemblies, which are held three times per year. We find this practice brings unity to the hosting districts and keeps us all willing to “get in the car,” as one of our past delegates would say. We hold an annual State Convention, usually over Labor Day weekend. We invite Al-Anon to be our guests at our assemblies and our State Convention, where we provide space for them to conduct and hold their meetings. We currently have 11 standing committees, two of which we recently adopted: Finance and Translation. These new committees are active and have made strides improving our area. We are excited to host the last of the additional Forums for our region, June 3–5, 2016 in Denver. We recently conducted an Area Inventory, which led to more questions about leadership, unity and how we can better serve the still-suffering alcoholic. No matter what issues seem to arise, the answers are always found within our spiritual principles — the tools which continue to not only save lives, but ultimately help us sustain sobriety. — *Tami Reynolds*

Connecticut: Area 11 is comprised of the entire State of Connecticut with the exception of two towns. We have 10 districts: 9 English-speaking and one linguistic Spanish district. We translate all local material into Spanish, and have translation equipment and interpreters on hand during our committee meetings and events. There are approximately 1,400 groups, 1,887 meetings, and over 35,000 members. We have 10 special service committees, 5 event committees and a representative to the Al-Anon Convention with A.A. participation. We have three assemblies a year with the purpose of preparing for the Conference, reporting back from the Conference, electing a delegate and conducting area business. At the opening of 2015 we hosted the New England Conference of Young People in A.A. The Connecticut State Conference of Young People in A.A. is an Area 11 event committee with a voice and vote at our Area Committee meetings and assemblies. All committees work hard in making their respective responsibilities effective in carrying the message of A.A. Whether it is cooperating with professionals, speaking in prisons, promoting Grapevine, writing an article for our local newsletter, Area 11 asks what can we do better? It is with great ease for me to say, the Three Legacies of Alcoholics

Anonymous guide Area 11 in carrying the message in the state of Connecticut and beyond. — *Craig Weidner*

District of Columbia: Area 13 encompasses Washington D.C. as well as two counties in Maryland. Characterized by great diversity, over 2,000 meetings are offered in the greater metropolitan area every week, with over 400 groups listed in Area 13, which is incorporated as the Washington Area General Service Assembly (WAGSA Inc.). Our three spirited linguistic districts include Spanish-speaking groups throughout D.C., Maryland, and Virginia. Also strong in service, two committees of Young People in A.A. have been generating enthusiasm lately, with members taking on leadership roles in the assembly. Historically close cooperation with our English-speaking intergroup continues, sharing our commitment to reach the still-suffering alcoholic through local committee efforts. A special Seventh Tradition collection for the G.S.O. is an inspiring area tradition at our November gratitude breakfast, while our spring mini-Conference provides time for A.A. members to consider agenda items before the Conference. Although one of the smallest areas geographically, Area 13 showed its huge heart two years ago after our whole treasury was stolen. Members and groups, though stunned, didn’t allow the area to flounder, but with A.A. love abounding, responded so generously that area business, including our mini-Conference only days away, was able to continue uninterrupted. While abiding faith in our Fellowship never falters, challenges remain in area service, especially how to improve communication in order to enable a truly informed and collective group conscience. — *Amy Carberg*

Florida (North): Area 14 has over 800 active groups spread across 30 districts, from Tallahassee to Jacksonville, down to our Space Coast, then crossing over Orlando to the Gulf of Mexico. We have four assemblies a year. The focus of our spring assembly is to review and discuss the Conference agenda items and then host a sharing session with all of our members and the delegate. Our area has also supported and embraced new technologies. Our website hosts over 1,600 users a month and we also provide our assembly minutes through email and a private webspace. This effort has resulted in the savings of thousands of dollars in duplication and postage costs. We have a thriving membership of young people, many of whom are active in the Florida Conference of Young People in A.A. (FCYPAA) and ICYPAA events. These same young people are also participating at our area level as G.S.R.s and D.C.M.s. Our pre-Conference workshops have improved the transfer of the Conference background information to the Fellowship to prepare for our assembly. As a result, interest has skyrocketed and this year every district, including our Hispanic district, had the opportunity to participate in one of these events. This great team effort entailed 9 workshops and nearly 1,500 delegate miles driven in only 5 weeks. This approach has helped to diminish the “them up in New York” mindset and reinforce to our members that “them up in New York” is actually us, and that we are as close and available as their local district meeting. — *Glenn Walters*

Florida (South), Bahamas, U.S. Virgin Islands, St. Maarten, Antigua, and the Cayman Islands: Area 15 has 19 districts; two are Spanish-speaking. Currently, we are serving 2,172 groups. We hold assemblies four times a year and have as many as 350 voting members in attendance for our business agenda. During our weekend assembly, our 14 standing committees meet to allow each committee a format to share experience. We also have Traditions and Concepts workshops, G.S.R. and D.C.M. sharing sessions and a What’s on Your Mind? session. Our website committee continues to provide our area’s committee

chairs generic email addresses to allow them to be contacted by the general public as necessary. There are links to Intergroup websites provided on our website, which provide meeting locations. We rotate hosting our Florida State Convention with Area 14, where participation has provided a self-supporting event. A portion of our excess funds from our State Convention will be utilized this year during the International Convention to provide a hospitality suite. Please stop by. The 57th ICYPAA will be held in Miami, Labor Day weekend; a group of young people in A.A. getting together to put on a weekend filled with the Three Legacies of A.A. and a lot of fun. With gratitude and responsibility it's a privilege to serve Area 15 and Alcoholics Anonymous. — *Graham Gobie*

Hawaii: Aloha kakou. Area 17 includes 14 districts on the Hawaiian islands of Oahu, Kauai, Maui, Lanai, Molokai and the Big Island of Hawaii. Not only is Hawaii one of the most remote island chains in the world, our islands are separated by hundreds of miles of ocean. We hold three weekend-long assemblies in odd years and four in even years. One-day committee meetings are held between assemblies. Each of our 14 districts take turns hosting these gatherings, thus fostering unity. Although travel costs are significant, we offer homestay to reduce the overall expenses. This practice of rotation facilitates neighbor island participation and Twelfth Step work to all the districts and over 300 groups. We are a diverse population with many ethnic backgrounds — a place where East meets West and many languages are spoken. Active participation with PRAASA and the Pacific Regional Forum fosters unity with A.A. as a whole. Hawaii Area has the honor of hosting the Pacific Regional Forum September 30–October 2, 2016 in Waikoloa on the Big Island. G.S.R.s are assigned to one of our standing committees at our Orientation Assembly in January of the first year of the panel. This panel will complete the digitization of our archives, making them available to the area while drastically reducing our storage costs. Mahalo nui loa from the Hawaii area, where the favorite language is “the language of the heart.” — *Cheryl Nesler*

Illinois (Chicago): Area 19 has a rich A.A. history dating back to our first meeting in September of 1939. But, though we recently celebrated the 75th Anniversary of Continuous Sobriety in the Chicagoland area, never have the words from “There is a Solution” been more true; “We are people who normally would not mix.” We are densely populated, rich in the arts, ethnicities, social backgrounds, and cultural influences. We have over 38,000 members, more than 3,900 weekly meetings, 20 districts, including three Spanish-speaking districts, one Polish-speaking district, and meetings in Russian, Lithuanian, and Ukrainian, to name just a few in our linguistic melting pot. Yet language is not the only, or most significant, barrier we face. Even with a state conference we host every three years, district meetings monthly, area assemblies every two months, standing committees meeting regularly, and workshops hosted by individual districts and committees, a significant portion of our Fellowship remains uninformed about the spiritual rewards of Service. We need to communicate the opportunities for service that are available, as we face the challenge of carrying the message to a more diverse audience; protecting the message while respecting the individuality of our membership continues to be a challenge, as well as an opportunity. Communication is difficult, but one alcoholic talking to another can overcome barriers that have defeated us in the past. — *Tommy Babuscio*

Illinois (Southern): Area 21 consists of approximately 440 registered groups in the southern two-thirds of Illinois. We have 17 districts, includes District 20, which has recently been relit.

There is at least one Spanish-speaking group. Our committees all have a chairperson. Our four area assemblies, one each quarter, rotate, which is established by a bidding process. The annual Spring Conference is also established with a bidding process. The Spring Conference is a service-related event whose purpose is to help prepare the delegate in presenting issues, concerns and group conscience items to take to the Conference. We are also hosting the Illinois State Conference, which will be held in Bloomington in August. We also hosted the Annual Illinois State Corrections Conference, in which we were grateful to have participation from Areas 19 and 20. Most of the state prisons are in Southern Illinois, and those areas were very gracious to provide a sizeable donation of books and literature. All of our functions are self-supporting, well attended, and have produced a noticeable interest in service work, the Concepts, Traditions, and A.A. as a whole. Another event was the 10th Annual Big Book Conference, held in Springfield. We have much the same challenges as others in that we have a huge rural population. We are attempting to reach as many members as we can crossing demographic, educational, financial, and societal barriers. We are definitely not a glum lot. I feel I represent the best area in the whole world! — *Paula J. Elliott*

Indiana (Northern): Area 22 is the Northern half of Indiana, bordering the Michigan state line, south to Indianapolis, and west to east from the Illinois state border to the Ohio border. We have 43 districts, 679 registered groups and nine standing committees. Assemblies are in February, May, August and November. In election years we meet in October, making that the 5th assembly in the even-number years. The May assembly is a fellowship service weekend with workshops, breakout groups and speakers; Sunday is customarily dedicated to the delegate's report. We also meet in March and October for our D.C.M. conferences. Our March D.C.M. conference is devoted to preparing the delegate for the General Service Conference. The October D.C.M. conference has evolved into a G.S.R. school, complete with a principal, phys. ed. teacher, math teacher, etc. This is where the G.S.R.s, D.C.M.s and A.A.s at large are familiarized with the service structure and their distinctive place in that structure. Area 22 alternates hosting the state convention with Area 23 in the odd years. This year was our 62nd Annual State Convention. Our theme was “We *Absolutely* Insist on Enjoying Life!” Area 22's website has proven to be a useful tool for members to obtain meeting schedules and area events throughout the northern half of Indiana. Area 22 is continually looking for ways to serve the area and help the still-suffering alcoholic. — *Irene Martin*

Iowa: Area 24 covers the entire state of Iowa; it has 23 districts, including a Spanish-speaking district that covers the entire state. We have had other challenges with inactive districts, but seeing them become active has been exciting. There are 670 registered groups and approximately 14,000 members. The area committee meets three times per year. January is a service weekend with a business meeting. In March we address agenda items, and in August is a business meeting. We hold two three-day area assemblies in June and October. A bidding process determines locations, giving smaller districts a chance to participate. The delegate's report is given at the June area assembly and by invitation from districts throughout the remainder of the year. We have translation equipment and have used it often. Al-Anon is invited and they hold their meetings in another part of the facility. Assemblies are made up of five area officers, eight area chairs, 23 D.C.M.s the G.S.R.s, and past delegates. Our area chairs actively carry the message by visiting districts and holding workshops around the area. Area 24 maintains its own website (www.aa.iowa.org), posting meeting schedules and area

events. We have various service entities throughout the area, including central offices, intergroups, answering services and district websites. I feel very fortunate to serve Area 24. Their dedication to our Three Legacies is inspiring and helps keep A.A. healthy and alive. — *Tom Clyce*

Louisiana: Area 27 encompasses the entire state of Louisiana and has 30 districts, one being a statewide Spanish-linguistic district. We have 573 registered groups and over 11,000 A.A. members. We hold four assemblies per year as well as a state convention that rotates around Louisiana. Over the next two years, the convention will be held in Baton Rouge, where our area assembly has been meeting for the past decade. We have a Pre-Conference Assembly where we review Conference agenda items to give feedback to our delegate. Every other year, our area conducts an Area Inventory facilitated by the Southeast regional trustee. As one of the results from our last inventory, we started a General Sharing session where we will discuss what is happening in our area and throughout A.A. as a whole. At our regular assemblies, the G.S.R.s and D.C.M.s attend various workshops and sharing sessions and participate on our area standing committees. We have a new website, balanced budget, and many new Grapevine displays in central offices and clubhouses throughout the state. Our archives are being digitized, and our Archives committee is taping oral histories from Louisiana old-timers. Regularly, our C.P.C. committee works with G.S.O. to staff national conventions in New Orleans and our P.I., Treatment and Corrections committees stay busy helping district committees throughout the state. We are happy to announce that our statewide linguistic district won the bid to host the National Hispanic Convention, which will be held September 4–6 in New Orleans. It is a privilege to serve A.A. as the Panel 65 delegate from Area 27. — *Terry Ernst*

Massachusetts (Eastern): Friendly greetings from Area 30, a diverse area which covers the beach and the islands through the Boston area and Worcester County, with 27 districts, which includes a Spanish-speaking district. Our assemblies are hosted by one (or a few) districts on a volunteer basis; we have five one-day assemblies a year. Our area committee meets monthly. We have 12 area-service committees. We are also blessed with involvement with liaisons from intergroups and various YPAA committees. Through our enthusiasm for service, our focus on unity, our outreach via Area Road Shows, and the hard work of our officers, districts, committees, and our liaisons, attendance at our assemblies has been growing; since 2011 our attendance has grown by 50%, and we see somewhere between 150–175 people. We are supported through generous contributions and have been able to host various committee events and provide outreach to our Fellowship and various professionals. We recently held our 51st whoopee sobriety event called the Massachusetts State Convention, which we cohost with Area 31, Western Massachusetts. We are looking forward to hosting the Northeast Regional Service Assembly in 2017. I heard once that the Legacy of Recovery depends on the Legacy of Service. Through continued efforts and the grace of HP, may Area 30 continue to be a part of extending the hand of recovery to any alcoholic who still suffers. — *Michelle Pattridge*

Michigan (Central): Area 32 has 700 registered groups meeting in 14 districts spanning an 18,000 square mile service area. Our assembly meets every other month in one of the 14 districts. Our 12 standing committees meet in the morning. We have a separate D.C.M. meeting with the delegate, past delegates, and the D.C.M.s to exchange information. Our alternate delegate provides a G.S.R. orientation for new G.S.R.s. Each quarter

the three Michigan delegate areas meet as a Statewide Service Committee to discuss and implement A.A. activities that are cooperative in nature. On a rotating basis, one of the three areas hosts the Michigan State Convention. 2015 will be Michigan's 63rd State Convention. The three areas jointly plan and conduct an annual Mock Conference in March to help our new delegates with Conference procedures and to provide the experience of being "delegate for a day" to G.S.R.s and other A.A.s who are welcome to attend. Our area houses the only state women's prison and the only federal prison in Michigan. Literature and support for Behind the Walls comes from all three delegate areas. We are fortunate that those who went before us had the foresight to establish a means by which all of Michigan is able to work cooperatively in carrying the message to those who as yet do not know there is a way out. — *Kirk Faupel*

Michigan (Southeast): Twice I was privileged to chair Area 33's Service Fair, where standing committee chairs set up exhibits and enlighten attendees of the committee's purpose and function, while secretly attempting to procure members to help carry the message. There's closeness at our assembly. All area officers visit as many of the 824 A.A. groups as possible. Our area wallet card contains a QR "Bar Code," which when scanned by a phone app will take the user to the mobile meeting list. Area 33 does provide instruction regarding the A.A. Service Structure via its G.S.R. Orientation, G.S.R. Workshop and monthly A.A. Service Manual Study. However, we seem to fall short in providing support and guidance, in terms of functional information, to help carry out their roles as G.S.R.s and D.C.M.s. This is one of my Legacy Goals. I like that word "Legacy." It means to bequest — to leave something behind. Will I leave what I wrote on paper? Probably not — I'm but a channel. Now I know why past delegates stay around. We're trying to figure out what we've left behind and to assist new delegates write their Legacy Goals. — *Betty Morton*

Minnesota (Southern): Area 36 covers the southern half of Minnesota. We have 27 districts serving over 1,200 registered groups and have two active Intergroup offices. Our organization includes six officers and 13 committees. In addition to committee chairs we have five nonrotating positions including Archivist, Pink Can coordinator, Treatment and Corrections Contact coordinators, and Technologist. Annual activities include our week-end Recovery, Unity and Service conference. Also, early in the year we have our Trusted Servant Leadership Training day to help A.A.s learn about their service roles. To help develop awareness of the Conference Agenda items we encourage participation in our annual West Central Regional Service Conference and our Delegates Workshop day in April. Area 36 holds four quarterly Area Committee meetings. Our C.P.C. participates in a number of professional conferences and there is also an increasing emphasis on "Sponsor Your Professionals." Our P.I. committee coordinates our participation in several state and county fairs and some of our districts have set up PSAs and paid ads. We have area-wide participation in our Treatment and Corrections contact work. Our Pink Can program provides tens of thousands of pieces of literature to those inside the walls each year. Other A.A. activities in our area are workshops, conferences and roundups, including the annual Gopher State Roundup, where more than 8,000 spend their Memorial Day weekend. We have also had the privilege of putting forward a candidate for the position of a Class A trustee. — *Lisa Dawn Gentry*

Missouri (Eastern): Area 38 serves 583 registered groups with about 9,400 members. We have 23 geographical districts covering 32,000 square miles and one area-wide Spanish-speaking

district. Our area is energized by more young A.A. trusted servants joining our general service structure; several hold prominent area positions, and an increasing number are now D.C.M.s. We hold four one-day assemblies per year; our election assembly covers two days. This spring we held our 6th "Mock Conference." These have greatly helped our delegates prepare for the General Service Conference; our members enjoy being a part of this process. We are grateful for the help of our past delegates. Our 11 standing area committees — working with their district committee counterparts — have been active in carrying the message. Many of our districts join together and take the lead in conducting service workshops, G.S.R. schools, Corrections, C.P.C., P.I. and Special Needs projects. Area 38 is looking forward to hosting the Southwest Regional Forum this October, in which approximately 700 members usually attend. We anticipate that this will introduce many of our members to A.A. general service. I am grateful for the privilege of serving.
— *Marge Del Carlo*

Missouri (Western): Area 39 serves 250 groups in 17 districts, including a newly formed linguistic district that encompasses the entire area. We hold four two-day assemblies, in January, March, June and September. Our committees, D.C.M.s, and G.S.R.s meet on Saturday and a workshop is held on Saturday evening. Area business is conducted on Sunday mornings. We recently formed a nonstanding committee of young people and they have liaisons to all standing committees to help them become more involved. We are currently looking at having a newsletter and have tried it for a year. An ad-hoc committee is looking at how to better use this tool. We cohost our state convention with Area 38 (Eastern Missouri) annually in Jefferson City, MO. Each year we hold a function called Institutions Weekend. Professionals and A.A. members get together to figure out how we can better serve our area. We also hold an area conference called Colors of Fall, in October, in Branson, MO. We always try to get some service-experienced speakers. It is an honor and a privilege to serve, and I thank them for allowing me this opportunity.
— *Dave Fite*

Montana: Area 40 includes most of the state of Montana, and is composed of 14 districts and 282 registered groups. We hold two 1.5 day area assemblies per year, in the spring and fall. At these, we discuss the General Service Conference agenda and conduct Area 40 business. A Friday night Welcoming Session/Orientation was recently added to the weekend's events. We also conduct three preassemblies prior to each Spring Assembly to discuss the Conference agenda. These get-togethers are geographically located to involve the districts in the eastern, central, and western parts of the state. We have a full and active area committee and have stable monetary support from our groups (48.2% contribute to G.S.O., 56% to our area). Area 40 has a statewide toll-free hotline and a superb website. Both of these services allow the newcomer to easily contact an A.A. member and to find up-to-date meeting locations. A calendar of events and many other forms and documents are also available on this website. Bill's story says that "we meet frequently so that newcomers may find the fellowship they seek." Area 40 strives to be a resource for our groups as they meet and make that fellowship possible. None of us are alone as *we trudge* those hundreds of long highway miles to happy destiny.
— *Libbie Lapp*

Nevada: Area 42 consists of the state of Nevada and the Eastern Sierras in California. The area serves two major population centers, and in the late 1970s the area was separated into "North & South" — separated by 7 hours by car. Our physical dispersion has led to a somewhat unique service structure. We have

separate service structures for North and South of the area to best serve our groups. Elections are held on even years for all positions, with area positions filled half from the North and half from the South. The area meets twice a year in the middle of the state of Nevada, while the North and South, meet five times a year in their respective sides of the area. This service structure assures we are as effective as we can be in our Urban and Rural communities.
— *Michael Miller*

New Jersey (Northern): Area 44 covers all of Northern New Jersey with 42 districts, nearly 1,400 groups and 33,000 members. We have two active Spanish-speaking districts supported by a hardworking Translation committee. We have seven standing, and 13 special committees; seven of which are jointly chaired and supported by Northern NJ Intergroup. Annually we hold six Area Committee Meetings, monthly officers' meetings, quarterly Joint Unity Meetings with Intergroup, a G.S.R. Mid-Winter Luncheon, Convention, and service workshops. We have a quarterly newsletter, a busy website at NNJAA.org, and an exciting archive collection representing Northern New Jersey's rich A.A. history. We foster group participation through extensive interaction with our G.S.R.s. Each year we have four G.S.R. assemblies, one of which is a Mini-Conference designed to engage our groups in the Conference process. Area 44's delegate and alternate meet with our past delegates to choose items from the full Conference agenda for discussion and debate in our groups and at our mini-Conference. Our G.S.R.s bring this information back to their groups, and then carry their group's conscience to our Mini-Conference Assembly. After our delegate returns from the Conference, our team hits the road again to deliver eight post-Conference reports, presenting the results of the entire Conference agenda. My first assembly as a G.S.R. was a mini-Conference — the excitement, enthusiasm, and sheer number of A.A.s working and sharing together was electrifying. I am honored to serve Area 44.
— *Jay Eckstein*

New York (Central): Area 47 has 11 monthly area assemblies and a yearly delegate's General Service Conference report at a separate get-together. We have approximately 675 groups, some registered and some not. These groups have many talented and gifted members who "pass it on," in a variety of ways, that there is a solution! They go into correctional and treatment facilities, hospitals, senior housing and schools. They encourage others to grow spiritually by sponsorship, bridging the gap, and using the daily Grapevine quote on handmade cards that are sent to those incarcerated or hospitalized. They celebrate sobriety with sober holiday events and member and homegroup anniversaries. They are reaching out to inform the public and professionals by supplying many offices, waiting rooms, bulletin boards, rest stops and information centers with literature, Grapevines and meeting lists. Libraries and schools are supplied with pamphlet racks and books. Annually, our Syracuse groups work together to man an A.A. booth at the New York State Fair. Our young members have been enthusiastic in planning the next Empire State Young People's Convention in Rochester. Area 47 is diligently seeking God's will for His ways of passing on the Three Legacies to our next generation. Our area assemblies and committee meetings are the training grounds for our next delegate by learning about and practicing the Twelve Concepts. We look forward to growing spiritually and passing on what has been freely given to us by God's grace!
— *Vicky Shaw*

New York (Southeast): Area 49 consists of 12 geographic counties and one nongeographic Hispanic district comprised of all Hispanic groups registered within the 12 counties. We are an extremely diverse area with approximately 1,800 groups in

SENY. We hold five full-day assemblies per year. In addition we hold a Delegate's Day of Sharing each March that includes presentations on Conference agenda items, which gives our trusted servants an opportunity to ask questions that will help them present to their groups those items which may come up at the Conference. We publish an area newsletter, *The Link*, ten times per year along with its Hispanic counterpart, *En Lase*. Our translation committee translates English to Spanish, Polish, and Russian at area events, as needed. All of our minutes and agendas are translated into Spanish. We work closely with our Young People's committees, seeking their participation in our Twelve Step efforts. Many have become involved at the area level in recent years. We continue to find ways to increase attendance at our area assemblies and committee meetings and have recently begun to see an uptick in our numbers as a result of these efforts. We have an energetic and enthusiastic group of men and women dedicated to service, and for that we are most grateful. — *Jim Wright*

North Carolina: Area 51 has 36 geographic districts and three Spanish linguistic districts. We have 1,090 regular and 44 corrections groups. Our area committee meets quarterly, twice in conjunction with our area assembly. In response to our recent Area Inventory, we are creating a P3: Policy, Procedure, and Practice Manual, and are examining eligibility requirements for area office and the current structure of our area meetings. We have recently added a Special Needs coordinator and both a Spanish translator and an interpreter. At our Winter Committee meeting we conduct a Mock Conference, which is followed by four Spring pre-Conferences where several hundred members gather to discuss upcoming Conference agenda items. North Carolina hosts an annual Freedom from Bondage Corrections Conference and a yearly State Convention. Unfortunately, we still struggle with inactive districts and groups who forfeit their voice and their vote. We don't have extraterrestrial beings, yet we do have approximately 19,000 sober alcoholics, which is a bit out of this world. I am grateful to have been entrusted with the responsibility and for the opportunity to serve our great Fellowship with you. — *Rachel Moysan*

North Dakota: Area 52 consists of 11 districts, 152 active registered groups, and approximately 3,300 members. Our Fellowship has experienced dramatic changes in the last few years. In the west, the oil boom has contributed to a population explosion. At the same time, rural areas in the remainder of the state continue to see people moving to our major urban centers of Minot, Bismarck, Fargo, and Grand Forks. This has created many challenges. Once-quiet districts are now seeing large numbers of newcomers and visitors, while others continue to face a shrinking membership, particularly those involved with service. I believe that Area 52 is equal to these challenges, and our state service structure is working to support our districts in carrying the message. For example, this year two of our three area assemblies will be held in the west, as will our annual state roundup. We have established two-day G.S.R. training classes in conjunction with a P.I./C.P.C. workshop. We are also grateful that Bismarck will have the opportunity to host the 2016 West Central Regional A.A. Service Conference. Like many western areas, and those in Canada, distance is a major issue for our rural districts. While anonymity has been a challenge in the digital age, technological assets have become an integral part of our service work. Area 52, and many of our districts, maintain webpages to serve as clearinghouses for information, meeting lists, and to serve our membership and those in need. I am grateful for the opportunity to be of service for Area 52, and A.A. as a whole. — *Tom Harlow*

Nova Scotia/Newfoundland/Labrador: Each province in Area 82 has a Service Weekend in the spring and we all come together in the fall for our annual assembly. We have 17 districts with 218 active groups. Labrador has several isolated areas and we concentrate our Remote Communities committee's activities on this region. Our chairperson, Murdo MacKay, is planning a trip to Labrador early this year. He will chair the Cross Canada/International Remote Communities Teleconferences for the next term. These calls take in a couple of U.S. locations, Alaska and Arizona, as well. It's great to see cooperation between our two countries in this regard. Several of our districts have very active P.I. and C.P.C. committees, and I love to mention the fact that the NL Medical Association has agreed to include our contact information in their monthly newsletter. There is an Intergroup Office in St. John's and a Central Services in Halifax/Dartmouth, which answers phone calls and provides meeting information. In recent years we have talked about using video-conferencing at our assemblies, and a committee was struck to look into the details. We are looking at helping Area 81 (NB/PEI) with hosting a Canadian Eastern Regional A.A. Service Assembly (CERAASA) and we have also applied to host an Eastern Canada Regional Forum in 2018. I am humbled to represent Area 82. — *Boyd Bragg*

Ohio (Central/Southern): Area 53 encompasses 38 of the 88 counties in Ohio. We have approximately 750 groups in 16 districts. We have one central intergroup, located in Columbus, which is the oldest intergroup service in the world. The area holds quarterly assemblies and quarterly area committee meetings. The area committee is made up of the five area officers, their alternates and the chairpersons of seven committees. A Friday night through Sunday mini-Conference is held the second weekend in March. Our most active committee is Correctional Facilities; the 2014 group contributions in the "Change for Change" jugs enabled the committee to allocate \$28,300 to buy and carry A.A. literature into 17 institutions that hold A.A. meetings. Ohio is comprised of four areas and each hosts the annual Ohio State Convention on a rotating basis. Last year, Area 55 was the host with over 600 registrations. We have a dynamic website (www.area53aa.org) where G.S.R.s, officers and committee chairs can file their reports, store and review archival assembly minutes and reports, check the area calendar, and access the latest version of the area guidelines. We have "Look up your group service number" widget on the website so that group treasurers, as well as others, can find their group service number to make contributions. Groups and individuals are able to make online contributions, subscribe to the area newsletter and register for the area mini-Conference and state conventions on the website. New Group Forms can also be found there. The Area 53 G.S.R. School Workbook is available for online viewing or PDF download. We have links to the other three areas in Ohio, the Central Ohio Intergroup, the *Box 4-5-9* newsletter, G.S.O. and Grapevine. Travel constitutes three hours each way for some of our area members and our goal is to one day web-cast meetings so that our committees can engage people from every corner of Area 53. It is an honor and privilege to serve as their Panel 65 delegate to this illustrious Conference. — *Kristi K. Hewitt*

Ohio (Northeast): Area 54 has over 1,500 registered groups and covers 20 of Ohio's 88 counties; there are 62 districts within our boundaries, which also includes a Spanish-speaking district. We have eight Intergroup/central offices and hold six area assemblies each year. In addition, our area hosts a G.S.R. School and a D.C.M. College. We hold a Unity Day in May to highlight the cooperative nature of A.A. services, and here we

receive the delegate's Conference report. In June we have our annual Open House Picnic. In November we celebrate Gratitude Sunday, where we come together to fellowship, break bread and express our gratitude for this way of life. We host a weekend mini-Conference each spring prior to the General Service Conference, where we review Conference agenda items and provide our delegate with the conscience of the area. We continue to strive to light up dark districts. In 1935 when Bill came to Akron he met Dr. Bob and the A.A. journey began. Each June we celebrate Founders Day with folks coming to Akron, from all over the world to participate in the celebration. In 1950 the First International Convention was held in Cleveland, where our Twelve Traditions were confirmed. This year our area will host a Hospitality room at the International Convention in Atlanta. We will also host the National A.A. Archives Workshop, which will be held September 24–27 in the Cleveland area. I am grateful to the members of Area 54 for allowing me to serve as their delegate to the 65th General Service Conference. — *Calvin Leonard*

Oklahoma: Area 57 covers all of Oklahoma; we have 417 registered groups with approximately 8,000 members. We have eight districts, four located in the metro and four in the rural parts of the state. We also have a Spanish subdistrict, as we have nine Hispanic groups across the state. We have four committee meetings and one assembly per year, and hold a minimum of four area-hosted workshops in the rural areas with a variety of service topics. We continue to offer our "Internet Friend or Foe" workshop to educate our Fellowship on personal and public anonymity regarding social network and the Internet. We also have our annual service conference, known as "Fun in the Fellowship," as a way to generate interest in our service committees. We have an extensive archive collection, area office and a paid secretary to support our area service structure; and we continue to inventory the role and function of these entities. We are excited to receive the bid to host the first Heartland Area Conference of Young People in A.A., known as HACYPAA. This conference is made up of nine states and will be held in Oklahoma City, March 24–27, 2016. This past year we had to say goodbye to some long-time trusted servants and, because they prepared us to continue the work, Area 57 has remained responsive, responsible and willing to serve. It is an honor and privilege to serve as the delegate for Area 57. — *Stephanie Bills*

Ontario (Eastern): Area 83 spans from the Quebec border, west to Toronto, north to Algonquin Park and south to New York, State. Currently our area has 25 districts. In 2014, one district folded and two dark districts, which were in upper New York, have since joined neighboring areas. There are 641 groups with 15,000 members. We have five Intergroup offices, one of them being in our linguistic district which serves an active Spanish population. We also have seven standing area committees, active in carrying the message, as well as putting on workshops at assemblies and within the area. We hold two assemblies each year, supplemented by seven area committee meetings over the term. We have now designated our spring assembly as a pre-Conference assembly, which gives members the opportunity to contribute their thoughts and views on agenda items. Area 83 hosted the second biannual CERAASA in February. We were also pleased to have our Eastern regional trustee, Richard Boisvert, in attendance. Our area has been so blessed to have our Panel 51 delegate, Joe Downey, serve as a Class B trustee of the General Service Board and director of A.A. World Services. Our Panel 55 delegate, Barb Kelly, has served as the trustee-at-large/Canada for the last four years. We couldn't be prouder of them both. I am truly humbled and honored to represent Area 83, Eastern Ontario, as their Panel 65 delegate. — *Joyce Saunders*

Ontario (Northwest): Area 85 is the farthest west of the four areas in Ontario, and also of the ten areas in the Eastern Canada Region. We are bordered to the east by Area 84, and Area 80 to the West. We have 26 Remote Communities in the north, with the majority speaking Ojibway. In the south we have 51 registered groups in the eight districts, with only half of them active at our two yearly assemblies, spring and fall, hosted by District 1, due to where the majority of members reside, as well as the expense of travel. Thunder Bay, in District 1, is our largest city with a population of approximately 250,000 (54%) and the second largest city is Kenora, ON, with 1,600. The population multiplies with the summer residents and lessens in the winter with the snowbirds going south. The drive between the two cities is about six hours. We have an Annual Area Roundup after the General Service Conference, so our delegate can give a report. We celebrate group Anniversaries, Founders Day BBQs, Fish Fries, Bonfire Night Meetings and Roundups where the delegate can give the report and we can come together with others to share the A.A. message in a fun way. We have a few members in their early 50 years of sobriety. Our concerns are the lack of members being responsible to volunteer, both with time and money. Many service positions are not filled and there is a lack of contributions to self-support. Some of you know Murray Mc., he is a big help at our assemblies. In 2003 to 2007, he was trustee-at-large/Canada. Thank you for letting me give back out of gratitude. — *Jennie Herd*

Pennsylvania (Eastern): Area 59 has 48 districts, including one Spanish-linguistic district, and serves 1,626 registered groups, and over 32,000 members. Four quarterly meetings are hosted in various locations. In January we hold a D.C.M. Orientation. The area conscience is voiced at a Pre-Conference Sharing Session in April, and in June the delegate gives a Conference report to the Fellowship during two assemblies, at workshops, and at districts. The report is also posted on our website at area59aa.org. In October, we take an area inventory to gauge our progress, and to see how we can better serve the still-suffering alcoholics. In addition to a combined Intergroup workshop, Share-A-Days are held with many of our 12 Intergroups, and with the Young People of A.A. (YPAA). Our nine subcommittees continue to be productive and proactive. For example, our Grapevine subcommittee conducted several writing workshops, submitting over 60 stories to the Grapevine, seven of which were published. Along with our talented webservant, our P.I. subcommittee launched a redesign of content and graphics on our website. We hold an annual Convention/Assembly in November, which consistently draws over 900 members, more than half of which are G.S.R.s. We are a vibrant and service-loving area. It is my sincere honor and privilege to serve both A.A. as a whole and Eastern Pennsylvania. — *Pat Fallon*

Pennsylvania (Western): Area 60 covers 28 counties. Within Area 60 are urban areas, such as Pittsburgh and Erie, as well as sparsely populated rural counties — so we are diverse. We are comprised of 44 districts and approximately 750 registered groups. There are four quarterly meetings, three assemblies, and a varying number of Days of Sharing, which are sponsored by the area and hosted by districts with the goal of educating and informing the Fellowship on topics of Recovery, Unity, and Service. The crown jewel of our events is our Getaway Weekend in late March. We employ the Conference format where attendees work in committees, reviewing and discussing Conference agenda items. Their impressions are presented at the Pre-Conference Assembly to give the delegate a sense of the area's group conscience regarding Conference agenda items. We also support the Pennsylvania State Convention by sending

our alternate chairperson to planning sessions, and our delegate attends the Convention. Area 60 seeks to inform and educate our members. We also strive to foster increased participation in general service so that the Unity of the Fellowship is preserved, our history honored and protected, and to help the still sick and suffering alcoholic recover. I hope to foster these ideals using this simple mantra: You can pretend to care; you can't pretend to show up. — *George Kulakowski*

Quebec (Northeast): Area 89 is a vast territory stretching from west Louiseville to east Blanc-Sablon and from north Chibougamau to south Lévis. Each year we hold two general assemblies and four regional assemblies; we have six committees and one working group in our area. For our regional meeting in December, in even years we have a meeting "Welcoming the newcomers" and in odd years it is our regional inventory, both for a whole weekend. Our area counts 23 districts and 275 groups, including 268 French-speaking, four English, two bilingual, one Atikamekw, and two in Innu. There are 308 meetings per week and 5,320 registered members. Our Regional Executive Committee meets three times a year with the Regional Committee of the three other Quebec areas. As delegate, we have the responsibility and privilege to be trustee of our bimonthly magazine, *La Vigne*. Eastern Quebec has a very well-built website, quite easy to use, and a seminars committee that share with us their knowledge and experience of our principles and our legacy. Our area also has the honor to hold, for 15 years next August, a Native Convention, held in Pessamit on the North Shore of the St-Laurence River. I am privileged to serve in an area that respects the A.A. principles and Traditions — a very healthy area in action. It is with gratitude that I represent my friends and thank them for giving me an opportunity to accompany you in my journey, especially during this Conference. — *Diane Perron*

Quebec (Southeast): Area 88 has existed since November 1974; it stretches from the Vermont border to the Gaspé Peninsula, some 600 miles to the east, following the St. Lawrence River for a great distance. Also included in our area are the Îles de la Madeleine (Magdalen Islands), 120 nautical miles from the Gaspé Peninsula. To reach the Islands, one must go through the whole of Area 81 and take a ferry, which represents a trip of 900 miles across the area. We have 18 districts divided into 166 groups, for a total of 2,494 members. Each year, we hold three regional assemblies and one annual general meeting. We have three committees: P.I., *La Vigne* and C.P.C.; the website and the Archives complete our services. Each year, we organize two dinners to express our gratitude to the movement for our total abstinence: one in the west, and the other in the east, gathering between 125 to 325 members and their guests. The profits of those dinners are sent to the G.S.O. Each year, the officers take part with three other areas of Quebec in a provincial assembly and three inter-regional meetings, where they share about their experiences and issues related to their respective areas. Distance is a serious challenge for us, counting a small number of members across a large territory. Moreover, as a big part of our members live in the west of the area, this results in an imbalance of representation. Finding a solution to that problem is not easy, but we are working on it. Thank you for your attention and this wonderful movement. — *Michel Bergeron*

Saskatchewan: Area 91 consists of approximately 275 groups in 19 districts with a membership of about 3,300. We, as an area, hold one area committee meeting in January, consisting of table officers, D.C.M.s and invited guests. We have a pre-Conference assembly in March and a fall assembly in October.

Approximately 35% of our groups are represented and close to 100% of the districts are represented at these events. We have had some major changes in Area 91 over the past few years. We have adopted, on a trial basis, a new committee system, which is far more representative of what happens here at the Conference. In order to increase participation and to keep the channels of communication open we have implemented eight committees, which look at one or two agenda items and, after discussion, provide a recommendation to the delegate who is then given the right of decision at the Conference. We have had a decrease in the number of districts with one of our districts consisting of only four groups, deciding to amalgamate with another neighboring district. There were also changes to the boundaries of the three districts that make up one of our larger urban centers, Regina. One virtually dark district and two active districts have been converted into three active districts. We have begun to look into updating our website. Despite working through some difficult changes, unity continues to flourish and new leaders immerge. Now, with a vested interest in what goes on here at the Conference and with the rest of A.A., we have a new group of trusted servants that leave me with no doubt that Area 91 is and will be in good hands for years to come. — *Christopher Stoppler*

Texas (Northeast): Area 65 covers approximately 70,000 square miles. We have over 475 active groups and an estimated 19,000 sober A.A. members. We have 29 districts; 24 districts for English-speaking groups, and five districts for Spanish-speaking groups. We replaced our winter assembly with orientation workshops for new G.S.R.s/D.C.M.s; one is held centrally, one in the western portion, and the other is held in the eastern portion. The presentation outline touches on our general service structure from the top to the bottom of the upside-down triangle and provides area-specific information for folks new to general service. So far, the feedback has been positive. We now hold our area assemblies three times each year: in the spring, summer, and fall. We typically hold two of the three assemblies in the central part of the area, with the third held outside the metropolis. At the spring assembly, we break into mock committees to review the items on the Conference final agenda, to gather the collective conscience of the Fellowship in our area and send the delegate off well-informed, but not instructed. At the summer assembly the delegate reports back about the Conference. We have 12 standing committees who, together with our D.C.M.s and area officers, meet four times a year. It is truly my pleasure and privilege to serve with so many folks in Area 65 that are hard at work to facilitate the carrying of A.A.'s message of hope, and I am honored that they have entrusted me to serve here with each of you. May God bless our wonderful Fellowship. — *Tom Misteli*

Texas (Southeast): Area 67 covers 30,000 square miles, with Houston as the largest city. Recent count indicates 550 groups among 18 districts, five of which are Spanish. One Spanish district recently added a local committee member and an alternate L.C.M. to its farthest-reaching sector, which now has five active groups. Each year begins with a curtailed assembly held during the area's annual convention. We also have three weekend-long quarterly assemblies, held in Houston. Our April assembly features a "Round Table" workshop at which members discuss segments of the Final Agenda Items. Their findings are reported to the delegate, who can then proceed to the Conference with a "sense" of where the area stands on the issues. The Gratitude Dinner in November is our second annual area event. Our Corrections committee organizes an annual Convention at which orientations and certifications for prison

access are held. The Literature committee is sponsoring a Book Club to read and discuss selected A.A. literature. The Grapevine committee holds workshops, including time to write articles, which are submitted to the Grapevine. An area website, with position-based email, quarterly newsletters, reports in English and Spanish, and 'Go-To-Meeting' sessions are among the tools we currently employ. Finally, the Texas State Convention is held in Houston every six years, with our next rotation being in 2019. — *Melissa Redd*

Utah: Area 69 A.A. is alive and well in the breathtaking landscapes of Utah. There are 11 geographic districts and one borderless Spanish-speaking district. We have 336 listed active groups, which are represented by energetic G.S.R.s. Our local service structure mirrors the General Service Conference using the committee system. We hold three assemblies, three workshops, and two committee meetings annually. In March we hosted the 2015 Pacific Region Alcoholics Anonymous Service Assembly (PRAASA) in Layton, Utah. The Utah 2015 PRAASA web servant is involved in the PRAASA Delegate Advisory Board's subcommittee on websites in its efforts to develop and make recommendations that will facilitate continuity and ease of transition for future PRAASA committees. Our Grapevine committee developed an innovative and successful idea of "a dime for the vine" collection can. Proceeds are spent on La Viña subscriptions to support the GV. Issues are distributed and used to enhance local service committees' efforts. During the past year we have worked in strengthening our communications with the five intergroup/central offices of Utah. Area 69 experiences many of the same challenges that riddle other areas, such as: How do we improve participation and grow enthusiasm in Third Legacy service opportunities? Are we effectively conveying the importance of group participation in the Seventh Tradition and how these contributions are used to carry the message worldwide? We will always be a "work in action" in such matters of concern—embracing them with gratitude and love for Alcoholics Anonymous. — *Rena Harkness*

Virginia: Area 71, the beautiful Commonwealth of Virginia, is also known as the birthplace of a nation. Jamestown was the first permanent English settlement in North America and likely where the first alcoholics landed. Our land area is nearly 40,000 square miles and reaches from Virginia's Eastern Shore on the Atlantic coast to the Blue Ridge Mountains in the west. We border four other areas in the Southeast Region; Area 51, North Carolina; Area 64, Tennessee; Area 26, Kentucky; and Area 73, West Virginia. Additionally we border two areas in the Northeast Region: Area 13, District of Columbia, and Area 29, Maryland. Virginia has approximately 1,260 groups that are serviced by 43 active districts. We have two assemblies, in the spring and fall. We also hold two area committee meetings where the D.C.M.s come together with the officers, standing committee chairs, and special assignment coordinators to set the agenda for the assemblies. These happen in the winter and summer. Our meetings and assemblies rotate locations around the state. We have witnessed that the local volunteers at these events are excited and enthusiastic about A.A. and service when they leave. This enthusiasm often spreads to other group members when they return to their home groups. I am humbled and excited to be here and look forward to spending time with you all. — *Chris Wells*

Washington (Western): Area 72 has 42 districts, over 1,200 listed groups and a membership of approximately 30,000. We have two nongeographic Hispanic districts. We conduct area business with one three-day voting assembly and three one-day

quarterlies. At our last election assembly, we had more than 400 voting members and more than 750 registered attendees. At our quarterlies, the D.C.M.s and area officers discuss area business and set the agenda for the October assembly. Because we only have one assembly, we typically hold six regional pre-Conference workshops in March and six pre-assembly workshops in August. This is the second rotation of our newly formed Area Web committee, which holds quarterly workshops where district and intergroup Web servants gather to share ideas and discuss creating and maintaining local A.A. websites. To help keep costs down for participating groups, this is the first year we will be using a 'Home Stay' program for our annual assembly weekend. Instead of using hotel accommodations, local members will be hosting visiting G.S.R.s and D.C.M.s at their homes. I am honored and grateful and thank Area 72 for this opportunity to serve as their 34th delegate. — *Darren Flint*

West Virginia: Area 73's first meeting was held in Charleston in March 1942. There are now 278 active groups in 16 districts. A few of our meetings are held just across our borders in Ohio, Maryland, Pennsylvania and Virginia. One of our meetings uses the Big Book in American Sign Language and has speaker DVDs in ASL available. Our 16 districts are in seven regions of the state. Our area committee meets twice yearly prior to each of our two assemblies, one in the spring and one in the fall. We hold one convention in the summer. The assemblies and conventions are hosted on a rotating basis by and in the various regions. Recently we received our 501C3, which will help our area treasury. Our 800 number, which carries the message to the still-suffering alcoholic by providing meeting information and patching calls from the alcoholic caller to one in recovery, is working well. Our website can be found at www.aawv.org. We are excited that WVCYPAA has been established in West Virginia as of December 2014. Check them out at www.WVCYPAA.org. Recently, we joined with the southeastern region states to hold service assemblies and will cohost the Southern States A.A. Service Assembly (SSAASA) with Kentucky, November 2015, in Huntington, WV. I invite you to come and visit our beautiful mountain state of West "By God" Virginia. I am humbled and grateful for this opportunity to serve my area and consider it a privilege to be here with you. — *Barb Colley*

Wisconsin (Southern): Area 75 currently has over 1,000 groups, served by 31 districts, including one Spanish-speaking linguistic district. In addition, five central or intergroup offices serve the area. Recent efforts to relight dark districts have been successful. We hold four all-day service assemblies plus a spring conference assembly and a delegate's workshop. At our winter and summer assemblies we hold a G.S.R. school and a D.C.M. sharing session. A delegate's workshop is held in March to give the Fellowship an opportunity to provide feedback on the upcoming General Service Conference agenda items. The delegate's report is shared at our spring conference assembly. Our Corrections committee continues to carry the message into a wide variety of correctional institutions and participates in "Re-entry Fairs." We purchase A.A. literature for correctional facilities using funds donated through our corrections literature project. In 2015 we will mark the 20th year of an annual Corrections Conference, hosted by corrections volunteers from Area 74 and Area 75. Our P.I., Treatment, and C.P.C. chairs are continuing to build relationships with the Veterans Administration Hospital staff. We have active area committees and together we are committed to carrying A.A.'s message. It is truly an honor and a privilege to serve as Area 75's Panel 65 delegate. — *Drew Armstrong*

Additional Committee Considerations

Advisory Action 40 of the 1990 General Service Conference states: "Items discussed, but no action taken or recommendation made, as well as committee recommendations which are not adopted, be included in a separate section of the Final Report." All items, listed by committee, are as follows.

AGENDA

- The committee reviewed the Conference Evaluation Form and made no changes.
- The committee discussed providing the General Service Conference Evaluation Form in an anonymous digital format, in addition to the current paper format, and requested that the trustees' Committee on the General Service Conference explore this option and provide a report to the 2016 Conference Agenda Committee.
- The committee reviewed the report on the Conference Agenda Process from the trustees' Committee on the Conference. After a thorough and lengthy discussion, the committee noted that while there were several areas of progress, the report did not fully explore the potential role that the Conference Agenda Committee might play in the selection process of Agenda items in the future. Therefore the committee requested that the trustees' Committee on the Conference fully explore the potential role that the Conference Agenda Committee might play in the selection process of Agenda items in the future and provide a report to the 2016 Conference Agenda Committee.
- The committee supported the concept under consideration by the trustees' Committee on the General Service Conference to make trustees' Committee background available to the delegate chairperson of their corresponding Conference committee at the quarterly board weekend prior to the Conference. The committee noted that this would increase the effectiveness of the delegate chairpersons' participation in the trustees' committee meeting.
- The committee discussed adding a review of the Conference week schedule (Conference Agenda) to the standing items on the committee agenda and took no action, noting that this is not necessary as this is included in the Conference Agenda Committee's Scope.

ARCHIVES¹

- The committee reviewed the contents of the Archives Workbook noting minor editorial changes and a new section, "Sharing on Digital Archives," which will provide sharing and suggestions for Archives committees.
- The committee discussed the "Shared Experiences" section in the Archives Workbook, which is refreshed every five years. The committee suggested including experience shared by local archivists and archives committees on where archives are housed, associated costs, access procedures, and description of contents.

COOPERATION WITH THE PROFESSIONAL COMMUNITY

- The committee reviewed the contents of the Cooperation With the Professional Community Kit and Workbook and made the following suggestions:
 - That changes suggested by the 2015 Cooperation With the Professional Community Conference Committee to the



Cooperation With the Professional Community Workbook be forwarded to the trustees' Committee on Cooperation With the Professional Community/Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities for review and implementation.

- That the trustees' Committee on Cooperation With the Professional Community/Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities review the pamphlet, "Three Talks To Medical Societies by Bill W., Co-Founder of A.A.," noting the 2015 Conference Committee's concerns related to its language, outdated information and relevance to modern day medical professionals.

The committee noted that future development of material may be needed to reflect current information about A.A. to be provided to medical professionals, perhaps utilizing past and current Class A trustees.

- That the trustees' Committee on Cooperation With the Professional Community/Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities continue to read and review the selection of pamphlets included in the C.P.C. Kit, taking into consideration whether the current selection best supports the needs of C.P.C. Committees and professionals in terms of language and content, particularly in the following pamphlets:
 - Speaking At Non-A.A. Meetings
 - A Brief Guide To Alcoholics Anonymous
 - Is There an Alcoholic In the Workplace?
 - How A.A. Members Cooperate With Professionals
 - The A.A. Member—Medications and Other Drugs

CORRECTIONS

- The committee discussed the Corrections Correspondence Service (C.C.S.) and requested that the trustees' Committee on Corrections consider reviewing the effectiveness of the criteria used for linking alcoholics behind the walls with outside volunteers. One specific concern is the distance requirement for correspondents participating in the Corrections Correspondence Service (C.C.S.).
- The committee discussed ways to engage members in Corrections service and noted the helpfulness of the new service piece, "Engaging A.A. Members in Corrections Work" in this effort.
- The committee reviewed the contents of the Corrections Kit and Workbook and suggested that the prison issue of the A.A. Grapevine publication, La Viña, be included in the English-language Corrections Kit.

¹Members serve on this committee as a secondary committee assignment.



FINANCE

- The committee reviewed the suggested area contribution for delegate expense for the Conference and after a lengthy discussion, agreed an increase was not appropriate at this time.
- The committee received and discussed information from the A.A.W.S. Self-Support Committee, looked favorably on work to date and urged continuing efforts.
- The committee ran out of time and did not review the Self-Support packet, however, it noted it was reviewed in detail last year.

GRAPEVINE

- The committee reviewed the 2015 Grapevine Office Report on Audio Strategy and requested that the Grapevine office provide an updated status and financial report on the project, including practices, financials, metrics and plans for the future to the 2016 Conference Committee on the Grapevine.
- The committee reviewed the A.A. Grapevine Board's 2015 Office Report on La Viña and agreed that La Viña is published as cost effectively as possible given existing parameters and conditions. The committee agreed with the A.A. Grapevine Board's suggestion to develop and implement a communication plan that utilizes (but is not limited to) A.A. Grapevine, Inc.'s newsletters, Forum presentations, and *Box 4-5-9* to clarify to the Fellowship La Viña's unique status as a hybrid entity that is at once a service to the Fellowship and is also required to strive to become self-supporting.
- The committee encouraged the support and purchase of Subscription Gift Certificates by local service committees, groups and members as a way to carry the A.A. message. These subscriptions would be used to provide magazines to people in correctional facilities, treatment centers, nursing homes, and other facilities or locations. This work would be accomplished at the local area level.
- The committee discussed ways to increase organization-wide support for Grapevine and La Viña and suggested that:
 1. Areas champion and embrace Grapevine/La Viña as the International Journals of A.A. through consistent narrative support in all relevant presentations, reports, announcements, newsletters and letters.
 2. All A.A. entities be offered the opportunity to include a GV/ LV link (with or without images) on local/area websites.
 3. All areas participate in AAGV Inc.'s 2015 Subscription Challenge.
- The committee agreed to forward to the A.A. Grapevine Board

the suggestion that Grapevine produce in the year 2016 or later¹

- 1 Armed Forces Members' AA Stories (working title). Members who have served in the military share their experiences with getting sober or staying sober in A.A., previously published in Grapevine magazine and/or AAGrapevine.org.
- 2 Voices from Early AA (working title) A collection of stories from the earliest days of Alcoholics Anonymous and Grapevine, previously published in Grapevine magazine and/or AAGrapevine.org.

- The committee reviewed the Grapevine Workbook.

INTERNATIONAL CONVENTIONS/ REGIONAL FORUMS¹

- The committee heard reports on the upcoming 2015 International Convention:
 - Over 40,000 people have registered for the Convention so far. About half of those have prepurchased the special 2015 Convention souvenir book, *Alcoholics Anonymous: 80 Years — Happy, Joyous and Free*. The Grapevine's commemorative edition of the book, *Happy, Joyous and Free*, has also been preordered and subscriptions to the Grapevine and La Viña have been sold through the preregistration process.
 - This is the third International Convention where online registration was available. Communications have been made to insure that all attendees are prepared for the Convention experience, and understand the challenges of weather and getting around the large convention facility.
 - Preparations are in place for the anonymity-protected broadcast of the Friday night Flag Ceremony.
 - The Advance Program guide has been sent to all registrants and is available on G.S.O.'s A.A. website.
 - Notices have been included in Convention material to emphasize A.A.'s Anonymity Traditions to attendees and the *Box 4-5-9* spring issue featured the article "Anonymity and the 2015 International Convention." The Convention program also includes a new panel meeting titled "Anonymity and the Convention – I get It!"
 - The Convention APP will be launched in early May for download on mobile devices.
 - New to the International Convention will be an Anonymity Booth and a "Carry the Message" pavilion featuring booths providing information on A.A.'s Cooperation With the Professional Community, Corrections, Grapevine/La Viña, Public Information, Special Needs-Accessibilities and Treatment committee service.
- The committee discussed ways to encourage interest in Regional Forums and attract first-time attendees, and suggested:
 - That delegates and area trusted servants communicate the value of Forum participation early and often;
 - Share with the Fellowship the easy availability of one-on-one conversations with trustees, directors and staff members that can be found at the Forums;
 - Consider utilizing A.A. Conventions and other A.A. events as opportunities to share the new Regional Forum Flyers with the Fellowship;

LITERATURE

- The committee reviewed a suggestion to produce a book combining Twelve Steps and Twelve Traditions with the Twelve

¹Members serve on this committee as a secondary committee assignment.

Concepts for World Service and took no action. The committee noted that the *Twelve Concepts for World Service* are suitably placed with *The A.A. Service Manual* and in a stand-alone volume.

- The committee suggested consideration of developing a service piece on A.A. as a resource for the mental health professional.
- The committee reviewed the complete text of “The A.A.W.S., Inc. Policy on Publication of Literature” and suggested that “The A.A.W.S., Inc. Policy on Publication of Literature” always be included as background for the Conference Committee on Literature.
- The committee suggested that the trustees’ Literature Committee develop a plan for the systematic review of recovery literature and bring it to the 2016 Conference Literature Committee for its review.
- The committee suggested that a white imprint area for local use be included on the back of each pamphlet as it comes up for reprint.

POLICY/ADMISSIONS

- The committee reviewed a request for a representative from the General Service Board of A.A. in the Czech Republic to attend the 65th General Service Conference as an observer. In light of a recent communication from the General Service Board of the Czech Republic that their group conscience had come to a decision not to send an observer to the 65th General Service Conference, no action was necessary.
- The committee requested that, to assist the committee in its deliberations, when background for any agenda item of the committee references specific policy, that the policy referenced be included as part of the background.
- The committee considered a request that a recording of the A.A. meeting at the opening dinner of the General Service Conference be provided to each member of the General Service Conference and took no action. The committee agreed that the A.A. talks at the Opening Dinner of the Conference are enjoyable and reflect the A.A. stories of the speakers, but are not specifically focused on A.A. service.

PUBLIC INFORMATION

- While discussing the proposed video public service announcement, “Doors,” the committee expressed their appreciation for the thinking behind attempting to use already-recorded A.A. members’ stories, as both a cost-saving measure and for the purpose of authenticity.
- The committee reviewed the 2014 Annual Report from the trustees’ Committee on Public Information regarding G.S.O.’s A.A. website. The committee appreciated the inclusion of selected website analytics and looks forward to emerging clarity of how this information might be useful to A.A.’s work of carrying the message.
- The committee discussed a brief video on anonymity produced to accompany the annual Anonymity Letter to the Media, and agreed that the video is an engaging tool for communicating with the press. The committee suggested that the Intra-Office Website Committee (I.O.W.C.) explore additional pages on the aa.org website where this video might be useful, in addition to the Press/Media page, and pass along their suggestions to the A.A.W.S. Board for consideration.
- The committee reviewed the 2015 Public Information

Comprehensive Media plan and expressed their appreciation for the report’s responsiveness to suggestions offered by the 2014 Conference Public Information Committee. The committee offered the following suggestions:

Refining existing tools.

- Considering the immediate need for guidance on the use of social media by A.A. members, the committee asked the staff secretary to share information with all P.I. committee chairs and area delegates about existing literature that offers suggestions regarding A.A. principles and the Internet. The distribution of this information should correspond with the launch of the new Anonymity Resource Page planned for the aa.org website, which promises to be a useful tool for sharing information on this vital topic with A.A. members, the media, and the general public.
- The committee also suggested that the Publishing Department develop a new section in the Public Information Workbook on the Internet and Social Media based on existing literature on the subject, with the understanding that such content may need updating as new information is gathered about online platforms.
- The committee agreed with the suggestion in the report from the trustees’ Public Information Committee on A.A. Video P.S.A.s that the Spanish video P.S.A. “Tengo Esperanza” be translated into English and French, and that the 2016 Conference Public Information Committee consider centrally distributing and tracking the new spots.

Exploring new forms/channels of presenting/distributing content.

- The committee considered favorably the suggestion that the 2015 trustees’ Public Information Committee gather information about the potential for using platforms such as Twitter, Instagram and Google+ for the purpose of providing information about A.A. to the public. The committee strongly suggested that the exploration take into consideration the still-relevant concerns regarding potential implications to our Traditions reflected in the 2012 Report of the Public Information Social Media Page Subcommittee. The committee suggested that the General Service Board explore these resources and report back to the 2016 Conference Public Information Committee with consideration of the following:
 - Specific benefits of using each resource for reaching the still-suffering alcoholic;
 - How each platform will help the public information task of providing accurate information about what A.A. is and what it is not;
 - How each platform might be utilized while still maintaining member anonymity;
 - How each platform might be utilized while avoiding the appearance of promotion and still allowing our friends to recommend us;
 - How user interaction with A.A. content on such platforms might avoid controversy, or the appearance of endorsement or affiliation;
 - Clear distinctions between (a) public information work, and (b) general communication such as fellowship among members, and interaction between members and nonmembers;
 - Information about terms of service and privacy policies;
 - Information about the use of these platforms by other Twelve Step fellowships;
 - Information about the local use of these platforms gathered from various parts of the A.A. Fellowship (e.g. delegate

areas, intergroup/central offices, YPAAs, the National A.A. Technology Workshop and G.S.O.s outside the U.S. and Canada).

- The committee discussed a suggestion that the trustees' Public Information Committee explore a project for anonymity videos produced by A.A. members for A.A. members and agreed that emerging technologies for how member-submitted content might be gathered should be explored prior to developing a proposal for such a project. The committee asked the staff secretary to forward a list of questions and concerns to the trustees' P.I. Committee, and asked that a report or draft proposal be brought back to the 2016 Conference Public Information Committee for review.
- The committee discussed how to increase A.A. member participation in local public information work, and asked the staff secretary to share a list of suggestions with the trustees' Public Information Committee and with local P.I. chairs.
- The committee reviewed the contents of the P.I. Kit and Workbook, and made the following suggestions:
 - Information about the new video on anonymity be included with information already in the Kit about annual communication with the media.
 - The committee suggested that the text on page 14 of the current P.I. Workbook be revised to reflect the current content on the F-20 Anonymity Card.
 - The committee suggested that the information on page 47 of the current P.I. Workbook regarding the G.S.O.'s A.A. website be updated to reflect the redesigned website.
 - The committee suggested that the online PDF version of the P.I. Workbook, when referencing other A.A. publications on the aa.org website, be linked digitally to those items online. The committee suggested that other service workbooks might need review for similar updates.
 - While discussing potential changes to the P.I. Kit and Workbook, the committee agreed that it would be helpful to have a way to easily identify new or updated information on the aa.org website and in printed material. The committee asked the staff secretary to share this suggestion with the A.A.W.S. Board.

REPORT AND CHARTER

- The committee accepted a report from the Publishing Department outlining the General Service Office process for timely and accurate preparation and publication of *The A.A. Service Manual 2015-2016 Edition*, and the 2015 General Service Conference *Final Report*. The committee noted that the "Report of the 2015 General Service Conference Inventory" in the Final Report may take longer to prepare than the other front matter and asked to review the page proofs of the inventory report as soon as possible prior to publication.
- The committee requested the opportunity to review the page proofs of the *Final Report of the General Service Conference Inventory* prior to publication.
- The committee reviewed a list of editorial updates from the Publishing Department for *The A.A. Service Manual* and suggested some revisions.
- In keeping with the 2009 Advisory Action that the General Service Board, the A.A.W.S. Board and the A.A. Grapevine Board annually review *The A.A. Service Manual* and forward necessary updates to the Conference Committee on Report and Charter,

the committee reviewed the updates from the General Service Board, the A.A.W.S. Board and the A.A. Grapevine Board and suggested some revisions.

- The committee considered a request to include a chart in *The A.A. Service Manual* in the section "Working with Local Intergroups and Central Offices" on pages S41-S42 and took no action. The committee noted that since local intergroups and central offices are not part of the general service structure, a chart could be misleading; and that the description of this vital service provided by these local intergroup/central offices was adequately expressed in the text.
- The committee considered the complexities involved in annual production of *The A.A. Service Manual* and requested that the General Service Office consider publishing *The A.A. Service Manual* every other year and requested that a report on alternative publishing schedules, including cost considerations, be brought back to the 2016 Conference Committee on Report and Charter.
- The committee considered the A.A. Directories (Canada, Eastern U.S., Western U.S. and International) and suggested that the section currently called "Online Meetings" be reviewed and possibly renamed "Online Meetings/Groups" to reflect the Twelfth Step work that some online groups carry out beyond the meetings.
- The committee considered the General Service Conference *Final Report* and suggested that the Publishing Department consider using a larger font to make the *Final Report* more accessible; and requested that a report from the Publishing Department on the feasibility of producing a large-print format of the General Service Conference *Final Report* including cost estimates be brought back to the 2016 Conference Committee on Report and Charter.
- The committee considered the General Service Conference *Final Report* and suggested that several items of interest be highlighted on the front cover including: "Advisory Actions," "Area Highlights," and "Presentations."

TREATMENT/SPECIAL NEEDS/ACCESSIBILITIES

- The committee supported the trustees' committee's request for the A.A.W.S. Board to consider posting contents of A.A. literature items produced in audio formats on G.S.O.'s website, aa.org.
- The committee expressed appreciation for the A.A.W.S. Publishing Department's consideration to publish a service piece of the Twelve Concepts for World Service for ASL signing purposes.
- The committee supported the efforts of the A.A.W.S. Board to explore ways to provide electronic versions of the Workbooks and other material in the Kits to committee chairs as an alternative to automatically mailing hard copies and noted the following:
 - The committee strongly encouraged that postal mailing of printed Workbooks and other material in the Kits be the primary means of delivery.
 - The committee noted that the "opt-in" measure in the welcome letter to new chairs did not reflect the intent of the 2014 Conference Committee's Consideration and resulted in incomplete data. They suggested that a survey be taken of new chairs from the "exploratory period" who did not respond to their welcome letter to attempt to better understand the effectiveness of the electronic service material and the exploratory approach in general.



- The committee reviewed the Treatment Committee Kit and Workbook and forwarded suggestions for updates to the trustees' Committee on Cooperation With the Professional Community/Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities.
- The committee reviewed the Special Needs-Accessibilities Committee Kit and Workbook and forwarded suggestions for updates to the trustees' committee on Cooperation With the Professional Community/Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities.
- The committee requested the trustees' Committee on Cooperation With the Professional Community/Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities consider how to better realize the commitment to make A.A. more readily available to all and suggested:
 - Focusing on the concept of overcoming barriers in accessing, receiving, and carrying the A.A. message, rather than the limiting concept of identifying "special needs" and to consider how this change might be reflected in the trustees' committee scope.
 - Changing all references to "Special Needs-Accessibilities" to "Accessibilities," including the trustees' and Conference Committee names.
 - Revising the Special Needs-Accessibilities Workbook with a particular focus on emphasizing solutions to overcoming barriers.
 - Reorganizing the Special Needs-Accessibilities Workbook to include the following sections: 1) Accessing the A.A. Message 2) Receiving the A.A. Message 3) Carrying the A.A. Message. Each section might include shared experience for overcoming barriers.

TRUSTEES

- The committee reviewed the resumes and approved, as eligible for election, all Class B trustee candidates for the Northeast and Southwest regional trustees and the trustee-at-large/Canada.
- Reflecting on the importance of Concept XI, the committee encouraged the General Service Board and A.A. Fellowship to identify, attract and recruit in a timely manner, a diverse, competent and qualified pool of candidates to serve as Class A (non-alcoholic) trustees, Class B (alcoholic) trustees, nontrustee directors and appointed committee members on trustees' committees.

RECOMMENDATIONS THAT DID NOT RESULT IN CONFERENCE ADVISORY ACTIONS

FINANCE

- The committee recommended that the maximum annual limit contributed to the General Service Board from an individual A.A. member be increased from \$3,000 to \$5,000.

LITERATURE

- The committee recommended that the draft text for the section "A.A. Grapevine, Inc." in "Inside A.A. Understanding the Fellowship and Its Services" be changed from:

A.A. Grapevine, Inc., while not a service agency, is a separate corporation with its own board, which is under the guidance of the trustees. A.A. Grapevine, Inc. is responsible for publishing the print magazines Grapevine and La Viña, the Website, books, audio and other products to carry the A.A. message to U.S., Canada and beyond.

To:

A.A. Grapevine, Inc. is a separate corporation with its own board that is under the guidance of the trustees. A.A. Grapevine, Inc. is responsible for publishing the print magazines Grapevine and La Viña, the A.A. Grapevine website, books, audio and other products to carry the A.A. message worldwide.

FLOOR ACTIONS THAT DID NOT RESULT IN CONFERENCE ADVISORY ACTIONS

- During reprints of Conference-approved literature and service materials, consider adding "aa.org" wherever the General Service Office contact information, and phone numbers are listed. **(Withdrawn by submitter)**
- That Section 12 of the Bylaws of the General Service Board be amended to state "The number of member trustees constituting the entire membership shall be twenty-one, except as otherwise provided herein." **(Withdrawn by submitter)**
- That the following text be added in Chapter Six of *The A.A. Service Manual* as the final bullet point under duties: "The outgoing delegate provides G.S.O. with contact information for all incoming area officers and committee chairs." **(Not approved)**
- Produce a book combining the Twelve Steps, The Twelve Traditions and the Twelve Concepts for World Service. **(Not approved)**
- Beginning with the 2016 General Service Conference, all general session voting will be done electronically. **(Withdrawn by submitter)**
- **Rescind the previous Advisory Action that reads:**

"The trustees' Committee on the General Service Conference create a plan to translate all Conference material with a progress report given to the 2016 Conference Committee on Policy and Admissions that describes the process and costs including options using third party translators and a proposal to change agenda submission deadlines."

And replace with:

"With a target date of 2018, the trustees' Committee on the General Service Conference create a plan to translate all Conference material with a progress report given to the 2016 Conference Committees on Policy and Admissions and Finance that describes the process and costs including options using third party translators and a proposal to change agenda submission deadlines." **(Not approved)**

**The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc.
Alcoholics Anonymous World Services, Inc. • Alcoholics Anonymous Grapevine, Inc.**

CONSOLIDATED STATEMENT OF FINANCIAL POSITION

December 31, 2014 (with comparative totals for 2013)

	General Service Board of A.A.								
	General Fund	Reserve Fund	Capital Projects Fund	Postretirement Medical Fund	Pension Benefits	A.A. World Services, Inc.	A.A. Grapevine, Inc.	Consolidated 2014	Consolidated 2013
ASSETS									
Cash	\$ 3,621,609	\$ 2,907,479		\$ 30,536		\$ 1,687,966	\$ 616,692	\$ 8,864,282	\$ 4,416,147
Accounts and interest receivable		3,156				175,571	64,379	243,106	198,883
Intercompany balances	(1,200,031)	(1,945,000)				1,153,038	1,991,993	-	-
Inventories									
Books, pamphlets, etc.						1,761,020	235,506	1,996,526	1,607,996
Paper, prepublication costs, etc.						132,750	44,566	177,316	269,325
Investments - at fair value (Note 2)		13,129,331		3,108,798				16,238,129	17,891,637
Property, Equipment and Software (net of accumulated depreciation and amortization of 2014 - \$4,491,480; 2013 - \$4,741,986) (Note 2)			\$ 357,485			443,702	8,143	809,330	1,018,850
Deferred charges and deposits	108,428					229,270	91,349	429,047	206,035
Prepaid conventions	1,060,067							1,060,067	292,118
Total Assets	3,590,073	14,094,966	357,485	3,139,334	\$ -	5,583,317	3,052,628	29,817,803	25,900,991
LIABILITIES									
Accounts and accruals payable	\$ -					\$ 647,130	\$ 108,515	\$ 755,645	\$ 479,410
Deferred income									
- orders and subscriptions, etc.	5,800					95,271	1,935,553	2,036,624	2,340,113
- convention registrations	3,527,260							3,527,260	
Accrued postretirement health benefits				\$7,253,849				7,253,849	5,664,481
Accrued pension benefits					\$8,205,766			8,205,766	3,569,738
Total Liabilities	5,533,060	\$ -	\$ -	7,253,849	8,205,766	742,401	2,044,068	21,779,144	12,053,742
Net Assets (Exhibit B)	57,013	14,094,966	357,485	(4,114,515)	(8,205,766)	4,840,916	1,008,560	8,038,659	13,847,249
Total Liabilities and Net Assets	3,590,073	14,094,966	357,485	3,139,334	-	5,583,317	3,052,628	29,817,803	25,900,991

The accompanying notes are an integral part of these financial statements.

**The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc.
Alcoholics Anonymous World Services, Inc. • Alcoholics Anonymous Grapevine, Inc.**

CONSOLIDATED STATEMENT OF ACTIVITY

Year Ended December 31, 2014 (with comparative totals for 2013)

	General Service Board of A.A.					A.A. Grapevine, Inc.				
	General Fund	Reserve Fund	Capital Projects Fund	Postretirement Medical Fund	Pension Benefits	A.A. World Services, Inc.	Grapevine	La Viña	Consolidated 2014	Consolidated 2013
INCOME AND COST OF LITERATURE										
Gross Sales						\$17,128,071	\$3,012,463	\$134,809	\$20,275,343	\$15,988,582
Less: Discounts						255,791	-	-	255,791	237,254
Net Sales						16,872,280	3,012,463	134,809	20,019,552	15,751,328
Cost of Literature Distributed										
Printing						(4,889,864)	(383,569)	(31,672)	(5,305,105)	(3,397,968)
Royalties on books						(38,627)	-	-	(38,627)	(27,840)
Direct shipping and warehousing						(2,049,813)	(590,530)	(33,359)	(2,673,702)	(2,159,128)
Gross Profit from Literature						9,893,976	2,038,364	69,778	12,002,118	10,166,392
CONTRIBUTIONS	\$6,898,068								6,898,068	6,906,371
INVESTMENT INCOME (Note 2)	35	\$33,313		\$182,198		391	7,100	-	223,037	436,614
Total Income	6,898,103	33,313		182,198		9,894,367	2,045,464	69,778	19,123,223	17,509,377
FUNCTIONAL EXPENSES (Exhibit C)										
Program	5,947,284	-				3,265,794	1,098,067	201,804	10,512,949	10,256,194
Supporting services	3,777,926	1,500,000	\$ 120,162	108,693	\$ (2,705,061)	2,424,810	621,570	-	5,848,100	6,175,347
Total Expenses	9,725,210	1,500,000	120,162	108,693	(2,705,061)	5,690,604	1,719,637	201,804	16,361,049	16,431,541
EXCESS OF INCOME (EXPENSE) FOR YEAR	(2,827,107)	(1,466,687)	(120,162)	73,505	2,705,061	4,203,763	325,827	(132,026)	2,762,174	1,077,836
Change in retirement liabilities – nonoperating	-	-	-	(1,229,675)	(7,341,089)	-	-	-	(8,570,764)	6,752,525
INTERCOMPANY AND INTERFUND TRANSFERS										
GSB La Vina support	(132,026)	-	-	-	-	-	-	132,026		
Other transfers	2,959,133	260,000	-	-	-	(2,959,133)	(260,000)	-	-	-
CHANGE IN NET ASSETS FOR YEAR	-	(1,206,687)	(120,162)	(1,156,170)	(4,636,028)	1,244,630	65,827	-	(5,808,590)	7,830,361
NET ASSETS										
Beginning of year	57,013	15,301,653	477,647	(2,958,345)	(3,569,738)	3,596,286	942,733	-	13,847,249	6,016,888
NET ASSETS										
End of year (Exhibit A)	57,013	14,094,966	357,485	(4,114,515)	(8,205,766)	4,840,916	1,008,560	-	8,038,659	13,847,249

The accompanying notes are an integral part of these financial statements.

**The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc.
Alcoholics Anonymous World Services, Inc. • Alcoholics Anonymous Grapevine, Inc.**

CONSOLIDATED STATEMENT OF FUNCTIONAL EXPENSES

Year Ended December 31, 2014 (with comparative totals for 2013)

OPERATING EXPENSES	Group Services	Fellowship Services	General Service Conference	World Service Meeting	International Convention	Regional Forums	Publishing	Grapevine	La Viña	Supporting Services	2014 Total	2013 Total
Salaries	\$ 775,853	\$1,008,762	\$ 175,505	\$ 2,100	\$161,056	\$166,662	\$1,432,133	\$ 457,403	\$132,073	\$2,672,501	\$ 6,984,048	\$6,691,798
Payroll taxes	57,224	76,538	11,987		11,793	15,071	110,089	34,371	11,335	205,780	534,188	512,811
Health and group insurance	116,590	154,953	24,188		23,348	30,035	220,736	69,865	12,099	705,762	1,357,576	1,263,752
Retirement expense - funding	232,380	309,196	48,190		44,998	59,942	440,277	79,111	26,713	800,017	2,040,824	2,429,421
Other program printing	238,913	67,988	63,079	6,620		7,412	4,425				388,437	349,736
Mailing labor	104,241	10,618	1,741			1,875	17,976				136,451	121,636
Postage and express	223,352	44,281	40,475	6,394	3,795	18,213	49,961	2,892		31,010	420,373	381,315
Writers fees	12,560	69,020	9,935	805		4,248	3,493			180	100,241	40,988
Foreign literature assistance		13,250									13,250	43,652
Selling expenses							392,601	151,793	3,925	42,609	590,928	568,721
Professional fees										351,964	351,964	173,725
Contracted services	134,266	158,061	51,255	41,721	4,892	32,273	219,667	139,192	8,643	649,739	1,439,709	1,244,030
Occupancy	108,670	140,711	10,914		10,544	3,134	204,139	28,626		362,698	869,436	856,878
Telephone	15,810	16,061	1,453			1,598	15,490	16,653		64,696	131,761	136,792
Equipment maintenance	1,667	4,030					12,880			55,447	74,024	81,668
Depreciation and amortization	39,475	21,224	9,534			12,355	108,534		503	72,291	263,916	350,556
Stationery and office	86,520	10,650	12,526	3,771	1,602	4,942	5,175	59,081		59,229	243,496	235,747
Office service and expense	6,245	12,400	24,656	3,387	454	12,444	16,500	59,080	1,408	262,738	399,312	378,964
Travel, meals and accommodations	2,928	15,071	568,805	217,145	435	69,493	11,718		5,105	474,959	1,365,659	1,303,070
Bad debts										12,686	12,686	6,328
Delegate fees			(257,650)	(123,374)							(381,024)	(292,036)
Total Operating Expenses	<u>2,156,694</u>	<u>2,132,814</u>	<u>796,593</u>	<u>158,569</u>	<u>262,917</u>	<u>439,697</u>	<u>3,265,794</u>	<u>1,098,067</u>	<u>201,804</u>	<u>6,824,306</u>	<u>17,337,255</u>	<u>16,879,552</u>
Postretirement health benefits										108,693	108,693	201,737
Retirement expense adjustment										(1,205,061)	(1,205,061)	(772,710)
Capital projects depreciation										120,162	120,162	122,962
Total Expenses	<u>2,156,694</u>	<u>2,132,814</u>	<u>796,593</u>	<u>158,569</u>	<u>262,917</u>	<u>439,697</u>	<u>3,265,794</u>	<u>1,098,067</u>	<u>201,804</u>	<u>5,848,100</u>	<u>16,361,049</u>	<u>16,431,541</u>
Allocation of supporting services to activities	<u>1,016,002</u>	<u>1,004,752</u>	<u>375,269</u>	<u>74,701</u>	<u>123,858</u>	<u>207,138</u>	<u>2,424,810</u>	<u>621,570</u>	<u>-</u>	<u>(5,848,100)</u>	<u>-</u>	<u>-</u>
Total Allocated Expenses	<u>3,172,696</u>	<u>3,137,566</u>	<u>1,171,862</u>	<u>233,270</u>	<u>386,775</u>	<u>646,835</u>	<u>5,690,604</u>	<u>1,719,637</u>	<u>201,804</u>	<u>-</u>	<u>16,361,049</u>	<u>16,431,541</u>
Services	\$3,172,696	\$3,137,566	\$1,171,862	\$233,270	\$386,775	\$646,835				-	8,749,004	\$9,059,571
Publishing	-	-	-	-	-	-	\$5,690,604				5,690,604	5,477,081
Grapevine	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	\$1,719,637	201,804		1,921,441	1,894,889
											16,361,049	16,431,541
COMPARATIVE TOTALS 2013	<u>\$3,455,114</u>	<u>\$3,458,590</u>	<u>\$1,422,515</u>	<u>\$-</u>	<u>\$-</u>	<u>\$723,352</u>	<u>\$5,477,081</u>	<u>\$1,688,811</u>	<u>\$206,078</u>		<u>\$16,431,541</u>	

The accompanying notes are an integral part of these financial statements.

**The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc.
 Alcoholics Anonymous World Services, Inc.
 Alcoholics Anonymous Grapevine, Inc.
 Consolidated Statement of Cash Flows
 Year Ended December 31, 2014
 (with comparative totals for 2013)**

CASH FLOWS PROVIDED (USED)

	<u>2014</u>	<u>2013</u>
FROM OPERATING ACTIVITIES:		
Change in net assets for year (Exhibit B)	\$ (5,808,590)	\$ 7,830,361
Realized and change in unrealized gains on investments	(145,298)	(314,997)
Amortization of bond premiums	2,033	4,423
Depreciation and amortization	393,184	496,601
Changes in assets and liabilities:		
Accounts receivable	(44,223)	141,982
Inventories	(296,521)	107,536
Deferred charges and other assets	(990,961)	(88,383)
Accounts and accruals payable	276,235	61,040
Deferred income	3,223,771	271,338
Postretirement health benefits obligation	1,589,368	(273,513)
Accrued pension benefits	4,636,028	(6,798,985)
 <u>Net Cash Flows Provided</u>		
<u>by Operating Activities</u>	<u>2,835,026</u>	<u>1,437,403</u>
 FROM INVESTING ACTIVITIES:		
Purchases of property and equipment	(183,664)	(374,645)
Proceeds from sales of investments	11,563,764	6,768,354
Purchases of investments	(9,766,991)	(6,291,053)
 <u>Net Cash Flows Provided (used)</u>		
<u>by Investing Activities</u>	<u>1,613,109</u>	<u>102,656</u>
 Net Increase (Decrease) in Cash	<u>4,448,135</u>	<u>1,540,059</u>
 Cash, beginning of year	<u>4,416,147</u>	<u>2,876,088</u>
 Cash, end of year	<u><u>\$8,864,282</u></u>	<u><u>\$4,416,147</u></u>

The accompanying notes are an integral part of these financial statements.

■ Report of the Independent Auditor

INDEPENDENT AUDITORS' REPORT

March 25, 2015

The Board of Trustees
The General Service Board of
Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc.
475 Riverside Drive
New York, New York 10115

Members of the Board:

We have audited the accompanying consolidated statement of financial position of THE GENERAL SERVICE BOARD OF ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS, INC., ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS WORLD SERVICES, INC., and ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS GRAPEVINE, INC. as of December 31, 2014 and the related consolidated statements of activities, functional expenses and cash flows for the year then ended. These financial statements are the responsibility of the Organizations' management. Our responsibility is to express an opinion on these financial statements based on our audit.

Management's Responsibility for the Financial Statements

Management is responsible for the preparation and fair presentation of these financial statements in accordance with accounting principles generally accepted in the United States of America; this includes the design, implementation, and maintenance of internal control relevant to the preparation and fair presentation of financial statements that are free from material misstatement, whether due to fraud or error.

Auditor's Responsibility

Our responsibility is to express an opinion on these financial statements based on our audit. We conducted our audit in accordance with auditing standards generally accepted in the United States of America. Those standards require that we plan and perform the audit to obtain reasonable assurance about whether the financial statements are free of material misstatement.

An audit involves performing procedures to obtain audit evidence about the amounts and disclosures in the financial statements. The procedures selected depend on the auditor's judgement, including the assessment of the risks of material misstatement of the financial statements, whether due to fraud or error. In making those risk assessments, the auditor considers internal control relevant to the entity's preparation and fair presentation of the financial statements in order to design audit procedures that are appropriate in the circumstances, but not for the purpose of expressing an opinion on the effectiveness of the entity's internal control. Accordingly, we express no such opinion. An audit also includes evaluating the appropriateness of accounting policies used and the reasonableness of significant accounting estimates made by management, as well as evaluating the overall presentation of the financial statements.

We believe that the audit evidence we have obtained is sufficient and appropriate to provide a basis for our audit opinion.

The prior year summarized comparative information has been derived from the Organization's December 31, 2013 consolidated financial statements, and in our report dated March 25, 2014, we expressed an unmodified opinion on those financial statements.

Opinion

In our opinion, the consolidated financial statements referred to above present fairly, in all material respects, the financial position of the three Corporations named

above as of December 31, 2014 and the changes in their net assets and their cash flows for the year then ended in conformity with accounting principles generally accepted in the United States of America.

Other Matter

Our audit was conducted for the purpose of forming an opinion on the financial statements as a whole. The consolidating information presented in the consolidated statement of financial position is presented for purposes of additional analyses and is not a required part of the financial statements. Such information is the responsibility of management and was derived from and relates directly to the underlying accounting and other records used to prepare the financial statements. The information has been subjected to the auditing procedures applied in the audit of the financial statements and certain additional procedures, including comparing and reconciling such information directly to the underlying accounting and other records used to prepare the financial statements or to the financial statements themselves, and other additional procedures in accordance with auditing standards generally accepted in the United States of America. In our opinion, the information is fairly stated in all material respects in relation to the financial statements as a whole.

Owen J. Flanagan and Company
Certified Public Accountants
New York, N.Y.

THE GENERAL SERVICE BOARD OF ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS, INC. ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS WORLD SERVICES, INC. ALCOHOLICS ANONYMOUS GRAPEVINE, INC. NOTES TO CONSOLIDATED FINANCIAL STATEMENTS DECEMBER 31, 2014

Note 1 Organization: The General Service Board of Alcoholics Anonymous, Inc. ("G.S.B.") and its affiliates A.A. World Services, Inc. ("A.A.W.S.") and A.A. Grapevine, Inc. ("A.A.G.V.") are not-for-profit organizations organized for the purpose of assisting in the formation of A.A. Groups and coordinating the A.A. program of rehabilitating alcoholics throughout the world, and publishing books, magazines, pamphlets and other material directly related to that purpose. The trustees of G.S.B. are members ex officio of A.A.W.S. and A.A.G.V., and as such, elect their boards of directors. As members, they also have the sole right to amend the A.A.W.S. and A.A.G.V. bylaws, and approve their budgets.

The activities of the General Service Board of A.A. itself are conducted in five separate funds, as follows.

The RESERVE FUND — This fund was established in 1954 for



the purpose of accumulating a prudent operating reserve, which during 1977, was redefined by a special General Service Board Committee as the prior year's combined operating expenses of A.A. World Services, Inc., A.A. Grapevine, Inc. and the General Fund of the A.A. General Service Board. The committee also recommended that all investment activities of the operating entities be consolidated into the Reserve Fund. That Advisory Action was approved by the Board of Trustees and since that time, all funds of the operating entities, in excess of those required for working capital, have been transferred to the Reserve Fund. Included in such transfers from A.A. Grapevine, Inc. have been amounts held for unfulfilled subscriptions reflected as a liability of the Reserve Fund. Any withdrawals from the Reserve Fund must be specifically authorized by the Board of Trustees upon recommendation of the Finance and Budgetary Committee.

The CAPITAL PROJECTS FUND — This fund accounts for the cost of leasehold improvements and computer hardware and software incurred under major capital projects, and records annual depreciation on such assets.

The CONVENTION FUND — A separate fund established to record the direct income and expenses of International A.A. conventions held every five years. These events are separate from the regular operations of the General Service Office, but the General Fund receives any excess of income, or pays any excess of expense, resulting from the activity.

From a historical perspective, the net direct result of all Conventions held to date is approximately an excess of income of \$1,561,000, and presently resides with all other income not required for working capital in the Reserve Fund.

The POSTRETIREMENT MEDICAL FUND — A fund established in 2006 with the goal of accumulating assets equal to 50% of the liability for postretirement health benefits by the end of ten years.

The Postretirement health benefits plan is described in more detail in Note 5.

The GENERAL FUND — This fund is comprised of those assets not included in any of the other funds and may be used for any purpose for which the Organization was formed. These purposes presently include activities related to communication and information services to A.A. groups and members, public information, cooperation with the professional community and regional, national and international meetings, conferences and conventions.

All net assets of the Organizations are free of donor restrictions.

Note 2 Accounting Policies: The Organizations use the accrual method of accounting, where income is recorded in the period earned and expenses are recorded in the period incurred and to which they pertain. The Organizations do not receive or solicit pledges, so contributions are recorded as income when the cash is received.

The Organizations receive revenue from sales of literature and magazine subscriptions and donations from A.A. groups and members.

Contributions received from A.A. groups and members are for the general activities of the General Service Office, and are recorded as unrestricted. Donations received from foreign A.A. entities for the International Literature Fund are also treated as unrestricted, as A.A.'s ongoing foreign literature assistance program satisfies the donor's condition on a current basis.

Intercompany balances and transfers are eliminated in the consolidated totals in the accompanying financial statements.

Operating expenses of the General Service Office are shared between the General Service Board of A.A. and A.A. World Services. Expenses related to service activities are charged

to the General Service Board, while expenses in connection with publishing activities are allocated to A.A. World Services. Administrative and overhead costs are apportioned between the program activities they support.

Occupancy costs related to A.A. Grapevine's share of office space at the General Service Office have been charged based on the actual lease cost; substantially all other expenses related to magazine activities are paid and recorded directly by A.A. Grapevine under its separate accounting system.

Cash: For purposes of the consolidated statement of cash flows, cash is defined as cash on hand, checking and money market accounts and short term cash investments.

Cash in excess of federally insured limits are potentially exposed to concentrations of credit risk. However, the Organizations only maintain accounts with quality financial institutions with high credit standings, so as a consequence, such risks are limited.

Accounts Receivable: Receivables from sales of literature are recognized when items are shipped. Allowances for doubtful accounts are recorded based on the age and collectibility of the receivables.

Inventories: Inventories are valued at the lower of cost or market using the first-in, first-out "FIFO" method of valuation. Proper allowance has been made for slow-moving or damaged merchandise.

Cost of literature distributed on Exhibit B for 2014 includes \$823,152 of inventory write downs on the 75th Anniversary edition Big Book due to quantities printed in excess of expected sales.

Literature distributed without charge is not accounted for separately, but is included in the cost of printing as a reduction of inventory.

Shipping and handling charges billed to customers are included in sales revenue.

Property and Equipment: The costs of major capital projects involving leasehold improvements and computer system acquisitions are capitalized and depreciated on a straight line basis over the term of the applicable lease, or the useful life of the equipment, in the Capital Projects Fund.

Normal recurring expenditures for furniture and equipment are capitalized and depreciated over estimated useful lives of three to eight years.

The following table sets forth, by classification of assets, the depreciation lives, the provision for depreciation for the year ended December 31, 2014 and the accumulated depreciation at that date:

	<u>Life</u>	<u>Cost</u>	<u>Current Year</u>	<u>Accumulated Depreciation</u>
Leasehold improvements	Terms of			
475 Riverside Drive	Leases	\$3,122,741	\$120,162	\$2,765,256
Furniture	8 Years	754,354	6,483	748,261
Computers	3 to 5 Years	489,336	90,777	326,304
Software	5 Years	1,384,379	175,762	1,101,659
		<u>5,750,810</u>	<u>393,184</u>	<u>4,941,480</u>

During 2013, \$125,000 of capitalized software for ebook applications was charged to expense after A.A.W.S. decided to discontinue their own application in favor of commercially available ebook applications.

Investments: Investments are recorded at fair value. Gains and losses on sales or redemptions are recorded by comparison of proceeds to amortized cost on a specific identification basis.

The Organizations follow Accounting Standards Codification ("ASC") 820, Fair Value Measurements. It establishes a framework for measuring fair value, and expands disclosures about fair value measurements. Investments are now classified into one of three categories.

Level 1 — Quoted prices are available in active markets for

identical investments as of the reporting date.

Level 2 — Pricing inputs are other than quoted prices in active markets, which are either directly or indirectly observable as of the reporting date, and the fair value is determined through the use of models or other valuation methodologies.

Level 3 — Pricing inputs are unobservable for the investment and include situations where there is little, if any, market activity for the investment.

All of the securities held by the Organizations at December 31, 2014 and 2013 have been valued at either Level 1 or Level 2.

Level 2 investments have been valued using the net asset values as reported by the mutual funds.

As described above, all funds of the operating entities not required for working capital are consolidated in the Reserve Fund of the General Service Board. In accordance with established policy, the Reserve Fund invests in short or medium term U.S. Treasury Notes or Bills normally held to maturity and certificates of deposit.

The Postretirement Medical Fund holds investments designed to assist in reaching the stated goal of accumulating assets equal to 50% of the accrued postretirement health benefits by December 31, 2015. This fund invests in bond and equity mutual funds.

At December 31, 2014, investments were comprised as follows:

	Cost	Fair Value	Level 1	Level 2
Reserve Fund				
Certificate of deposits	\$10,624,191	\$10,624,191	\$10,624,191	\$ -
U.S. Treasury	2,505,140	2,505,140	2,505,140	-
Totals	<u>13,129,331</u>	<u>13,129,331</u>		
Postretirement Medical Fund				
Bond funds	1,114,658	1,105,804	-	1,105,804
Equity funds				
Small Cap Index	138,954	155,090	-	155,090
Mid Cap Index	139,014	155,617	-	155,617
S&P 500 Index	1,205,349	1,321,606	-	1,321,606
International Index	371,361	370,681	-	370,681
	<u>2,969,336</u>	<u>3,108,798</u>		
Totals	<u>16,098,667</u>	<u>16,238,129</u>	<u>13,129,331</u>	<u>3,108,798</u>

Investment income for 2014 and 2013 is comprised of the following:

	2014	2013
Interest and dividends	\$ 106,044	\$ 148,078
Realized gains	509,525	15,937
Change in unrealized appreciation	(364,228)	299,060
Investment expenses	(28,304)	(26,461)
	<u>223,037</u>	<u>436,614</u>

Functional Expenses: The consolidated statement of Functional Expenses (Exhibit C) provides detail as to program costs by major activity and supporting services. In addition to the program costs reflected on that Exhibit, amounts shown on the consolidated statement of activities (Exhibit B) as cost of literature distributed also relate to the publishing and magazine programs.

Two of the major program activities described on Exhibit C are for "Group Services" and "Fellowship Services." Group Services includes those activities most closely associated with serving A.A. groups, including staff services, the *Box 4-5-9* newsletter, directories, group records and files, the contributions department and services to French- and Spanish-speaking groups in North America. Fellowship Services include activities outside of the group, such as public information, cooperation with the professional community, treatment and correctional facilities, archives and loners and overseas services.

Supporting services include costs of the General Service Office, which cannot be attributed to any specific program activity. These include administrative management, data processing and

information systems, editorial and clerical support, trustee and director activities, copy center, accounting, human resources and miscellaneous administrative functions.

The allocation of supporting services to program activities on Exhibit C is done on a pro rata basis to program expenses by entity, and is provided for informational purposes only.

Fundraising costs are immaterial.

Operating Expenses: For purposes of the Statement of Functional Expenses, operating expenses are defined as recurring items requiring the current outlay of cash.

Management Estimates: The management of the Organizations use estimates and assumptions in preparing financial statements in accordance with accounting principles generally accepted in the United States of America. These estimates and assumptions affect the reported amounts of assets, liabilities, revenues and expenses. Actual results could vary from the estimates that management uses.

As described in Note 5 of this report, management made certain significant estimates in the calculation of liabilities for postretirement health benefits. These estimates include employee retention, health care cost trends and the actuarial lives of present and projected retirees eligible for benefits. It is reasonably possible that changes in these estimates will occur in the near term. The effect of changes in these estimates cannot be determined.

Subsequent Events: In connection with the preparation of these consolidated financial statements, Management evaluated subsequent events after the balance sheet date of December 31, 2014 through March 25, 2015, which was the date the financial statements were able to be issued.

Note 3 Retirement Plan: The Organizations adopted a defined benefit pension plan effective January 1, 1965 to provide retirement benefits to eligible U.S. employees who have completed one year of service.

The plan provides an annual benefit equal to 2% of final average compensation multiplied by years of service (not to exceed 35 years), less 0.65% of average social security earnings multiplied by years of service (not to exceed 30 years). The social security offset can not reduce the gross benefit by more than 50%.

Pension expense is recorded in accordance with ASC 715 under which costs are accrued ratably over an employee's years of service based upon factors that are not necessarily the same as those used to calculate the annual funding requirements. In addition, ASC 715 requires an employer to report an asset or liability on the Organization's balance sheet depending upon a comparison of the Plan's assets to its benefit obligations.

The contributions made to fund pension benefits are recorded by the operating companies as an expense. The difference between the amounts actually paid and the net periodic pension cost under ASC 715 is recorded as an adjustment to retirement expense as a non-cash item that does not affect current operations.

The following tables set forth the Plan's funded status, assumptions, benefit cost and payments and employer contributions for 2014:

Fair value of plan assets (at December 31)	\$ 27,848,370
Benefit obligation (at December 31)	<u>36,054,136</u>
Funded status	<u>(8,205,766)</u>
Accrued pension cost recognized in consolidated statement of financial position	<u>\$ 8,206,766</u>
Accumulated benefit obligation	\$ 31,508,096
Benefit cost	485,039
Employers' contributions	3,190,100
Benefits paid	1,189,353

Classification of benefit costs:	
Operating expense (cash funding)	\$ 3,190,100
Non-operating expense (non-cash adjustment to pension cost)	(2,705,061)
	<u>485,039</u>

Weighted — Average Assumptions used to determine benefits obligations at December 31, 2014:	
Discount rate	3.89%
Salary increases	3.5%
Expected long-term return on assets	8.0%

Weighted — Average Assumptions used to determine net periodic pension cost for year ended December 31, 2014:	
Discount rate	4.76%
Salary increases	3.5%
Expected long-term return on assets	8.0%

The expected rate of return on plan assets is determined by those assets' historical long-term investment performance, current asset allocation, and estimates of future long-term returns by asset class.

The fair value of plan assets at December 31, 2014 were composed as follows:

	Total	Level 1	Level 2
Cash and equivalents	\$ 1,434,011	\$ 1,434,011	\$ -
Domestic equity mutual funds	15,024,446	-	15,024,446
International equity mutual fund	2,870,597	-	2,870,597
Bond mutual funds	8,519,316	-	8,519,316
Totals	<u>\$27,848,370</u>	<u>\$1,434,011</u>	<u>\$26,414,359</u>

The mutual funds in the plan are primarily index funds designed to achieve diversification between fixed income and equity investments among asset classes including S&P 500, small capitalization companies and international stocks.

The expected benefits to be paid for the next ten years are as follows:

2015	\$ 1,577,133
2016	1,632,436
2017	1,622,891
2018	1,656,829
2019	1,723,669
2020 – 2024	9,371,946

The employers' contributions for 2015 are expected to be \$1,500,000.

Effective January 1, 2013, the Corporations implemented a "soft freeze" of the defined benefit pension plan. Employees in the plan as of December 31, 2012, continue to accrue benefits; however, employees hired after that date participate instead in a new defined contribution plan. The contribution rate is 5% plus a 50% match on employee contributions up to 5%. Therefore, the maximum combined rate is 7.5%. The 2014 pension cost was \$47,947.

Note 4 Lease Commitments: At December 31, 2014, A.A.W.S. as fiscal agent for the G.S.B. and the A.A. Grapevine, Inc. was subject to the following noncancellable leases (exclusive of future operating increases) for office space at 475 Riverside Drive in New York City:

\$775,450 annual leases effective January 1, 2009 through December 31, 2018 for space on the 10th and 11th floors;

\$37,427 annual lease effective December 1, 2014 through November 30, 2015 for space on the 12th floor.

Future minimum rental payments due under the leases are as follows:

2015	\$ 809,758
2016	775,450
2017	775,450
2018	775,450
	<u>\$3,136,108</u>

The space on the 10th floor is subleased at \$121,255 per year from February 15, 2012 through December 31, 2015 to an unaffiliated not-for-profit organization. The above lease expense will be offset by payments due under the sublease as follows:

2015	121,255
	<u>\$121,255</u>

Note 5 Postretirement Health Benefits: The Organizations provide health care benefits for retired employees, substantially all of whom become eligible if they attain retirement age while working at the General Service Office. Benefits are provided through health insurance contracts maintained by the Corporations. For employees hired before 2004, 25% of the cost is borne by the retirees.

For employees hired after January 1, 2004, there is a three-tier structure in the level of group medical insurance premiums paid for on behalf of employees who retire directly from GSO. For employees with 5-9 years of service, the Organizations pay 25%, 10-15 years 50% and more than 15 years 75%.

The assumed health care cost trend rate used to measure the expected cost of benefits covered by the plan is 6.0%. A discount rate of 3.89% has been used to measure the accrued postretirement health benefit obligation shown on Exhibit B at December 31, 2014. The discount rate was 4.76% at December 31, 2013.

Prior to 2006, the Plan was unfunded. However, as described in Note 1, a Postretirement Medical Fund was created by the Board with the purpose of accumulating assets equal to 50% of the postretirement health benefits liability after ten years. As of December 31, 2014, the Fund's assets were equal to 43.3% of the benefit obligation.

The following table sets forth information regarding the Plan for 2014:

Benefit obligation (at December 31)	\$7,253,849
Benefits paid	<u>\$ 250,789</u>
Benefit cost	<u>\$ 610,482</u>
Benefit cost reported by:	
Operating entities	\$ 501,789
Postretirement Medical Fund	<u>\$ 108,693</u>
	<u>\$ 610,482</u>

The expected postretirement benefits to be paid for the next ten years are as follows:

2015	\$ 265,836
2016	281,786
2017	298,693
2018	316,615
2019	335,612
2020 – 2024	2,005,391

Note 6 Tax Status: The Organizations are exempt from Federal income taxes under section 501(c)(3) of the Internal Revenue Code, and are classified as public charities. They are also exempt from New York State franchise and sales taxes.

The Organizations have not entered into any uncertain tax positions that would require financial statement recognition. They are also no longer subject to audits by the applicable taxing jurisdictions for the periods prior to 2011.

Note 7 Litigation: G.S.B. and A.A.W.S. have been named as defendants in a legal action filed in California. Although management believes that the claim will ultimately be dismissed in their favor, no opinion can be expressed at this time as to the likely outcome of the matter or the possible loss.

The General Service Office 2015 OPERATING BUDGET

INCOME	2014 Budget	2014 Actual	2015 Budget
GROSS SALES	\$15,300,000	\$17,128,071	\$14,820,000
Discounts Allowed	594,000	255,791	250,000
<u>Net Sales</u>	14,706,000	16,872,280	14,570,000
Cost of Literature Distributed			
Manufacturing	3,503,500	4,889,864	3,038,700
Royalties	38,870	38,627	28,000
Gross Margin	11,163,630	11,943,789	11,503,300
DIRECT SHIPPING AND WAREHOUSING	1,940,070	2,049,812	1,866,550
<u>Gross Profit from Literature</u>	9,223,560	9,893,977	9,636,750
	62.72%	58.64%	66.14%
Contributions Received	7,000,000	6,898,068	7,000,000
Interest Income	400	426	400
<u>Total Revenue</u>	16,223,960	16,792,471	16,637,150
OPERATING EXPENSES			
Salaries	6,390,500	6,146,670	6,675,000
Payroll taxes	444,250	468,270	486,000
Insurance	1,244,791	1,177,284	1,209,800
Retirement expense	1,916,750	1,883,995	1,787,000
Other program printing	406,150	388,437	405,800
Mailing, labor, etc.	134,700	136,452	131,500
Postage & express	436,000	417,481	441,800
Writers' fees	205,000	100,240	152,250
Other literature assistance	50,000	13,250	50,000
Selling expenses	499,250	435,210	417,750
Professional fees	209,500	304,640	354,500
Contracted services	1,201,400	1,291,874	1,312,000
Occupancy	836,000	822,354	848,500
Telephone	122,200	103,993	111,700
Equipment maintenance	75,300	60,651	76,800
Furniture & equipment	273,500	259,208	244,000
Stationery & office expense	180,750	184,414	204,500
Office service & expense	326,275	302,415	343,425
Travel, meals, & accommodations	1,073,700	912,008	1,185,200
Bad debts	2,500	6,969	2,500
TOTAL OPERATING EXPENSES	16,028,516	15,415,815	16,440,025
INCOME (LOSS) FOR PERIOD	\$195,444	\$1,376,656	\$197,125

Alcoholics Anonymous Grapevine, Inc.

2015 BUDGET

	GRAPEVINE			LA VIÑA		
	2014 Budget	2014 Actual	2015 Budget	2014 Budget	2014 Actual	2015 Budget
PAID CIRCULATION—						
AVERAGE # OF Print COPIES	73,401	74,000	69,632	10,607	10,379	9,860
Online Circulation	4,561	5,262	5,368			
INCOME FROM MAGAZINE						
Subscription income	\$1,969,167	\$2,035,530	\$1,915,379	\$111,790	\$111,940	\$106,343
Single copies and back issues	30,255	38,405	38,405	9,590	9,947	9,947
GV Online	133,429	156,440	159,591			
<u>Total magazine income</u>	2,132,851	2,230,375	2,113,375	121,380	121,887	116,290
<u>Total direct costs</u>	750,733	701,314	680,761	64,113	62,439	59,317
Gross Profit on Magazine	1,382,118	1,529,061	1,432,614	57,267	59,448	56,973
OTHER PUBLISHING INCOME	787,557	782,087	734,373	9,649	12,924	11,632
<u>Total direct costs</u>	266,556	272,782	228,560	1,751	2,593	2,334
Gross Profit on Other Items	521,001	509,305	505,813	7,898	10,331	9,298
Total Gross Profit	1,903,119	2,038,366	1,938,427	65,165	69,779	66,271
COSTS AND EXPENSES						
EDITORIAL COSTS						
Salaries, including temporary help	398,421	389,007	414,813	95,479	89,858	97,606
Payroll taxes and benefits	153,114	136,635	158,499	33,639	31,593	34,838
Occupancy costs	36,344	37,132	38,246			
Office supplies and expenses	24,238	26,032	26,813	1,696	1,408	1,450
Product development & Web	75,000	57,577	135,000			
<u>Total Editorial</u>	687,117	646,383	773,371	130,814	122,859	133,894
CIRCULATION AND BUSINESS						
Salaries, including temporary help	380,640	316,297	334,340	41,012	42,215	45,031
Payroll taxes and benefits	208,843	216,257	220,079	19,103	18,554	20,079
Fulfillment	95,603	142,635	159,630	8,218	8,643	8,903
Occupancy costs	37,652	37,719	38,851			
Office supplies and expenses	91,833	92,129	94,893			
Selling expense-regular	95,000	85,581	95,000	5,008	3,925	12,046
- GvR program	11,589	5,192	11,589			
Postage	5,120	2,892	2,979			
<u>Total Circulation and Business</u>	926,280	898,702	957,361	73,341	73,337	86,059
GENERAL AND ADMINISTRATIVE						
Computer Consulting	30,000	13,373	30,000			
Insurance	7,783	8,978	9,247			
Professional fees	60,000	47,324	60,000			
Meetings and conferences	62,000	67,523	78,000	2,441	5,105	5,258
Furniture and equipment	15,000	4,205	15,000		503	518
Canadian exchange and other	5,800	9,550	9,837	144		
Bank service charges	16,707	17,882	18,418			
Bad debts	10,000	5,717	10,000			
<u>Total General and Administrative</u>	207,290	174,552	230,502	2,585	5,608	5,776
TOTAL COSTS AND EXPENSES	1,820,687	1,719,637	1,961,234	206,740	201,804	225,729
Add: Interest earned	11,800	7,100	8,200			
Support from GSB General Fund				141,575	132,025	159,458
NET INCOME (LOSS) FOR PERIOD	<u>\$94,232</u>	<u>\$325,829</u>	<u>(\$14,607)</u>	<u>\$0</u>	<u>\$0</u>	<u>\$0</u>

The Budget Highlights

2015 G.S.O. Budget

These budget highlights describe the "OPERATIONS" of the General Service Office — A.A. World Services (the Publishing operation), the General Fund (Service activities) and the Grapevine Operations. It excludes any activities reported separately in the Reserve Fund, Convention Fund, Post Retirement Fund or the Capital Projects Fund.

Income: The 2015 budget projects literature gross sales of \$14,820,000. The 2015 budget was developed with unit sales volumes projected to be approximately even with 2013, reduced further for the effects of the large purchases made by clients prior to the October 2014 increase in selling prices of literature. The budget anticipates a small amount of sales of the 75th Anniversary Edition of the first edition of the Big Book, as well as increased revenue resulting from the literature price adjustment effective October 2014. When approving the 2015 budget, the A.A.W.S. Board continued to focus diligently on revenue and expense assumptions and how they ultimately affect the long-term fiscal health of the General Service Board and its Reserve Fund.

Manufacturing, royalties, and shipping and warehousing costs are budgeted lower than both the 2014 budget and the 2014 actual results, primarily due to 2014 expenses associated with both the sales of the 75th Anniversary Edition and the purchases from clients prior to the literature price increase.

After subtracting manufacturing, royalties and shipping and warehousing costs, gross profit is budgeted at \$9,636,750, or 66.1%. Gross profit has been budgeted about \$257,000 less than 2014, again primarily due to the anticipated reduction in sales of the 75th Anniversary Edition and pre-price increase sales. The 66.1% gross profit percentage anticipated for 2015 compares with 58.6% realized for 2014.

It should be recognized that as we continue to strive to have literature available throughout our Service Structure in Spanish and French, as well as English, lower print runs in non-English languages usually results in higher production costs. We strive to have the same selling prices regardless of the manufacturing cost; therefore lower gross profit margins for low volume items will affect the overall gross profit percentages in the future.

The table below reflects the Gross Profit Percentages from 2010 through the 2015 budget.

2010	2011	2012	2013	2014	2015 Budget
64.5%	63.7%	63.7%	64.3%	58.6%	66.1%

Prudence dictates that ongoing reviews are necessary to control costs and reinforce the revenue stream to provide sufficient funds to continue providing services. Trusted servants continue to evaluate costs of operations as well as assess the services provided.

Contributions: Seventh Tradition self-support contributions for 2015 are budgeted at \$7,000,000, which is at the same level as the 2014 budget and slightly greater than 2014 actual contributions received of \$6,898,000.

During 2014, contributions from groups and individuals (as distinguished from those received for the World Service Meeting literature efforts) of \$6,828,490 were \$135,500 less than budget and \$41,759 less than 2013. Contributions received from World Service Meeting countries toward the World Service Meeting International Literature Fund efforts amounted to \$69,600, approximately double the \$36,000 received in 2013. Total contributions, including WSM efforts, were just over \$6,898,000.

The percentage of the A.A. groups that choose to list with the General Service Office that have participated in the Seventh Tradition by contributing to the General Service Office has remained in a relatively stable range (between 41.6% and 45%) for the past ten years.

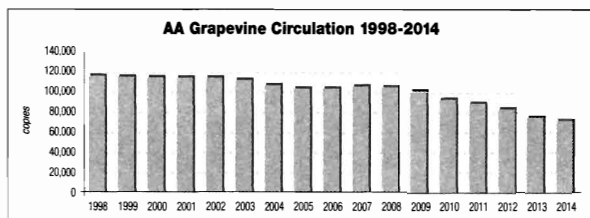
Total Operating Revenue for 2015 is anticipated at \$16,637,150, a decrease of approximately \$155,000 (.9%).

Total Operating Expenses for 2015 have been budgeted at \$16,440,000, approximately \$1,024,200 or 6.6% greater than 2014 expenses and approximately 2.5% greater than the 2014 budget. The 2015 budget is higher because the General Service Conference is back in New York City, as well as additional staffing needs for a full-time IT manager, accounting department personnel and the transition to a new general manager.

The 2015 G.S.O. budget anticipates an excess of revenue over expense of \$197,125. After considerable discussion, the A.A.W.S. Board recommended and the General Service Board approved the 2015 budget.

It should be remembered that generally the Reserve Fund is funded by literature profits. This anticipated profit for 2015 compares with a profit of \$1,376,656, \$31,554 for 2013, \$152,448 for 2012, \$819,132 for 2011, \$1,255, 289 for 2010, \$1,273,500 for 2009, and a loss of \$275,000 for 2008.

2015 Grapevine Budget



The 2015 Grapevine Budget calls for an average circulation for the print magazine of 69,632. This anticipates 3,769 fewer copies than the 2014 budget and approximately 4,368 fewer copies than the 2014 average paid print circulation of 74,000. The 2015 budget calls for approximately 5,368 GV online subscriptions, which compares with the 2014 budget of 4,561 and the 5,262 actually achieved. Print magazine circulation for the last 16 years is depicted in the adjacent chart.

Income: Magazine income of \$2,113,375 is expected to be approximately \$117,000 less than 2014. Other Publishing Income from books, booklets, compact discs, ebooks and other items is budgeted at \$734,373, approximately \$47,000 less than 2014.

Total Gross Profit: Combining the magazine and other publishing items, a gross profit of \$1,938,427 is budgeted for 2015. This compares with \$2,038,336 achieved for 2014 and the 2014 budget of \$1,903,119.

Total Operating Expenses: Total Operating Expenses for 2015 are budgeted at \$1,961,234, \$241,597 greater than the 2014 expenses of \$1,719,637, and \$140,687 greater than the 2014 budget.

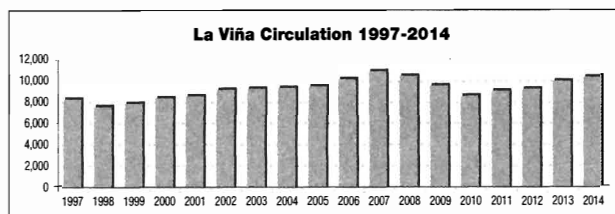
Net Income (loss): For 2015, the Grapevine anticipates a net loss of \$14,607. This compares with a 2014 budgeted profit of \$94,232 and an actual profit from operations of \$325,829.

2015 La Viña Budget

Following the 1995 General Service Conference Advisory Action #7, the publication of the Grapevine magazine in Spanish was approved by both the Grapevine Board and the trustees' Finance Committee of the General Service Board. Recognizing this publication as a new venture, both boards were to review the financial impact on the Fellowship and the progress in circulation growth and to continue to monitor the viability of this new venture. In 2001, the General Service Board recommended, and the 2001 Conference approved, that the La Viña magazine continues to be published by the Grapevine and that any ongoing shortfall between revenues and operating expenses be funded by the General Service Board's General Fund, instead of continuing to draw funds directly from the Reserve Fund.

For 2015, La Viña expects a gross profit on the magazine of \$56,973, compared with \$59,448 achieved in 2014. Circulation for 2015 is estimated to decline to 9,860, some 519 or 5% less than the 2014 average and 7% fewer than the 2014 budget. Other Publishing Income is estimated at \$11,632, which after deducting cost of product of \$2,334 expects to contribute \$9,298 to revenue. Total costs and expenses are estimated at \$225,729 for 2015, approximately \$24,000 greater than 2014 and \$19,000 more than the 2014 budget. The 2015 budget projects a shortfall of expense over revenue of \$159,458, to be funded by the General Service Board's General Fund. The anticipated 2015 shortfall is \$27,000 greater than the 2014 shortfall of \$132,035. As noted above these shortfalls for this service activity are funded by the General Service Board's General Fund. Net shortfall since inception (1995) to date are approximately \$1,800,670.

The Chart above reflects the La Viña magazine circulation.



2014 Contributions From Groups, Individuals, Specials, Special Meetings — by Delegate Area (in U.S. Dollars)

AREA #	GENERAL SERVICE CONFERENCE AREA	#GPS. REPORTED	#GPS. CONTRIB.	% OF GPS. CONTRIB.	TOTAL GROUP CONTRIB.	MEMBERSHIP	CONTRIBUTION PER CAPITA	INDIVIDUAL MEMBERS	MEMORIAL	SPECIALS ⁽¹⁾	SPECIAL MEETINGS ⁽²⁾	TOTAL AREA CONTRIBUTIONS	PER CAPITA
1.	Ala./N.W. Fla.	450	190	42.2%	\$38,901	9,082	\$4.27	3,432	\$0	\$50		\$42,383	\$4.67
2.	Alaska	184	92	50.0	18,617	3,176	5.85	1,295	0	160	\$117	20,189	6.36
3.	Arizona	979	451	46.1	121,430	21,653	5.60	13,000	2,100	6,630	511	143,670	6.64
4.	Arkansas	264	126	47.7	27,265	4,531	6.01	762	0	2,233		30,260	6.68
California													
5.	Southern	1,359	416	30.6	120,971	47,920	2.51	8,045	0	1,077	1,314	131,407	2.74
6.	N. Coastal	2,012	1,109	55.1	286,634	59,496	4.81	32,408	67	11,446	879	331,435	5.57
7.	N. Interior	1,016	458	45.1	93,553	28,801	3.24	7,258	0	5,664	480	106,956	3.71
8.	San Diego/Imp.	1,046	397	38.0	78,344	28,331	2.76	5,792	0	1,470	648	86,254	3.04
9.	Mid-South.	2,063	826	40.0	187,014	61,774	3.02	9,124	1,154	8,825	309	206,426	3.34
10.	Colorado	842	434	51.5	113,340	19,255	5.88	9,004	0	3,887	133	126,364	6.56
11.	Connecticut	1,417	634	44.7	136,971	32,623	4.19	15,953	1,441	16,892	50	171,307	5.25
12.	Delaware	253	123	48.6	38,805	3,824	10.14	3,707	0	3,992		46,504	12.16
13.	D.C.	502	208	41.4	53,597	14,790	3.61	755	0	2,231		56,583	3.83
Florida													
14.	North	982	438	44.6	115,755	20,065	5.76	7,071	211	9,967	150	133,154	6.64
15.	South/	2,104	918	43.6	204,775	42,081	4.86	12,998	4,600	36,807	111	259,291	6.16
16.	Georgia	764	468	61.3	115,612	19,045	6.06	9,567	0	2,512	64	127,754	6.71
17.	Hawaii	318	182	57.2	39,992	5,477	7.29	1,432	0	3,553		44,978	8.21
18.	Idaho	254	99	39.0	20,557	4,591	4.47	2,471	0	3,372	154	26,554	5.78
Illinois													
19.	Chicago	1,353	330	24.4	71,394	28,697	2.48	5,401	277	4,210		81,282	2.83
20.	North	1,261	478	37.9	72,873	23,090	3.15	7,858	20	30,413	543	111,707	4.84
21.	South	437	174	39.8	27,778	7,432	3.73	477	0	430		28,686	3.86
Indiana													
22.	North	654	260	39.8	39,449	9,649	4.08	2,544	150	3,990		46,133	4.78
23.	South	668	295	44.2	41,877	11,852	3.52	776	150	3,352		46,155	3.89
24.	Iowa	709	305	43.0	55,324	14,155	3.90	3,063	5,009	1,888		65,284	4.61
25.	Kansas	351	164	46.7	31,309	8,769	3.56	2,660	100	7,846	105	42,020	4.79
26.	Kentucky	747	313	41.9	74,476	11,893	6.25	8,064	100	2,808		85,448	7.18
27.	Louisiana		593	186	31.4	47,238	11,410	4.13	2,874	0	0	50,112	4.39
28.	Maine	553	173	31.3	21,609	8,640	2.49	3,014	0	4,538	650	29,811	3.45
29.	Maryland	1,027	429	41.8	87,405	15,779	5.53	10,382	3,050	1,559	17	102,414	6.49
Massachusetts													
30.	East	1,521	545	35.8	138,464	46,977	2.94	8,837	10	1,501		148,812	3.17
31.	West	323	152	47.1	19,822	5,380	3.67	2,066	0	225	400	22,513	4.18
Michigan													
32.	Central	702	248	35.3	39,676	15,313	2.58	5,773	0	2,076	100	47,625	3.11
33.	Southeast	958	284	29.6	47,400	20,822	2.27	1,172	0	3,550		52,122	2.50
34.	West	616	213	34.6	47,922	12,071	3.96	1,748	0	6,011		55,682	4.61
Minnesota													
35.	North	568	264	46.5	34,676	8,433	4.10	1,280	100	0		36,055	4.28
36.	South	1,147	431	37.6	96,103	27,284	3.51	2,559	60	12,724		111,446	4.08
37.	Mississippi	237	92	38.8	20,246	4,595	4.40	112	0	636		20,993	4.57
Missouri													
38.	East	599	242	40.4	55,547	9,662	5.74	3,763	0	3,282		62,592	6.48
39.	West	231	123	53.2	18,675	6,690	2.78	490	0	290		19,455	2.91
40.	Montana	271	141	52.0	31,966	5,558	5.74	2,853	0	590	40	35,449	6.38
41.	Nebraska	677	263	38.8	46,903	15,050	3.11	2,335	160	715	110	50,223	3.34
42.	Nevada	635	217	34.2	43,569	14,556	2.98	6,033	0	1,222	25	50,849	3.49
43.	New Hampshire	640	244	38.1	35,697	9,970	3.57	3,582	0	5,235	88	44,602	4.47
New Jersey													
44.	North	1,335	576	43.1	138,055	31,905	4.32	13,961	25	2,642	409	155,092	4.86
45.	South	550	265	48.2	65,948	8,831	7.46	5,094	0	700		71,742	8.12
46.	New Mexico	390	183	46.9	36,403	7,358	4.94	2,402	0	4,489		43,294	5.88
New York													
47.	Central	769	269	35.0	47,090	10,748	4.37	8,740	366	578	179	56,953	5.30
48.	H./M./B.	735	302	41.1	33,907	10,853	3.11	1,372	3,000	2,442	30	40,752	3.75
49.	Southeast	1,809	729	40.3	266,053	56,285	4.72	12,816	3,000	4,476	839	287,185	5.10
50.	West		85	22.5	18,668	6,159	3.02	498	500	1,000	14	20,680	3.36
51.	N. Carolina	1,162	573	49.3	153,119	19,727	7.75	10,836	750	11,719	2,250	178,674	9.06
52.	North Dakota	164	72	43.9	14,729	3,492	4.21	1,833	0	2,528		19,090	5.47
Ohio													
53.	Cent. & S.E.	857	224	26.1	30,686	10,555	2.90	1,403	0	1,669		33,759	3.20
54.	Northeast	1,553	336	21.6	43,993	19,547	2.24	2,311	400	1,052	50	47,806	2.45
55.	N.W. Ohio/S.E. Mich.	303	93	30.7	12,502	4,133	3.01	1,590	0	405		14,497	3.51
56.	S.W. Ohio	537	258	48.0	47,102	9,324	5.04	1,198	0	602		48,902	5.24
57.	Oklahoma	408	184	45.1	41,099	8,915	4.60	2,492	0	722	350	44,663	5.01
58.	Oregon	1,195	437	36.6	80,298	22,378	3.58	3,709	0	5,334	50	89,391	3.99

Pennsylvania														
59.	East	1,642	775	47.2	171,937	32,661	5.25	12,937	1,823	13,757	444	200,899	6.15	
60.	West	919	389	42.3	67,577	12,091	5.58	1,263	0	1,864		70,704	5.85	
61.	Rhode Island	300	122	40.7	21,799	5,944	3.66	1,467	1,000	6,800	54	31,119	5.24	
62.	South Carolina	404	209	51.7	57,492	9,776	5.87	1,832	0	3,241	72	62,636	6.41	
63.	South Dakota	185	68	36.8	12,580	4,788	2.62	367	0	1,201		14,147	2.95	
64.	Tennessee	602	233	38.7	57,751	12,729	4.53	4,210	0	1,273		63,234	4.97	
Texas														
65.	Northeast	528	196	37.1	105,822	19,403	5.44	9,066	59	3,635	311	118,893	6.13	
66.	Northwest	269	66	24.5	19,636	5,229	3.75	976	0	2,641		23,253	4.45	
67.	Southeast	663	291	43.9	79,230	16,916	4.67	4,451	100	1,106		84,887	5.02	
68.	Southwest	636	270	42.5	102,692	14,623	7.01	5,553	84	1,741		110,070	7.53	
69.	Utah	389	161	41.4	34,893	7,084	4.92	928	0	55	81	35,957	5.08	
70.	Vermont	291	130	44.7	26,973	4,666	5.77	1,439	63	2,795	75	31,344	6.72	
71.	Virginia	1,502	701	46.7	161,421	25,843	6.24	17,634	382	4,705	231	184,373	7.13	
72.	Western Washington	1,502	601	40.0	141,073	30,654	4.59	13,286	55	15,022	173	169,609	5.53	
73.	West Virginia	281	122	43.4	16,171	2,902	5.56	146	0	500		16,817	5.79	
Wisconsin														
74.	N. Wis./Upper Pen. Mich.	739	275	37.2	28,849	10,790	2.66	1,046	0	445		30,340	2.81	
75.	South	1,072	412	38.4	54,368	19,473	2.78	864	0	926		56,158	2.88	
76.	Wyoming	122	56	45.9	19,651	1,939	10.12	552	0	1,192		21,395	11.03	
77.	Puerto Rico	123	70	56.9	8,089	1,206	6.70	119	0	392		8,600	7.13	
78.	Alberta/N.W.T.	539	239	44.3	75,591	9,258	8.15	493	27	4,493		80,605	8.71	
79.	B.C./Yukon	820	390	47.6	93,275	14,947	6.23	2,025	0	5,542		100,843	6.75	
80.	Manitoba	153	41	26.8	10,559	3,932	2.68	6	0	177		10,743	2.73	
81.	N.B./P.E.I.	202	82	40.6	13,418	3,163	4.23	84	0	1,177		14,678	4.64	
82.	N.S./Nfld./Lab.	251	97	38.6	19,826	3,268	6.06	309	919	2,730		23,783	7.28	
Ontario														
83.	East	593	231	39.0	54,580	14,315	3.80	2,204	163	4,419	949	62,315	4.35	
84.	Northeast	167	75	44.9	14,568	1,757	8.28	0	0	2,704		17,272	9.83	
85.	Northwest	59	17	28.8	5,031	1,002	5.01	100	0	329		5,461	5.45	
86.	West	591	257	43.5	71,842	10,458	6.86	394	0	17,010	550	89,795	8.59	
Quebec ⁽³⁾														
87.	Southwest	564	418	74.1	20,130	10,354	1.93	1,788	0	13,680		35,598	3.44	
88.	Southeast	178	128	71.9	3,253	2,692	1.20	2,174	0	4,948	171	10,546	3.92	
89.	Northeast	319	246	77.1	1,598	5,853	0.26	226	0	27,216		29,040	4.96	
90.	Northwest	370	306	82.7	2,942	5,948	0.48	726	0	92,083		95,751	16.10	
91.	Saskatchewan	273	122	44.7	26,479	2,846	9.29	472	0	2,577		29,528	10.38	
92.	Washington East	465	195	41.9	32,036	5,775	5.54	136	0	1,059		33,231	5.75	
93.	Central Calif	1,077	391	36.3	93,749	28,760	3.25	3,128	0	3,548	230	100,654	3.50	
Total U.S./ Canada		65,222	27,103	41.6%	\$5,816,065	1,373,497	\$4.23	\$396,444.68	\$31,473.30	\$507,200.61	\$14,508.68	\$6,765,692	\$4.93	
Individual, in-memoriam, & special meetings					442,427									
Specials					507,201									
Total for U.S. & Canada					\$6,765,692									
FOREIGN AND OTHER														
Online and Telephone Meetings					\$2,456								\$2,456	
Correctional & Hospital facility groups					\$36								36	
Foreign, WSM, other					\$127,400								127,400	
Internationalists					\$160								160	
International Lawyers in A.A.					\$1,000								1,000	
Loners					\$1,323								1,323	
Grand Total					\$6,898,068								\$6,898,068	4.97

CONTRIBUTION COMPARISON – 2014-2013 – (in U.S. dollars)

	#GPS. REPORTED	#GPS. CONTRIB.	% OF GPS. CONTRIB.	TOTAL GROUP CONTRIB.	MEMBERSHIP	CONTRIBUTIONS PER CAPITA	TOTAL PER CAPITA INCLUDING SPECIALS ETC		
U.S. & Canada 2014	65,222	27,103	41.6%	\$5,816,064.53	1,373,497	\$4.23	\$4.93		
U.S. & Canada 2013	64,694	27,841	42.5%	\$5,718,305.63	1,389,602	\$4.12	\$4.91		
Increase (Decrease)	528	(738)	-0.9%	\$97,758.90	(16,105)	\$0.12	\$0.02	EST. COST OF SERVICES PER CAPITA	2014 7.08
									2013 \$6.84

(1) A Special contribution is one that comes from any number of AA entities that is not an A.A. Group. For example, a Conference, a Committee, an Area, a District, an Intergroup, etc.

(2) A Special Meeting is a meeting that does not want to be a group but does want to contribute to the General Service Board.

(3) Reflects not only those groups that contributed directly to G.S.O., but also those groups that contributed through their Conference Areas (per info from areas).

■ 2015 Conference Committees

Conference Agenda

Michel Bergeron
Marge Del Carlo
¹Michelle Dobek-Koinberg
²Anne Fines
Darren Flint
Ron Miscavich
Betty Morton
Michelle Patridge
Jose Rivera-Vazquez

Secretary: Mary Cumings

Cooperation With the Professional Community

Boyd Bragg
Amy Carberg
Barb Colley
¹Heidi Dahlberg
Paula Elliott
Rena Harkness
Jen Noonan
²Gus Palmitessa

Secretary: Racy Joseph

Corrections

²Don Greene
Tony Jordan
George Kulakowski
Irene Martin
Terry Mills
Cheryl Nesler
¹Bill O'Malley
Chris Wells

Secretary: Clement Cann

Finance

¹Dean Brady
Raymond Denis
Graham Gobie
Jennifer Kuntz
Joe McAndrews
Nancy Murphy
Tami Reynolds
²Rebecca Thomason
Craig Weidner

Secretary: Donald Meurer

Grapevine

Marshall Carter
²Cathi Clark
Kirk Faupel
Dave Fite
¹John Hogan
Jake Jacobson
Raymundo Lujano
Vicky Shaw

Secretary: Eugene O'Brien

Literature

Kenny Brown
¹Bruce Dinneford
Jay Eckstein
Tom Harlow
Pat Latimer
Tom Misteli
Lisa Part
²Luc Tremblay
Cheryl Vassau

Secretary: Mary Clare Lynch

Policy/Admissions

²Mary Ann Ehrhardt
Lisa Dawn Gentry
Vernon Heiskell
Calvin Leonard
Frank Malota
Scott Mulligan
Mary Jo Rone
Joyce Saunders
¹Garren Taylor

Secretary: Julio Espallat

Public Information

Tom Clyce
Garwood Faunce
Cesar Flores
²Ken Lawson
¹Clint MacKenzie
Rebecca McNeill
Diane Perron
Glenn Walters

Secretary: Jim Malone

Report and Charter

Dave Allen
Tommy Babuscio
Stephanie Bills
Pat Fallon
¹Kathi Fowler
Michael Miller
²Mary Lou Quinn
Jim Stone

Secretary: Tracey Ober

Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities

²Dolores Edelman
Terry Ernst
Anne Frey
Jennie Herd
Kristi Hewitt
¹Russ Larsen
Melissa Redd
Sally Williams

Secretary: Steve Smith

Trustees

Drew Armstrong
Veronica Ernst
²James Hurst
Libbie Lapp
¹Kelley Moran
Rachel Moysan
Christopher Stoppler
Jim Wilson
Jim Wright

Secretary: Clay Rittenhouse

³Archives

Dean Brady
¹Mary Ann Ehrhardt
Lisa Dawn Gentry
James Hurst
Calvin Leonard
Vicky Shaw
Christopher Stoppler
²Jim Wilson

Secretary: Michelle Mirza

³International Conventions/A.A. Regional Forums

Dave Allen
Amy Carberg
²Marshall Carter
Tom Clyce
Michelle Dobek-Koinberg
Garwood Faunce
¹Vernon Heiskell
Cheryl Nesler

*Secretaries: Eva Sanchez
Clay Rittenhouse*

2016 CONFERENCE CHAIRPERSONS AND ALTERNATE CHAIRPERSONS⁴

Committee	Chairperson	Alternate
Agenda	Michelle Patridge, Eastern Massachusetts	Betty Morton, SE Michigan
³ Archives	Christopher Stoppler, Saskatchewan	Calvin Leonard, NE Ohio
Cooperation With the Professional Community	Amy Carberg, District of Columbia	Paula Elliott, So. Illinois
Corrections	Christine Wells, Virginia	George Kulakowski, W. Pennsylvania
Finance	Craig Weider, Connecticut	Graham Gobie, S. Florida/Bahamas
Grapevine	David Fite, W. Missouri	Raymundo Lujano, California, Northern Interior
³ International Conv./Regional Forums	Tom Clyce, Iowa	Cheryl Nesler, Hawaii
Literature	Jay Eckstein, N. New Jersey	Tom Harlow, North Dakota
Policy/Admissions	Lisa Dawn Gentry, S. Minnesota	Scott Mulligan, S. California
Public Information	Glenn Walters, N. Florida	Rebecca McNeill, Arkansas
Report and Charter	Stephanie Bills, Oklahoma	Jim Stone, Alabama/NW Florida
Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities	Terry Ernst, Louisiana	Kristi Hewitt, Central/SE Ohio
Trustees	Rachel Moysan, North Carolina	Christopher Stoppler, Saskatchewan

¹Chairperson

²Alternate Chairperson

³Members of this committee serve on this as a secondary committee assignment.

⁴The 2015 committee chairs rotated at the end of the 65th General Service Conference.

■ 2015 Trustees' Committees**

Archives

Frances Brisbane, *chairperson*
Lynda Bergeron
Corliss Burke
Bill Farnsworth
John Fromson
Nancy Haynes
Ed Martin
Michelle Mirza, *secretary*

Audit

David Morris, *chairperson*
Ivan Lemelle
Bill Noonan
Andrew Ware
Don Meurer, *secretary*

Compensation

J. Gary Lutz, *chairperson*
Corliss Burke
Nancy Haynes
Bill Noonan
Don Meurer, *consultant*
Eugene O'Brien, *consultant*
Gary Glynn, *consultant*
Olga Mesonjnik, *secretary*

Conference

Nancy Haynes, *chairperson*
Lynda Bergeron
Joe Downey
J. Gary Lutz
Chet Parker
Clayton Vandivort
Andrew Ware
Mary Cumings, *secretary*

Cooperation With the Professional Community/ Treatment/Special Needs- Accessibilities

Bob Wilcox, *chairperson*
Carole Boerner
Ralph (Beau) Bush
Joel Castellaw
John Fromson
Barb Kelly
Ed Martin
Racy Joseph,
secretary — C.P.C.
Steve Smith, *secretary*
— Treatment/Special
Needs-Accessibilities

Corrections

Bill Farnsworth, *chairperson*
Carole Boerner
Richard Boisvert
Frances Brisbane
*Robert Fernando Cordero
*Terry Flynn
John Fromson
Barb Kelly
Ivan Lemelle
Paz Preciado
Clement Cann, *secretary*

Finance & Budgetary

David Morris, *chairperson*
Michele Grinberg
J. Gary Lutz
David Noll
Bill Noonan
Chet Parker
Andrew Ware
Albin Zezula
Kevin Sunkel,
consultant/independent auditor
Donald Meurer, *secretary*

International

Barb Kelly, *chairperson*
Richard Boisvert
Ralph (Beau) Bush
Joel Castellaw
Michele Grinberg
Paz Preciado
Bob Wilcox
Rick Walker, *secretary*

International Conventions/ A.A. Regional Forums

Ivan Lemelle, *chairperson*
Lynda Bergeron
Richard Boisvert
Joe Downey
David Morris
David Noll
Bob Wilcox
Eva Sanchez, *secretary*
— International Conventions
Clay Rittenhouse, *secretary*
— Regional Forums

Literature

Chet Parker, *chairperson*
Carole Boerner
Joel Castellaw
Joe Downey
Bill Farnsworth
*Teresa Frohock
*Christine Hofer
David Noll
Albin Zezula
Greg Tobin, *consultant*
Eleanor Widdoes, *consultant*
Mary Clare Lynch, *secretary*

Nominating

J. Gary Lutz, *chairperson*
Frances Brisbane
Nancy Haynes
Ivan Lemelle
David Morris
Bill Noonan
Clayton Vandivort
Clay Rittenhouse, *secretary*

Public Information

Clayton Vandivort, *chairperson*
Corliss Burke
Ralph (Beau) Bush
*Carolyn Carney
*Josh Eggleston
Michele Grinberg
Ed Martin
Paz Preciado
Albin Zezula
Jim Malone, *secretary*

General Sharing Session

John Fromson, *chairperson*
Julio Espallat, *secretary*

Officers of the General Service Board

Chair
Terry Bedient
First vice-chairperson
Ivan Lemelle
Second vice-chairperson
Nancy Haynes
Secretary
Albin Zezula
Treasurer
David Morris
Assistant secretary
Julio Espallat
Assistant treasurer
Donald Meurer

The new slate of officers
is given on page 10

*Denotes appointed committee members.

**Terry Bedient is an ex officio member on all committees; Phyllis Halliday is an ex officio on all committees except the Audit Committee, Compensation Committee and the Nominating Committee.

■ 2015 Conference Members

NONALCOHOLIC (CLASS A) TRUSTEES

Terrance M. Bedient, FACHE (99 Washington Ave., Suite 410, Albany, NY 12210) was elected chairman of the board in 2013, and has served as a Class A trustee and treasurer since 2008. Currently vice president of the Medical Society of New York, his career has included various executive positions, including hospital chief executive officer. He has served on a dozen nonprofit boards, including as trustee of the New York Lawyer Assistance Trust, which oversees substance abuse programs for attorneys and judges, and as treasurer of the Federation of State Physician Health Programs. Terry is a Fellow of the American College of Healthcare Executives.

***Frances L. Brisbane, Ph.D.** (53 Rustic Ave., Medford, NY 11763) was elected a Class A trustee in 2009. A graduate of Columbia University School of Social Work, she received a doctorate in Organization Development from Union Graduate School and University, Cincinnati, Ohio. Frances is the author of five books and over 60 articles and has over 100 major presentations, nationally and internationally, on topics relating to alcoholism and substance abuse prevention and treatment. She is currently dean and professor, School of Social Welfare, S.U.N.Y. at Stony Brook, New York. Frances chairs the Archives Committee and serves on the Corrections and Nominating Committees.

***Corliss R. Burke, B.Ed.** (11 Hayes Place, Whitehorse, Yukon Y1A 0E1) was elected a Class A trustee in 2009. During her 26 years in the addiction field, Corliss has worked as a counselor, trainer, director and Deputy Minister. Throughout this time, she has always been involved with Alcoholics Anonymous, attending open A.A. meetings in many countries and working to implement the Bridging the Gap committee service in Alberta and in the Yukon. Currently, her consulting business focuses on addictions program design and development, as well as on counselor training. Corliss serves on the Archives, Compensation and Public Information Committees.

John A. Fromson, M.D. (Brigham and Women's Faulkner Hospital, 1153 Centre St., Boston, MA 02130) was elected Class A trustee in April 2010. He is a board certified addiction specialist. John is a vice chairman of the Dept. of Psychiatry at Brigham and Women's Hospital and Chief of Psychiatry at Brigham and Women's Faulkner Hospital, and teaches at Harvard Medical School. He is the author of many articles and lectures widely. John chairs the Sharing Session and serves on the Cooperation With the Professional Community/Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities, Corrections and Archives Committees.

Michele Grinberg, J.D. (P.O. Box 4879, Charleston, WV 25364) was elected Class A trustee in April 2010. She is a 1985 graduate of West Virginia University College of Law, where she now teaches a legal writing course as an adjunct instructor. Michele is a practicing attorney with a concentration in health policy and medical staff relations. She is co-editor of *Women and the Law*. Michele serves on the Finance, Public Information and International Committees.

The Hon. Ivan L.R. Lemelle (U.S. District Court, Eastern District of Louisiana, 500 Poydras St., Chambers C-525, New Orleans, LA 70130) was elected Class A trustee in April 2013. A graduate of Loyola University School of Law, New Orleans, Judge Lemelle has an extensive background in both state and federal law. He currently serves as a U.S. District Judge, Visiting Judge in various other federal courts, Immediate Past President of the District Judges Association for the U.S. Fifth Circuit, and lectures often at national and international forums. Ivan chairs the International Conventions/Regional Forums Committee and also serves on the Audit, Corrections and Nominating Committees.

David M. Morris, CPA (1060 Park Ave., Apt. #4G, New York, NY 10128) was elected Class A trustee in April 2013. Currently, David is the owner of Morris Consulting, a practice that focuses on providing financial and accounting guidance. He is retired from the position of senior vice president, JPMorgan Chase Bank. David chairs the Finance & Budgetary and Audit Committees and serves on the Nominating and International Conventions/Regional Forums Committees.

ALCOHOLIC (CLASS B) TRUSTEES

Richard Boisvert (409 rue du Rhone, Terrebonne, Quebec J6W 5M3) was elected Eastern Canada regional trustee in April 2014. A Panel 60 delegate from NW Quebec. Richard remains active in his area and region. He is retired from the Aerospace industry. Richard serves on the International Conventions/Regional Forums, Corrections and International Committees.

Joel Castellaw (4239 Collwood Lane, San Diego, CA 92115) was elected Pacific regional trustee in April 2014. A former Panel 60 delegate from the San Diego/Imperial Area. Joel is active in his area. A college professor, he chairs the Communication department. Joel serves on the Cooperation With the Professional Community/Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities, Literature and International Committees.



Joe Downey (43 Lennox St., Kingston, Ontario K7M 4S3) was elected general service trustee in April 2014, after having served as a nontrustee director on the A.A.W.S. Board. Joe was a Panel 51 delegate where he was chair of the Conference Literature Committee. He is a clinical researcher at a major university. Joe serves on the Conference, International Conventions/Regional Forums and Literature Committees. He is a member of the A.A.W.S. Board.

William (Bill) Farnsworth (716 Fifth St., Marietta, OH 45750) was elected East Central regional trustee in April 2013. A former Panel 47 delegate, Bill is active in his district with the Corrections committee. His professional background is in law enforcement and he is involved with community projects. Bill chairs the Corrections Committee and serves on the Archives and Literature Committees. He is a member of the Grapevine Board.

***Nancy Haynes** (P.O. Box 151, St. Helena, CA 94574) was elected general service trustee in May 2011. A former Panel 49 delegate, Nancy served as a nontrustee director on the A.A. Grapevine Board. She is president and CEO of a coffee roasting company. Nancy chairs the Conference Committee and serves on the Archives, Nominating and Compensation Committees. She is a member of the Grapevine Board.

***Barbara (Barb) Kelly** (752 Skyline Rd., RR #1, Oakwood, ON K0M 2M0) was elected trustee-at-large/Canada in May 2011. Barb was a Panel 55 delegate from Eastern Canada and remains active in her area, as well as in community affairs. Now retired, her most recent position was as mayor of Kawartha Lakes. Barb chairs the International Committee and serves on the Corrections and Cooperation With the Professional Community/Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities Committees.

***J. Gary Lutz** (2210 13th St., Bethlehem, PA 18020) was elected Northeast regional trustee in May 2011. A Panel 55 delegate from Eastern Pennsylvania, J. Gary is a university professor of education, specializing in educational research methodology and currently serving as Vice Provost for Institutional Research. He chairs the Nominating and Compensation Committees and serves on the Finance & Budgetary and Conference Committees. He is also a member of the A.A.W.S. Board.

William (Bill) Noonan (2345 Valley Mill Drive, Buford, GA 30519) was elected general service trustee in April 2013, after serving as an A.A.W.S. nontrustee director for four years. Bill, a Panel 49 delegate, is an executive in the Financial Risk Management field. Bill's love of general service developed as a result of his involvement with The International Conference of Young People in A.A. Bill chairs the A.A.W.S. Board and serves on the Finance & Budgetary, Nominating, Audit and Compensation Committees.

Chet Parker (1006 Eastern Way, Orlando, FL 32804) was elected Southeast regional trustee in April 2013. A Panel 59 delegate, he is involved in his area's Traditions Workshops. Chet is an attorney who has taught various courses at local institutions. Chet chairs the Literature Committee and serves on the Conference and Finance & Budgetary Committees. He is a member of the A.A.W.S. Board.

***Clayton Vandivort** (Box 158, 316 S. Kingshighway St., Sikeston, MO 63801) was elected Southwest regional trustee in May 2011. A former Panel 49 delegate from Eastern Missouri, Clayton is active in his area and region. He is an attorney in

private practice. He chairs the Public Information Committee and serves on the Conference and Nominating Committees.

Andrew Ware (3214 Cummins Way, Missoula, MT 59802) was elected West Central regional trustee in April 2012. A former Panel 57 delegate, Andrew is active in his area and region. He is a university professor and chair of the Department of Physics and Astronomy. He chairs the Grapevine Board and serves on the Conference, Finance & Budgetary and Audit Committees.

Robert (Bob) Wilcox (30 Whispering Wind Rd., Westfield, MA 01085) was elected trustee-at-large/U.S. in April 2013. Bob was a Panel 52 delegate, where he chaired the Public Information Committee. He owns an independent insurance agency. He chairs the Cooperation With the Professional Community/Treatment/Special Needs-Accessibilities Committee and serves on the International Conventions/Regional Forums and International Committees.

Albin Zezula (100 Connecticut Ave., Long Beach, NY 11561) was elected general service trustee in April 2013, after having served four years as a nontrustee director on the Grapevine Board. Albin is an associate publisher with a newspaper publishing company. He serves on the Public Information, Literature and Finance and Budgetary Committees, and is a member of the Grapevine Board.

Trustees elected by the General Service Board following 2015 Conference

Leslie Sanders Backus (301 East 55th St., Savannah, GA 31405) was elected Class A trustee in April 2015. Leslie's professional background is in volunteer leadership and fund development. She is currently chief financial officer in an outpatient substance abuse treatment facility.

Yolanda Flores (119 Saint Francis Ave., San Antonio, TX 78204) was elected Southwest regional trustee in April 2015. Yolanda was a Panel 50 delegate where she chaired the Literature Committee. She is retired from the engineering department of a telecommunications company. She is active in local A.A. group and district activities.

Scott Huyghebaert (#836, 15 Hudson Bay Trail, Kamloops, BC V2C 6S6) was a Panel 61 delegate. Scott currently takes meetings into a local detox and facilitates Twelfth Step weekends. He is an attorney.

Peter F. Luongo, Ph.D. (20312 Sandsfield Terrace, Germantown, MD 20876) was elected Class A trustee in April 2015. Peter's professional background is in public health services at state and local levels. He is currently executive director, Institute for Research, Education and Training in Addictions (IRETA).

****Edward Martin** (4063 Utah St., St. Louis, MO 63116) was elected general service trustee in April 2015. Ed is a former Panel 51 delegate, where he chaired the Grapevine Committee. He remains active in general service. Semi-retired, Ed continues his work as a photographer.

Richard Purtell (6 Pete's Way, Pelham, NH 03076) was elected Northeast regional trustee in April 2015. A Panel 60 delegate, Richard is active in his district and area. He is a certified staffing professional and currently serves as a senior consultant to the Staffing Industry.

A.A. World Services Directors

Bill Noonan, *chairperson, general service trustee*
 Carole Boerner, *director*
 Joe Downey, *general service trustee*
 Julio Espallat, *G.S.O. staff member*

Phyllis Halliday, *G.S.O. general manager*
 J. Gary Lutz, *regional trustee*
 David Noll, *director*
 Chet Parker, *regional trustee*

A.A. Grapevine Directors

Andrew Ware, *chairperson, regional trustee*
 Lynda Bergeron, *director*
 Ami Brophy, *executive editor/publisher*
 Bill Farnsworth, *regional trustee*

Nancy Haynes, *general service trustee*
 Ed Martin, *director*
 Paz Preciado, *director*
 Albin Zezula, *general service trustee*

General Service Office Staff

Phyllis Halliday, *general manager*
 Clement Cann
 Mary Cumings
 Julio Espallat
 Racy Joseph
 Mary Clare Lynch

Jim Malone
 Tracey Ober
 Clay Rittenhouse
 Eva Sanchez
 Steve Smith
 Rick Walker

Grapevine Staff

Ami Brophy, *executive editor/publisher*
 Irene Donoso, *La Viña editor*

Jon Witherspoon, *senior editor*

Others Assisting the Conference (nonvoting)

Militza Alma-Noyola, *IT project assistant*
 Julie Anderson, *staff assistant*
 Nadine Baker, *staff assistant*
 Janet Bryan, *GV office mgr./executive asst.*
 Amalia Castillio, *Spanish language interpreter*
 Cindy Copeland-Woolford, *consultant, electronic voting*
 Cathalina Davis, *copy room coordinator*
 John DeStefano, *Spanish editor*
 Ashley Duffy, *consultant, Talley Management*
 Cynthia Garippa, *IT manager*
 Danielle Isaac, *staff assistant*
 Stefan Jetchick, *French language interpreter*
 John Kirwin, Jr., *hotel coordinator/on-site manager*
 Andree Lanoix, *French language interpreter*
 Fern Leclerc, *French editor*
 Oliver Lepage, *French language interpreter*
 Pamela Lewis, *staff assistant*
 Ayleen Martinez, *staff assistant*
 Donald Meurer, *C.F.O., A.A.W.S.*
 Michelle Mirza, *archivist*
 Eugene O'Brien, *GV controller*
 Joselin Pichardo, *GV production associate*
 Carlos Restrepo, *Spanish language interpreter*
 Ivelisse Rivera, *staff assistant*
 Linda Samuels, *staff assistant*
 Jason Seder, *artist, Final Conference Report*
 Frank Segui, *finance assistant*
 Robert Slotterback, *controller, A.A.W.S.*
 Kevin Sunkel, *independent auditor*
 Ames Sweet, *writer*
 Greg Talley, *consultant, International Convention*
 Greg Tobin, *publishing director*
 Andre Washington, *office manager*
 Eleanor Widdoes, *writer/editor, Summer Edition Box 4-5-9, Conference Report*
 Nay Williams-Wise, *Conference staff assistant*
 Sandra Wilson, *exec. asst. to general manager*

Trustees emeriti

Leonard Blumenthal
 Ward B. Ewing, D.D.
 Gary Glynn

Area Delegates

What do panel numbers mean? Delegates to each Conference are made up of two "panels." One is even-numbered and includes those elected to start serving in an even year. The other is odd-numbered and includes those elected to start serving in an odd year. The 65th Conference includes Panel 64 (delegates now serving for their second year) and Panel 65 (new delegates).

UNITED STATES

State	Area no.	Panel	
Alabama/N.W. Florida	1	65	Jim Stone 203 Thach Ln. Meridianville, AL 35759
Alaska	2	64	Bruce Dinneford 6745 Marquerite Juneau, AK 99801
Arizona	3	64	Kathi Fowler 3060 N. Soldier Trail Tucson, AZ 85749
Arkansas	4	65	Rebecca McNeill 3109 Mossy Creek Dr Little Rock, AZ 72211
California Southern	5	65	Scott Mulligan 325 Avalon Ct. Upland, CA 91784
Central	93	65	Lisa Part 14625 Kingsbury St. Mission Hills, CA 91345
Northern Coastal	6	65	Raymundo Lujano 265 N. 26th St. San Jose, CA 95116
Northern Interior	7	64	Kelley Moran 903 Tanner Court Folsom, CA 95630
San Diego/Imperial	8	64	Dean Brady 1533 La Flesta Dr San Marcos, CA 92078
Mid-Southern	9	64	Cesar Flores 1309 Maple St. Santa Ana, CA 92707
Colorado	10	65	Tami Reynolds 5977 S. Pierson St. Littleton, CO 80127
Connecticut	11	65	Craig Weidner 36 Deer Run Bethel, CT 06801
Delaware	12	64	Veronica Ernst 148 S. Lexington Dr Felton, DE 19943
District of Columbia	13	65	Amy Carberg 1716 Swann St., NW Washington, DC 20009
Florida North	14	65	Glenn Walters 7130 Hartman St. Cocoa, FL 32927
S. Florida/Bahamas/ V.I./Antigua/St.Maarten/ Cayman Islands	15	65	Graham Gobie 12305 SW 90th Ave. Miami, FL 33176
Georgia	16	64	Rebecca Thomason 5818 Lakeshore Dr Buford, GA 30518
Hawaii	17	65	Cheryl Nesler 68-1025 Kaniku Dr., #619 Kamuela, HI 96743
Idaho	18	64	Garren Taylor 1720 E. 2800 South Wendell, ID 83355-3025

<u>State</u>	<u>Area no.</u>	<u>Panel</u>		<u>State</u>	<u>Area no.</u>	<u>Panel</u>	
Illinois				Montana	40	65	Libbie Lapp 440 Creston Rd. Kalispell, MT 59901
<i>Chicago</i>	19	65	Thomas (Tommy) Babuscio 29 169th St. Hammond, IN 46324	Nebraska	41	64	Bill O'Malley 1130 H Street, #504 Lincoln, NE 68508
<i>Northern</i>	20	64	Cheryl Vassau 40710 N. Lake Bluff Dr Antioch, IL 60002	Nevada	42	65	Michael Miller 2409 Brockton Way Henderson, NV 89074
<i>Southern</i>	21	65	Paula Elliot 8232 Jefferson Rd. Freeburg, IL 62243	New Hampshire	43	64	Kenneth (Ken) Lawson 39 Sandy Beach Rd. Springfield, NH 03284
Indiana				New Jersey			
<i>Northern</i>	22	65	Irene Martin 2309 Barbara Jean Dr Schererville, IN 46375	<i>Northern</i>	44	65	Jay Eckstein 1269 W. Laurelton Pkwy Teaneck, NJ 07666
<i>Southern</i>	23	64	Cathi Clark 802 Acorn Woods Dr Indianapolis, IN 46224	<i>Southern</i>	45	64	Joseph (Joe) McAndrews 318 E. Third Ave. Runnemede, NJ 08078
Iowa	24	65	Tom Clyce 3922 74th St. Urbandale, IA 50322	New Mexico	46	64	Jennifer (Jen) Noonan 2200 Corley Dr., #8G Las Cruces, NM 88001
Kansas	25	64	Donald (Don) Greene 124 W. Minneapolis St. Salina, KS 67401	New York			
Kentucky	26	64	*Kenneth (Kenny) Brown 309 Chaplin Rd. Bloomfield, KY 40008	<i>Central</i>	47	65	Vicky Shaw 45091 Olney Rd. Redwood, NY 13679
Louisiana	27	65	Terry Ernst 6000 Canal Blvd. New Orleans, LA 70124	<i>Hudson/Mohawk/ Berkshire</i>	48	64	Pat Latimer 20 Twiller St. Albany, NY 12209
Maine	28	64	Mary Lou Quinn 1 Pleasant St. Lubec, ME 04652	<i>Southeast</i>	49	65	James (Jim) Wright 1470 East Ave., #4G Bronx, NY 10462
Maryland	29	64	Ronald (Ron) Miscavich 29868 Nicholas Way Easton, MD 21601	<i>Western</i>	50	64	Frank Malota 109 Southridge Dr West Seneca, NY 14224
Massachusetts				North Carolina	51	65	Rachel Moysan 305 S. Rowan Ave. Spencer, NC 28159
<i>Eastern</i>	30	65	Michelle Pattridge 40 High St. Natick, MA 01760	North Dakota	52	65	Thomas (Tom) Harlow 10 Vail Circle Grand Forks, ND 58201
<i>Western</i>	31	64	Anne Frey 182 N. Washington St. Belchertown, MA 01007	Ohio			
Michigan				<i>Central/Southeast</i>	53	65	Kristi Hewitt 5 S. High St. Glouster, OH 45732
<i>Central</i>	32	65	Kirk Faupel Box 283 Saline, MI 48176	<i>Northeast</i>	54	65	Calvin Leonard 3571 Riedham Rd. Shaker Heights, OH 44120
<i>Southeast</i>	33	65	Betty Morton 930 John R Rd., #2516 Troy, MI 48083	<i>Northwest</i>	55	64	Nancy Murphy 1507 Park Ridge Lane Toledo, OH 43614
<i>Western</i>	34	64	Russell (Russ) Larsen 4748 Zuder St. Norton Shores, MI 49441	<i>Southwest</i>	56	64	Garwood Faunce 217 E. Main St. Piqua, OH 45356
Minnesota				Oklahoma	57	65	Stephanie Bills 15904 Sheffield Blvd. Edmond, OK 73013
<i>Northern</i>	35	64	Michael (Jake) Jacobson 1921 E. 27th St. Hibbing, MN 55746	Oregon	58	64	August (Gus) Palmitessa P.O. Box 51328 Eugene, OR 97405
<i>Southern</i>	36	65	Lisa Dawn Gentry 4325 Portland Ave. Minneapolis, MN 55407	Pennsylvania			
Mississippi	37	64	Tony Jordan 605 20th Ave. North Columbus, MS 39701	<i>Eastern</i>	59	65	Patricia (Pat) Fallon 312 Hamel Ave. Glenside, PA 19038
Missouri				<i>Western</i>	60	65	George Kulakowski 303 Buggy Rd. Punxsutawney, PA 15767
<i>Eastern</i>	38	65	Marge Del Carlo 3126 Portis Ave. St. Louis, MO 63116				
<i>Western</i>	39	65	Dave Fite 8281 E. Farm Rd., 146 Rogersville, MO 65742				

<u>State</u>	<u>Area no.</u>	<u>Panel</u>	
Rhode Island	61	64	John Hogan 52 Watch Hill Rd. Westerly, RI 02891
South Carolina	62	64	Marshell Carter 30 Kendal Green Dr Greenville, SC 29607
South Dakota	63	64	Anne Fines 22571 Smokey Ridge Rd. Rapid City, SD 57702
Tennessee	64	64	Mary Ann Ehrhardt 141 Bishop Lane Burns, TN 37029
Texas			
<i>Northeast</i>	65	65	Tom Misteli 652 Harter Rd. Dallas, TX 75218-2114
<i>Northwest</i>	66	64	Vernon Heiskell 1907 Cherokee Trail Dalhart, TX 79022
<i>Southeast</i>	67	65	Melissa Redd 21484 Tower Guard Dr Kingwood, TX 77339
<i>Southwest</i>	68	64	James Hurst 818 Alden Corpus Christi, TX 78412
Utah	69	65	Renae Harkness 2286 Willow View Way Sandy, UT 84092
Vermont	70	64	Heidi Dahlberg 22 Athens Dr Essex Junction, VT 05452
Virginia	71	65	Christine (Chris) Wells 2251 Eisenhower Ave., #418 Alexandria, VA 22314
Washington			
<i>State East</i>	92	64	Dolores Edelman P.O. Box 246 Malott, WA 98829
<i>Western</i>	72	65	Darren Flint 1206 N. Pine St. Tacoma, WA 98406
West Virginia	73	65	Barbara (Barb) Colley 3939 Highland Ave. Shadyside, OH 43947
Wisconsin			
<i>No. WI/ Up. Pen. MI</i>	74	64	Mary Jo Rone 2437 Sherman Creek Rd. Eau Claire, WI 54703
<i>Southern</i>	75	65	Peter (Drew) Armstrong 1660 Alvin Ln. Brookfield, WI 53045
Wyoming	76	64	Sally Williams 415 N. Second East Riverton, WY 82501
Puerto Rico	77	64	Jose (Chepo) Rivera-Vazquez P.O. Box 672 Barranquitas, PR 00794-0672

CANADA

<u>Province</u>	<u>Area no.</u>	<u>Panel</u>	
Alberta/N.W.T.	78	64	Michelle Dobek-Koinberg P.O. Box 402 Blairmore, AB T0K 0E0
B.C./Yukon	79	65	Jennifer Kuntz 92 Wickstrom Rd. Whitehorse, YT Y1A GN2
Manitoba	80	64	Clinton (Clint) McKenzie 411 Booth Dr Winnipeg, MB R3J 3M9
New Brunswick/P.E.I.	81	64	*David (Dave) Allen 4 Kilburn Ave. Moncton, NB E1A 3N6
Nova Scotia/ Newfoundland/Labr.	82	65	Boyd Bragg 1-2430 Topsail Rd. Conception Bay South, NL A1W 5R4
Ontario			
<i>Eastern</i>	83	65	Joyce Saunders 133 Wynford Dr., Suite 803 Toronto, ON M3C 0J5
<i>Northeast</i>	84	64	Terry Mills 252 Ash St. Sudbury, ON P3C 1Z8
<i>Northwest</i>	85	65	Jennie Herd 450 Laurenson Ln., #611 Kenora, ON P9N 4C9
<i>Western</i>	86	64	James (Jim) Wilson 118 West 27th St. Hamilton, ON L9C 5A1
Quebec			
<i>Southwest</i>	87	64	Raymond Denis 11773 Avenue Matte Montreal-Nord, QC H1G 3P8
<i>Southeast</i>	88	65	Michel Bergeron 234 A-La Rochelle Asbestos, QC J1T 3M7
<i>Northeast</i>	89	65	Diane Perron 497 Baron Baie-Comeau, QC G5C 3W4
<i>Northwest</i>	90	64	Luc Tremblay 440 Theberge, #304 Terrebonne, QC J6W 2R4
Saskatchewan	91	65	Christopher Stoppler 777 Montague St. Regina, SK S4T 3H1

